A duty to fulfil

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Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Additional Tags:
Inspired by Bridgerton (TV), Princes & Princesses, Normalised homosexuality, Alternate History, Alternate Universe, Eventual Smut, Smut, Fluff and Angst, Angst, Enemies to Lovers, Skippable Smut, Slow Burn, Slow Build, Alternate Universe - Regency, Grief/Mourning, Magic, Canon magic, Hurt/Comfort, Canon Species, No beta we die like Randor and Melendy, Infertility, Halfmoon (She-Ra)

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Part 1 of A duty to fulfil

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by catraofhalfmoon

Summary

You do not have to have seen / read Bridgerton to be able to read this! :)

Adora Grayskull is expected to find a perfect bride this Season, and Perfuma of Halfmoon checks every box. But when Adora unknowingly crosses paths with Perfuma's fiercely protective sister, Catra, sparks fly on horseback and tension brews in the ballroom. Neither of them planned on falling in love, least of all with each other.

OR

Adora is looking for a wife this season, and her requirements are hefty. Once she meets Perfuma- who meets her expectations exactly, she can't help but feel a pull towards the woman's fiery sister, Catra.

Chapter 1: Childbearing Hips

Chapter Summary

> Adora has a duty to fulfil and that is to be make sure her family is taken care of. she will need to find a suitable wife this season, one that can carry her children and also has some level of smartness. Catra is bringing her sister from Halfmoon to Lady Light Spinner's house. Perfuma is to marry this season and Catra would rather die than have that be her.

Chapter Notes

> OKAY so some prefaces : Light Spinner is not evil here, just manipulative. Lady whistledown and side characters aren't really part of this- it's a main focus on Catradora. There may be direct quotes from the show cuz… i love that show. Halfmoon is inspired by south Asia cuz desi catra is sooo freaking regal. OH and anyone can get anyone pregnant in this- normalised homosexuality n stuff… don't ask me how… Adora also uses some masculine terms like Viscount, Lord instead of lady etc.
>
> ALSO this first chapter is pretty descriptive and takes a minute to get into the dialogue, it won't ALWAYS continue like that, i just want to be descriptive of the setting for those who haven't watched bridgerton before.

In Brightmoon, the Season began not with trumpet nor decree, but with fresh gossip in the morning markets.

The city bloomed with anticipation.

Magnolia blossoms unfurled against white stoned walls, their petals wide as saucers and perfuming the air with something soft and heady. Carriages bearing individual noble crests clattered down the moon-polished roads, each one lacquered with mirror gloss and drawn by horses with manes braided in silk. Their

wheels left delicate half-moons in the damp, enchanted cobbles and trailed a soft purple glow of magic.

Tailors were already weeks behind on orders, embroidered waistcoats trimmed in opalite threads, sari silks imported from Halfmoon in shades of marigold and crimson, garments so fine they shimmered even in shadow. Every lantern shop in the Silver District had sold out by midmorning. There was talk of desperate barons bribing apprentices with perfume and coin to secure a second rate chandelier for their drawing rooms.

And at the centre of it all stood the palace.

Not merely grand, but otherworldly - a towering sweep of glass and precious moonstone, each spire catching the late rays of dawn and scattering them like fallen stars. The marble of each outer wall was veined with precious crystals, smooth to the touch and always faintly warm with power, as if kissed by the light of some unseen moon. Veils of gossamer cloud passed behind the highest tower, where Queen Angella herself had stood just days earlier and declared, much to everyone's shock, that no debutante, viscount or Lord had yet impressed her.

The ton was in a frenzy.

The Queen had always named a Diamond before the first full moon ball. This silence, this deliberate withholding, had sent every family of station scrambling to polish their manners and straighten their lineage scrolls.

Still, the nobility of Brightmoon was nothing if not composed. Those eligible still bowed and curtsied like ballerinas or with spine-straight humility, and every noble household with a shred of ambition prepared for this Season with honeyed words and hidden gossiping knives.

From Queen’s walk to the Moon Temple Gardens, the city moved like a waltz- timed, practiced and beautiful. The lanterns were lit earlier each night, strung in high, sweeping arcs across marble

courtyards and balcony gardens. Their flames were enchanted to flicker in soft silver and gold, casting the streets in a dreamy glow that made even the most cynical courtier look a touch divine.

And in the shadows behind every drawing room, behind every whispered invitation and midnight rendezvous, the Season waited.

Watching. Listening.

And ready to begin.

- - - - -

Viscount Adora Grayskull didn't really care about the diamonds.

She cared far more about managing the tangled ledgers of Grayskull House, the land holdings near the Mystacor border or the rapidly rising costs of moonstone tariffs- than she did about being named a diamond. She cared about keeping Adam from gambling away what remained of their father's inheritance, which he had already foolishly staked once on a bet involving a duel, a bottle of fire nectar alcohol and a dancer named Teela. And more than anything else, she cared about ensuring no one- not some simpering baroness, some sharp tongued marquess or a drunk viscount with too much time and too little tact- would ever so much as mention her older sister Mara in a ballroom. Not a whisper behind a fan, not a smirk exchanged across the supper table.

Going into this season was daunting, but she had put it off far too long. Most would consider her too old now, if it weren't for her status. Despite Mara's fuck up, her father's reputation was too established to be immediately tarnished, and that would mean even if the ton hadn't forgotten last Season's scandal, they would still be expect to show her the utmost respect, and she would still be considered the most eligible bachelorette of this Season. Her mother had ensured to tell her that she didn't need to make herself available this season, that she could indeed go another few years without finding a lady this way, that maybe she would

find one on her travels- but she doubted it. The women she courted on her travels weren't exactly… *Viscountess material.*

Still, even though Marlena had assured Adora that she could take it slowly, she couldn't exactly avoid the slowly tightening expectations in the air, as her family's carriage rolled into Brightmoon. Inside, her gloves were folded neatly on her lap, but her fingers were still curled, restless, desperately wanting to pick at her cuticles despite her fresh manicure.

Adam sighed dramatically opposite here. "You're doing it again, Adora."

"I'm not doing anything," she scoffed.

"Nobody expects you to actually find a wife this season, you know that right?" Adam said, placing his hand on her shoulder.

But Adam didn't understand.

He never had to.

He had the luxury of still fooling around- attending masquerades in Mystacor under false names, kissing illegal dancers in candlelit wings, wagering coins he *didn't have*, always trusting that someone at home would clean up the mess. The third oldest could *afford* to be charming and reckless, that was expected. Even Lonnie, for all her gruffness and disdain for social etiquette, had time to wander and *live*.

Adora had once had that luxury, too. Before Mara had ruined it.

Before she had fallen in love with a married woman nearly twice her age- Hope, *of all names,* and caused a scandal so vast that Queen Angella herself had to send back the Grayskull invitation to the Autumn Ball, *unsigned*. Before she had left their family to fend for itself only ten months after the previous Viscount's death. Their father.

After that, the world had narrowed.

Mara disappeared into exile and whispers, though Adora knew she still corresponded with their mother. And Adora, at twenty one had put away her dancing slippers and picked up the estate ledgers. She swallowed her grief and rage and shame in one large inhale and stepped into the role that no one had properly prepared her for.

She had learned to speak like a diplomat, to calculate interest in her head, to read between the lines of trade offers and matchmaking proposals. She had become the heir not because she was chosen, but because there was no one else.

And now, six years later, she was expected to smile sweetly and find love with someone suitable.

Love. As if that had ever been the point.

No- Adora would fulfil her duties as she must. She would find a wife with quiet manners and strong hips and a sensible dowry. Someone who would raise their children kindly and not ask too many questions about Adora working late in her study. Someone respectable, likeable and maybe even a little forgettable- the sort of woman who would fit neatly into the portrait of a Grayskull painting.

She didn't need passion. Or danger. Or unpredictability.

Not anymore.

"Adora? Hello??"

Adora's eyes snapped up and she blinked owlishly at Adam who was waving his hand in front of her eyes.

"Sorry what?"

"I asked, dear sister, what you seek in a wife this Season, if you must have one."

Adora rolled her eyes, opening her small A5 notebook to her notes and began reading.

"Someone with a solid family name, perhaps connections in trade or court, somebody agreeable and educated, well-spoken but perhaps not overly opinionated…"

Adam's face scrunched up. "Wow…that sounds…wildly romantic."

She laughed a little, deeming the notion ridiculous. "I'm not looking for romance, Adam. I'm looking for stability."

"Oh? Pray tell what else constitutes stability?" He said, smirking and leaning back.

"She should be fertile- able to bear children. At least two, preferably three. It's practical for heirs and succession. Strong constitution, childbearing hips, mother must like her."

Adam coughed, going a little red. "Adora?!"

"What? It's true. It matters."

Adam guffawed, sounding more like a donkey than a lord. "You sound like a livestock auction. It's practically offensive. Would you like another lady to be talking that way of you?"

"Don't be crude, Adam. If another lady talks this way of me so practically then I should marry her on the spot. She would be very sensible and practical. But I would not be the one carrying the child so…that part would be refutable."

"You're the one being crude with the mention of hip size."

"Why shouldn't I mention that? I intend to keep managing our estate- the books, the holdings, the delegations of trade. I need someone who wants a quiet life, someone motherly who will keep a warm home and raise our children without fuss or need for fantasies."

Adam titled his head. “But what about love? Mama is always drilling that into your head.”

Adora paused, her chest aching a little at the childish naivety her brother was displaying. “Love is a luxury, Adam. If it comes, it comes, but I won’t risk building a life on something that… uncertain.”

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The Grayskull townhouse rose like a soldier from the polished lane, carved from pale Brightmoon quartz, veined with crystals and shaded by high-limbed moonwillow trees that the late Viscount Randor had planted when his first child had been born. It stood tall and symmetrical, each window framed with enchanted ivy that bloomed differently in each lunar phase. From the upper balconies, one could see clear across the Moon Temple Gardens, where the Queen’s swan-dappled reflecting pool lay still as glass.

Inside, the air buzzed with the sounds of preparation- hammering from the ballroom’s far wall, the murmur of decorators consulting floor plans, the scent of fresh wax and lavender polish.

Lady Marlena Grayskull stood in the centre of it all, like the calm eye of a storm, dressed in lavender silk, her white-gold hair swept in a precise twist. She looked up from a scroll when Adora entered and raised a brow.

“Your shoulders are too stiff.”

Adora reflexively straightened them further.

“I meant *relax*, darling.”

Adora tried- truly- but her body held tension the way a sword would hold its edge, not out of obstinacy, but survival. It had been her default posture for six years now.

She waited for her mother to comment further, but instead Marlena turned towards the mantel, where a velvet-lined box sat

unopened, haloed in the low afternoon light.

The Halfmoon delegation will arrive in two days," she said coolly. "I expect you to attend the evening welcome ball."

Adora's throat went dry. "Are they expecting... an offer?"

Halfmoon was a land Adora frequently traded with, their silks and materials being of impeccable quality- along with their spices. However she wasn't adequately prepared to barter tonight. She wasn't sure if perhaps the delegation came for business or a match this Season.

"They are expecting *civility* ," Marlena replied. "And tact. Both of which I know you can manage."

Adora crossed to the hearth, her boots silent on the marble. Her gaze kept slipping to the box.

"May I see your ring?" she asked.

Marlena paused. A small, thoughtful silence.

"I don't want it yet, Mother." Adora added quickly. "Not until- well if- I find someone, but I would like to see it."

Marlena's expression softened by the faintest margin. She reached for the box and flipped open the clasp with a practiced hand, then turned it toward her daughter.

The ring was simple. A band of gold, set with a cluster of moonstone and a single, precise diamond. Not ornate. Not flashy. But undeniably old, older than Adora's memory, older than her mother's smile. It glowed faintly in the light like something blessed.

It was, she thought, a ring made for someone who lived by duty. Someone like her.

“You’ll have it,” Marlena said, voice quiet, “when you find someone you *love* .”

Adora sighed, exasperated. “Love?”

Her mother gave her a look that could only be described as *pointed* . “Yes, love. I married your father for alliance, yes, but I did love him. Contrary to rumor.”

Adora flushed faintly. “I just thought... suitability would be enough.”

“Suitability,” Marlena said, reclining with the grace of an ex-swordswoman turned stateswoman, “will bore you, darling. Trust me.”

- - - - - - -

The morning was heavy with silver light, the kind that clung to everything- to saddle leather, to misted grass, to the curls of breath rising from her horse’s nostrils. The district was quiet still, still holding its breath before the sun could claim it entirely. The bells hadn’t rung and the markets hadn’t opened. It was a rare hour when even nobles slipped out under borrowed cloaks and hoped to be anonymous.

Adora Grayskull rode alone through the western wood paths of the Moon Temple estates, letting her horse stretch into a quiet gallop.

She rode to think. To breathe. To loosen the knot in her spine that court shoes and dinner conversations always seemed to pull tighter. Her mount- a white Brightmoon stallion named Swift Wind- responded easily to the subtle press of her heels, the gentle tug of her gloves.

The air smelt of damp earth, pine needles and oddly something sweeter- perhaps jasmine or lingering cherry tobacco from nearby gardens.

And then, in a clearing up ahead, she saw her.

Another rider.

She was astride a lean bay mare, one that was dark as molasses, low and wild throughout the mist. She wore a burnished plum and ochre riding coat- not typical Brightmoon fashion- which was usually pastels and golds. Her hair was a deep brown and thick- wild and unbound, caught by the wind like a battle flag.

Adora had pulled Swift Wind just short of the clearing, leaning him into a trot near the stranger. The woman turned her head slightly and their eyes met across the morning hush and held.

It was hard not to think the woman was beautiful. Her eyes were two different colours, like a beautiful storm held in amber- fierce and molten, impossible to look away from once caught. There was something wild in them, untamed and sharp, unlike any of the ladies Adora had met before, in a way where she always looked two steps ahead of anyone else and dared them to catch up. They were ringed by thick lashes that curled upward, dark against her sun-warmed skin.

The woman noticed she was staring and smirked at her catlike, not in a polite way like she was used to.

Adora blinked. “You’re trespassing.”

“So are you,” the woman said. Her voice was low, amused, touched with a rolling cadence Adora didn’t recognize.

“I’m a Grayskull.”

“Congratulations, Princess,” she cackled, a squeaky sound.

“Viscount.” Adora corrected, her nostrils flaring at the rudeness of this woman. She opened her mouth to issue something resembling a warning- something dutiful and proper, but the woman had already nudged her mare forward.

“You’re slow,” she said over her shoulder.

Adora frowned. “Excuse me?”

“Your horse,” she said, grinning now. “Looks like he hasn’t run in weeks.”

Swift Wind, affronted, huffed and stomped at the ground.

Adora arched a brow. “Is that a challenge?”

The woman tilted her head. “Unless you’re afraid.”

Adora didn’t answer. She pressed her heel into Swift Wind’s side, and they were off.

The Whispering Woods blurred around them- moss and stone, bark and glimmering leaves. Birds scattered from branches as the two horses flew over roots and shallow ditches. The path wound tighter and then opened into another clearing, where the wind caught the hem of the stranger’s coat and ripped it behind her like a comet’s tail.

They raced neck and neck, no further words spoken, just the shared rhythm, of hooves pounding and lungs burning. And just when Adora thought she might pull ahead- the woman laughed,

A real laugh. Untamed and sharp and *thrilling* .

Adora’s heart stuttered in her chest.

By the time they reached the old stone marker at the edge of the orchard, they had both reined in, breathless, sweating, glowing with exertion.

Adora tried to speak, but the words tangled.

The woman smirked at her. “Not bad for a Grayskull.”

“You know who I am,” Adora said slowly.

“I know enough.”

“And yet you haven’t given me your name.” *She desperately wanted to know.*

The woman shrugged, wiping a bit of sweat from her brow with a gloved hand. “What fun would that be?”

Adora studied her, the proud tilt of her chin, the way her eyes sparked like struck flint. She was… *beautiful* , but not in the soft, polished way debutantes tried to be. There was a wildness to her. A strength that you didn’t really see in Brightmoon.

“You’re married, then?” Adora asked suddenly, not really knowing where her sudden forwardness had come from.

The woman blinked and then scoffed. “Why would you assume that?”

“You’re too bold not to be,” Adora said, regretting it the moment it left her mouth.

To her surprise, the woman threw her head back and laughed again. “Gods, no.”

Adora flushed, more than she meant to. “Then you’re with the court?”

“Maybe I’m just a ghost.” Her brows waggled at Adora’s incredulous look.

Adora gave her a flat look. “You don’t *seem* spectral.”

“Well, you haven’t caught me yet.”

And with that, the stranger turned her mare and rode off, back into the trees without a proper farewell. No curtsy. No name.

Just that maddening smirk lingering in Adora’s mind long after the mist swallowed her.

Adora stayed there a while longer, chest rising and falling, Swift Wind gently nudging her gloved hand as if in question.

She didn't know who the woman was.

She only knew one thing for certain.

She would be thinking about her for the rest of the day.

And likely the rest of the Season.

- - - - - - - - -

The estate of Lady Light Spinner sat just outside the temple walls, nestled in a crescent of silverleaf trees that caught the moonlight and made the house appear to glow from within. Built from pale stone and crystal laced bricks, it was graceful in its age- a shell of timeless glamour meant to remind its guests of exactly what kind of woman owned it: powerful, connected and a lot more observant than she let on.

Catra hated it on sight.

Not because it wasn't beautiful- because it very clearly was. Opulent gardens, a music room with seven harps, silk screens depicting the myth of the Warrior of She-Ra, in threads of gold and sapphire. But everything about it felt…observed. As though the house was already judging her before she had even taken her boots off.

She said none of this aloud, of course. She never did.

Instead, she stood besides her mother, Cyra, with her hands folded behind her back and her eyes downcast as Lady Light Spinner greeted them at the door with her usual crystalline smile.

"Lady Cyra," Light Spinner purred, pressing cold lips to both of Cyra's cheeks. "You've not changed in the slightest. Is that cinnamon I smell? Always such warmth when you walk in."

Cyra accepted the compliment with a nod, her spine straight and her eyes like polished amber. "Brightmoon has grown sharper since last I was here," she said. "I hope your walls are still thick enough to keep the worst of the gossip out."

Light Spinner's laugh trilled like crystal wind chimes. "Oh darling. The gossip *starts* inside these walls."

She turned then to Perfuma, who curtsied with practiced grace, and then to Catra, who gave a short, polite nod.

"And this must be Catarina," Light Spinner said, her voice laced with approval and something more calculating. "Your eldest."

Catra forced a tight smile. *Catarina.* She hated that name- it was the name embroidered on childhood dresses and scrawled on letters sent to people who barely remembered her. She hadn't used it in years.

"Catra is fine," she said, quietly.

Cyra's gaze sharpened, warning.

Light Spinner ignored it entirely. "Your mother says you have been quite the tutor. Perfuma is as polished as any Brightmoon debutante I've ever seen- instruments, languages, court dancing- even graceful archery." She smiled at Perfuma. "I'm impressed."

Perfuma blushed prettily. "Catra has taught me everything."

Light Spinner's eyes slid back to her, calculating. "Everything?"

"I wouldn't say everything," Catra said. "But enough to get by without embarrassing us."

Light Spinner's smile deepened. "You trained your sister better than most governesses in this court. And tell me- what about *you* , dear? Will you be seeking a match this Season as well?"

Catra stilled.

She would actually rather chew on the crystals that adorned every tower in Brightmoon than to ever have to seek a match this season. The people of Brightmoon were much too rigid in their tradition- too polite and too boring. She knew that Perfuma's type was here: boring, homely and stable. She wanted something that would be uncertain and didn't care for monotony or riches. She only had been in Brightmoon for a couple of hours but she already had taken note of the snooty, rich vibes of the ton- and knew her future wife would not be among these.

Her fingers curled slightly in the fabric of her coat.

"No," she said smoothly. "I'm not here for that. I only want my sister to find someone worthy of her."

"Worthy," Light Spinner repeated, amused. "A bold word."

"She deserves a love match," Catra continued, ignoring the tilt of Cyra's head and the flick of her fan, both warnings to be less… pointed. "But I also hope for someone with a steady family name, sound investments, trade interests, and the ambition to build a future. She's bright. She needs someone who sees that."

Perfuma smiled at her gently, her eyes full of that trusting warmth that always left Catra slightly unmoored.

Light Spinner considered her carefully. "And you? You wouldn't want those things for yourself?"

Catra forced a pleasant laugh. "I'd rather be free."

She didn't mention her late mother, Melendy. Didn't mention the kind of love she had witnessed between both Cyra and Melendy that didn't ever leave room for ballrooms and calling cards. Didn't mention how small she already felt in this foreign place, in these silks and ridgid courtesies.

Cyra's hand briefly brushed hers– a rare show of softness. But when Catra glanced at her, her mother's face was unreadable.

“Well,” Light Spinner said, with a flick of her sleeves, “we shall see what Brightmoon brings. Your welcome ball will be tomorrow, and the Queen will be in attendance- as most of the ton, Best that we all get our beauty rest.”

Perfuma nodded, her golden Halfmoon sari rustling gently as she turned toward the grand stair. “I’ll go choose my jewels for the morning.”

When the sisters were alone at last, walking the candlelit corridor to their rooms, Catra glanced at her.

“Are you ready for this, sister?” she asked.

“Only if you are with me.” Perfuma said, taking her hand and squeezing it.

“Always.”

Chapter 2: The diamond of the season

Chapter Summary

> The Driluths are introduced to the queen, Catra overhears Adora's requirements for a bride and takes offence to them, the queen names a diamond of the season.

Chapter Notes

> Okay so you may see some direct quotes from s2 Bridgerton but its not going to be the exact same. I probably won't focus on side characters outside of the romance.

The ballroom in Lady Light Spinner’s mansion had been transformed into a beautiful dream.

Climbing vines wreathed the soaring white columns, twining up towards the vaulted ceilings which were carved into the scenes of moon phases and royal triumphs. Pale marble gleamed underfoot, polished so finely it caught reflections like a pool of light. Fragrant sprays of purple wisteria and starlight blossoms draped from balcony rails, whilst floating lanterns shimmered gently against the vast windows, their glow caught in the gilded trim of the walls.

A decorative waterfall gurgled softly in the far alcove, catching the pale light and diffusing it like crystal. Music drifted through the air, delicate and harp-led, as if the very palace itself were humming in welcome.

Among the glittering guests, the Halfmoon delegation made their entrance.

Perfuma walked ahead, adorning herself in a pale silk kameez, embroidered with delicate silver vines and scattered pearl accents that gleamed against her tan skin. Her arms were dusted with intricate mehndi patterns that twined up her arms much like the vines of the ballroom, and her hair was pinned into a curly updo,

held in place by floral pins that shimmered when she turned her head. A pair of delicate jhumkas brushed her cheeks.

Catra followed beside her, composed but observant. Her deep purple kameez was a stark contrast to that of her sisters, bearing gold threadwork along the sleeves and hem- subtle yet unmistakable. She wore crisp white gloves and a decorative gold jewellery piece that laid centre of her forehead, the gold catching the light like a star against her dusky skin. Her eyes, feline and piercing, flicked across the crowd with an assessing calm.

Light Spinner stood just ahead of them, regal as always, dressed in a midnight gown and bearing the self-satisfied look of someone who knew her presence still held sway in the court. She approached the throne where Queen Angella stood with her attendants, and offered a graceful bow.

"Your Majesty," she said. "May I present my honored guests from Halfmoon: Lady Cyra Driluth, Miss Catrina Driluth, and Miss Perfuma Driluth."

Queen Angella's eyes narrowed ever so slightly.

"Lady Cyra," she said coolly. "A high honor indeed, to be a guest of Lady Spinner's. I only wish your departure from Brightmoon had been half as gracious as your return."

Catra bristled slightly, at the harshness of the words directed towards her mother.

Cyra's face, warm and expressive, flickered with restrained pain. Her eyes met the Queen's, but she curtsied low, replying with simple formality.

"Your Majesty, Brightmoon is as beautiful as ever, I did miss it so."

"Indeed," Angella said. "Though some of us recall its beauty was not enough to keep you here."

With that, the Queen turned and moved on, her silken train trailing behind her like a banner of frost. The courtiers around them stirred slightly and yet no one missed the sting of the words.

Cyra's mouth drew tight and her gaze flickered to the floor in shame. Light Spinner didn't miss this and leaned towards her whispering "She'll come around. We always did like a challenge, didn't we?" Her smirk was stretched wide and Catra would have thought she was a Magicat in a past life.

Catra said nothing. She only noted the way Perfuma held herself a little straighter, smiled a little more brightly.

Later, while the room spun with dances and champagne flowed like nectar, Catra hovered by the carved arch of the ballroom doors, watching.

Her sister stood in a radiant pool of candlelight and lanterns, the glow unmistakable- and being introduced to suitors one by one. Her smile was soft and practiced, her laugh like wind chimes, and warmth settled in Catra's gut knowing she would do well here, not just in the marriage market, but eventually when she would settle down in Brightmoon.

"She certainly is beautiful," came a voice beside her. Light Spinner again, ever watchful.

"She is," Catra replied, proud despite herself.

"She will be noticed by many this season," the woman added, then turned her attention towards a cluster of nobles by the side stairs. "Have any suitors been deemed notable by you yet?"

Catra blinked, turning her attention to the cluster of nobles and her eyes widened. The tall, broad-shouldered woman from the morning ride now stood at the center of a small polite crowd. She wore a tailored navy coat embroidered with silver thread, the Grayskull crest just visible at her collar. Her blonde hair was tied neatly, and her expression was unreadable, lips pressed firm, blue eyes scanning the room like a soldier on a battlefield. Something

about her thick furrowed brows and slightly serious expression made Catra squeeze her legs together and inhale sharply.

“That,” Light Spinner nodded subtly. “Is Viscount Adora Grayskull.”

“I know her,” Catra said under her breath. “We met. Briefly.”

“Then you’ve quite the eye,” Light Spinner said, sounding pleased. “Viscount Adora is wealthy, well connected, serious and her family is among the most respected in Brightmoon. She’s hoping to marry this season- would be the first in her family to do so… Legitimately of course.”

Before Catra could ask any further questions about that, Perfuma sauntered over and her gaze flickered to where both women’s were. “Wow…” she breathed, “she’s very handsome.”

“She is,” Catra agreed, too quickly., swallowing the thick knot in her throat.

Before she could say more, a young baron approached Perfuma and bowed, asking for a dance. Perfuma accepted graciously and drifted into the crowd, a flurry of silk and charm.

Catra remained where she was, eyes still drawn to Adora.

The Viscount was clearly attempting to court. She spoke to one woman after another, her brow furrowed with what clearly was forced interest. She asked polite, stiff questions about language and philosophy, her mouth twitching with visible frustration as she received only surface-level answers and giggles in reply. Eventually, her shoulders raised and grew rigid, as she turned away, murmuring a stiff excuse and striding out onto the wide balcony that overlooked the glowing city.

Catra hesitated, only a beat, then followed.

She passed through the tall glass doors just as a group of lords and barons stood near Adora, laughing over some shared jest. Her laugh was mesmerising.

"-It is not merely that. If I must tie myself down to the shackles and pains of marriage," Adora said tightly, "the lady should have more to recommend her."

"Don't tell us you want to fall in love, Viscount?" One baron jeered, swirling his wine.

"Love?!" Adora all but scoffed. "Love is the last thing on my mind. But if I am to marry, I'd like a woman to have wit about her. A pleasing face, quiet manners– someone who might raise my children with some sense. It should not be so hard to find!" She complained.

Catra felt her stomach tighten with something akin to revulsion. She couldn't believe she was somewhat charmed by the woman. The Viscount spoke as though she were selecting livestock- listing off her requirements with a cool detachment: agreeable, educated, capable of bearing children. As if that were the full measure of a woman's worth.

It was galling- infuriating really! This woman- so certain of her own superiority- believed that no one in this ballroom could possibly be her equal. That no one had the wit to challenge her, impress her or move her. She wore the title of Viscount like armour, but it had been inherited, not earnt. What had she done, truly, to deserve it? Nothing but being born into the right name, the right blood.

And she still stood there, confident that all the world should bend to her preference, as though her only problem in life was choosing which woman had the widest hips to bear her sickeningly blonde children.

Catra's jaw tightened. What arrogance.

"Wait until the Queen names her Diamond," another said. "You'll know when you see her."

The group chuckled and drifted away down the stairs.

Catra remained hidden in the shadow of the balcony's ivy-covered pillar, fuming. She waited until they passed, but as she turned to slip away, her elbow knocked a crystal centerpiece from its side table.

It toppled against the marble.

Adora spun around and their eyes met.

Catra froze- not really knowing what to do about her position and eavesdropping being compromised. Adora's expression shifted from shock, recognition and then something else.

"You…I didn't expect a lady such as yourself to be in attendance here." She said.

Normally that wouldn't be an offensive statement to Catra, but after hearing the drivel the Viscount had just gone on, it infuriated her.

"A lady such as myself? And pray tell me, Viscount, what sort of lady do you deem me to be?" She sneered, walking closer to the woman. "A lady with acceptable wit? With wide enough hips?"

Adora's eyes widened and she shook her head with stern conviction. "You should not have eavesdropped. That was not for your ears."

"You were speaking loud enough for anybody passing by to hear, proclaiming your many requirements for a wife that frankly-"

"You take issue with my requirements?" Adora pressed, her brows furrowing.

"I take issue with any requirements that view any woman below herself as breeding stock!"

The Viscount sputtered, going a little red. "I do not view-"

“Tell me Viscount, when you find this woman of genteel manners and suitable breeding- whatever makes you think she will want to accept your suit?!”

“Well if she is smart enough, she definitely will.” Adora crossed her arms and Catra sputtered, definitely not drawn to the way the Viscount’s arms flexed in her navy coat.

“Any woman charmed by you after you open your mouth would be a fool. The only match for your disgustingly large ego, is your forehead.” Catra pushed her finger up and poked at the Viscount’s forehead, pushing her back slightly and revelling in the woman’s furrowed brows and sneering face. Her finger buzzed from the contact and she frowned even deeper, angry at the way her body was responding to this infuriating woman.

“Y-You are-!” Adora growled, her left eye twitching at Catra’s boldness. Catra merely sneered at her and then turned away, stalking down the steps to the ballroom once more.

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“Perfuma-” Catra barked out as she stalked down the steps, calling for her sister who was in the middle of dancing with some random gentlewoman.

“Yes, sister?” She called back, stepping away from the woman and curtseying.

“Make haste, we are leaving.” She growled out, stalking towards Lady Light Spinner.

“Ah Catrina, come here,” Light Spinner called, her hand going to curl around Catra’s arm, before Catra stepped back. “ I wanted to introduce you to Marlena Gra-”

“Charmed.” She nodded at the woman before dismissing her. “Lady Light Spinner, we are retiring early. I have come to realise we are extremely unprepared for this as of yet and would like to retire to the drawing board to further navigate this lion's den.”

“Catrina do not make a hasty decision. You are clearly upset and you’d be a fool to make a scene.” She hissed, keeping her voice low but her grip almost bruising on Catra’s wrist.

“I am not making a scene. Leaving now will make Perfuma seem more desirable and we can just excuse ourselves. The Queen has already left and the ton will gossip about anything regardless. My Mama and sister are already in the carriage, I will wait for you there.” She said, rushing off once again.

“It seems we both have our hands full, this season.” Lady Marlena said to Light Spinner after Catra had stalked off.

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The morning light spilled through the tall arching windows of Light Spinner’s estate, gilding the carved stone walls in warm hues of gold. The manor bustled with anticipation, maids fluttering through the halls carrying silk-wrapped boxes and crystal combs, voices rose in every room, and even the marble floors seemed to be echoing the nervous excitement in the air.

Perfuma sat in the drawing room, her back ramrod straight on the embroidered chair, nodding obediently as Lady Light Spinner paced before her.

“You mustn't tilt your chin so high, girl! It looks arrogant and unbecoming. Lower- yes! Like that. And remember to smile with mainly your eyes if someone flatters you- a full teethed smile is far too eager. You must learn to be subtle, dear. Subtlety is the language of the ton.”

Perfuma nodded again, ever serene, her hands resting in her lap, rings glinting gently in the light.

“And tonight,” Light Spinner glowered, folding her hands behind her back, “there must be none of last week’s drama. No surprise departures. No scowling sisters lurking near the doors about to have a hissy tantrum.”

Catra, who had just entered with a tray of sweets, rolled her eyes so hard it was a wonder they stayed in her skull.

"I don't scowl," she muttered.

"You glower," Light Spinner corrected, not even turning to look at her. "And the Queen *does* take note of glowering."

"I wasn't even in the ballroom," Catra replied, biting into a dried apricot and flopping unceremoniously onto a nearby settee. "I was outside. With the horses."

"Exactly," Light Spinner sniffed.

Cyra cleared her throat from where she stood near the window, arms crossed. Her expression was soft but firm.

"Tonight is important, *Catarina.* The Queen is rumoured to name a Diamond. Don't you want it to be your dear sister? Don't you want everyone to take note of how special she is?"

At that, the tension in the room crystallized. Perfuma's fingers tightened slightly on her lap. Catra stilled. Even Light Spinner paused.

No pressure, I suppose.

Cyra finally spoke. "A Diamond would be…more than a mere title. It means attention, status and power. Not just for her- but for all of us. We do need that…especially after everything."

Catra looked at her mother. Then at her sister. Perfuma's face was unreadable to most, a picture of grace. But Catra knew that tightness around her mouth, the way she blinked too quickly and the rigidity in her shoulders. Pressure sat around her shoulders like a velvet cloak.

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Later that afternoon, the two sisters retreated to their shared chambers, the sun slanting low and pink through the gauzy curtains. Their trunks lay open, silks spilling over the edges like water, makeup and jewellery strewn everywhere.

Perfuma stood before the mirror in her pale corset, arms outstretched. Catra moved around her with a focus bordering on reverence, brushing perfumed oil into her skin and hair, the scent of jasmine and sandalwood rising and bringing back her memories.

“I can do the braid,” Perfuma offered.

Catra snorted. “Your partings are always crooked.”

They both smiled at that.

Catra carefully combed out Perfuma’s honey-gold curls, working slowly from the ends. Then, with deft fingers, she braided the hair into a thick plait down her sister’s back, tying it with a ribbon of silk.

Together, they picked out Perfuma’s sari- a luminous olive green silk embroidered with delicate threads of gold and soft pearl. It shimmered with every movement, the border etched in floral patterns that mirrored the mehndi already drying on her arms, vines curling down her wrists to her fingertips.

Catra helped wrap the sari around her, folding the pleats perfectly at the waist, the pallu draped over Perfuma’s shoulder like a waterfall of moonlight.

“You look like a true dream.” Catra said softly, fastening the golden jhumkas to her sister’s ears. “They won’t know what hit them, Fuma.”

Perfuma turned, studying herself in the mirror, then looked at Catra.

“I couldn’t do this without you.”

“You don’t have to,” Catra replied.

There was a beat of silence.

“Do you think the Queen will choose me?” Perfuma asked.

Catra stepped back, taking her in fully. “If she has eyes in her head, she will.”

And as dusk fell over Brightmoon, the manor came alive with carriages, lanterns, and distant music. But in that quiet room, Perfuma stood like the heart of something blooming.

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The ballroom glittered like starlight trapped in crystal.

Gold detailing shimmered along the walls and vaulted ceilings, chandeliers of cut glass rained warm across the polished marble floor. The Queen’s palace was always astonishing, but Adora didn’t find it in her to look around all that much. She had been her often as a child, playing with Princess Glimmer and the royal librarian’s son, Bow.

She stood stiffly at the edge of the dance floor, her hands clasped behind her back in the way of a soldier, not a suitor. Her jaw was set, her collar felt too tight and the wine in her glass was no longer bubbly.

She had already danced with two ladies that evening, and each conversation had passed with absolutely no warmth or feeling. She understood most women weren’t often schooled in the same ways she had been. She was schooled with privilege, an abundance of books at her disposal, language tutors and horse riding instructors. She understood not everyone had these privileges, but was it so much to ask for someone who knew how to point to Brightmoon on a globe? Or someone who at least knew Etheria was *round…*

None of them could hold her interest, not for longer than a minute. And yet, she smiled—stiff, polite, unreadable.

Next to her, Adam playfully nudged her with his elbow. "Is there anyone here you haven't offended yet?" He asked cheerfully. "Or anyone you haven't ruled out for their lack of wit, manners or fertility?"

Adora scowled. "I haven't offended anyone," she muttered.

A boldfaced lie- she had literally gotten screamed at by a Magicat last ball.

"Not with words. With your entire... energy? Yes."

Adora turned to him, lips thinning. "You see anyone who fits my list yet?"

Adam laughed softly and gestured at the crowd with his goblet. "I see a lot of people trying to be exactly what you're looking for. That's not the same thing, is it?"

She didn't reply.

She exhaled and looked out at the ballroom again, her gaze scanning over curled hair and expensive jewelled crowns, practiced, stiff laughter and carefully veiled glances. The pressure prickled at her neck just like her too tight collar. Her future was supposed to be here- standing in this room, smiling with the right woman, securing her family's palace. The Viscount Grayskull's wife should be one of these lovely, eligible, well-groomed women.

And yet.

Her mind wandered- unbidden and unwelcome- to the woman from the forest, all wide eyes, sharp teeth and thunder in her voice. Her hair had been wind tossed and carefree, her posture defiant. No curtsies, soft smiles or politeness. She had challenged her to a race and won, and then vanished into the mist like something of a myth.

That was until last week- when her carefree hair had been forced into an elegant updo, pinned with garnet pins and wound into a pretty coil. Yet stray, stubborn curls had already broken free, framing a face carved from fierce intent, high cheekbones and a slanted snarl. Her eye was the colour of sunlit amber and the other of blue oceans- she had never seen eyes like that even on her travels. All the wilderness Adora had tasted on that misty morning seemed caged now, beneath silk and etiquette- until she spoke of course.

Even though she was crude, unwilling to hear Adora out and quite frankly- mannerless; Adora still had felt her heart stutter at the woman who had all but screamed at her. No one had ever spoken to her with such abrasiveness, and that excited her. No one else at this ball had that spark to them- and whilst she really wasn't what Adora wanted in a wife, she was certainly still extremely attracted to her. When she had pushed Adora back by her forehead, Adora had not only sputtered from the sheer audacity and lack of manners, but from the heat that pooled in her chest.

But that was dangerous. She couldn't let her fleeting attraction cloud her judgement on finding her actual wife. A woman who was challenging but more meek, less opinionated and snarky, more soft spoken and with more manners. *Someone that wouldn't insult her forehead.*

"I'll pick whoever the Queen names," Adora said suddenly.

Adam blinked. "What?"

"The Diamond," she said. "If she's the Diamond, she's already the most suitable."

Adam eyed her carefully. "Suitability is a fine way to pick a horse, sister. Not a wife."

"I don't need to love her," Adora said under her breath. "But she'll be the mother of my children. The bearer of my family name. That should mean something."

Adam didn’t argue. He simply sipped his wine, looking toward the raised platform at the front of the ballroom.

The orchestra stilled.

A hush fell over the crowd as Queen Angella stood, luminous in silver and sapphire, the pale halo of her hair swept up like the moon crowned her.

“The Season has already began with its usual frills, gossip and favour,” she said smoothly, her regal air clouding the ballroom. “But as of yet, I had found myself uncharmed.”

The tension in the room was palpable.

“Until now.”

A rustle of anticipation.

“Tonight, finally, one debutante has caught my eye. Not only with her beauty but with her display of grace, composure and her promise.” Queen Angella’s smile curved like a secret. “This Season’s Diamond is to be…”

The air was thick and you would be able to hear a pin drop.

“Miss Perfuma Driluth of Halfmoon!”

A flurry of gasps, applause, and quickened whispers filled the ballroom.

Adora snapped her gaze to look at the girl who was ushered forward in an olive silk sari that caught the light like a tide pool. Her hair was braided in a glossy rope with flowers adorning it, and her arms shimmered with henna. She moved with the quiet assurance of someone being watched with a light blush dusting her cheeks. She seemed coy and honestly shocked she was chosen, and Adora smiled to herself.

Beautiful, Adora thought*. Graceful. She looks capable.*

She began to make her way through the crowd, determined to reach her first and make herself known. How she had not met this woman yet, she did not know.

Just as she stepped into the Queen's path, Angella turned and smiled at her warmly. "Viscount Grayskull, how convenient. You know I was just telling my daughter about your impeccable dance skills you have displayed this season. She could learn a thing or two from you."

Adora bowed with impeccable form. "Your Majesty flatters me."

She was introduced at once. "Miss Perfuma Driluth," said the Queen, gesturing with a hand of subtle command. "Viscount Adora Grayskull. I believe the two of you will get along splendidly."

Perfuma turned to her and seemed to blush when their eyes met. Her gaze seemed to fight against her thoughts as she checked Adora out, appraising her and seemingly her figure. Adora smirked cockily, and Perfuma gulped when she was caught. "It is a pleasure to meet you, Viscount."

Perfuma turned toward her and curtsied with effortless elegance. Adora offered her hand. "The pleasure is mine."

As they moved to take their place for the next dance, Adora felt all eyes on them, noble families, suitors, dukes, duchesses and royalty.

From the edge of the ballroom, a pair of mismatched eyes watched her.

But Adora had not yet noticed.

Not yet.

Chapter 3: I always get what I want.

Chapter Notes

> OKAY someone called me unemployed cuz I update too frequently...
> I JUST finished full time education guys like the other week please let me live... I haven't even graduated yet.
> god forbid a girl has a hobby dang...
> Plus I write a shit ton in one day and then separate them into separate chapters and post them individually...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The floor shimmered beneath their shoes, candlelight casting golden veins across the marble floor like magnum beneath the stone. Perfumed air clung to her collar. The violins sang their way into a familiar waltz as Adora stepped forward, every move calculated, rehearsed and precise, until she was facing the Diamond of the Season directly.

Perfuma turned to her, soft and expectant, a look of quiet wonder in her brown eyes.

“My lady,” Adora murmured, offering her arm.

Perfuma accepted with a smile like honey and jasmine.

Adora had danced dozens of times in her life, at family gatherings, at galas, at state functions in Brightmoon, but this was the first time the air between her and her partner had actually felt charged with curiosity, scrutiny and somewhat teetering just outside the bounds of mere obligation.

“You dance well,” Perfuma said as they swept into motion, silk trailing like water around her feet.

“So do you,” Adora replied. “Though I admit I’m far better with a sword.”

Perfuma giggled. “I should hope you’re not challenging me to a duel, Viscount.”

Adora smiled, though her mind was already moving ahead of the beautiful woman in front of her. She studied Perfuma closely, not her face yet, but her poise, the fluidity of her turns, the modesty of her dress and her sparkling jewels. She looked every inch deserving of the Diamond title.

But Adora needed to know more than the surface shine, if she was to wed her.

“Do you play any instruments?” she asked, twirling Perfuma elegantly.

“I do,” Perfuma smiled without hesitation. “The harp, violin, sitar and some flute- though in that, I am not particularly talented.”

Adora smiled to herself, *check*.

“So you play because you enjoy it?”

“Yes, creating a melody is extremely fulfilling. But also, I believe that having talents to show for yourself is also important.” She nodded seriously.

Adora hummed thoughtfully, realising she heavily agreed. “And hobbies? I mean—beyond your accomplishments.”

Perfuma smiled, widely as though she had been asked an unusual question. “Archery! I play with my sister often but she is much better than me- though I still thoroughly enjoy it. I enjoy needlework, reading and poetry- especially the emotive kind.”

Adora blinked. “The emotive kind?”

“Well, anyone can write about their surroundings, it takes real craft to convey emotion.”

Adora didn’t expect that. And it stirred something, an itch of respect she hadn’t quite anticipated.

She glanced around, noting the watchful eyes of the court, the queen seated high above them. The gold detail in Perfuma’s sari caught the light as they turned, and Adora forced herself to ask the next, more pointed question.

“Children,” she said softly. “Would you want them?”

Perfuma’s brows raised slightly but she did not look undeterred. “I would,” she said. “Three or perhaps maybe even four, I’ve always liked the idea of a full table and children bickering. My sister and I were so focused on duty and proprietary that we did not really bicker or have childlike wonders- I should want something different for my children.”

Adora smiled at her earnestly for the first time that night, causing Perfuma to go a few shades darker.

“I would want that for my children too.”

They twirled again, skirts flaring.

Perfuma's gaze lingered just a moment too long on Adora's jaw, tracing the sharp angle of it with open curiosity. Adora caught it, and for once, didn’t flush, only straightened her spine slightly and allowed herself a flicker of satisfaction.

But it was Perfuma who broke the silence next.

“And…” she said, voice softer now, her eyes lifting to meet Adora’s with something like quiet steel beneath the warmth, “what would you expect for a wife?”

Adora blinked. The question landed with more weight than she’d expected.

“I understand,” Perfuma continued, her words careful but sincere, “as Viscount, you would be busy often. I understand you’d have a

deep responsibility on your shoulders, not just to your house, but to your future heirs. To the city. To tradition."

She paused briefly. "You'd need an upstanding wife. One who would not embarrass you, not falter under pressure. But beyond simply… finding her, what would you expect of her? What *qualities* would she need, to truly be Viscountess?"

Adora exhaled slowly, caught off guard by the earnestness of the question, and how precisely it struck at the thoughts that had haunted her for weeks.

"I suppose…" she began, gaze fixed just above Perfuma's shoulder as they turned through the waltz again, "she would have to be intelligent. Not just book-smart, but capable of holding a conversation that means something. Someone who could advise me, challenge me, if needed. I may carry the title, but the household is shared."

Perfuma nodded once, attentively.

"She'd need to be kind. But not soft. I don't have room for softness- not in the way society would want it. She must be composed, capable and have a steady sense of duty. Someone who doesn't shy away from expectation or wither in the spotlight."

Perfuma's mouth twitched, just a little, almost self-deprecating.

"She should like children, of course. Be willing to raise them with affection, discipline, and pride. I would never leave her to do it all alone. But I can't lie, I would rely on her somewhat, more than maybe other barons would."

Perfuma looked thoughtful. Not intimidated. Not overwhelmed.

"And love?" she asked, lightly. "Does that factor in?"

Adora was quiet for a beat.

“I don’t expect it,” she said at last. “Not as the foundation, no. I want… respect. Friendship, if I’m lucky. Affection, ideally. But love?” She shook her head, just slightly. “That’s a risk. I don’t want to give someone that kind of power over me. Not when so many depend on what I choose.”

Perfuma tilted her head, but there was no judgment in her gaze, only understanding.

“Well,” she said, her voice lilting again with a smile, “it sounds like you don’t want a Viscountess. You want a co-ruler.”

Adora blinked.

And then she laughed, quiet and sharp, because that was *exactly* what she wanted, and had never quite put into words.

“Yes,” she said simply. “I think I do.”

They slowed, the waltz drawing to a close. Perfuma’s hand lingered briefly in hers before slipping away. As they stepped back, bowing politely, Adora studied her once more, the flush on her cheeks, the glow of confidence beneath the polished exterior.

She could see it now.

Perfuma had been trained for this. But she was not *playing* at it. Sure she clearly felt the pressure from being named a Diamond, but she truly could be the perfect match.

She could very well be the answer Adora had been looking for.

“You didn’t find my line of questioning untoward? Offensive?”

Perfuma giggled a little, and Adora smiled, realising she felt affection towards the woman.

“I think…knowing what you want is rare in today’s society. It is admirable. That speaks more for a future wife than half of the compliments I have heard tonight.”

Adora blinked.

Perfuma smiled gently. “I understand the burden of it. You don’t just need a companion, you need a partner. One who can hold her own. One who understands duty, and grace.”

The words struck deeper than they should have. For a moment, Adora faltered in her step.

She steadied, aware again of the beat of the music, of the polished hands on her shoulders, of the eyes on them both. Her gaze fell- briefly and foolishly- to the elegant line of Perfuma’s throat, her Adam's apple, the gleam of pearls dusted along her collarbone and the oil that sheened her skin.

“You do look beautiful tonight.” She admitted, almost hesitant to compliment her.

Perfuma’s lashes fluttered. “Thank you, my lady. You look rather... handsome yourself.”

Adora went a little red, coughing lightly. “Thank you.”

The dance drew to a close. As they stepped apart, bowing slightly, Adora felt the weight of a decision beginning to settle on her chest.

Perfuma had answered every question with grace. She was composed. Intelligent. She had a sense of duty and just enough warmth to make the edges of responsibility soften.

“Do you have a parent I should speak to?” Adora asked finally, the anxiety bubbling a little in her chest.

“I have my mother but…she doesn’t really answer for me. My sister is the person you have to impress.”

Adora smiled, Perfuma’s sister sounded rational and far less scary than any overbearing mother or father could be.

“Very well, would you lead me to her?”

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Well this certainly complicated things.

As Perfuma led her through the crowd, the light and color parting around them like waves, Adora felt her gaze instinctively drawn toward the small cluster waiting ahead. Her steps slowed just a fraction.

Standing besides an elegant older Magicat woman in pale silk and silver thread, the younger figure was unmistakable. Adora recognised her instantly, though the version of her standing there was composed and stately, a far cry from the wild temptress she’d met on horseback or the sharp-tongued audacious woman she had met on the balcony.

Her hair was swept into an intricate braided bun, dark waves pinned with gold combs, but there was still something untamed in the way a few strands curled against her cheekbone. The tikli on her forehead glittered like a blade in the low candlelight. She was dressed in a deep crimson and Adora wondered if it was deliberate. Her chin was titled and jaw clenched as though she was prepared to argue with the entire ballroom if it came to that.

Her sister blinked angrily, clearly caught off guard as Perfuma brought Adora forward, hopefully. Her eyes widened ever so slightly before narrowing, a flicker of disbelief flashing across her expression before she masked it again with a clipped, polite smile that did not reach her eyes.

Adora straightened, suddenly and inexplicably nervous.

She was Viscount Grayskull, the Queen’s own childhood friend’s daughter, heir to the oldest houses in Brightmoon, inheritance of a large fortune and more educated than most her peers- yet under the heat of the woman’s stare, she felt vaguely like a misbehaving schoolgirl.

This was the woman who had challenged her to a race on horseback, who had reprimanded her for classism, who had insulted her forehead and who had been on Adora's mind since the first time she saw her.

This was the woman who, for reasons entirely her own, *did not like her* .

And Adora had never found herself so inexplicably drawn to anyone.

"Ah, Viscount Grayskull."

The voice came from just behind her shoulder, smooth, measured, and unmistakably amused. Adora turned to find Lady Light Spinner, regal in midnight silk, watching her with an arched brow and a knowing smile.

"I see you've become acquainted with Lady Perfuma," the older woman said, hands folded neatly at her waist. "Is she someone you find… intriguing?"

Adora hesitated. Her eyes flicked to Perfuma, radiant in gold and pink, then to the figure standing just beside her, the sharp-eyed woman with a jaw set like carved stone, who had already begun shaking her head. Subtly. Firmly.

Adora swallowed nervously, but felt a spark of determination to challenge the woman.

"Lady Light Spinner, I—yes. Lady Perfuma is—"

"No," the other woman said at once, tone clipped and cold.

"Catrina," Lady Light Spinner hissed under her breath, her smile faltering as she glanced at her.

Catrina ?!

Adora blinked. That… didn't suit her at all.

Catrina sounded like a name one would whisper politely in drawing rooms, a name written on stiff calling cards and spoken with curtsies. It was wrong for someone with wild hair and sharper eyes.

“Apologies,” She said, her tone still seething but tight with politeness. “I was under the impression we were still considering other offers.”

Perfuma gave a mortified laugh. “Catra-”

Catra…now that suited her much better.

“No need to rush,” she continued, stepping neatly between them. “After all, the *Season* has barely begun, has it not? I would hate for my sister to make such a... hasty decision.”

Adora opened her mouth to respond, but for once, words didn’t arrive. Her spine remained straight, her hands calmly folded behind her back, but inside, something flickered- heat, amusement and determination. Not quite anger but nothing akin to politeness.

Light Spinner gave a dark chuckle and turned quickly to try smooth things over. “My apologies, Viscount. You must forgive Miss Driluth. She is quite…devoted to her sister’s future. Almost ferociously so.”

“Yes,” Adora said, leveling her gaze at Catra. “I can see that.”

Their eyes met. For a moment, the ballroom noise faded to a murmur behind them. Adora felt her heart beating faster in what she believed was slight attraction but mostly challenge. She already did not like Catra despite whatever surface level attraction she felt. How she and Perfuma were related was simply baffling. Perfuma looked helplessly between them, caught in the awkwardness of two forces bristling on either side of her.

“Your concern is admirable,” Adora added, cool but clipped. “Truly. It’s just unfortunate that it comes at the expense of basic

manners.”

Catra smiled, slow and biting. “And it’s unfortunate that your idea of courtship involves interrogating a lady like you are buying a well bred horse.”

Perfuma let out a tiny, panicked noise. “I think I need a drink.”

“I’ll get you one,” Catra said, instantly taking her hand and pulling her away.

Light Spinner sighed deeply. “Well. That went as expected.”

Adora watched them go, her heart beating far faster than it should’ve. Marlena’s voice appeared beside her like mist.

“The diamond truly sparkles this season,” her mother said with a warm, diplomatic smile. “And not just her, hm?”

Adora didn’t answer. She was still watching the back of Perfuma’s silk sari fade into the crowd.

And beside her, the wild shadow in purple.

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The next morning, the Grayskull mansion buzzed with its own kind of chaos.

Adora hadn’t even finished her morning tea when Lonnie had burst in with news.

“There’s a line outside the Spinner estate.” She said, leaning against the room’s door frame. “They’re queueing for Perfuma.”

Adora glanced up. “Already?”

“There’s dozens.” Lonnie said, raising her brows. “She must be a real catch. You may want to hurry- if you’re planning to court her that is.”

Adora scoffed. She wouldn't hurry. She had never needed to fight for attention and she certainly wouldn't need to now, not when she had seen Perfuma's eyes spark with interest. She arrived fashionably, if not strategically, late, her waistcoat clean, her gloves immaculately fastened and her horse brushed to shine.

But even from the top of the street, she could see how long the queue had grown. Lords and ladies with polished shoes, their hair slicked and tied, bearing gifts and flowers, letters of intent, or worse, verses of poetry. She sighed, realising that she hadn't even brought much besides herself. When had she gotten so bad at courting?

She was nearly at the steps when the door opened.

And out stepped Catra.

Her mouth was pressed in a line and her gaze was unmistakably sharp as it landed on her. Her gold bangles clinked softly as she crossed her arms.

"Viscount Grayskull," she said, tone clipped. "You're late."

Adora inclined her head. "Fashionably so, I hoped."

Catra snorted, unceremoniously. "Or perhaps deliberately. Do you always plan your movements so precisely?"

"I do try," Adora said, evenly.

"Well then," Catra said, stepping closer, her voice lowering. "Let me save you the effort."

Adora raised a brow.

"My sister does not need a wife who thinks of marriage as a transaction," Catra said, her voice stern and steely. "She is not another tick on your list, nor someone you will entertain for the sole purpose of breeding. And if you dream of hurting her-"

“I wouldn’t dream of it.” Adora rushed out.

“No,” Catra said.

Adora’s mouth opened, just slightly and this time she did feel anger raise.

“Have you even asked what your sister would want? Maybe she is fine in a loveless marriage,” she defended.

“Who would be happy with that?!” Catra laughed, dismissing Adora’s words as ridiculous and irrational.

“I laid it all out for her yesterday and she still seemed interested. She would be taken care of and we would be friendly. She would have a large, happy family and security-”

“She had security, family and friendship in Halfmoon.” Catra sneered, stepping close to her. “She came to Brightmoon to secure a match. I will not let my sister settle for someone who does not love her. For someone who only offers materialistic things. Perfuma deserves everything.”

Adora sighed, knowing that she couldn’t really fault Catra for her views. She would be the same about Lonnie- but she also understood that Lonnie’s choices were her own. And Catra was seemingly difficult purely because she didn’t like the viscount- not because she was a purely bad match for her sister.

Catra was already turning, heading back inside with a swish of silk and attitude.

And Adora, Viscount of House Grayskull, with all her careful plans and noble lineage, stood at the end of the line, rattled.

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“Viscount!” Perfuma gasped as Adora stepped into the room, smiling shyly at her.

Adora smiled despite herself. It was hard to have her guard down around the woman, who seemed to only offer encouraging smiles and wore her heart on her sleeve.

"Lady Perfuma. I apologise for my tardiness, I only hope I didn't keep you waiting too long."

Perfuma patted the space beside her, urging Adora to sit next to her.

"You did keep her waiting *very* long in fact." Catra called out from the opposite of the room, clearly ruffled at her presence. "Not to worry though, it meant Fuma had the opportunity to see what other fish were in the sea."

Adora rolled her eyes and Perfuma caught it, giggling a little shamelessly.

"Ah but I bet there were no *sharks* though." She said, waggling her brows and ripping an exasperated huff from the Magicat.

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Catra didn't like the Viscount. Not even a little. She found her cocky, crass, and far too entangled in business for someone meant to be courting her sister. In another context, maybe Catra would have admired that kind of ambition, might've even seen it in herself. But not for Perfuma. Perfuma, with her wildflower heart and open arms, deserved softness and wonder. She deserved someone who would give her a garden to grow in, not a ledger to manage.

Adora looked good on paper, yes, Catra would admit that, but love wasn't an employment application. And Adora, with her crisp manners and unbending sense of duty, didn't seem capable of sweeping anyone off their feet, let alone keeping up with the kind of love Perfuma needed. Catra didn't want her sister shackled to someone who would vanish into a study for hours on end, who would love her with structure instead of spontaneity. She worried Fuma would be dazzled by the Viscount's looks and miss the

warning signs. That she'd say yes to a life full of schedules instead of smiles, of responsibility instead of romance.

And that, Catra couldn’t accept.

It wasn’t fair that the Viscount wouldn’t really have to court Perfuma like the other suitors. She hadn’t even brought a bouquet of flowers to court her with- and those were Perfuma’s *favourite* .

Yet it didn’t even seem to matter when she looked into Perfuma’s eyes and realised all of her worries would be dismissed. She was already in too deep.

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Perfuma was sat on the edge of the greenhouse bench, bathed in late afternoon light, her hands resting gently in her lap. The floral scent around them was sweet and thick, almost too much for Catra. Who was pacing with a restless sway of her tail.

“You want to do what?!” Catra said, folding her arms tightly and trying to even her breathing.

"I want to court her," Perfuma replied, voice soft but resolute.

“Her as in Adora- Viscount Adora?!”

Perfuma smiled, a little nervously. “Yes. I know what you’re going to say, Catra, but I like her.”

Catra threw up her arms, exasperated. “Of course you do! She’s rich and powerful and good-looking, of course you want to court her.” She snapped, before cutting herself off, regretting the bitterness in her tone. She softened but didn’t back down. “Fuma, you don’t even know her, not really.”

Perfuma swallowed, keeping her tone even despite her sister’s harsh tone. “I would like to have the chance to know her. I know she is kind, she listens when I speak and she is gentlemanly. I know what she expects of me and I know that I can trust her.”

Catra scoffed. “That’s not love. That’s politeness. You can’t marry someone hoping that they’ll fall for you eventually, sister. That’s not how it works.”

Perfuma met her gaze determined. “Maybe not for you, maybe not in Halfmoon. But here marriages of convenience happen, and I cannot fault Adora for doing what is best for her family. Maybe it just takes time with her, maybe stability matters more to me right now than some whirlwind romance.”

Catra’s eyes narrowed. “You have always said you wanted love. When Mama died, you always wished for love like our parents. You deserve that, Fuma. You can find someone who will love you not only for stability and what you offer, but for love. I have seen what happens to people who marry for the wrong reasons- do not let that be you. It is hard to leave marriage without some label being stuck on you.”

Her jaw tensed, the same quiet stubbornness she’d had since childhood, rising to the surface after years of playing the best future wife. “I am not settling. I am choosing. If love comes later, then I should welcome it when it arrives. I won’t dismiss other suitors but I won’t dismiss the Viscount either.”

Catra opened her mouth to protest again, but Perfuma was already standing, brushing pollen from her skirt.

“I know you’re trying to protect me,” Perfuma said gently. “But this is my choice. I want to see where it goes.”

Catra didn’t say anything as Perfuma left the greenhouse, the faint scent of roses trailing behind her like a farewell.

“Dear…” Catra heard, and she spun around to see her mother, walking into the greenhouse.

Cyra had been uncharacteristically quiet this season, letting Catra and Light Spinner take the reigns in Perfuma’s choices. Catra knew it was because she was feeling unsure and anxious about being back in Brightmoon, a place that shunned her when she

decided to marry someone who was a mere shoeshiner. It just made her dislike the place more, the rules and regulations and how quickly they dismissed anyone that went against the norms.

“Mother, if you’re here to lecture me, please spare me-”

“Not a lecture.” She said, quietly. “Just a word of advice.”

Catra nodded, allowing her to continue.

“Being so vehement against Perfuma’s choices will only push her towards the Viscount. You should do more to support her options.”

“But!-”

“No, Kitten.” She said, and Catra paused.

Her mother hadn’t called her that since Mama died, and the sound of it settled in Catra’s chest like a stone. When Melendy passed, whatever tenuous thread had held her and Cyra together snapped. They didn’t know how to grieve, let alone grieve as a family. Cyra had folded inward, retreating behind her bedroom door, emerging only to criticize or correct. And so, by quiet default, the task of raising Perfuma had fallen to Catra. She had become a sister and a mother all at once, still a child herself, trying to hold everything together with scraped hands and a breaking heart.

“Try not to be too hard on her,” she said quietly. “I know, coming from me, that’s laughable. And maybe it’s too late for me to admit I was wrong. But truly… keep her close. I know you want more for her- better, even- and that kind of hope feels like pressure when you’re the one holding the line. But Perfuma’s not a child anymore. She’s her own person. You can only shield her so much. Sooner or later, you have to let her choose. Let her make her own way.”

Catra’s head spun. It felt like she couldn’t even be angry anymore- not when her mother admitted her faults…at least in her own way.

“Okay mother.” She settled on, because her thoughts were running too far to even consider continuing this conversation in a productive way that didn’t involve tears and screaming.

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Adora stood by the fireplace in Adam’s study, cradling a glass of brandy she hadn’t really touched. Her brother lounged in an armchair, sleeves rolled and a book long forgotten on the table beside him.

“She absolutely hates me,” Adora said flatly, looking into the fire.

Adam raised a brow. “The sister?”

She nodded. “Catra. She thinks I’m…too cold, too calculating. That I’ll never love Perfuma. That I’m incapable of romance, apparently.”

Adam snorted. “Didn’t you, yourself, say that you wouldn’t love her?”

Adora rolled her eyes. “I’ll win the sister over. I always get what I want.”

Adam gave her a look. “You mean…you always get *who* you want?”

She grimaced, feeling sheepish. “Y-yeah. Who.”

He tilted his head. “And you want Perfuma?”

She hesitated for a fraction too long. “She’s suitable. Charming. Strong. I admire her.”

Adam hummed, unconvinced, but didn’t press. He’d known Adora long enough to see when she was chasing something for reasons even she didn’t understand yet.

Adora downed the rest of the brandy and set the glass aside. “If it wasn’t a disapproving sister, it’d be a father or a Mama or someone else. There’s *always* someone.”

Adam laughed. “And you love the chase.”

She smirked. “Maybe I just hate losing.”

Chapter End Notes

Adora is a little bit annoying...

Chapter 4: Blossoms

Chapter Summary

> Adora takes Perfuma on a picnic, Princess Scorpia visits Brightmoon this season, Catra has to face that she feels attraction to Adora.

Chapter Notes

> There's some smut at the end of this! It starts where 'Catra tosses the blanket off of her legs' So skip it if you wish! :)

The afternoon sun stretched lazily over the Brightmoon gardens, lighting every petal and blade of grass in molten gold. A breeze rustled the tall hedges, sending sweet-jasmine air through the trees and rippling the silks of Adora’s blouse as she fussed with the corners of the picnic blanket. She had been here for twenty minutes already, adjusting and readjusting the set up, convinced each repositioning would make it a bit more perfect.

Perfuma arrived with sunlight in her smile and a basket on her arm, her bright waves tumbling down her embroidered bodice. She took one look at the setup and beamed, then gracefully knelt beside Adora and placed her hands to the earth.

In a slow, deliberate bloom, soft-petaled flowers of blue, pink and white and purple emerged in a crescent around the blanket, weaving themselves into a ring of colour.

Adora gaped, an unexpected flush covering her cheeks as Perfuma giggled and handed her the same flowers in a new bouquet, urging her to take it.

“I wasn’t aware you were magic.” She said, still slightly awed from the woman.

“Does that help my chances?” Perfuma joked, bringing a chuckle from Adora.

“No, you were already perfect before.” Adora said, not lying one bit.

From a little further away, hidden partially behind a willow tree, Catra lounged on her own blanket, with a book in one hand and an expression that seemed neither smirk or scowl. She kept one sharp ear turned towards them and the other flicked lazily as she pretended not to pry.

They began with sandwiches and soft fruit, moving into discussions on local arts, council affairs and finally, as the sun beat down warmer and Perfuma curled her legs beneath her, the conversation drifted.

“We have talked a lot about me…” Adora started, her voice soft and sincere, “so what is it exactly that you want- in a partner, I mean.”

Perfuma smiled at her softly, her gaze growing even fonder- if that was possible.

“Someone who is calm- steady. Who would wake with me and sit in stillness. Perhaps someone who may do yoga in the morning sun, or meditate through a storm.”

Adora’s eyes widened. Well that certainly wasn’t her…But she could try, right?

Her thoughts were interrupted when a fit of giggles was heard to her left. Her head snapping in that direction, she saw Catra there practically about to throw up from quiet laughter. Her eyes opened then widened as she realised she was caught listening, and also wasn’t laughing as quietly as she thought.

“Sorry- don’t mind me!” Catra called out, her voice a poor attempt at innocence. Her teeth sank into her bottom lip, doing little to hide the grin tugging at the corners of her mouth or the laughter still threatening to spill out. Her eyes sparkled with amusement, betraying just how *not sorry* she actually was.

Adora wanted to say she felt anger at Catra's blatant read on her- how she definitely was not the type to meditate or partake in yoga- but all she really could focus on was her bottom lip being pulled by her teeth.

Instead, she peeled her eyes away from the scene and looked back at Perfuma, who was red at her sister's obvious rudeness.

"I could…learn." Adora said adamantly, hoping to impress Perfuma.

Catra laughed again, this time burying her face in her book to muffle it. It was gorgeous and squeaky and just made everything harder to focus on.

Like her literal *sister* she was *courting* in front of her.

Focus, Adora.

Perfuma was undeterred though, gently touching Adora's hand and smiling. "I like people who try. People who care enough to work on themselves. ." She paused, then added, "Emotional maturity is a rare quality. I think it matters more to me now than it did when I was younger."

"I think I'm getting there," Adora offered quietly. "I want to be the kind of person who shows up. Who doesn't run. Who… listens."

"That's a good start," Perfuma said warmly.

Behind them, Catra didn't laugh this time. She only watched with guarded eyes, the tip of her tail flicking in the grass.

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Not far from the picnic, on an iron bench half-buried in wisteria, Lady Marlena, Light Spinner and Cyra all sipped chilled tea from crystal goblets, their gowns ruffling in the breeze.

“She’s quite infatuated, that one,” Light Spinner mused, nodding toward Perfuma.

Marlena’s smile tightened. “Yes, haha…” she trailed off, “and Adora seems equally…enthusiastic about pursuing her.”

“She’s spoken to you of marriage?” Cyra asked, intrigued.

“She speaks more with her eyes than her mouth,” Marlena said. “But yes, she seems eager to wed this season, find herself a bride and future Viscountess. I only hope true affection blossoms from this. It is still early.”

“Well,” Cyra said with a twinkle in her voice, “Perfuma’s quite good with blossoms. She’ll manage to grow something there.”

Light Spinner chuckled softly. “She seems a miracle with gardens and hearts alike.”

There was a lull and then Cyra’s tone grew intrigued. “And…your other daughter? Your oldest, I mean- Mara was it? I haven’t heard her mentioned in years, did she finally marry?”

Light spinner choked on her tea, coughing and sputtering as Cyra’s eyes grew wide, not realising the question would be so sensitive. It clearly was judging by Marlena’s stiff posture and the tension in the air.

“She left,” Marlena said after a moment, her tone slightly clipped. “Some years ago now, she fell in love with a woman who was-” she swallowed, “-twenty years older…and married already. She divorced him and they eloped - and with them, a portion of our name and reputation went. The scandal didn’t ever quite fade.”

Marlena didn’t really want to mention the scandal to any Mamas of suitors courting Adora, but she figured that they were somewhat owed the information, as it could potentially hurt their family too.

Cyra said nothing at first, but then reached for Marlena's hand, covering it with her own.

"I do not judge," she said eventually. "My late wife, Melendy, was a mere shoe-shiner. When I chose her over the noble my parents had arranged for me, I was cast out. We eloped too- and never looked back."

Something in Marlena's expression shifted, slightly less brittle now, the mask cracking just enough to show the pain beneath.

"I suppose that's what love does," she murmured. "Tears apart the plans we make and demands something truer."

Cyra nodded. "And gives us the courage to follow it."

They sat quietly for a while longer, the three of them watching as Adora fumbled her way through a half-hearted attempt at yoga under Perfuma's guidance, falling over with an embarrassed grin as Perfuma laughed beside her.

"Perhaps there's hope for them yet," Marlena said quietly.

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The moon had begun its slow ascent when Adora had stepped back into the gardens, the heat of the day long since softened into a lavender dusk. A hush had fallen over the estate as evening settled, the guests had retired indoors and the air smelt of moss and wisteria, clean and faintly sweet.

She hadn't meant to wander.

Truly, she had intended to follow Perfuma inside after their picnic, offer to help unpack the basket and maybe steal a final moment with her before their evening ended. But then Perfuma had been swept away by a footman and Adora found herself wandering again, her thoughts too loud and her shoes too quiet.

The soft crunch of gravel beneath her boots guided her to the far side of the garden, where moonlight caught on pale blossoms and illuminated a hedge of star shaped flowers. They glowed faintly, seemingly alive with dew. She paused before them, unsure why they pulled her in so.

“Night jasmine,” a voice behind her said.

Adora turned, already knowing who it was and bracing herself.

Catra stood a few paces away, arms crossed loosely and a slight tilt to her brow. Her hair was out now, wild and carefree, blowing softly in the breeze that made Adora shudder a little.

Yes, the *breeze* made her shudder.

Adora swallowed. “You’ve got a habit of sneaking up on me.”

“Well you are in the garden of the place I reside,” Catra said coolly.

Adora smiled faintly. “I didn’t know the gardens were off-limits.”

“They’re not.” Catra stepped closer, gaze sharp. “But you might want to look less enchanted. You’re drooling on the hedges.”

Was she talking about the look Adora was giving her now or when Adora saw the flowers?

Adora gave a soft, disbelieving laugh. “Do you always talk like that?”

“Only when someone stares at a plant as though that will be their new viscountess.”

“That would be fitting for Perfuma, would it not?”

Catra scowled at her, though it seemed more like a childish pout. She wasn’t too intimidating to Adora now.

“You heard Perfuma today, she wants someone who is the exact opposite of you.”

Adora scoffed. “She did not say that! The things she listed are achievable…” The words felt like lies as soon as she said them.

“You fidget maniacally at any still, quiet moment. Perfuma may have closed her eyes when meditating but I saw you…You could hardly keep still,”

“So what, now I fidget, I am undeserving of your sister?”

Catra’s lips pressed into a thin line. She looked down briefly, then back at her with something unreadable in her expression.

Adora didn’t really know what possessed her then to ask, maybe it was the weight of the day or the way the moonlight curled around Catra’s cheekbones, but she took a step closer.

“Why don’t you like me?” Adora asked quietly.

Catra blinked, caught off guard by the honesty. “I didn’t say I didn’t like you.”

“You’ve said everything but.”

“You’re courting my sister.” Catra defended

“And that’s a problem?” Adora tilted her head. “Because I’m a viscount?”

“No,” Catra said, more softly than expected. “Because I’ve seen your kind before. You want a woman who makes sense on paper. Polished, pleasing, proper. You’ll marry the one who meets your criteria and leave the rest of her unexplored.”

Adora’s jaw tightened. “That’s not fair.”

“Isn’t it?” Catra’s eyes sparked, something hot and bitter stirring. “You have a checklist, Viscount. She’s not an essay to pass.”

"I know that," Adora said, suddenly tired. "I don't *just* want someone who fits a mold. I want someone who will stand beside me. Someone I won't tire of speaking with. Someone who… sees me."

Catra didn't answer. Her eyes flicked over Adora's face, the softness of her jaw, the earnestness in her voice. It would've been easy to mock her again. But instead, she looked away, arms loosening slightly at her sides.

"I suppose," she said eventually, "that's not the worst thing to want."

Adora studied her, really studied her. The way her earrings caught the moonlight, the slant of her mouth when she wasn't smirking, her fank that pressed into her lip, the way her voice had lowered just enough to become something private. And then she realized her gaze had lingered a moment too long.

She looked away, heat rising to her cheeks.

"I should go," Catra murmured, clearing her throat. "Lady Light Spinner will wonder where I've wandered off to."

But Catra didn't move. She just watched her.

And for a second, just a second, Adora wondered what her hands would feel like if she touched her, how that biting voice would sound if it softened against her skin.

But then, a servant's bell rang from the house, and the moment fractured.

Catra turned away without another word, disappearing into the shadows between trees, her braid swinging like a curtain as she vanished.

Adora stood alone in the moonlight, hand tightening at her side.

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The ballroom glittered under a thousand magical orbs, suspended from ornate chandeliers that bathed the marble floor in silvers and whites. Music curled through the air in elegant ribbons, a waltz rippling through the string ensemble, as silk skirts whispered across the floor and laughter floated from glittering corners.

Perfuma was absolutely beautiful in her baby blue silks, her waves pinned half up with woven vines and pearls, making her look almost siren-like. She spun in time with her partner, a polished young baron's daughter, with good posture and a forgettable name. Perfuma was smiling, pleasantly and politely, but her eyes were wandering to the sidelines, where Adora stayed besides Glimmer and Queen Angella.

"She's being very polite," Glimmer whispered, observing the dance.

"That's the third one tonight," Adora muttered.

"She is the diamond," Angella reminded, her tone amused. "It's her duty to dazzle."

"And she does," Adora said, arms crossed too tightly. "Dazzlingly."

Before Glimmer could needle her further, the ballroom hush fell.

A herald stepped forward at the top of the stairs. "Princess Scorpia of the Scorpioni Kingdom" he announced, voice ringing clear.

All heads turned.

The woman who descended was a striking contrast, tall, broad-shouldered, beaming with a nervous kind of cheerfulness. Her snow hair was twisted into a regal braid and her crimson dress shimmered like a flame against her pale skin. At her back, a pair of scorpion pincers, glimmering with oils and polished, twitched faintly with nerves.

Perfuma’s eyes widened as she took in the new arrival, feeling a weird energy bubble in her chest and desperately wanting the woman’s gaze to fall on hers.

But it didn’t.

Scorpia's eyes scanned the crowd eagerly, until they caught on Catra. She crossed the room with more purpose than grace, nearly bumping into two noblewomen as she made a beeline for her, who raised one skeptical brow as the princess halted in front of her.

“Hi!” Princess Scorpia said, flushed yet grinning. “I do hope this isn’t terribly forward but…are you Lady Perfuma? You look to be of Halfmoon.”

Catra blinked. “Wow. No. That’s my sister.” She nodded vaguely toward the center of the ballroom. “She’s dancing.”

“Oh!” Scorpia’s face dropped, but only for a second. “Oh well, she looks very nice. You both do! I just- Uh I thought- I mean—” She cleared her throat. “Would you like to dance instead?”

Catra looked as though the woman had just asked her to jump into a bush filled with stinging nettles.

“I… don’t really do dancing,” she said quickly, tail twitching.

Across the room, Lady Light Spinner, who was watching like a hawk, lifted her glass and glared steadily at Catra.

Catra groaned softly under her breath, taking the hint. “But apparently, I do now.”

She let Scorpia take her hand with a delicate pincer and lead her to the floor.

From their place on the sidelines, Angella leaned slightly toward Adora, her expression unreadable.

“Perhaps Catra will find herself a match this season after all,” she murmured.

Adora’s spine went rigid and she forced herself to breathe evenly.

Glimmer turned to her, questions in her gaze. “Are you… frowning?”

“What? No,” Adora said quickly. “I just- Scorpia doesn’t really seem like her type.”

“So you know Perfuma’s….sister’s type?” Glimmer asked, even more confused.

“No- I just…Princess Scorpia is always said to be dopey and lovely, Catra is…mean.” She defended.

Angella hummed, unconvinced. “Catra seemed lovely when I met her, did you give her a reason to be mean?”

Adora scoffed. “No! She just doesn’t agree with my requirements for a wife- she is simply overprotective and is angry at me as a result of that.”

“She didn’t look at you with anger, that’s for sure.” Glimmer mumbled and Adora frowned, a rosy tint spreading across her face.

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On the dance floor, Scorpia led gently, though she was obviously new to this style of dancing. That wasn’t a problem though, so was Catra. Her steps were heavy, her timing a little off, but her grip was steady and her grin was, admittedly, infectious.

“You know,” she started, as they turned, “it is just so nice to meet another hybrid here. I mean, don’t get me wrong, Brightmoon is stunning and the people are kind but well– I have never seen so many humans all in one place in my life. Sometimes it feels as

though I have walked into a doll shop and I am the only thing not made of porcelain.

Catra let out a laugh, unexpected and real. "Yeah. That's one way to put it."

"And your ears- sorry, is that rude? I just mean to say they are absolutely amazing- and your eyes are different colours and your tail? It is so expressive! I love it."

Catra blinked, caught between horror and amusement. "You're… really bad at hiding things, aren't you?"

"I try!" Scorpia chuckled, then added with more softness, "But I figure if something's worth liking, why not say it?"

Catra was quiet for a beat. Her mouth twitched as she realised she felt a slight fondness at this Scorpioni. She was just about the most tolerable person in this snooty town.

"You're weird."

"I've been called worse." Scorpia beamed.

The two spun, slightly off time with the music, but something about their laughter made the missteps invisible.

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From her vantage point by the refreshments table, Adora's gaze hadn't left them.

Catra and Scorpia. Laughing. Smiling. *Dancing* .

Her fingers clenched around her glass, the cool condensation bleeding into her palm. She told herself she should be watching ***Perfuma*** , surrounded by a rotating orbit of eligible nobles, some of them charming, most of them persistent.

That was where her attention belonged.

Not on Catra.

Not on the soft curve of her smirk, or the way her ears twitched when she laughed, or how the ballroom lights caught the gold in her eye when she glanced up shyly– *shyly!* – at Scorpia.

Something tugged in Adora's chest in the same way it had so many times before with Catra. It was too sharp to be called concern or anger, but too persistent to be written off as nothing.

She told herself it was just protectiveness. A perfectly natural thing. After all, wasn't it normal to feel defensive of one's potential fiancee's sister?

Except that wasn't how it felt.

It felt like... losing something.

"Wrong sister, *idiot!*" Glimmer hissed, materialising beside her like a glittery explosion.

Adora startled. "What?"

"Don't 'what' me," Glimmer said, watching her with narrowed eyes. "You've been glaring at them for five minutes like they owe you money."

Adora blinked. "I'm just being…protective," she insisted, as if that made it sound any less pathetic.

"Oh?" Glimmer said sweetly. "Is *that* why you haven't asked Perfuma for another dance yet? Because she seems to have one eye on the Catra-Scorpia situation too."

Adora looked sharply toward the dance floor.

Sure enough, Perfuma, though graceful and charming in conversation with a handsome duchess, had let her gaze wander to the pair. It was easy to mistake it as curiousness for her sister's

dance partner, but clearly to Glimmer and herself, the gaze on Scorpia's muscular frame was unmistakable.

What is happening?

How had *Scorpia* managed to charm both sisters in under ten minutes?

Adora gritted her teeth. "That's it."

"What's it?" Glimmer asked, but Adora was already storming off, descending the staircase with the dramatic flair of someone on the verge of making either a heartfelt declaration or a terrible mistake.

Poise, Adora. *Poise*.

She found Perfuma by the terrace doors, half-listening to a noble wax poetic about imported teas.

Adora stopped just in front of her, chest rising and falling far too fast for something as simple as asking for a dance.

Perfuma turned to her, brightening at once. "Adora," she said, a warm surprise in her voice.

"I was hoping," Adora said, extending her hand, "you might grant me this next dance."

Perfuma hesitated only a heartbeat, looking up at Adora's rigid expression, then smiled and took her hand.

"I was hoping you'd ask."

They stepped onto the floor, just as the musicians began another waltz, this one slower and more romantic. Around them, couples twirled with effortless grace, and Adora tried to forget the tension she felt from the bumbling fool that seemed to charm the only woman she was interested in this season.

Perfuma, of course.

Perfuma moved easily in her arms, and Adora tried to focus on the feeling of closeness, the floral perfume clinging to her collar, the weight of Perfuma's trust.

"You seem tense," Perfuma said softly.

"I'm not tense," Adora lied.

Perfuma tilted her head knowingly and though she said nothing, her gaze pressed into Adora's. Then, it flickered again, over her shoulder, towards Catra.

"Princess Scorpia seems nice…" She murmured, almost absently.

Adora forced a smile. "She-" Adora almost wanted to lie, to tell Perfuma the woman was actually some scheming Princess out to seduce any likely maiden…but she felt too deceitful. "She does."

"She's interested," Perfuma replied.

Adora's feet faltered for half a step. "In… you?"

Perfuma arched a brow at her and then giggled a little, at Adora's seeming protectiveness.

"In my sister."

Adora didn't answer. Her throat was suddenly dry.

Perfuma, to her credit, didn't press the point. But her smile had dimmed, just slightly, and her attention drifted again.

Behind them, Catra and Scorpia had broken into a fresh laughter, Scorpia's booming and wild, Catra's low and hushed.

It echoed across the polished floor like a *dare* .

Adora swallowed hard.

She could tell herself it didn't matter. That it was good, actually, that Catra had someone to charm her. Maybe now she would stop glaring at Adora and poking too deep into her courtship with her sister, ruining all her efforts to be composed and perfect.

Except Adora kept glancing back.

And Perfuma noticed.

"She is no match for you."

'What?!' Adora thought, was Perfuma something of a mind reader, did she know of her attraction for her sister or-

"I only have eyes for you, Viscount." She whispered, smiling at Adora and attempting to comfort her. It worked somewhat, she was less worried about seeming obvious in her silly crush, one that would *never* be acknowledged, outside of her mind at least.

Adora cleared her throat before plastering on a fake smile. Perfuma was right for her and they were too far deep for Adora to even consider courting anyone else. Reputation, duty and her future was on the line, and that would not be compromised.

"As do I, Perfuma." She said, causing Perfuma to beam widely.

- - - -

Catra tossed the blanket off her legs for the fourth time.

Moonlight bled across the ceiling of her bedroom, quiet and silver. The window was cracked open and the scent of lavender drifted in from the garden, teasing her to lull to sleep, yet even that couldn't calm her.

She should be asleep. The ball had ended hours ago, and she had danced- actually danced, with someone who was kind and interested in her, not sharp tongued, cocky or vexing.

And yet…

Catra let out a low growl and rolled onto her side, squirming and clenching her pillow like it may anchor her. It didn't. All it did was press her deeper into a mess of feelings she did not want to name.

She thought about Scorpia. Her big, bright smile. Her gentle compliments. The way she said she liked Catra's features. The honesty in her voice.

It should have been enough to distract her. To interest her. But every time she tried to picture that ballroom smile again, it got muddled, blurred by another one entirely. One with dimples and that stupid jawline and eyes like the ocean just before sunset.

Adora.

Ugh. *Adora.*

Catra groaned and flipped onto her back, throwing an arm across her eyes and willing the heat that pooled between her legs to calm down. "You are such an idiot," she muttered to herself. "She is courting Perfuma. *Perfuma.* Your sister. Your kind, sweet, perfect sister."

But those images, those stupid persistent images, kept coming back. Adora in her fitted vest and too polished boots. Adora laughing at the picnic, falling out of yoga poses, how her voice sounded low and rough when she said, *I want someone who sees me.*

She had no right to sound so sincere. No right to look at her the way she sometimes did, like she wanted to *understand* Catra, not just tolerate her.

And now every time Catra closed her eyes, she saw *that* Adora. Not the stuck-up Viscount she'd scorned from the start, but the one who flushed when Perfuma handed her flowers. The one who looked so painfully earnest she didn't know whether to mock her or pull her closer.

She exhaled sharply through her nose, ears flattening against her pillow. “Think about Scorpia,” she ordered herself. “Think about the woman who actually liked you. Who didn’t laugh at you or bicker with you every other sentence.”

But her traitor of a brain didn’t listen. It kept looping back to the ball. To the way Adora had watched her dance. Not just watched. *Stared.* Like she wanted to rip Catra from Scorpia’s grip and claim her for herself.

The thought sent something sharp and shameful through her. Guilt. For even *entertaining* the idea. For letting her own head spin around someone who belonged to her sister’s future.

“I don’t like her,” Catra mumbled, eyes still closed. “I *cannot* like her.”

Despite the resistant words, her hands still moved lower, slowly, as though testing the strength of the resolve. Except she had no resolve left, and she was decidedly a very weak woman. Only heat and ache met her fingers. They slipped between her thighs, and the moment they brushed over her swollen clit, she gasped- a hissed sound through clenched teeth, as her hips lifted off the mattress in a desperate arc.

She hadn’t done this in months. Not since the Season had began, not since her world had become too consumed with Perfuma, keeping Light Spinner content and abiding by every damned rule in Brightmoon. Her body had long since been begging for relief, but her mind had never quietened enough, not until now. Or maybe her body hadn’t quietened at all, maybe that was why this need felt so urgent and overwhelming.

The unfamiliar walls of her guest chamber at Light Spinner’s estate felt too close, but her touch distracted her from the nerves. There was something illicit about doing this here, under this roof, where everything was meant to be proper and polished. And yet her fantasies bloomed like wildfire.

She imagined hands that weren’t hers. Rougher. Larger. Confident. She imagined Adora behind her, breath warm on her neck, that determined look in her eyes from the day they first crossed paths in the forest. That same impossible focus she’d worn then, directed now at her.

Catra whimpered, pressing harder. In her mind, it was Adora’s hand between her legs, not her own. Adora’s mouth brushing her shoulder. Adora’s palm at her breast, thumb circling a peaked nipple. She pictured strong arms caging her in, golden hair brushing her cheek, and a voice, deep, low, infuriatingly composed, murmuring something filthy against her ear.

Her breath caught. Her thighs trembled.

“No,” she whispered, shaking her head, but her hips refused the protest. Her body betrayed her, chasing the pressure, grinding into her hand as her need built and coiled and surged.

She tried again to think of Scorpia. The attractive and extremely sweet woman. Her warm compliments, her broad shoulders. Catra kind of liked her. She *should* be thinking of her.

But Scorpia's image wouldn’t stay. It flickered, faded, was eclipsed by the sound of a laugh, *her* laugh, and the memory of sharp blue eyes catching her mid-lie, mid-swoon, mid-something she couldn’t quite name.

Catra moaned, helpless now to stop the wave cresting inside her.

This wasn’t supposed to happen. Not like this. Not with *her* .

And still, she didn’t stop, rubbing feverishly like she was in heat.

The tingle of her orgasm was drawing closer and closer and she rutted shamelessly into her hand, growling at the thought of wider fingers stretching her impossibly, claiming her and burying so deep inside of her she couldn’t think.

“A-Adora!” The name tore from her lips in a gasp, unbidden and raw, as her climax broke over her like a tide.

Her back arched off the mattress, every nerve inside her, alight, hips jerking helplessly as the waves of release pulsed through her. The pleasure hit hard, all-consuming, wetness spilling out of her in a flood that left her trembling and open, breath caught in her throat.

The aftermath was no quieter. Her body twitched as aftershocks rippled through her thighs, her chest rising and falling in frantic rhythm. For a moment, everything was silent, save for the pounding of her heart in her ears and the name that still lingered, shamefully, reverently, in the quiet space she'd created for herself.

Her hand stilled between her legs, slick and shaking.

She closed her eyes, biting her lip so hard it hurt, as the guilt crept in to replace the rush.

Adora .

She had whispered Adora's name.

And even though no one had heard, she felt exposed, like her body had betrayed her, had revealed some terrible truth she’d been trying to bury beneath reason and responsibility.

Catra rolled onto her side, curling in on herself, the sheets sticking to her skin.

What the hell was wrong with her?

Chapter 5: Love just is.

Chapter Summary

Adora grapples with being back in the house where her father had died, and gets a surprise guest.

Chapter Notes

Hi guys! Sorry it's been a while since I updated, I had some writer's block...

Seven years earlier

The sun broke across the lake like a mirror cracked with light, scattering warm ripples across the surface as Adora sat at the edge of the dock, her legs dangling, toes barely brushing the water. She gripped the fishing rod too tightly, jaw clenched in determined frustration.

"I don't think they are coming," she muttered, the words sharp as the stone she kicked into the shallow water. "This is boring."

Behind her, the gentle, deep rumble of her father's laugh rolled through the air.

"Patience, sweet," he said, as he settled beside her, his boots creaking against the wood. "Fishing is just about stillness as it is about luck. You cannot rush a fish. You wait and listen. You learn the rhythm of the stream."

Adora huffed, swinging her rod again. "But we've been here for *hours!* I wanna catch something!"

He leaned forward, dipping his fingers into the cold water. "Then maybe you need to *follow* the stream. The fish move with it. Find the current, find where it leads. Sometimes, to catch what you want, you have to go where it's going… not just where you *want* it to be."

She frowned at that, too big of an idea for her naive brain to fully swallow and much too much effort for her already thin patience, but she obeyed, trudging a few streams downstream and dragging her boots through the mud.

She almost gave up again. *Almost.*
Until the line tugged.
Hard.

Her eyes went wide with excitement, her hands grasping the pole as though it would fly away and reeling in the line with all her strength.

" *Father!* " she cried. "I've got one! A big one!"

He was beside her in an instant, both of them hollering with joy as she reeled in a thrashing, gleaming fish, bigger than her head, silver and spotted and absolutely *real* .

"I *did it!* " she yelled, dancing in the shallows, soaked from the knees down and grinning so wide her cheeks ached.

Her father knelt and ruffled her wet, flyaway hair with one hand, beaming.

"You *did,* " he said. "You were patient. You listened. I'm proud of you, my Adora."

That moment stayed bright in her memory, clearer than everything else that day.

They had been walking home together, nearly at the doorway, her fish slung in a pail and her arm clenched around his. He bent down along the path and gently plucked a small bundle of hyacinths growing near the fence.

"For your mother," he murmured, brushing dirt from the stems.

Adora wrinkled her nose. "They smell weird."

He gave her a mock-wounded look. “You will too do this one day, you know. Pick little flowers and put them in water, just to see someone you love smile. You will be just as *disgusting* as me.”

She giggled, rolling her eyes. “I *won’t. ”*

“You *will, ”* he grinned. “Just wait.”

But then there was a low buzzing.
A flash of yellow.
And a *sting.*

“Damn it-!” he cursed, swatting the bee from his neck. “Bloody bee– *agh* -”

He started to laugh, shaking his head at the sudden pain, but the sound caught. Became strained.

Adora stopped. “Father?”

His chest heaved. A wheeze. Another.
He gripped the flowers in one hand. His other pressed to his throat.

“Father?” she repeated, panicked now. “ *Dad?!”*

He didn’t answer. Only strangled gasps and choking noises making it out.

Then he stumbled. His knees hit the gravel.
Adora screamed.

“ *Help* !” she shrieked, clutching at arms as he fell forward, choking on shallow, gasping breaths. “Someone- *anyone* , please- *MOTHER! ”*

She didn’t understand. She didn’t *know what to do.* She held him, tears pouring down her cheeks, sobbing for him again and again as her mind raced.

Then came thundering footsteps. Her mother, running from the manor barefoot, followed by servants, and a physician. Marlena's scream split into the air, agonising and raw.

"No - no, no, NO- Randor–!"

She collapsed beside them, shaking as she touched his face, then turned wild eyes on Adora.

Adora was staring at her mother who was screaming at her, but she couldn't really make out the words above the ringing in her brain and the shallowness of her own breath."

" *Inside!* " she shouted. "Go inside, Adora! *NOW!* Your siblings, don't let them - *GO!* "

Adora scrambled up, shaking, slipping in the dirt. She turned, legs numb, and ran for the manor.

She could still hear her mother sobbing. Still hear the yelling. Still see the hyacinths crushed into the ground beside her father's hand.

She didn't even remember how she got to her room, or how she closed the curtains so that Adam, Lonnie and even Mara wouldn't see what she had seen.

- - - - - -

Present day

The country estate had never felt quieter.

Years ago, it echoed with childish laughter, the clatter of muddy boots on the stairs, the shrieks of chasing games in the halls and garden. Even the walls had seemed to hum with life, meals shared under candlelight, the soft thrum of her father's voice telling stories beside the hearth, the scent of hyacinths, lilies and daisies always fresh on the table, even when they were out of season.

Now it stood still. Cold. Like the air had been sucked out of it the moment he died.

They hadn't returned since that day.. Not since the accident, since the bee sting that spiraled into chaos, since her father had fallen gasping into her arms, eyes wide with shock and pain, his hand reaching for hers and then… nothing.

Everyone else had moved on, it seemed. They could speak of him in soft tones, toast his memory on anniversaries, even laugh at his old jokes as though his absence was a faded ache and not a gaping wound.

But Adora? She was still *there* , stuck in that golden field, watching a man fall under the sky like a marionette with its strings cut. Still hearing the way her mother screamed. Still feeling the crunch of gravel beneath her knees as she knelt helpless beside the body that had once been her entire world.

Now she stood frozen in the front foyer, fists clenched tight at her sides, her nails biting half-moons into her palms.

She had walked these floors as a child. She had sat cross-legged in the corner of that great hall, listening to her father explain the constellations as they shone through the atrium glass. And now, it was all too quiet. The silence pressed on her like a weight. The ghosts of the past lingered in the edges of her vision, just out of reach, familiar laughter, a passing shadow, a door left ajar.

"Hey, Dor."

Adora's glazed over eyes suddenly snapped to the doorway and another ghost had appeared, one that she hadn't even been dwelling on for once.

"Mara," she said flatly, even though her heart was beating at an unbelievable pace

Her sister stood in the open doorway, framed by the golden light of the gravel drive behind her. She looked…older. Sun kissed and

slightly windswept, in riding trousers and a soft coat, collar undone just enough to betray her usual disregard for rules. She looked happy, more happier than Adora had ever seen her growing up at least.

Behind Mara, stood a woman just shy of twenty years her senior. She was regal in her own quiet way, with black-grey curls pulled into a low bun, and a kind of stillness that came from decades of being watched, a stark contrast to Mara. Her hands rested lightly but protectively on Mara's back.

Hope .

Adora had never met her, only heard her name in whispers, half-shouted behind closed doors.

Mara's *wife* .

"You didn't write," Adora said. Her voice was brittle. "You didn't *warn* us."

"No," Marlena said, appearing behind Adora, her voice wobbling with emotion. "But we are *so glad* you're here."

And just like that, the floodgates opened. Marlena wept as she pulled Mara into her arms, clutching her tightly and forgetting the previous betrayal. Lonnie and Adam followed suit too, gasping and chattering and hugging her all the same. The three hugged in a devastatingly happy family reunion.

Adora didn't *dare* move.

Her boots stayed planted, her fists curled at her sides as her whole family rejoiced. As if nothing had happened. As if Mara hadn't *vanished* ten months after their father's death, after *Adora* had watched him die, watched his body swell and choke and collapse in her arms while screaming for help that had come too late.

A bee sting. *One* sting. It was *supposed* to be harmless.

But he was gone. And then Mara was too.

“I thought you'd yell,” Mara said, catching her eye as the others dispersed to help with luggage.

“I already did,” Adora replied. “You just weren’t around to hear it.”

Mara followed behind her into the old drawing room that smelled faintly of dust, parchment and lavender. A place where her father would read to her, a place that hadn’t changed and remained untouched.

“You look well,” Mara offered.

“I had to be.”

The silence stretched.

Adora swelled with sadness that she couldn’t control this time and the words came tumbling out.

“Did you ever think of us? Of *him* ?”

Mara blinked, her eyes sheen with tears as she stared at Adora, as though her question was ridiculous.

“Of course. Every day.”

The answer angered Adora even though it was what she wanted to hear.

She turned, her voice turning sharp. “Then how could you leave when you *knew* I was the one who found him? That I held him while he- while he-” Her voice broke, just slightly, and she hated it.

“Adora…” Mara’s eyes were swimming in sadness and she put a hand on Adora’s shoulder, something that used to give her an unbelievable sense of comfort but now only made her feel as

though her throat was swelling with the same allergy Randor had.

She shoved Mara's hand off her and ignored the heartbreak on her sister's face.

Adora stared at her. "You had ten months. Ten months to grieve. To help. And then you ran off with someone else's wife. While I had to stand in front of our family, in front of *everyone* , and tell them our name still meant something."

"I couldn't be who they wanted me to be," Mara said. "Not anymore. Not without him."

"You *were* the chosen one," Adora snapped, bitter. "You had his magic. You were supposed to lead us. They didn't even want me, they just needed *someone* when you disappeared."

"I never wanted it," Mara whispered. "The expectations. The weight. The spellcraft lessons, the rituals. He loved me, but he loved what I could *do* more. And I broke under it. I broke, Dor."

Adora swallowed, her hands trembling at her sides. "So you left me to carry it."

Mara stepped forward, softer now. "And you've carried it beautifully. You were so much more suited to this Adora, look at what you have created. You are going to potentially wed and you have the Queen's favour as well as her daughter's. I never would have been able to do that no matter what magic I cultivated."

Adora looked away.

There was a pause before Mara added, "Do you love her? The woman you're courting?"

Adora exhaled slowly. "She's agreeable. Logical. We suit."

"That's not what I asked."

Adora didn’t answer.

“Forgive me Adora, I know I am about to overstep but…does she even make you feel *anything* ?”

“It does not matter what I feel. We fit each other perfectly and we both have duties to fulfil. She knows that well and truly, and I haven’t given her any promises of love.”

“You deserve to be happy too, regardless of your duty. I know I chose my happiness over my duty but it is possible to have both. I know what I did was selfish-”

“It was.” Adora cut in. She knew her words were harsh but she couldn’t find any possible way to talk to her sister without resentment coating every word.

“--But it’s alright to want something different, sometimes. I never would’ve been happy here, trapped in all these rigid rules and traditions. This place was never meant for me.

But you…” Mara gave her sister a soft look, her voice low. “You aren’t like me, Dora. I think you could be happy here. You just have to let yourself look for it, *really* look.”

Adora sighed, looking in the doorway where the older woman was now standing, her hands clasped before her, quiet as the moon. When Mara turned to her, something bloomed in Hope’s eyes, soft and anchored, melting all of Mara’s tension in her posture.

Adora saw it. The love. The ease. The *cost* .

And something in her chest twisted, feelings of envy and wanting.

“You could have written,” Adora said finally.

Mara smiled sadly. “I didn’t think I deserved to.”

“You didn’t,” she said. But her voice cracked just slightly.

And Mara, the only person who had ever known her in that deep, gut-level way, simply reached out and placed a hand over her sister's heart.

"I missed you anyway."

- - - - - - - - -

Mara was now upstairs with her wife, speaking freely and brightly with her mother as if she hadn't abandoned everything, as if she hadn't let Adora here to pick up all the pieces. And now she had the gall to return, smiling, beloved and forgiven. As if her absence hadn't gutted the family, as if they hadn't suffered a great enough loss already, as if Adora hadn't been the one to hold their mother together, to manage the estates and to sit in her father's empty seat and pretend she couldn't feel the choking weight of expectations and betrayal throughout her body.

They had moved on.

She hadn't.

And now, with Perfuma's family due to arrive by the morning, a looming ball to host soon and the ghosts of memory rising in every hall, Adora found herself spiraling. She wasn't sure if she would be able to be present for any of it. Her body might be here, on this land, in this house, but part of her had never left that fateful summer. That flower bed. That moment.

She blinked hard, willing the tears not to come. Not now. Not when she needed to be composed.

Not when the whole world expected her to look like a Viscount. And not the broken girl who couldn't forget how it all ended.

- - - - - - - -

The soft clip of the carriage wheels echoed through the quiet country lanes, flanked on both sides by tall oak trees that filtered late morning light into golden ribbons across the floor. Perfuma

practically glowed in her seat, one hand braced across the sill to peer out the small window, the other resting gently on her lap as she hummed a tune under her breath.

“She wrote to say the whole estate had been dusted and polished, even down to the chandeliers.” Perfuma said, turning to Catra with a hopeful smile. “I think she is nervous about us staying, which is…sort of endearing, don’t you think?”

Catra shifted in her seat. Her arms were crossed, tail twitching softly across the cushion behind her. She gave a noncommittal hum in response.

Perfuma didn’t take any notice, or maybe she simply decided to ignore it. “She is trying, I can feel it. I think her heart is in this, even if she is not quite ready to say the words, she seems to really have taken to me…”

“Maybe,” Catra muttered.

Perfuma gave her a curious glance, her brow creasing. “You’ve been quiet all morning.”

“I don’t like carriages,” Catra said simply. “You know that.”

Perfuma tilted her head. “It’s not the carriage. You have been quiet since the last ball. Since…*Scorpia*. Tell me, dear sister, is there something there?”

Catra flinched almost imperceptibly at the name.

“No. Scorpia and I would not work.”

“Oh come on, Cat!” Perfuma threw her hands up, exasperated. “She is seriously interested in courting you! And you said she knows much about Halfmoon too, you guys have lots in common!”

“I am not interested.” Catra said flatly.

"Well I heard she may be at this ball, Maybe she would settle for a fling." Perfuma wiggled her eyebrows suggestively and Catra felt something twist in her gut. *Guilt.*

Since that night, the one where she had breathed the Viscount's name like a confession into the dark, Catra hadn't been able to look her sister in the eye.

She had tried, really tried.

Tried to meet Perfuma's gaze over breakfast, to hold her hand when they strolled through Brightmoon's blooming gardens, to smile when her sister laughed and spun tales of what their life may look like in a house by the river with ivy climbing by the windows. But her smile never reached her eyes and her hands always felt sweaty.

Because everything had changed the moment she realised she had given into the attraction she was denying. The attraction to the woman who may wed her sister. The moment she curled in bed, flushed with heat and let her fingers move with aching desperation, whilst her thoughts, wants and needs formed only one shape, only one name.

Adora.

She hadn't even said it loudly. Just a soft gasp in the dark, barely a whisper. But it had shattered her.

It was like she had cracked herself open with it, the truth of it, the *wrongness* of it, echoing back at her in the silence that followed. And since then, no amount of distance, no polite smiles, no carefully performed sisterly affection could undo the sharp, sickening guilt that curled in her belly like rot.

She couldn't even picture Scorpia anymore. Sweet, kind, bumbling Scorpia, who had danced with her and made her laugh and seemed so wonderfully out of place in Brightmoon's polished world. Even trying to summon the memory of her brought only

emptiness. A hollow space where something should have bloomed.

All Catra could feel was shame.

She couldn't entertain the idea of Scorpia.
She couldn't entertain the idea of staying.
She couldn't even entertain the idea of looking Perfuma in the eye and lying to her, again.

The thought of Perfuma's gaze, bright with love and hope, made her chest clench so tightly it was hard to breathe. Catra wasn't sure what hurt more: the fact that she didn't deserve her sister's love… or the fact that, deep down, some part of her didn't want it the way she should.

She just wanted to *run* .

To get out of this wretched town with its stiff collars and suffocating expectations, its dances and its whispered rumors. To go back to Halfmoon, to the cliffs and the cold wind and the silence. To be *alone* , where no one could see her like this. *Torn in two.*

But she wasn't alone.
Not yet.
And every step forward in this engagement, every dress fitted, every guest list updated, every ball scheduled, was another step deeper into a life she could no longer pretend she wanted.

And still, she said nothing.
Because she didn't know how to stop what had already begun.
And because she was terrified of what would happen when she finally did.

"She's not the only one who deserves happiness," Perfuma said gently, laying a hand on Catra's arm. "You've always protected me, Catra. Maybe it's time to let yourself be protected too."

Catra's ears flicked at the touch. She swallowed hard, unable to speak.

Outside, the trees gave way to open fields, and in the distance, the Grayskull country estate rose from the mist like something out of a painting, all pale stone and dark slate, its windows glinting in the sun.

Perfuma leaned forward eagerly to see it, hope blooming in her eyes.

Catra leaned back into her seat, staring straight ahead, her guilt thick in her chest.
Perfuma thought things were finally going well.
Catra wasn't sure they ever had.

And yet, she couldn't say the words. Not here. Not yet.

So she sat in silence.
And hoped that, somehow, her silence wouldn't destroy the one person she was supposed to protect.

- - - - - - - - - - - -

The orchard behind the Grayskull country estate had once been alive with childhood laughter, of swordplay with sticks, and Mara telling stories of the trees being ancient magical protectors. Now it was quiet. Still. Adora walked slowly beside her sister, the tense silence between them stretching like a pulled, fraying thread.

They hadn't spoken much since the morning. Since Mara had asked about Perfuma.

"She will be arriving soon," Mara said finally, breaking the stillness. Her voice was soft, but her words held shape and weight. "Are you nervous?"

Adora's eyes stayed fixed on the crooked rows of apple trees ahead. "No. I'm prepared."

“That’s not the same thing,” Mara said, echoing her earlier teasing tone, but it lacked bite this time.

Adora's fingers flexed at her side. “I’ve done what was expected. Her family is reputable, her temperament is agreeable, and her sensibilities are well-matched to mine. It is… logical.”

Mara didn’t respond right away. They walked a few paces in silence, the birdsong around them chirping faintly, unconcerned with the tight knot forming in Adora’s chest.

“Can I tell you something?” Mara said at last. “Something I think I never got to say before I left?”

Adora hesitated, then nodded.

“When I met Hope,” Mara began, her voice quieter now, “it wasn’t logical. It wasn’t *safe.* It wasn’t even particularly wise. I’d just watched Father die. I was being groomed to follow in his footsteps, to be the perfect heir. The magical Grayskull. The one who could carry everything.”

She swallowed. “But the first time I heard Hope laugh, it was like the world changed color. Like I’d been walking around my whole life hearing muffled noise, and suddenly someone turned the volume up. I couldn’t breathe around her, and yet being near her was the only time I felt like I *was* breathing.”

Adora’s lips parted, but she couldn’t speak, her thoughts racing.

“I would find myself looking for her in every room,” Mara said, her smile tinged with an aching memory. “Even if I had just seen her moments before. And when she touched my arm, or said my name like it was important… it made me feel seen. Like I wasn’t just a title or an expectation. I was *me.* ”

The breeze rustled the branches above them, the soft hush of leaves playing like a lullaby.

“That’s what love feels like,” Mara said gently. “Like a presence in your skin. Like you’re suddenly aware of every heartbeat and every breath you take because they belong to *you* again, not to your duties. It’s a kind of madness, but the good kind. The kind that makes you bold.”

Adora’s stomach churned. Her hands were fists.

She tried to think of Perfuma. Tried to see her smile. Her kind eyes. Her laugh.

But instead…

Catra taunting her as she bound further into the woods.

Catra, flushed and wild eyed as she yelled at Adora.

Catra’s giggles as she watched Adora fall over during yoga.

Catra, pressed to another girl, smiling, in a way that made Adora’s throat close.

And suddenly she was burning.

She sucked in a breath like she’d been caught doing something wrong.

Mara’s brows lifted slightly. She watched her sister with a softness that cut deeper than any accusation.

“Oh,” she said, with a knowing little lilt. “That’s very interesting.”

“I didn’t say anything,” Adora rasped, already too defensive.

“You didn’t need to.” Mara smiled with maddening ease. “That look on your face said everything.”

“There’s nothing-” Adora’s voice broke, and she forced her shoulders back. “It’s complicated.”

“How can it be complicated when you clearly feel those things for Perfuma!”

Adora’s jaw tightened.

“I don’t. I simply care for her.”

That wasn’t a lie at least.

“That’s not what I asked.”

Adora looked away, pulse pounding.

“Look,” Mara said, tone gentler now. “I get it. You’ve spent your whole life trying to fix what I left behind. You think love should be an obligation you fulfill, something you *earn* by doing everything right. But it isn’t. Love… love just *is.* You can’t force it to bloom in a field where it doesn’t grow.”

The orchard was so quiet.

Adora felt something wet in the corner of her eye and blinked it away.

“I just want you to be *happy,* ” Mara whispered. “Not just… sufficient.”

Adora couldn’t speak. The truth clanged in her ribs like a bell she couldn’t unring.

And in the silence, all she could think of was the way Catra had smiled at her when she thought no one was watching.

The way her own breath had caught.

The way she still hadn’t let go of that adventure in the woods.

Chapter 6: Magic

Chapter Notes

> I do not know how people update their fics so often when one chapter is 5k+ this is HARD, it was easy when it was like 2k...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora stood at the end of the long, sun-dappled driveway, the familiar gravel path glittering light powdered glass beneath her boots. The marble pink carriage rolled toward her at a gentle pace, drawn by glossy white mares. The Driluth family had arrived.

She straightened her spine. Her hands, despite her best efforts, were clenched behind her back.

The door opened with a creak, and out stepped Perfuma first, radiant in a pale yellow day gown that fluttered in the breeze. Then came Light Spinner, ever-elegant in dusk toned silks, followed by Lady Cyra, whose cadence was full of confidence in her pastel green kameez. And then:

Catra.

Adora swallowed. The air felt thicker all of a sudden, like the summer heat had wrapped around her throat like a snake around a mouse. Catra didn't smile, just lifted her brow slightly to acknowledge her. Catra, unlike her sister and mother, chose to wear a fitted pant, sharply tailored and dark as ink, paired with a tight waistcoat that cinched at her narrow waist, the buttons straining just slightly as she moved. A frilled white shirt peeked out at the collar and cuffs, softening the ensemble just enough to draw the eye. Her boots were scuffed from the ride, laced tight, and dusted with the chalky road.

It wasn’t far off from what Adora herself wore on most days: practical, clean-cut, just a little defiant of what was expected. And yet, on Catra, it looked like something else entirely. Like danger made beautiful. Like a challenge wrapped in brocade. Adora had seen her in gowns before, delicate silks, flowing pastels, but this? This was something different.

She couldn't quite comprehend how one person could pull off both looks, the softness of a debutante one day and the hard edges of a rogue the next, and manage to look *better* than anyone else in either. It made no sense. None. And the way her body was reacting to it made even less.

“Lady Adora,” Light Spinner said warmly. “The estate is... quite breathtaking.”

“Indeed,” Cyra agreed. “The countryside becomes your family.”

“Thank you,” Adora managed, dipping into a practiced bow. “We are very honored to host you here.”

Perfuma beamed as she reached Adora’s side. “It’s even lovelier than I imagined.”

Now that she looked again, Perfuma did look particularly lovely today. Her golden hair had been swept into an elegant half-updo, the loose waves catching their light like spun honey. A delicate crown of green vine circled the top of her head. She looked exactly like someone should look when stepping into a countryside romance, graceful, warm and safe.

Maybe something could grow with Perfuma after all, she did look particularly charming. Maybe that stirring she felt around Catra was pure anxiety and this was what she should feel instead, safety.

From behind them, the great oak doors creaked open as Adam and Lonnie appeared, Adam waving a mallet with unnecessary flair.

“Good afternoon!” Adam called out cheerfully from the steps, his grin broad and sun-warmed. “I hope you’re all prepared for the next few days of rustic adventure, assuming someone had the good sense to pack the pall-mall set.”

“French croquet?” Lonnie teased, elbowing him with a smirk. “You only like it because you get to swing violently and call it strategy.”

Perfuma laughed lightly and, without hesitation, slipped her arm through Catra’s. Adora’s eyes flicked to the gesture, catching the subtle way Catra’s shoulders stiffened under the contact.

“Oh, that does sound exciting, doesn’t it, sister?” Perfuma said brightly. “Catra turns into an unhinged beast around a mallet.”

“An unhinged beast?” Catra echoed with an incredulous huff, glancing at her sister. “I’d prefer... ruthlessly focused.”

“But unhinged is still accurate,” Perfuma muttered to Cyra, who nodded solemnly.

Adam chuckled and turned to Adora, giving her a nudge. “Then we’re in for a show. Adora’s just as bad. Don’t let her smile fool you, she plays to destroy.”

“I’m not just competitive,” Adora said smoothly, meeting Catra’s gaze with a pointed grin. “I’m undefeated.”

Catra raised a brow, lips curling in that familiar almost-smile that never quite reached her eyes. “Undefeated? Please. Your poor siblings probably let you win to spare themselves the tantrum.”

Adora bristled, her jaw tightening. The teasing tone hit a little too close. Why did Catra always have to reduce her to a petulant child? Maybe, just maybe, she was actually *good* at the game.

“Well,” she said coolly, “I suppose we’ll see soon enough, won’t we?”

The others laughed as the two of them descended into teasing bickering, all quick-fire retorts and narrowed eyes. Perfuma watched them, smile lingering but ever so slightly strained.

Then, a new voice rang out from behind the group.

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"Mara, *slow down* . You're going to trip on the gravel."

All turned to see a pair approaching from the stables: one in breeches and an open riding coat, chestnut curls pinned messily beneath her hat, the other in a flowing cream skirt and boots stained slightly from the morning dew.

Adora's posture stiffened immediately.

"Mara," she said, her voice harder now.

Catra blinked.

The brunette stepped forward and smiled broadly, resting a hand on the other woman's back. "Hello, everyone. Sorry we're late. We got a bit distracted by the orchard."

"I insisted we try the pears," said the woman beside her, Hope, presumably.

Marlena appeared then from within the house, her tone light but lined with something Catra couldn't read. " Mara is my daughter," she said to the gathered group, "and this is her wife, Hope."

There was a small pause.

Mara cleared her throat before smiling and extending her hand to shake Perfuma's and then Catra's. She gripped Catra's hand and shook it with gusto, a twinkle in her eye. "You must be the Miss Perfuma I have been hearing so much about."

Catra faltered, her eyes widening as she shook her head slowly, a strained smile painting her face,

“That is her sister, actually.” Adora cleared up, glaring at Mara. “You just shook Perfuma’s hand.”

“Yes-” Catra found her words now. “You flatter me but that is my beautiful sister, this Season’s diamond.” She stepped aside to gesture towards Perfuma.

Perfuma gave a modest curtsy, cheeks blooming pink.

Mara blinked, clearly surprised but gracious enough to pivot. “Of course. A pleasure to meet you, Miss Perfuma, you do seem like the picture perfect Diamond.”

Adora cleared her throat, looking very interested in a patch of grass near her boot.

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The estate gardens stretched lazily beneath the late afternoon sun, golden light spilling over manicured hedges and tall foxglove stalks swaying in the warm breeze. A gravel path meandered between rose bushes and climbing ivy, its curves offering just enough privacy to pretend they were alone, though they were anything but.

Adora offered her arm to Perfuma, who accepted it with a smile as sweet as the scent of the blooming wisteria overhead. Behind them, trailed their designated chaperones: Mara, Hope and a visibly unenthused Catra, who walked several paces behind with her hands in her pockets and her mouth set in a bored line.

“It’s peaceful here,” Perfuma said softly, her fingers lightly brushing Adora’s arm. “Everything feels slower. Softer.”

“Too slow sometimes,” Adora replied, glancing sideways at her. “But... I suppose that’s the point. No court pressure. Just air and space.”

Perfuma laughed. “Air and space and an undefeated pall-mall champion.”

Adora flushed, both flattered and slightly embarrassed. “Well, I’ll try not to crush your spirit too badly when we play.”

“I can’t even really play.” Perfuma admitted, a soft blush painting her cheeks.

Behind them, Catra rolled her eyes dramatically. “Are we going to keep pretending this is subtle courtship? I bet they’ll kiss under a willow tree like its scripted.”

“You sound annoyed,” Mara said, clasping her hands behind her back. Her tone was easy, but her eyes flicked toward Catra with curiosity.

“No! I just–” Catra paused. “I am not really a fan of romance when it is…expected. When it’s a part of the performance. All these rules, dances and chaperones. I want- I want my sister to have something that sweeps her off her feet.”

Mara hummed in agreement. “I used to feel like that. Still do, honestly.”

Hope raised a brow from beside her but didn’t interrupt.

“You’re lucky,” Catra said dryly. “You got to escape it.”

Mara barked a laugh. “Escape? I was exiled. By choice, but still. And Hope and I didn’t exactly start out like a fairytale.”

Hope huffed, raising both eyebrows now. “She hated me.”

“I *did* ,” Mara said unapologetically. “You were arrogant and controlling. And you hated me because I had magic and you didn’t.”

“I didn’t hate you,” Hope said with an exaggerated sigh. “I was... envious. I thought you were born into power. I didn’t know you

never wanted it. And I was maybe jealous that homosexuality was so normalised by then, I had to endure a boring, fruitless marriage with a man I had never been attracted to."

Catra glanced between them, silent for a beat.

"I think I'd hate to have magic." She said finally. "I would never know what to do with it. The pressure and expectations. Everyone watching you to see if your power will make you into something great or if it'll just be something boring. People weren't exactly kind to Perfuma when they found out she could only sprout plants."

Mara looked at her, surprised, and something softened in her.

"Yeah," she said. "Exactly."

A quiet understanding passed between them, shaded not by pity, but by recognition.

Up ahead, Perfuma and Adora had stopped at a rose-covered archway. Perfuma was pointing out the way the petals had turned slightly toward the sun, speaking with a soft reverence for the way the world bloomed when left untamed.

Adora didn't say much, but her smile deepened with every word.

Behind them, Mara and Catra had fallen into an easier rhythm now, not quite friends, but no longer strangers either.

"Perfuma doesn't seem as though her power is merely plants though." Mara nodded, to the way the blooms sprouted in the ground from her every step.

"No. She is extremely powerful. She is just too afraid to hurt anyone by being too powerful, she would much rather be grateful for the smaller things." To many, they may think that was a critique from her sister, but Catra was fond of how Perfuma was always content, never wanting more because she was already so grateful. It was no matter, Catra would always want more for her

sister even if she was content. She deserved everything Catra couldn't have.

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Perfuma bent slightly to pluck a fallen petal from a low hedge, blooming it into a white flower and tucking it into Adora's ear, who blushed a pretty shade of pink. "So if we were to wed…we would live here?"

"Yes."

"Did you always know you'd want to live somewhere like this?" she asked, eyes lingering on the curling stonework of the manor visible in the distance. "It feels so… old and grand. Like a place people expect to find someone important."

Adora chuckled. "You make it sound like I'm a relic."

"No," Perfuma said, glancing at her sideways with a little smile. "Just… someone meant to be here. It suits you."

Adora flushed. "I'm not sure it does, actually. It was my father's place. And his father's. And his father's before that. I think I just… inherited the role more than I chose it."

"You don't like it?"

"I don't know," Adora admitted. "I like parts of it. The work. Taking care of people. The quiet. But sometimes it feels like I'm just walking around in someone else's shoes, trying to look like I belong in them."

Perfuma slowed her steps slightly, as though to make space for honesty to settle between them. "You seem like you do."

'That's because I practice,' Adora thought. "You're right. This must be where I am meant to be."

Perfuma was quiet for a moment, thoughtful. Then: “I’m glad you invited us here.”

“I’m glad you came.”

“I wanted to see you outside the city,” Perfuma admitted, her voice gentler now. “I think I wanted to know if you changed in the light.”

Adora glanced at her. “And?”

Perfuma smiled again, and this time it lingered. “You’re still you. Just… softer. Quieter, maybe. A little sunstruck.”

Adora’s heart did something traitorous in her chest, tightened, jumped. She quickly looked away. “Well. It’s hard not to be when you’re with the Season’s diamond.”

Perfuma laughed, a melodic sound that startled a bird from a nearby branch. “You never say things like that.”

“Maybe I should start.”

They passed under another arch of climbing vines, and the dappled light turned the world gold and green. Ahead, there was a marble bench tucked behind a curtain of jasmine.

Perfuma tugged gently on Adora’s arm. “Shall we rest a minute?”

Adora hesitated, then nodded. “Sure.”

They sat, the bench cool beneath them. For a while, they simply watched the wind move through the garden, their arms brushing now and then, innocently, accidentally, but Adora was sharply aware of every point of contact, anxiety curling a little in her stomach.

“Adora,” she said gently, “may I ask you something slightly... sensitive?”

Adora blinked, slightly on edge from the sheer shift in tone. “Of course.”

Perfuma hesitated, then turned to fully face her. “How do you feel about my sister?”

Adora choked, a blush rising to her cheeks and her heart racing. “W-What?”

Was she a mind reader? Adora hadn’t been that obvious, had she?

Perfuma didn’t flinch, though her voice remained kind. “I just mean... I can’t help but notice the tension between you two. Every time we’re in the same room, the aura is like lightning, static, crackling, ready to strike. I wondered if that’s why you might be... hesitant. About courting me.”

Adora opened her mouth, then closed it. Her heart pounded. “You think I’m hesitant?”

Perfuma smiled softly, but there was a hint of sadness in it. “I think you’re careful. And I respect that. But I also know my sister isn’t always the easiest to be around, especially if she’s made her mind up about something. If she’s been rude to you, I want to apologise. She’s protective, of me, of our family. Sometimes that comes out as barbed words and unflinching stares.”

Adora could still feel the weight of those stares from earlier, like a stone pressed just beneath her collarbone. “She hasn’t exactly been welcoming,” she admitted.

“No,” Perfuma said, sighing. “I’m sorry for that. I truly am. I think... She's afraid of me being hurt. But I’ll talk to her, ask her to be more civil. Nicer. Warmer, if you’d like.”

Adora felt her stomach twist. “That’s not necessary.”

Perfuma tilted her head, confused. “It’s not?”

“I mean, it’s kind of you to offer,” Adora said quickly, “but it’s not your job to manage your sister’s every reaction. I can handle myself.”

Perfuma gave her a look, unreadable but thoughtful. “All the same, I want her to understand that I care for you. And that if you’re planning to propose, she’ll have to accept you.”

Adora’s pulse skipped. “Propose-?”

Perfuma let out a quiet laugh. “Don’t look so horrified. I’m not saying you *have* to. Only that... if you were waiting because of her, I wanted to clear the air.”

Adora looked away, heart thundering in her ears. “I appreciate your honesty,” she said at last. “Really. And you deserve the same in return.”

Perfuma nodded, waiting.

“I care for you,” Adora continued, choosing her words carefully. “I enjoy our time together. You’re thoughtful. Kind. And being with you, it’s comfortable. I wouldn’t be courting you like this if I didn’t intend to propose, that would not be gentlemanly and could even ruin our families. I wouldn’t do that.”

Perfuma smiled, but it looked a little strained and for the life of her, Adora couldn’t figure out why. Was that not what she wanted to hear?

“And I’m not seeing anyone else, if that’s what you’re wondering,” Adora added, a little too quickly.

Perfuma laughed. “I was wondering, yes.”

“Well, I’m not,” Adora said, forcing a chuckle. “I don’t exactly have the time or the energy for multiple scandals.”

Behind them, the others began calling from the far end of the garden, Catra’s voice sharp and unmistakable, Hope’s lighter tone

wrapped around a laugh, and Mara's deep, dry chuckle.

Perfuma looked toward the sound. "Shall we rejoin them?"

Adora offered her arm. "Lead the way."

As they walked back through the blooming arches, Adora felt the tension settle again in her chest, not from Perfuma, not even from the idea of marriage, but from the weight of something unspoken between her and Catra. Something Perfuma had sensed. And something Adora wasn't sure she could keep pretending not to feel.

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The Pall Mall set gleamed under the summer sun, nestled near the lower slope of the Grayskull estate lawn. Mallets arranged like soldiers, wickets perfectly aligned, colored balls catching the light like polished candies. To Catra, it looked less like a lawn game and more like a battlefield.

Adora was already there when she arrived, sleeves rolled to her forearms, blonde hair tied back hastily with a ribbon that had come loose. She was talking to Bow and Glimmer, laughing, easy, but when Catra stepped into view, something in Adora's expression flickered and her smile fell away.

Do I make her that uncomfortable?

"How often do you play?" Adora asked, tapping the green mallet against her shoulder.

"Not often but I have enough practice" Catra replied, selecting the black mallet with casual defiance. "But I'm a quick learner."

"Good," Adora said. "Because I don't go easy on beginners."

Bow let out a low whistle. "They're going to kill each other."

Glimmer smirked. "I'm betting on the Viscount."

Bow and Glimmer had arrived a few hours after Catra's family had. Catra didn't really know what to make of them, she thought she liked Bow. His absolute refusal to societal rules regarding covering his torso was pretty endearing, and he was just quite easy to get along with. Glimmer however, seemed to know too much. She kept glancing at Catra with all-too-knowing smirks and wiggling her eyebrows whenever Catra would simply look at the Viscount.

Catra narrowed her eyes. "That's your mistake."

Perfuma, to her credit, tried. She chose the yellow ball, smiled at everyone, and lined up her first shot with hesitant grace. The mallet swung… and the ball rolled a foot before flopping gently into a divot.

"Oh," she said. "That's all right. I'll… adjust next time."

There was a long, well-meaning silence.

Adora cleared her throat. "You'll get it soon," she said brightly.

Catra said nothing. Her gaze lingered on her sister for a moment, Perfuma's soft frown, the strain behind her sunny demeanor. Catra had no idea why Perfuma had insisted on playing today. She clearly wasn't having fun.

Adora, though, was grinning, practically vibrating with the need to compete. She lined up her shot with precision and sent her green ball sailing halfway down the pitch, knocking Glimmer's pink ball off course with a clack and causing the small girl to shriek angrily.

Catra made her shot without ceremony, aiming directly at Adora's ball. She didn't strike it quite cleanly, but the hit was enough to redirect it toward the edge of the lawn.

Adora's mouth fell open.

"That was petty," she said.

“ *That* was strategy,” Catra shot back, brushing a fleck of dirt off her cuff.

“You’ve barely even play!”

“Yeah, and I’m still better at it.”

Adora stepped closer, the sunlight catching in her hair like honey. “You really think you can win?”

“I think I already am.”

Their gazes locked, sharp-edged and crackling with something unnamed. The summer heat pressed against them like velvet, thick and golden and too much.

Catra wasn’t sure when Adora started looking at her like that, not angry, not annoyed, but distracted. Like she was trying *not* to look. Like it took effort to keep her focus on the game and not on…

“Your turn,” Adora said suddenly, voice a little hoarse.

Catra blinked. “What?”

“It’s your turn.”

Right. The game. Catra smirked to cover how suddenly off-balance she felt.

Perfuma missed again. Glimmer and Bow bickered over the rules. But all of it felt like background noise now, humming under the strange tension that had built between her and Adora like a taut string.

Adora kept stealing glances. Catra noticed. She always noticed.

Then Adora knocked Catra’s ball clean off the pitch and toward the trees.

“Oh, you f-!” Catra huffed, narrowing her eyes.

“Payback,” Adora said, lifting her mallet in mock salute. “You're welcome.”

Catra didn’t hesitate, she stalked toward the trees, boots crunching on dry grass. The ball had rolled into the edge of a muddy patch near the woods.

Adora followed. “You don’t *have* to go get it right now-”

But Catra was already stalking off into the woods, leaving Adora to growl and follow after her.

The grass gave way to dirt and roots, and then, abruptly, mud. Catra’s ball was partially submerged near a shallow gully that had filled with water from the last rainfall.

“You got it stuck,” Catra groaned.

“No, *you* got it stuck.” Adora retorted, childishly.

Catra rolled her eyes and shrugged off her waistcoat in one smooth motion, tossing it onto a dry patch of grass. The soft *thud* of it landing was nothing compared to the way Adora’s breath caught.

Her gaze snagged, *helplessly* , on Catra’s rolled-up sleeves, the way they hugged her arms, lean, strong and defined. Adora blinked hard and tore her eyes away, cheeks heating faster than she could school her expression.

Catra didn’t seem to notice. Or maybe she did, judging by the smirk tugging at the edge of her mouth.

With a dramatic sigh, she stepped closer to the edge of the mud pit and dipped one boot in. It sank with an ominous squelch.

“You cannot be serious,” Adora blurted. “You are going to ruin your boots!”

“You scared of a little mud, *Viscount* ?” Catra tossed over her shoulder, voice syrupy with challenge.

Before Adora could form a retort, Catra took another step, sinking deeper into the muck as she stretched forward, fingers reaching determinedly for the stray ball.

“Ah, *seriously?* ” she hissed.

Adora yelped. “Catra!”

“I’m *fine!* ” Catra snapped, though the mud was halfway up her calves and crawling higher. “I just- ugh. You just had to get it stuck here, didn’t you?”

Adora hovered nearby, arms out like she could catch her. “Do you want a hand?”

“No.”

“You’re clearly stuck.”

“Shut up.”

“You shut up!”

A moment passed.

Catra sighed. “Okay. Fine.”

Adora knelt and offered her arm. “On three?”

Catra grasped her wrist. “One…two - *ugh!* ”

The two of them tumbled sideways into the mud with a *splat* , Catra gasping as she landed half on top of the Viscount.

“Oh my god,” Adora wheezed.

Catra pushed herself up on her hands. Her waistcoat was soaked. Her hair was stuck to her cheek. Adora, beneath her, was blinking

mud out of her lashes like she couldn’t quite believe what just happened.

Catra really couldn’t help it. She screamed of laughter, the bright squeaky sound tumbling out of her before she could stop it. Adora just looked so utterly stupid, especially now she was gawking at her with mud streaked lashes.

Adora found herself staring. Not just looking, but *staring* , fully transfixed, as Catra laughed with her whole body, head tossed back, dark hair catching the gold of the afternoon sun like a flame. It wasn’t a polite laugh, or a reserved one, it was wild and unfiltered, cracking open something in Adora she hadn’t realized was there. Her eyes followed the curve of Catra’s smile, the scrunch of her nose, the way the sound rumbled out of her like a spark catching dry grass. It hit Adora then, with dizzying clarity, just how beautiful she was when she wasn’t guarded. It felt like something she shouldn’t be allowed to witness, and yet, she couldn’t look away.

“I told you,” Catra cackled. “You and your stupid pressed trousers. You look like a drowned sheep.”

Adora stared at her for a moment, and then let out a reluctant snort. “You’re impossible.”

They sat like that for a moment, knee-deep in mud, surrounded by trees and filtered sunlight. It was weirdly nice if Adora ignored the mud feeling like it was sticking to her very soul.

Then the trees rustled.

Catra stilled.

“What was that?”

Adora frowned. “Probably a squirrel.”

But then the ground *shuddered* . Not like a breeze. Like something big had landed.

Catra squeaked. Actually squeaked.

Adora turned to her. “Did you just squeak? Is that your scream?”

“Shut up!”

“I thought you were the brave one!”

“I *am!* I just- what the - *what is that?* ”

A large red blur darted out of the woods. Adora shrieked. Catra yelped and shoved her behind her, teeth bared and hissing, like she could fight the thing off with sheer attitude.

Something bounded toward them, large, red, fast.

The creature skidded to a stop in front of them, kicking up dirt and leaves, its form blurring like a heat haze before it shimmered, trilling, as though it was trying to speak in music. Then, right before their eyes, its body began to ripple and shift, limbs stretching, spine curling, until it stood as a massive red feline, easily the size of a panther. Its fur was a deep crimson with its mane flowing behind it, turquoise and transparent, and its eyes, Adora couldn’t look away, were soft, intelligent and turquoise, gleaming with something ancient. Its long tail twitched with a dancer’s grace. Its ears flicked toward Catra like it recognized her.

But even more than the impossible creature before her, what stunned Adora was Catra. The woman had stepped in front of her without a second thought, shielding her with nothing but muddy boots and bare hands. No weapon, no plan, just instinct. Adora felt her breath catch in her throat. She was so used to being the protector, the one who stood between others and danger. Yet here was Catra, doing it for her, without hesitation. Something warm and unfamiliar fluttered in her chest. Gratitude, yes, but something sharper too. Something she wasn’t ready to name

It mewed.

Catra gaped.

It stepped forward and butted its head gently against her arm.

Adora, breathless, stared. “It… it likes you.”

“I’ve never seen anything like it before in my life,” Catra whispered.

Adora’s expression softened, touched with awe. “I don’t think it matters.”

The creature purred, loud and affectionate, curling against Catra’s legs.

“What is this?” she asked, not daring to move. “Do you just have magic shapeshifting panthers on the grounds?”

“I don’t know,” Adora replied. “I haven’t been back here in seven years.”

Catra looked at her. Then at the creature who mewled again and licked Catra’s cheek, who scoffed and wiped the spit on her arm.

“It said it’s name is Melog.”

Adora gaped, *Catra could speak to it? Maybe she was magic too.*

“How do you understand it?”

“No clue.” Catra half-heartedly shrugged. “Hey Melog? Can you help us out of here?” She asked the creature, petting along its ear slightly, as though paying it for its services. Melog mewled again and hoisted itself under Catra, who grabbed its scruff and bundled on. She brought her hand down, and Adora realised she was offering it to her, to help her out of the bog. Adora took it, ignoring the weird jolt she felt in her stomach from holding Catra’s palm, and bundled onto Melog too, steadying herself behind Catra.

“Okay…uhh- giddy up?” Catra said to it, causing Adora to chuckle.

Melog huffed and set off, the mud not even sticking to its sleek body and simply rolling off. Adora squealed a little as she nearly fell off from the fast pace Melog took as it bounded from the woods, grabbing onto Catra's waist to steady herself, as the woman laughed at her again.

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They had returned to the garden like an odd little procession, Catra and Adora both caked in dried mud, shoes squelching awkwardly with every step, and trailing behind them, the enormous, shimmering red feline, whose paws barely made a sound.

The rest of the party had gathered around the patio, teacups in hand, gossiping and laughing. Pall Mall had long since been abandoned. Glimmer, spotting them first, let out an incredulous snort.

"So," she said, loud enough for everyone to hear and turn their eyes to the pair, "you disappear for twenty five minutes, come back covered in bog, and with a magic panther?"

Catra gave a tired, deadpan blink. "Yeah, that's... pretty much the summary."

Adora gave a weak smile, still trying to pick dried reeds from her braid. Melog, unbothered, sat back on its haunches and began grooming its paws like this was the most natural thing in the world.

Bow pushed forward, eyes wide. "A real shapeshifter? That's incredible! I have to write to my dads, they've studied dozens of rare Etherian species, but I don't think I've *ever* seen anything with a shimmer signature like this."

"Do you think it's dangerous?" Lonnie asked from her seat, but her voice carried more intrigue than concern.

Melog let out a soft trilling sound and padded toward Mara and Hope. It circled them both once, and then pressed its head gently into Mara's hip. She laughed in surprise and bent down to stroke the soft red fur.

"Oh you are just the cutest thing, aren't you?" she squealed, letting it nuzzle into her hand. "I'm magic too," she added after a moment, as though she was confessing something.

Catra half listened, her fingers absentmindedly scratching behind Melog's ears. The creature leaned into her touch, then paused. Slowly, it's soft cerulean gaze lifted and locked onto hers, almost unnervingly.

She felt it, rather than heard it, a strange hum in her chest, like the flicker of a thought that wasn;t her own.

Adora, magic, unused power, light.

Catra blinked, stilling. The sensation passed through her like a breeze over water, impossible to hold.

"What is it saying?" Adora asked beside her, voice hushed.

Catra looked up at her, then back at the creature. "It… says you have magic. Or something like it. Something you haven't learned to use."

Adora's brows pulled together, her face suddenly twisting into an anxious frown.

"That doesn't make sense. I've never felt… anything like that."

But her voice faltered. Because her eyes were drifting again, to a point across the lawn, half hidden by tall hedges and the dappled reach of trees. Her smile faded completely, and a shadow moved across her face - something quiet, unreachable.

Catra noticed it now. The way she kept *looking* there. Like she didn't want to, but couldn't stop herself.

When the group finally dispersed, pulled back toward the house with promises of dry clothes and warm tea, Catra lingered behind. Melog stayed at her side, its ears perked like it sensed her intention.

She made her way down the gravel path, past the rows of roses and the trimmed hedges, until the laughter of the others was far behind her. The further she walked, the quieter the air became, as if the very garden knew to hush itself.

Then she saw it.

Tucked away in a shady grove, wrapped in ivy and overgrown ferns, stood a single weather-worn gravestone.

Randor Grayskull. A loving father and husband.
Born 1768 — Died 1813.

Seven years ago.

Catra froze.

She stepped closer, drawn in by a feeling she hadn't expected. The grave was clean, but clearly old. A small bouquet had been placed at the foot of the headstone, the kind of thing you left behind after a visit. A quiet promise that you'd come. That you remembered.

And suddenly, it all made sense.

The heaviness in Adora's eyes. Her stiffness. Her silence about the estate. The way she carried herself like every joy was something she had to *earn* .

Catra crouched down, brushing a fallen leaf from the base of the stone.

"You're the reason she hasn't been back in seven years," she whispered.

She looked around, taking in the secluded garden, how it must have once been his favorite place. She could imagine Adora as a girl, running across the lawns, laughing beneath the trees. She could imagine her older, standing in this very spot, broken by grief.

And now here she was again, trying to keep it buried beneath perfectly ironed clothes and duty and politeness. And maybe even a marriage she wasn’t sure she wanted.

Catra swallowed. The knot in her throat ached unexpectedly.

It reminded her of her own mother. How they had both probably taken over the families after their parents died. But Adora wouldn’t have had to, it was Mara who chose to leave with Hope. Suddenly Catra felt resentment bubble towards the older sister, she had just left her to take care of everything? Catra never would have done that to Perfuma, no matter what love she felt, no matter any pressure she felt. Mara didn’t protect her like she should have.

She looked back at Melog. The creature blinked slowly, as if it understood. It padded forward and nuzzled gently against the gravestone before sitting beside it in silence.

Catra stood up, brushing dirt from her knees.

She didn’t know what she felt exactly. But she knew what it meant now, that Adora was still hurting. Still haunted.

And Catra, without realizing it, had just walked straight into the heart of it.

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Chapter End Notes

Hey guys! Let me know how you are liking this fic so far? I know regency, lengthy fics aren't everyone's cups of tea so I'm curious since this is so different to my last fic.

Chapter 7: Perfect in the general sense

Chapter Notes

> TW- semi-graphic scenes of death mentioned at the *** towards the end of the chapter, it finishes at the next *** so its not too long.
>
> Okay so in this world, you can get pregnant regardless of gender so long as there is magic involved - whether you or your spouse is magic or if you go to someone else who possesses the gift. Magic is in around 42% of people but all princess will have access to it - since yknow, runestones. Though you can STILL be unable to carry children since ...yknow wombs and shit I suppose.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The early morning sun cast a soft amber light over the balcony of the Grayskull estate, bathing Catra in its gentle warmth. She moved in the warm stillness, barefoot and a robe wrapped tightly over her sheer nightgown. She poured hot water over the loose tea leaves, watching the steam curl up into the air like a slow sigh. The house was still mostly asleep, leaving her in a rare and welcome quiet.

Then with a crackle of magic and a soft *pop,* Glimmer appeared right in front of her.

Catra gasped, scrambling to steady herself to not spill the hot spiced tea on herself.

"Gods!" she hissed, stepping back and stilling her bristled and lashing tail. "You!- do you always *have* to appear like that?"

Glimmer giggled. "Only when I know it'll be funny."

"You could have just knocked! Do teleportation powers absolve you of manners?"

"I *could* knock," Glimmer said, sliding into a chair like she owned the place. "But then I wouldn't get to see you jump like that."

Catra groaned and retrieved another teacup without being asked. "You're insufferable."

"Thank you," Glimmer said sweetly.

They drank in companionable silence for a few moments before Glimmer spoke again, her voice light. "I figured I'd come get to know my best friend's potential sister-in-law. You know. Vet the scary, glaring one."

Catra gave her a flat look. "You're one to talk about glaring. You look like you'd hex someone for chewing too loud."

"Oh, I *have.* " Glimmer smirked, then added, "I like you."

Catra lifted her brow. "You teleport in to annoy people you *like?*"

"Only the ones I think are interesting." Glimmer sipped her tea and eyed her. "So. Are you finding the estate tolerable?"

Catra leaned against the counter, nodding slowly. "It's fine. Quiet. Which I like. Weirdly magic, which I don't." She hesitated, then added, more carefully, "I took a walk yesterday. Found a… gravestone."

Glimmer's smile dimmed, just slightly. She set her cup down with more gentleness than before. "Randor."

"Yeah." Catra exhaled. "I didn't mean to pry, but…I could tell it meant something. The way the Viscount looked at that part of the garden…"

"She hasn't talked about him in years," Glimmer said softly. "But I think being back here, it's… bringing it all up. He died so suddenly. One moment he was laughing in the garden, the next…" She shook her head. "It was the kind of grief that doesn't leave. Not really. Just changes shape."

Catra was quiet. Then: “She carries a lot.”

“She always has,” Glimmer said. “Ever since.”

Catra leaned on the counter, curling her hands around her mug. “I get it. I’m the eldest too, taking care of Perfuma when my Mother– You don’t get to fall apart, even when everything else does.”

There was a pause. Glimmer looked up at her.

“I wouldn’t have done what Mara did,” Catra added quietly, not meeting her eyes. “I’d never leave my sister behind.”

Something about the way she said it: sharp, certain, made Glimmer blink in surprise. Then a slow, understanding smile spread across her face.

“I felt the same way,” she admitted. “I was furious. We both were. But… if their family wants to move past it, we kind of have to go along with it. “

Catra shrugged, but her throat tightened. “I couldn’t forgive her if I was Adora.”

Glimmer nudged her foot under the table. “Good thing you aren’t her. Just be decent. For Adora’s sake.”

That made Catra roll her eyes, but her voice was softer when she said, “She’s… so strict. With herself. With everything.”

“She thinks the world will fall apart if she’s not perfect,” Glimmer said, without bitterness. “Maybe because, for a while, it *did*.”

Catra nodded. Then after a pause, she added, “It’s not a quality I’d want in a suitor for Perfuma. But it’s one I admire. As a sister.”

Glimmer looked at her for a moment, then said gently, “Then maybe don’t punish her for trying to be good. She’s not perfect,

but she loves harder than anyone I know. And if you let her… she might surprise you."

Catra's brow furrowed. "Are you still talking in regards to Perfuma?"

Glimmer tilted her head. "Aren't you?"

But there was something in her voice…something just barely playful and knowing, that made Catra look away, her face warm. She cleared her throat and took a long sip of tea.

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Blooming honeysuckle wafted through the open windows of the living room. Mara had settled herself beside Adora on the grand settee, legs crossed comfortably and elbow hooked on the armrest. Across from them sat Perfuma, hands folded neatly in her lap, her posture open and unguarded.

Adora glanced between the two of them, her fingers absently brushing a lock of hair behind her ear. Mara had invited herself into the conversation under the guise of a friendly chat, but Adora knew her sister well enough to catch the sharper curiosity beneath the soft smiles.

"So," Mara began, casual but direct, "what do you hope for, Perfuma? In your life, I mean. What's the endgame, if there is one?"

Perfuma blinked, then smiled gently. "Oh. That's a big question."

"She's clearly unaware of a concept known as small talk," Adora muttered under her breath, earning a light elbow nudge from Mara and a quiet laugh from Perfuma.

"No, it's fair," Perfuma said, thoughtful now. "I suppose… I want companionship. Not just to be with someone, but to share something. Peace. The kind of peace you build with someone, not the kind you wait for." She looked down for a moment, fingers

brushing over the soft fabric of her dress. “I know that might sound… poetic. Idealistic. I’ve been told I see the world through flowers too often.”

“I imagine flowers see the world quite well,” Mara said.

Perfuma’s smile tilted, appreciative. “I’ve been cared for my whole life. Protected. Especially by my sister. Catra’s always been... relentless about it. She fought off every heartbreak, every harsh lesson, before it could reach me. I don’t take that for granted. But I also don’t want to be fragile forever. I want to grow. To work on myself. To be someone who can give as much as she receives, if that’s what the universe intends for me.”

Adora watched her, words caught in her throat. There was something soft and searching in Perfuma’s gaze that made her chest ache a little.

Mara nodded, polite and kind, but Adora could sense it, something not quite clicking behind her sister’s eyes.

Later that afternoon, the drawing room long emptied and the moon hanging high outside the windows, Adora paced in her study. The desk was covered in scattered papers, the scent of old ink and candlewax clinging to the air.

Mara leaned in the doorway, arms crossed, her expression unreadable.

“She’s perfect,” Adora said, out of nowhere.

“She is,” Mara agreed, after a pause. “Perfect. In the general sense.”

Adora turned, annoyed, already. “What does that mean?”

Mara took a few steps in, the soft swish of her long coat brushing the floor. “It means she’s lovely. And kind. And well-suited to practically anyone, I imagine. But I’m not asking about people in general, Adora. I’m asking about *you* .”

Adora turned back to the desk, palms braced on the surface. "Why are you so against this?"

"I'm not," Mara said. Her voice was quiet. "Not if you love her."

There was a long pause. Then Adora scoffed, shoulders tensing. "I don't know what that's meant to feel like. Maybe it'll come in time."

Mara stepped closer, voice still soft. "That's not nothing, Adora. That *uncertainty.* You talk about her like she's a duty, not a dream."

"I *do* care for her," Adora said, almost defensively. "She's gentle. Smart. Patient. I know I can give her a good life. I'm not seeing anyone else, and she deserves someone who's ready."

"Deserve has never been the same as *want* . And do you really want to be the one to give her a good life? Don't you want to be the one that gets taken care of for once?"

"She said she wants to take care of people!"

"But she also needs someone who is equally there to emotionally take care of her too!" Mara yelled.

"Maybe I can do that! You barely know me!" Adora yelled back.

"Of course I know you! I knew you for twenty one years, Adora!" Mara was pouting childishly and tears welled in her eyes, Adora imagined her own expression mirrored that.

"I just…" Mara cut in, sniffing. "I just think you need someone more like you. If you are sure about her though-"

Adora snapped her gaze to face her sister. "I *am* sure," she said, eyes narrowed. "I'm going to propose. Soon."

Mara studied her face for a long moment, lips pressed together. Then she nodded once. "Alright," she said. "If that's what you

truly want.”

Adora growled and then stalked out of the room, heading towards the stables.

She needed to ride.

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She was storming more than walking, her boots striking the cobblestone floor with rhythmic irritation, shoulders tense, jaw clenched. The smell of hay and leather should have soothed her like it used to when she was younger, but not today.

She turned the corner sharply, and collided straight into someone’s shoulder.

Adora didn’t expect anyone to be in the stables.

“Stars-” she gritted out, stumbling slightly, her hand shooting out to steady herself on the stall door.

“Watch it,” came the reply, dry and bristling.

Adora blinked up, already recognising the voice, of course it was Catra.

The Magicat raised a brow, arms folded over a fitted riding vest, her hair slightly windswept as though she had already been out for a short ride. “I was here first, you know.”

Adora bristled at her shortness, but was too exhausted to argue. “I know.” She muttered, brushing straw off her sleeve. “Whatever, I’ll go somewhere else.”

Catra blinked, seemingly caught off guard by the immediate retreat. “Wait- I…Are you okay?”

By the awkwardness on Catra’s face, it was like the question pained her to ask.

Adora stilled, her mouth opened as if to respond, then closed again. She bit her bottom lip, hard, trying to summon the practiced smile she usually wore around the family. Instead, her expression hardened, her spine going straight.

"Yeah. Just... stressed," she said, waving a dismissive hand.

Catra scoffed. "That's bullshit."

Adora's head snapped up, surprised.

"I passed the drawing room," Catra continued, stepping closer. "Didn't hear what it was about, but there was *definitely* yelling. That's not 'just stress,' Adora."

Adora's face flushed, not wanting to be called out on her obvious lie "Maybe you should mind your own business." She gritted out, scowling at her.

The woman in turn growled. "Oh, please. I was literally minding my business before you stomped in here like a thundercloud ready to scream at the next person you saw."

Adora opened her mouth to retort, then paused.

She sighed. The anger, like a balloon pricked by something sharp, slowly deflated in her chest.

"You're right," she said quietly. "Sorry."

That caught Catra off guard more than the yelling. She blinked once, then shifted uncomfortably. "I suppose you are right too," she muttered. "I shouldn't have pushed."

They stood in silence for a moment, the distant sound of horses snorting in their stalls filling the air between them. A heavy weight in the air, neither of them seeming to know where to go from there.

Then Catra's mouth curled into a grin.

“You wanna race?”

Adora blinked, confused. “What?”

Catra jerked her chin toward the row of horses. “Come on. I already had one saddled up. Thought I’d stretch my legs a bit. Or are you too scared I’ll beat you… *again?”*

Adora’s brows lifted slowly, the beginnings of a real smile tugging at the corners of her mouth. “You just got lucky that time. I was… off my game.”

“Well Viscount,” Catra practically purred, stepping closer, causing Adora to gulp. “Here’s your chance to prove it.” She smiled, shoving a saddle into her arms and promptly walking to her own horse and mounting it.

Adora shook her head, amused despite herself. “You are insufferable.”

“And yet,” Catra said, already turning toward her horse, “here you are, still following me.”

Adora hesitated a moment longer before stepping forward and picking her own mare.

“Fine,” she said, mounting with ease. “Let’s see who really ends up eating dust.”

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Catra paced the room like a caged animal.

“This is bad,” she muttered, dragging both hands down her face before bunching them in her hair. “This is *so* fucking bad.”

Her boots echoed sharply on the floorboards as she made another tight turn. The walls of the guest chamber felt like they were closing in, thick with the scent of lilac incense from the sticks

Perfuma had purchased and the faint echo of hoofbeats still ringing in her ears.

She should never have suggested that fucking ride.

She had told herself it was just some harmless fun, a way to take the edge off after the standoff in the stables and to take Adora's mind off of her other previous fight with her sister. But the moment Adora's ponytail had snagged on a low hanging branch, and her hair had tumbled down around her shoulders like liquid gold in the sunlight as she galloped ahead through the trees, Catra had known.

She was utterly done for.

Every smug grin Adora threw over her shoulder, every teasing glance, every wild, unabashed laugh that broke loose without thought, Catra clung to longer than she should. Admiring them as though she was meeting a new woman. Admiring them way longer than she had any *right* to.

And now? She was *liking* her. Not just admiring or begrudgingly respecting. *Liking* **.** Like a friend. Like… something else.

Catra stopped, hands on her hips, heart pounding. "Nope," she whispered to herself. "This ends now."

They had been distant before, which had been safe. Sure, Catra had been attracted to her the minute she saw her but that clearly was secondary when she downright hated the woman. It was more controlled that way, when their interactions were brief and tense. She would dial herself back again, retreat.

No more riding, no more challenges or teasing, no getting stuck in a bog together.

She'd be short, curt. Dismissive, even. Just until the proposal came. And then it would all be over.

She had just taken a breath to center herself when the door creaked open.

"Catra?" Perfuma's soft voice preceded her entrance.

Catra spun around, instinctively straightening. "Hey Fuma…" She looked up, seeing the unusual look of anxiety on her younger sister's face, "you okay?"

Perfuma's usually sunny expression was dimmed, her brows knit with worry. She hesitated in the doorway before stepping in, wringing her hands. "I... don't know."

Catra's concern overrode everything else she had just been feeling. She closed the distance quickly, guiding Perfuma toward the little divan beneath the window. "What's wrong?"

Perfuma sat down, fidgeting with the edge of her sleeve. "I suppose... I'm just a little anxious. It's been weeks. And still there's…nothing."

Catra blinked. "Nothing?"

"No proposal," Perfuma said softly.

Catra frowned. "You think she's not going to?"

Perfuma bit her lip. "I don't know. I *thought* she was serious. I *think* she is. She even said she intended to but… But then why is it taking so long?" She looked over, eyes wide and anxious. "Am I just fooling myself?"

"You're not," Catra said, though the words tasted wrong. "Maybe she just… needs more time."

Perfuma gave a brittle little laugh. "I know. I keep telling myself that. Maybe she's being thoughtful. Careful. But…" She trailed off, then took a breath. "What if she's only being careful because she's not sure? She says all the right things and she…she is doing

everything right but I can't help but feel like there's still a barrier… that I'm missing something."

Catra shifted awkwardly. "There's still time. Maybe there are— other options."

Perfuma looked at her then, surprised. "You think I should look elsewhere?"

Catra winced. "No- I mean… I don't know. I just meant... if she's unsure, you don't have to wait around forever."

"But I want this to work," Perfuma said quickly. "I *do* like her. I know I'm idealistic, but I believe in building something peaceful, steady. I think she does too."

Catra sighed and nodded, but her stomach twisted.

Perfuma went quiet for a moment, then turned her gaze sharply on Catra. "I know why it's taking so long."

Catra's heart seized. "What?"

"It's you."

Catra sat up straight, spine stiff. "What's that supposed to mean?"

Perfuma reached out and took her hand gently. "Not because you're doing anything wrong. Not really. But I think she's... scared. That you don't like her. That she isn't welcome."

Catra looked away. "That's not fair."

"I'm not accusing you," Perfuma said softly. "But it *feels* that way to her, I think. You glare at her. You challenge her. You don't laugh with her the way you do with Glimmer or I. And I know you. I know that's not who you really are."

Catra swallowed. "Fuma, I don't…"

Perfuma squeezed her hand. “Please. Just try. Try to let her in a little. Show her the you that *I* see. Because I think if she feels like she’s part of *our* world, not just some outsider trying to win me over, then maybe she’ll feel like she belongs. Like she can love us both.”

Catra looked down at their joined hands, feeling bile rise in her throat. Just mere minutes ago she was deciding to step away from Adora, and now here her sister was, trying to push her back into the arms of her suitor, completely oblivious to Catra’s feelings.

“Just get to know her,” Perfuma urged. “It doesn’t have to be much. But spend time with her. Let her see you. Because you’re a beautiful person when you let people in.”

Catra wanted to say no. She wanted to run.

But Perfuma’s eyes were so hopeful.

“Okay,” she whispered, voice tight. “I’ll try.”

Perfuma smiled in relief and pulled her into a hug. Catra closed her eyes, breathing in the scent of rosewater and warmth, guilt prickling at her chest.

Because *trying* was going to get her in deeper.
And she wasn’t sure how much farther she could fall before it was too late.

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When the royal carriage arrived, the Grayskull footmen rushed to greet it. The estate buzzed with preparations for the soon upcoming ball, but all fell momentarily quiet as the grand doors opened and Queen Angella stepped down with all the grace of royalty who knew precisely how to command a room to her attention.

Trailing after her came two markedly less regal figures, one towering and bashful, the other small and bouncing, almost entirely upside down as she leaned far out of the coach to inspect the axle.

Catra, standing on the periphery near the fountain, raised a brow.

"Princess Scorpia of the Scorpioni Kingdom," the butler announced with a mild look of panic, as Scorpia offered an eager wave, nearly knocking off the cap of the servant closest to her. "And Princess Entrapta of Dryl."

Scorpia bumbled forward with an apologetic grin and spotted Catra at once. "Lady Catra! Hi there- uh, I mean, hello. It's nice to see you again!" Her voice cracked at the end and she blushed furiously, making Catra smile a little fondly.

"Yes, it's a pleasure to meet you again."

Scorpia beamed, blushing pink and then gesturing behind her. "This is my friend Entrapta, she's a princess and also a genius? You'll see."

"Hello!" Entrapta called, swinging her feet down from the carriage and landing with a puff of dust. "Nice to meet you!"

She extended a thick strand of purple hair, which coiled toward Catra like a handshake.

Catra's eyes widened. "That's…okay, that's incredible. You control it? Fully?"

Entrapta beamed, her hair still shaking Catra's hand. "Yes! It responds to neurological impulses, kind of like an extension of my motor function. Would you like to see it pick up a teacup? Or dismantle a lock? Or braid a bird's nest?"

Catra opened her mouth to answer that she absolutely would love to see that, but Entrapta's gaze had snapped elsewhere.

“WHAT IS *THAT* ?!” she screeched, pointing with both hands.

Melog, lounging in a patch of sunlight on the terrace, startled at the sound, tail flicking.

Entrapta bolted forward, arms wide, hair flailing like a flag in the wind. “You are *magnificent!* You don’t even have bones, do you?! Oh—do you speak? Wait, you must! What’s your magical field output? Can I scan you??”

Melog backed up, eyes narrowed warily. It sniffed once, twice, then gently nudged its head into Entrapta’s hair.

Entrapta gasped. “It’s communicating through touch! This is better than I imagined!”

While she babbled on, Catra felt someone shuffle beside her. Scorpia was lingering awkwardly.

“Sorry about her. She gets… excited. Uh, how’s your stay here been so far?”

Catra, arms crossed, offered a polite shrug. “No need to apologise. It’s nice to have some life here. The estate is…quiet. Nature-filled. Not bad.”

“That’s good!” Scorpia nodded. “It’s beautiful here. I mean, wow, so many trees! And birds! And the *grass* !”

Catra raised a brow but didn’t reply.

She spotted Perfuma across the courtyard, deep in conversation with Adora, their heads tilted toward one another. Catra frowned, then grabbed Scorpia gently by the arm.

“You haven’t met my sister yet, have you? Come.”

Scorpia’s eyes widened in panic but followed obediently as Catra cut across the gravel.

Perfuma looked up as they approached. “Catra,” she said, eyes narrowing slightly.

“I brought someone to meet you,” Catra said smoothly. “It’s not bad to meet other options, is it?” she whispered under her breath, just loud enough for Perfuma to hear.

Perfuma’s eyes flashed. “Catra. Don’t.”

But then she turned, and her expression shifted slightly. Scorpia stood with her hands clasped, smiling brightly and not at all subtly. “Hi! I’m Scorpia. It’s so nice to meet you, Lady Perfuma!”

Perfuma froze, a faint pink blooming in her cheeks. “Oh…Uh- I… hello. Yes. A pleasure.”

Catra watched in silence, her eyes flicking from the blooming flush on Perfuma’s face to the entirely oblivious delight on Scorpia’s to just meet another friend.

Adora, still standing nearby, glanced at Catra as if to ask if she had done that on purpose. Catra smirked, folding her arms and rocking back on her heels.

“Just being helpful, Viscount,” she said with a shrug, voice casual, but her heart was thudding a little harder than it should have.

Because this had just gotten complicated.

Again.

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The night was quiet, but not peaceful. It was the kind of quiet that pressed deep into Catra’s chest, trapping her beneath the covers and leaving her breathless.

She woke with a gasp, torn from her sleep by a suffocating dread. Her sheets were twisted, damp with sweat, her body tense and aching. Her throat felt raw, though she wasn't sure if she had screamed out loud or just inside her mind.

The dream still clung to her every bone, viscous and unrelenting. Her Mama's voice, soft but final: Take care of them kitten. The last thing she had ever said to Catra, and she hadn't even understood what she had meant, not until they returned from their brief trip from the seaside markets, arms full of silks and satins, only to find the house thick with the sweet foul stench of death.

Catra pressed her hands to her face, then swung her legs over the side of the bed, shaking.

She had screamed for the maids to get Perfuma and her Mother out, away from the smell, away from the sight of the woman who had raised them lying rigid and thin, her smile had gone slack. Catra had stayed. Of course she had. Stayed beside her until the morticians came. She still remembered the flies, the sound they made as they flitted across her dead body that looked as though it would melt in the heatwave that had plagued Halfmoon that year.

She couldn't breathe.

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Getting up, she staggered to the balcony doors and shoved them open, desperate for air. The cool night kissed her sweaty fevered skin, and then she froze.

Adora was already there.

She stood with her back to the door, leaning against the stone, her sheer white nightgown catching the moonlight, hair loose around her shoulders. The curve of her neck turned when seh heard the door creak.

"Catra?" Her voice was rough with sleep but somehow still gentle. "Are you alright?"

Catra tried to speak, to dismiss her, but no sound came. Her mouth opened and closed like she could shake the dream from her tongue.

Adora's brow furrowed and she looked at her worriedly. "You're shaking,"

"I'm fine," she croaked, a lie that was so transparent it added to her nausea.

Adora stepped closer again. "You're not."

Without waiting for permission, she took Catra's wrist in her hand, firm but not forceful. Her fingers found the rapid, erratic thrum of Catra's pulse.

"This sometimes helps me," she admitted quietly.

Catra blinked at her.

"Count the beats. Breathe with them. It helps."

The warmth of Adora's fingers shouldn't have felt like an anchor, but it did. Catra, shaking, wild-eyed, let her breath sync with the rhythm Adora whispered.

"In… two… three… four. Out… two… three… four."

The breaths were so exhilarating it made her a little dizzy. Gradually, the world returned to her, slower and quieter. The night didn't feel so foreboding and choking anymore.

Her eyes flicked up to Adora's, the blue in them calming her as though she was truly looking at the sky and not the black of the night.

"Nightmare…" she croaked out.

Adora nodded, her gaze still soft and sincere. "I understand," she admitted.

Catra hesitated, something thick and rising in her throat. “My mother.”

“My father.”

“I saw…” Catra trailed off, jutting her chin in the direction of the gravestone, causing Adora to nod again.

“It seems…” Catra began again, her voice quieter now, roughened by the rawness of what she’d shared. She hesitated, eyes tracing Adora’s face, searching for something she couldn’t name. “It seems we have that in common. Taking care of our families after…”

There was a tremble in her words, not just from the memory, but from how close Adora still was, the steady heat of her body grounding her in the dark. She wasn’t sure why she said it, why she pressed further, but part of her didn’t want the quiet to close around them again. Maybe if Adora kept speaking, the memories wouldn’t feel so sharp.

Catra’s shoulders gave a small, involuntary shiver, and without thinking, she let out a faint sound, a soft, low purr, the kind she barely realized she made anymore. It wasn’t for Adora. Not really. It was for herself. A sound she’d made as a girl to self-soothe in long nights alone. But now it rumbled gently in the space between them, and it made Adora pause.

Adora’s expression shifted. Her brows softened, lips parting slightly in surprise. She stared at Catra like she was seeing something new and precious. Not pitiful, *awed* .

The purr deepened for a moment, before Catra caught herself and swallowed it down, face heating with embarrassment. She looked away. “Sorry. I— I don’t usually…”

But Adora shook her head slowly, her voice barely above a whisper. “Don’t apologise.”

She looked at Catra like she was something *extraordinary* , not broken, not strange. Just *real* . And in that quiet space between them, something shifted. Something warm and delicate and frightening.

"I didn't…" Adora's voice caught, brittle and thin. Her eyes stayed locked on the stars beyond the balcony, but her hand had curled slightly against the railing. "I didn't want to take care of everyone."

The admission hung between them like a breath held too long.

Catra didn't speak right away. She *felt* it, the way Adora's chest rose with the weight of saying something she'd never dared give voice to. Not out loud. Not even, perhaps, to herself. Slowly, Catra nodded, her expression softening. There was something sacred in the moment — in being the person Adora chose to say this to.

"You shouldn't have had to," Catra said, and her voice came out sharper than she meant, rough with old rage. Her hands clenched at her sides, her tail twitching. "It wasn't your burden, it was-"

"It shouldn't have been anyone's burden," Adora interrupted, but not with anger. Her voice trembled with the weight of clarity. "Not one person should have… been responsible for everyone else's grief. We should've leaned on each other."

Catra inhaled, her own throat tightening. She looked at Adora, really looked, and for the first time, she didn't see the perfectly pressed Viscount, the polished heir holding up the legacy of Grayskull with straight shoulders and tired eyes. She saw a girl. A *young* woman who had been asked to carry too much too soon. Who had done it without complaint, because that's what everyone expected.

"I suppose," Catra said finally, her voice quieter now. "Your mother, Mara… everyone *should* have helped. But it doesn't always work that way. People…" She exhaled slowly. "People disappear. Even when they're right in front of you."

Adora turned then, eyes shining but dry, and nodded once, a small, aching movement. They stood in silence again, but this time it didn't sting. It wrapped around them like a shared truth, warm despite everything it carried.

A soft rustle stirred the quiet between them.

Melog appeared soundlessly from the hallway shadows, eyes shimmering gently in the moonlight. The creature padded forward and coiled themself around Catra and Adora's legs bumping and purring into their warmth. A low, soothing trill filled the space, not quite a purr and almost a song, just enough to shift the air, and to press them closer together.

Adora blinked at the sound, and Catra glanced down, murmuring a soft, amused "Hey, log." But as she looked up again, her breath caught.

Adora was staring at the horizon, jaw tight, her shoulders rigid, but her eyes shone, glassy and rimmed red. Her hand came up, brushing discreetly at the corner of her eye, but it was no use.

Catra's heart sank. That old, protective ache rose in her chest. She cleared her throat gently. "Adora..." she said, voice rough. "Do you maybe… want a hug?"

Adora didn't look at her right away. But after a beat, she nodded. Just a small dip of her chin. And that was enough.

Catra stepped forward and wrapped her arms around the taller woman, tucking her chin to Adora's shoulder. The hug started stiff, uncertain. But then Adora melted.

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She couldn't remember the last time she'd been hugged like this.

Not politely embraced. Not tapped on the shoulder in consolation. But held. *Seen* . Her arms wrapped tightly around Catra's waist, and she buried her face in the crook of Catra's neck, the scent of

her, warm spices and linen, flooding her senses. Her heart beat harder with each breath. Her chest rose and fell too quickly. She wasn't sure if it was the vulnerability, the comfort, or…

She pulled back slightly, needing air, needing distance…and found Catra already watching her. Her eyes were wide, pupils dilated, uncertain. *Scared* , maybe. Adora's breath caught.

And that's when she noticed.

They were both in their nightgowns, sheer and thin from the heat of summer. Their bodies pressed together, nipples hard, brushing fabric and touching. Adora froze. Her cheeks flushed. She willed herself not to look down, to keep her gaze steady on Catra's, but even *that* felt dangerous. Catra's eyes flicked lower down her face. Once. Then again.

A jolt of heat spread through Adora's spine.

"Adora...what are we doing?" Catra whispered, her voice trembling like a struck chord.

Adora's pulse thundered in her ears. "I don't… I don't know," she breathed.

She leaned in. Just a little. She was angled close enough now to feel the hitch of Catra's breath, see the flutter of her lashes as she closed her eyes and angled her own face up further.

And then the door slammed open.

Adora sprang back like she'd been burned.

Mara stood in the doorway, her face pale, wide-eyed. "Is everything alright?" she asked, her voice caught between concern and suspicion.

Adora swallowed hard, chest heaving, shame creeping in. "Yes. We were just-" she didn't know how to finish that sentence.

Catra had already stepped away, gaze averted, arms crossed tightly across her chest.

Melog had vanished.

And the cool night air felt much colder now.

Chapter End Notes

Hey! Thanks so much for your guys support and encouragement on this fic, it truly motivates me so hard. I've kinda set myself up for writing a bit more about grief now, since I know a heck of a lot more about it after this past week,, so if I end up going really into it soon then that's why.

Chapter 8: This curse

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora stood in the drawing room, the large windows bathing the room in silver light, cascading down her body and leaving her breathless. Her hair was down, cascading down her back and unbound for what felt like the first time in years. The air was warm, despite the hour, heavy with the scent of foxgloves and lilac, and the buzz of crickets hummed low in the distance.

She didn't remember walking here, but it didn't matter.

The door creaked open.

Adora stilled, breath caught, and then she saw her.

Catra.

She emerged from the doorway like a secret taking shape. Her nightgown clung softly to her body, almost sheer in the moonlight. Her hair was tousled from sleep, the shorter strands curling along her jaw. Barefoot, bare-armed, her golden skin glowed. Her eyes were unreadable, focused.

Adora forgot how to breathe.

"I thought I might find you here," Catra said, her voice low and a little amused.

"You were…looking for me?" Adora's own voice sounded faraway, breathless even to her.

"Perhaps I was." She shrugged, stepping closer.

Adora didn't move.

The moonlight bathed everything in silver, but Catra's presence burned in gold. Heat pooled low in Adora's stomach as she caught the faint scent of her, soft cologne and something sweet. Her heart beat faster. The world felt both impossibly sharp and dangerously soft.

"I couldn't sleep," Adora said, her voice smaller now, honest.

"Neither could I." She whispered, her gaze flicking down to Adora's bare legs, then back up her face, making the blonde gulp.

They were too close.

Adora felt her body sway forward before she could even think to stop herself, a tether that had been pulled far too taught already, snapping inside of her. Catra's hand came up in tandem, slow and sure, brushing a stray blonde strand from her face, the touch a whisper against her cheek. Adora didn't flinch like she usually would have, instead she leaned into it.

This was dangerous, but she couldn't bring herself to pull away. She was showing a tremendous amount of strength not taking Catra against the door like she had wished to for so long.

"You're flushed," Catra said.

"So are you."

They stared at each other.

And then Catra leaned in.

Her lips brushed against Adora's cheek first, a lingering, uncertain pressure near the corner of her mouth. Testing. Waiting.

Adora tilted her head. "Please," she whispered, her gaze flitting to meet Catra's hungry one. She didn't know where the plea had come from, she had never pleaded for something in her life, not since…

But maybe she should start, because that was all it took.

The kiss came hot and breathless, with no hesitation now. Catra's hand slid tightly to her waist, pulling her in as though she was fragile, and Adora gasped into the contact. Their bodies pressed together just like it had on the balcony, the soft linen clinging to damp skin and giving her a very realistic depiction of what Catra's unclothed body would feel against hers. Suddenly the room didn't exist anymore, only the taste of Catra's mouth, the way her lips moved against Adora's, hungry and searching. Their noses bumped, teeth softly clashed, breaths tangled and Adora let out a soft gasp that startled even her.

Catra caught it, drank it like she'd been starving.

Adora gripped her arms, fingers curling around bare, toned skin, feeling the flex of muscle beneath. Her mind was clouded with sensation, the heat between them, the scrape of Catra's claws on her back through the nightgown, the feeling of her own pulse thudding wildly in her neck.

She could barely stand.

Then Catra pulled back, just slightly, resting her forehead against Adora's, both of them panting.

"I've wanted to do that for so long," she murmured.

Adora's eyes fluttered shut. "Why didn't you?"

Catra's fingers ghosted along the curve of her neck. "Because I didn't think you'd let me."

Adora's hands shook as she raised them to cradle Catra's face. "Maybe I didn't think I would either."

They kissed again, slower this time, almost reverent. Catra's mouth moved to her jaw, her throat, whispering heat against the fluttering pulse there. Adora arched into her, her body aching with

want, with release, with *feeling* . There was nothing logical here– no titles, no expectations, no Perfuma, no duty.

Only Catra.

Her hands slipped beneath the fabric of Adora's nightgown, skimming over skin, fingers splayed across her back. Adora moaned softly and buried her face into the crook of Catra's neck, inhaling her like oxygen.

"Catra…" she gasped.

"Mmm?"

But the sound of her name cracked the illusion. Something in Adora's chest twisted.

This wasn't real.

And she knew it suddenly.

Like a bucket of cold water, the realization hit her. She wasn't in the garden. She was in her bed. Alone.

Adora jolted upright in the dark, sheets tangled around her thighs, her nightgown clinging to sweat-damp skin. Her breath came in gasps. Her lips still tingled. Her body still burned. And her heart…

Her heart was breaking and twisting guiltily.

She pressed a hand to her chest.

Because it hadn't felt like a dream.

It had felt like *what she wanted* .

And that was more terrifying than anything.

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Catra had decided that she would still try her utmost best to be more distant from the viscount. Maybe she could not be physically distant, but emotionally, she was going to cut off. Whatever was happening with Adora was dangerous and utterly unfair to Perfuma. She hadn't done anything with the Viscount and still felt as though it was probably only more from her end, but still, it was wrong. She had told herself that it was just until the Viscount proposed, then they would shortly be wed and she would be off to Halfmoon. Away from that infuriating blonde ponytail, and living a life by herself, with utterly no regrets.

She contemplated on her plan as she sat with her legs tucked beneath her on the bench, a delicate porcelain teacup balanced in her hand as she stared at the blooms she couldn't name. Perfuma, sitting across from her, poured more tea and hummed along to the chirping of the birds - serenely composed as always.

Catra sipped slowly, letting the warmth settle her frayed nerves. After last night's nightmare and…the fiasco after, she needed something gentle.

Then came the soft crunch of boots on gravel.

She didn't need to look up to know who it was.

Adora's voice was light, careful. "Good morning, Lady Perfuma. Lady Catra."

Perfuma looked up and smiled warmly. "Good morning, Viscount."

Catra flicked her gaze to Adora and then away just as quickly. Her cheeks burned softly at the image of what Adora looked like at night, her hair down and her utterly feminine nightgown, clinging to her loosely. The memory haunted her in the worst way.

It seemed she wasn't the only one avoiding eye contact, as Adora had turned her unreadable gaze to set to Perfuma and did not let it wander.

"I wanted to let you know," Adora said, directing her words to Perfuma, "that I'll be riding out shortly. My siblings and I are going on a hunt with the Queen's party."

Perfuma blinked. "A hunt?" She wrinkled her nose delicately and set her cup down. "Oh, I don't think I'll join. I find hunting… well, rather savage. All that violence and blood, it's hardly meditative."

Perfuma was understating her dislike. She found hunting barbaric, and usually despised any mention of it. Too often had she cried when Catra announced she herself was going hunting, she would beg Catra to stop, or to at least let them go after she caught them. The sadness in her voice did make her go hunting less. She had only been a handful of times in the past decade.

Adora tilted her head, not surprised but maybe a touch disappointed. "Of course, I understand."

Perfuma brightened. "But Catra enjoys the occasional hunt, don't you, sweet pea?"

Catra choked slightly on her tea. "Uh I..what?"

Perfuma leaned toward her and whispered, "Catra…you promised you'd try to get on her good side."

Catra narrowed her eyes at her sister, who was now giving her the sweetest smile in the realm.

She did say that but…things were even worse now! It was almost perilous to be around Adora alone now.

Adora blinked, looking between them. "There's no need, really. If you're not interested, Catra, I can-"

"Why?" Perfuma interrupted gently, with a teasing lilt. "You don't think my sister can handle it?"

Adora bristled, just a little. "No, it's not that. I'm sure she's capable, but I doubt she's experienced with Brightmoon's terrain

or our hunting traditions. The creatures here are… particular.”

Catra raised an eyebrow. “Particular?”

“Yes,” Adora said, lifting her chin. “And unpredictable. The last thing we need is someone getting hurt.”

Oh here she goes again, thinking she’s better than everyone again. Why did Catra even like her again?

“Oh, I see,” Catra said, her voice as sharp as the blade she wasn’t currently carrying. “You think I’m going to be some helpless deadweight?”

Adora sighed. “I didn’t say that.”

“You didn’t have to.”

Perfuma, caught in the middle, looked mildly amused.

Catra stood, placing her teacup down with a deliberate *clink* . “I’ve hunted in Halfmoon since I was twelve. Woods are woods, animals are animals, and I know how to track and shoot.”

Adora crossed her arms. “It’s not about shooting, it’s about understanding-”

“-These oh so 'particular' Brightmoon creatures?” Catra said with a roll of her eyes. “Are they enchanted with royal manners too?”

Adora’s nostrils flared. “Fine. If you want to come and prove your point, be my guest.”

Catra smirked, victorious. “Gladly.”

Perfuma sipped her tea, humming, seeming utterly pleased with herself.

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The forest was alive with birdsong and the distant snap of twigs underneath hoofs as the Grayskull hunting party rode out in stately procession. Adora kept a polite pace a few beats in front of Catra, though the air between them was silent and thick with tension, despite the groups chatter.

“We should stick to the path,” Adora said firmly, nodding toward the winding trail ahead. “It’s wide enough for the horses, and familiar. That’s where the game will be.”

Catra scoffed, rolling her eyes from atop her dappled gray mare. “You mean that’s where all the noise will be coming from.”

Adora arched a brow, “the noise will flush the prey from their hiding places. It’ll cause birds to fly out into the clearing.”

“No, noise warns prey.” Catra turned her horse sharply towards a narrower trail that veered to the left, its entrance half-covered by drooping moss. “You’re going to spook everything if you ride in with a parade.”

“That’s called coordination.” Glimmer butted in.

“No, it’s called amateur hour,” Catra muttered, and with a click of her tongue, she nudged her horse off the trail and into the brush, disappearing beneath the canopy of whispering leaves.

Adora stared after her, bristling. “Unbelievable.”

“Go after her.” Lonnie told Adora. “Make sure she doesn’t get lost.”

“Maybe…one of us should go after her instead?” Mara cleared her throat, gazing at Adora with a stern look that none of the other group seemed to notice.

“No,” Adam waved off, “if she is going to be her sister-in-law, they need to learn how to get along. Go, Adora.”

Adora swallowed, feeling like a scolded child under Mara's simmering gaze, and Adam's stern one. Still, she grumbled under her breath and steered her own horse in the direction of Catra. Low branches slapped at her arms and she winced as her boots scraped against a jagged root.

She finally caught sight of Catra dismounted, crouched behind a fallen log, rifle in hand. She was poised, surprisingly quiet, every part of her body trained on a shadow just ahead. A red-furred creature moved cautiously through the brush.

Then Adora scoffed. Catra was holding the rifle wrong. The grip was stiff, her shoulder too high, her stance all wrong for the Brightmoon weapon.

Adora dismounted quickly and crept up behind her. "You're going to dislocate your shoulder."

Catra flinched slightly at her voice but didn't look back.

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Adora pressed forward, one hand sliding gently against Catra's wrist, the other adjusting her shoulder. Her chest touched Catra's back, her breath brushing against the shell of her ear as she murmured, "The recoil is different from Halfmoon rifles. The trigger is lighter, but it will kick sharper, it will hurt you if you hold it like this."

Catra tensed, holding her breath as Adora's breath tickled her ear, as her fingers brushed the nape of her neck as she adjusted her shoulder, as she placed her fingers atop of Catra's to adjust it closer toward the base of the trigger. Why was she doing this? Surely she knew she was affecting Catra so? Did she not know how much this could cost them? Was she just toying with her?

She steeled, inhaling and then- "Back off, Adora."

Adora blinked, stepping back immediately. "I was just helping."

“I didn’t ask you to,” Catra snapped, still focused ahead, waiting for the creature to make its way into the clearing. “This is not yours to concern yourself with.”

Adora sighed, “It *is* my concern if you get hurt on a hunt, *I* invited you to. Here, you are my responsibility-”

“I am *not* your responsibility!” Catra growled out. “Why do you need to control everything-!”

“This is not about control it’s-”

“Shut up.” Catra slapped a hand over Adora’s mouth and Adora’s eyes widened, staring at Catra who was suddenly all too close. Then- she removed her hand, dropped to the floor on all fours, disregarding her rifle and wiggling her hips slightly.

In one swift, fluid motion, she vaulted over the log like it was a practice beam, and took off after the creature on all fours, with a low, catlike grace. Adora blinked, stunned as she watched Catra weave through the trees, lithe and fast, her movements feline and practice.

She didn’t shoot.

She *pounced.*

There was a sharp yelp, a thud, and then silence.

Adora rushed forward only to find Catra crouched proudly over the stunned creature, breathing hard witha wild glint in her eye. Her hair was mussed wildly, her legs braced in dirt and her body vibrating with a loud purr from the thrill of the chase.

Adora felt her mouth go dry.

“You *tackled* it,” she said, somewhere between horrified and impressed.

Catra looked up, a smirk tugging at her lips. “Told you I could handle it.”

Adora stared at her, stared unabashedly, at the flush on her cheeks, the rise and fall of her chest, the spark in her eyes. *She is utterly ridiculous,* she thought. *She is incredible.*

And, stars help her, cute. That was the main thing on her mind as she stared at the purring feline with wide, dilated eyes sparkling proudly at her prey.

“I..uh” Adora coughed. “That’s not how hunting is usually done here.”

“Maybe you should change the rules,” Catra said, brushing dirt off her palms and tossing her hair over her shoulder.

Adora opened her mouth to argue, but couldn’t seem to remember how. So she shut it again and just followed Catra’s stride as she headed back to retrieve her rifle, smug as ever.

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Perfuma paced the length of her guest chamber, fingers twisting the edge of her shawl in anxious spirals. The soft scent of pressed herbs wafted from the open window, the late afternoon breeze carrying with it the distant echoes of horse hooves, The Viscount and her sister, still away on their hunt.

She let out a frustrated breath and sat briefly on the edge of the bed, only to stand again, restless. Her thoughts refused to settle. It should have been simple. Adora was kind. Responsible. Poised. She was a viscount, noble, dependable, and with a future Perfuma could step into like a well-tailored gown. It was the life she had always imagined for herself: warm hearths, joint causes, quiet affection, and steady, loyal companionship.

But why, then, was her heart so tangled?

She turned toward the mirror and caught her own reflection, eyes clouded with something she couldn’t name. Yesterday's meeting with Princess Scorpia had stirred something in her—something foolish, perhaps. Childish. A flutter in her chest she had brushed off as mere novelty. Scorpia was funny, bright-eyed, a little clumsy, and… warm. So extremely warm. Her laugh had been genuine, her awkwardness charming. And she had looked at Perfuma like she mattered, not for her status or her title or her worth as a diamond of the season, but for her *self* . Still, what did that mean? They had known each other for a day. Twenty-four hours was not a lifetime. It was barely a heartbeat. Adora did see her as the Season’s Diamond. And she could not fault her for it, she was looking for someone who was equally dependable, motherly and stable- and Perfuma was exactly that…so why did it feel so good when Scorpia asked her about her favourite flowers, her favourite composers and her meditation process?

Perfuma groaned softly and leaned her forehead against the cool wood of the window frame.

“This is ridiculous,” she whispered to herself. “Get your head out of the flower bushes.”

She had promised herself she would stop romanticizing everything. It had been a vow she’d made after watching her sister break herself to take care of them both. Perfuma had told herself she would be mature now, clear-headed, grounded. Love would not be a whirlwind. It would be mutual peace, shared goals, and stability. That’s what Adora offered.

And yet…

The flowers in her stomach bloomed anyway when she thought of someone else's laugh.

Perfuma stepped away from the window, heart pounding harder than she liked. She hated feeling unmoored. This wasn’t like her.

She needed clarity. So she made a decision, one that felt as close to control as she could manage.

"I'll stop chasing it," she murmured aloud. "Adora already knows who I am. She's had time. If she wants this… truly wants *me* , then she'll say so. If not…"

Her voice caught.

"If not, then I have to stop wasting my heart on maybes."

Perfuma stood straighter, wrapping her arms around herself.

"One more week," she said, more firmly now. "No more pretending. No more planting gardens on barren soil. Either something grows… or I walk away."

She tried to ignore the image that surfaced, one not of Adora, but of stronger arms and a beaming grin, and a voice that had called her name like it was sunlight.

She shut her eyes.

"Just one more week."

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Mara found her in the corridor outside the Grayskull library, where Adora had retreated after the morning hunt. The heavy wooden doors swung closed behind her, muffling the buzz of conversation outside. Adora paused, tensing as she sensed Mara's presence before her voice even came.

"We need to talk." She said, her voice steely.

Adora inhaled, steeling her posture and pressing her fingers to her aching temple. "Now?"

"Yes," Mara said, stepping closer. "Now."

Adora turned, spine rigid. "Fine. Say what you need to say."

Mara exhaled sharply. “What was that, Adora? The other night. On the balcony.”

The words hung in the space between them like a lit fuse. Adora’s face didn’t shift at first, but Mara saw it, the clear flicker of panic behind her eyes, quickly swallowed down by a practiced calm.

“You don’t understand what you saw,” Adora said carefully, too carefully.

“I saw you pressed up against Perfuma’s sister in a sheer nightgown,” Mara shot back. “I saw the way you both looked at each other, and what might have happened, had I not interrupted.”

“It was nothing,” Adora defended a little too fast, her voice attempting to be monotone but cracking towards the end. “It was just a moment…I was vulnerable. We both were. She had a nightmare.”

Mara’s eyes narrowed. “Do not lie to me.”

“I am not,” she gritted out, running a hand through her hair, exasperated. “Even if there was something, it was just…a passing thing. Nothing that matters. Surface level.”

Mara stepped closer, lowering her voice. “But it *does* matter. And you know it.”

Adora’s jaw tensed.

“You are courting Perfuma. You may not be bound to only see each other yet, but you at least should have the respect to see others outside of her own family!” Mara gritted out. “She is waiting for your proposal, Adora. If you aren’t going to give it to her, if your heart isn’t in it–”

“My heart is in it!” Adora barked, louder than she meant to. Her voice echoed off the stone, and she immediately recoiled, drawing it back in.

Mara softened, but only a little. “Then prove it. Because what you’re doing, this thing with Catra, it’s dangerous. For you. For her. For Perfuma most of all.”

Adora looked away. “It wasn’t supposed to happen like this.”

Mara’s voice cracked, quieter now. “Things never are. But that doesn’t mean you can pretend nothing’s wrong. Either call off the proposal or stay away from Catra. You can’t have both.”

A beat of silence passed.

Adora’s hands clenched at her sides. “You don’t get to tell me what to do.”

“I’m trying to protect you.”

“I don’t need your protection.” Adora’s voice was back to monotone and her eyes back to steel as she stared down her once best friend and sister. “Not anymore.”

Mara swallowed, hurt bubbling up in her eyes as they welled. “Then at least admit you’re not sure.”

Adora didn’t answer. She stared past Mara, into some distant point on the wall, jaw set tight.

Finally, she spoke.

“Back off.”

Mara took a breath as though she might say something else, might plead, or argue, but she stopped. She saw the wall slam down behind Adora’s eyes, and she knew there was no reaching her at this moment.

So she nodded, slowly.

And walked away.

Leaving Adora alone in the hallway, pulse thundering, breath caught somewhere between guilt and anger, and something far more dangerous still.

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The Grayskull dining hall glowed with candlelight, the flickering flames dancing across silver cutlery and crystal goblets. Laughter murmured like wind through leaves, but beneath it, a low thrum of anticipation pulsed, specifically towards the end of the long table, where Adora sat stiff-backed, barely touching her food.

The seats were all filled tonight. Marlena watched the gathering with ease, Cyra beside her sharp-eyed and unreadable, Light Spinner casting judgmental glances over her wine. Down the table, Glimmer and Bow were chatting quietly with Perfuma and Hope. Entrapta fiddled with some small metal contraption next to her considerably smaller pudding, whilst Scorpia seemed to hone in on herself, shoulders hunched in polite nervousness besides Catra and Perfuma.

Everyone at the table expected a proposal from Adora tonight, after all, it was the last night that Adora had alone with the Driluth's before the rest of the ton arrived tomorrow for the ball.

Catra hadn't spoken much all evening. She sat in soft shadow, jaw tight, gaze fixed on the tablecloth in front of her, until Adora looked her way.

It wasn't intentional. Adora's eyes had been drifting since the meal began, restlessly flickering across faces, finding too much noise in each of them.

Except hers.

The moment their eyes locked, it was like something pulled taut inside her spine. Catra's amber gaze was cool, guarded, but underneath it, something trembled. Something unreadable. She looked away first.

But Glimmer noticed.

Adora could feel her best friend’s stare as Glimmer’s eyes shifted between the two women, slowly, her expression tightening with a confirmed realisation.

And then there was Mara. At the far end of the table, her older sister hadn’t touched her food at all. She was watching Adora like a hawk, seemingly calm, but devastatingly perceptive. A silent warning lived behind her eyes.

Adora looked down at her glass of wine. Her hand was shaking. She didn’t even realize she was standing until her chair scraped sharply against the floor.

"I’d…like to make a toast," she said. Her voice echoed far louder than she intended, cracking faintly.

All conversation died.

Perfuma turned to her with a wide, hopeful smile, her cheeks shaded in a pretty pink. She smoothed her gown and looked at the viscount with glittering eyes.

Glimmer’s brows furrowed, gaze sharp as she stared, confused.

Mara leaned forward, still holding her breath.

Catra didn’t move, didn’t dare look up.

Adora swallowed. "To…to someone very special."

Perfuma’s lips parted, the breath catching in her throat.

"Someone who’s brought a…lightness to this house that’s been missing for far too long," Adora continued, stumbling slightly. Her pulse pounded in her ears. Her eyes met Perfuma’s for only a second, and then darted, uncontrollably, back to Catra.

Catra’s gaze still on the table, no teasing smirk, no roll of her eyes, just a disassociated stare of the cloth in front of her. Her face gave nothing away, but her fingers were twisting around the napkin in her lap, her claws almost shredding it.

Adora’s mouth opened. This was it. She had rehearsed the words in her head again and again.

But then she saw Mara, stiff in her chair, that same sharp look, warning her.

And Glimmer, lips pressed together, arms folded, her gaze a blade between her and Catra.

Adora’s courage faltered. Her hand gripped her glass too tightly. She looked back at Perfuma, radiant and full of hope.

"I have…a question," she said, the words catching painfully in her throat.

The silence was instant and unbearable.

Perfuma leaned forward slightly, her fingers twitching in anticipation.

Scorpia, beside her, looked like she might be ill.

Adora took a breath.

"How…how on *earth* did you manage to put up with my family this whole vacation?"

It dropped like a stone in a well.

Perfuma blinked. Her expression fell immediately, embarrassed and darting towards her sister, who was just staring at the tablecloth in front of her, in utter horror, her breathing sharper.

Adora kept going, rambling now, voice tight and unnatural. "Because I know we’re…a bit much. But you’ve been so gracious

and warm, and I find that…really endearing. For the future."

A single, awkward laugh left her lips before she sank back into her seat.

No one moved. No one spoke.

Perfuma's hand slowly lowered her wineglass. She tilted her head and gave a careful, forced smile. "That's…very kind of you, Adora. It has…been a pleasure to spend this week with your family."

Glimmer and now Bow, were staring at her in utter horror, Mara exhaled softly, her relief unmistakable.

Catra still didn't look up.

Across the table, Scorpia poked at her untouched custard.

Entrapta's little machine whirred.

And Adora sat there, face burning, heart pounding, the weight of too many eyes pressing down on her, knowing she had just broken something, and not knowing if it could ever be put back together.

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Catra ran her fingers gently through Perfuma's hair, carefully smoothing oil through each sunlit strand. The scent of jasmine and rosemary oil lingered in the air, soft and familiar, usually just like Perfuma herself. But tonight, she was quiet. Still. Tense.

They sat cross-legged on the rug near the hearth in Catra's room, fire low and flickering. The only sounds were the occasional pop of the bottle, and the glug of oil in the palm of her hand.

Perfuma hadn't said much since dinner. She hadn't cried, not exactly. Not in the loud, crumbling way Catra would when the world felt too cruel to her, when she was heartbroken, but there

were tears in her long lashes, and her nose was pink as she sniffed quietly.

“You must know, it is not your fault.” Catra said to her gently, her voice low, soft like thread weaving through cloth.

Perfuma didn't answer right away. She stared at the fire, blinking slowly. Then, in a voice thin as paper, she said, "It feels like it is."

Catra stilled.

Perfuma blinked again, and this time a tear slipped free, curling over her cheek before she brushed it away. "Maybe I didn’t connect with them as well as I thought I did. I tried. I really did. I thought…" Her throat bobbed. “I thought Adora was serious.”

"She is-" Catra started, but stopped. She didn’t believe it. Not anymore. Not fully.

Perfuma turned, just slightly, so Catra could see the grief in her face. "Surely if she were going to propose… it would’ve been tonight, wouldn’t it?"

Catra inhaled sharply through her nose, then turned her attention back to the strands of hair between her fingers. She rubbed the oil in gently, kneading it into Perfuma’s scalp with more care than she’d ever shown anyone.

"Maybe," she murmured. "But maybe she just got scared. You know how she is, all duty and pressure and… whatever’s going on in that stubborn brain."

Perfuma gave a quiet laugh, broken and breathless.

Catra swallowed and dared to add, "There’s still time."

Perfuma hesitated, her hands clasped tightly in her lap.

"Keep your heart open," Catra said softly. "Just a little longer…if not for Adora…for someone else.”

“It is too late, Catra.” She said, almost pleading. “I’ve spent all this season courting Adora. Not only will it reflect badly on our family, it reflects badly on the Diamond.”

“It is never too late.” Catra replied, “to hell with any gossip there is. You will find a worthy suitor this season, I will make sure of it.”

Perfuma turned her head to look at her. “Why are you always the one who picks me back up?”

Catra’s lips twitched, a shadow of a smile. “Someone’s got to.”

She leaned forward, pressing her lips gently to Perfuma’s forehead.

Outside, the wind rustled the trees. Inside, for just a moment, Perfuma let herself believe in second chances, and Catra knew what she had to do.

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The drawing room was dim, lit only by the dying fire crackling low in the hearth. Shadows stretched along the wood-paneled walls, dancing softly over portraits and velvet curtains. The house had gone still, hushed with sleep. But Catra’s pulse thundered in her ears as she stepped into the room, wrapped in a modest dark robe, the fabric belted tight at her waist. She only hoped Adora matched her modesty this time.

Adora stood by the window, arms crossed as she stared out into the moonlit night. She was dressed similarly, thankfully, her shoulders hunched with tension. She didn’t turn when Catra entered, as if she’d known she was coming.

Catra stopped several paces away, keeping a wide distance between them.

She cleared her throat. “What was that?” Her tone was dripping venom.

Adora didn’t look at her. “What do you mean?”

“The toast,” Catra snapped, her voice low and sharp like a blade drawn in velvet. “You looked her in the eye. You said you had a question. Everyone knew what you were initially intending to do.”

Adora scoffed, finally turning. “You can’t possibly expect me to propose now, can you?”

Catra stared at her, stunned. “Why ever not?! You told her you intended to, or were you just wasting her time? Playing with her feelings?”

“I wasn’t playing,” Adora hissed, an edge in her voice. “I meant it. I do care about her. But marrying Perfuma means…that I would be tying myself to you. For the rest of my life.”

Catra blinked, caught off guard. “And?”

Adora took a step closer, her voice trembling. “And I’ll spend the rest of that marriage… wanting.”

Catra took a step back, her breath hitching.

The silence between them stretched taut as wire.

“Wanting what?” she whispered, too scared of the answer.

Adora’s eyes glinted in the firelight, challenging and steely. “You know what.”

Catra flushed, biting the inside of her cheek. Her heart was pounding. She knew what, she hadn’t known it was actually reciprocated to any extent besides surface level sexual tension, but this confirmed that maybe Adora did feel a fraction of what she did.

“It doesn’t matter,” she said firmly, shaking her head. “This- whatever it is- it’ll pass. I’ll have to take my leave soon anyway.”

Adora frowned, her brow creasing. “Take your leave?”

“Yes.” Catra crossed her arms, grounding herself. “That was always the plan. After Perfuma is wed, I’ll return to Halfmoon. I have no place here.”

“You’re leaving your sister?” Adora’s brows furrowed and she looked almost panicked at the idea.

“No.” Catra shook her head, looking at the other woman like she was ridiculous. “She will be starting her own family. She won’t need me hovering. I will go to Halfmoon, back to my life and build something for myself.”

Adora’s expression of panic only grew deeper, something heavy setting behind her eyes akin to horror. “Back to your life in Halfmoon…is there someone back there?” Her voice was nearly a whisper at the end.

Catra blinked, caught off guard. “That is frankly none of your business.”

Adora swallowed hard and looked away. The silence pulsed between them like a bruise.

“Do you think Halfmoon will honestly be far enough?” She said then, her tone hard as she stepped closer towards Catra, who stepped back again, her back hitting the wall as she gazed up at Adora, with wide eyes. *This was bad.*

“Far enough?” She whispered.

“Do you think there is a corner of Etheria that you could travel to, far away enough that would free me from this torment?” Adora’s words were gritted out now, and her arm was caging Catra beneath her. *This was so, so bad.*

Catra gulped, her heart was beating so hard, she knew that Adora could practically hear it. It was torment, to fight off the urge to surge forward, finally connect her lips with the Viscount she had

spent the past few months wanting, to finally kiss the woman she realised actually wanted her back, just as much.

"Adora…" She almost pleaded.

"My father raised me with honour," Adora continued. "And I have done everything I can to follow that, but you- you are testing that with *every move* you make. Catra…you… *vex* me. I have never met anyone like you, it is *maddening* how much you consume my very being."

Catra was shaking her head now, bile rising in her throat as she fought herself so deeply. Her hands were shaking and she scrunched inwardly, her claws digging into her palms, warning herself to not move, to not do something so precarious that would harm her sister.

She ripped her gaze from Adora's one, her breath not slowing as she quickly ducked and moved back from her grasp.

"You *have* to propose to her," Catra said after a beat, quieter now but no less firm. "Whatever this is between us… it is a curse. And it will pass. But if you leave her standing in the wake of this, if you humiliate her—"

"A curse?!-" Adora gasped a little. If Catra had looked at her in that moment, she would've seen the hurt sheening in her gaze.

Catra pressed on. "It will reflect badly on both our families. But especially mine. The Grayskulls will be fine, you'll weather it with grace and noble name intact. But Perfuma… She's the Diamond, yes, but we have no real political weight in Brightmoon. This could ruin her. Ruin us."

Adora's jaw tightened. She looked like she might be sick, too.

Catra stepped back toward the shadows. Her voice cracked, but she steadied it. "Don't let your indecision ruin her future. If you care for her at all, you'll do what you promised. Don't let this curse destroy us."

She turned and left without another word, closing the door gently behind her, as if anything louder might shatter the fragile thing still trembling between them.

Chapter End Notes

I'm so sorry to those of you that hoped this would be simple and straightforward. No, this is messy shit. Anyway- Adora said the thing!! Viscount Adora, Viscount Anthony? No difference.

Chapter 9: The honor of Grayskull

Chapter Notes

> Please don't hate me for this. Sorry this chapter is a couple days late!! but it’s longer!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The night air chilled against her skin, but it did little to cool the feverish thoughts in Catra’s head as she stumbled down the corridor and out into the garden, pulling her robe tighter around her. The moonlit hedges blurred into her vision, the gravel crunching against her bare feet. Her chest felt tight, too tight. Like something inside her was clawing to get out.

She found a quiet bench beneath the old tree by the rose trellis and sat, gripping the edge of the stone seat with trembling fingers.

You told her to propose.
You told her to choose Perfuma.
And then…what if she does?

Catra pressed a hand to her mouth, trying to calm her breathing, but her body wouldn’t listen. Her thoughts spiraled, shame, guilt, and something worse, she didn’t want to name.

Perfuma.

She had seen her sister’s tear-filled eyes, the way she looked at Adora as though she was her entire future. And she had pushed Adora even further into that future, had practically demanded it of her, even while her own heart screamed in protest.

She had called it a *curse* . Even though she knew she shouldn’t have said it, it honestly felt that way. How else was she supposed to frame slowly falling for her sister’s intended? How do you approach this situation?!

“I shouldn’t have said that,” she muttered into the night, curling in on herself. “I shouldn’t have said it…”

“You shouldn’t have said what, dear?”

Catra startled so hard she nearly fell off the bench.

From the shadowed path, Light Spinner emerged with her shawl drawn around her shoulders, as composed and ghostly as ever.

“I—n-nothing. I didn’t hear you,” Catra said, hastily wiping her eyes and sitting up straighter.

“Oh, I imagine you didn’t,” Light Spinner said calmly, settling beside her. “You were breathing like the house was burning down. Tell me, what are you panicking about?” She crooned.

Catra glanced away. Her fingers dug into her robe.

“I fear I’ve ruined the proposal,” she muttered.

Light Spinner blinked slowly. “Because…you and the Viscount cannot seem to get along?”

“Yes,” Catra said. “No. I don’t… I don’t know. I told her she *had* to propose, that it was the only thing that made sense.”

“And yet,” Light Spinner said, arching a brow, “you look ready to be sick at the very idea.”

Catra pressed her knuckles to her lips, shaking her head. “Why is this happening?” she whispered. “Why am I getting in the way? Why can’t I just be normal and let this happen like it’s supposed to?”

Light Spinner gave her a long, unreadable look. “Why are you giving up when you are so close to getting what you want?”

“I don’t know what I want!” Catra snapped, her voice cracking.

The silence that followed was not unkind, but it was heavy.

“Then there is only one thing to do,” Light Spinner said gently. “You must tell your sister what you feel.”

Catra froze. “Tell her…about my *dislike* for the Viscount?”

“I mean,” Light Spinner said, rising slowly and brushing a leaf from her sleeve, “about whatever it is you *feel.* Dislike or otherwise.”

She turned to go, then paused, glancing over her shoulder. “I am going inside now. Be careful.” She hissed at the end, any false impression of warmth melting away into a growl.

And then she was gone.

Catra sat very still, her chest heaving with the remnants of her panic.

“She knows,” she whispered.

Her hands shook in her lap. “Light Spinner knows. Mara knows. Maybe even Glimmer. They’re all watching. I’m losing control. Too many people are catching on. I can’t- I can’t-”

She dropped her head into her hands, curling in again.

“What am I supposed to do?” she whispered to no one. “What if I already ruined everything?”

The wind stirred the trees gently. Far off in the manor, a door creaked.

And Catra remained where she was, surrounded by roses, drowning in thorns.

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The ballroom glowed like something out of a dream. Candles glittered in crystal chandeliers above their heads, casting soft light on the polished floors and velvet-draped windows. Music floated

gently from the quartet in the corner, the violins weaving notes delicate and haunting. The room was full of color and light, but Adora felt like her lungs were full of smoke.

She stood beside Perfuma at the edge of the ballroom floor, dressed in silver and pale green, both of them luminous. The crowd parted as the first waltz of the evening was announced, and Adora offered her hand with practiced grace.

Perfuma took it, albeit with a little hesitance.

They danced.

For a moment, it was quiet, just the rhythm of their steps, the turn of Perfuma's confused gaze, the tension buzzing beneath Adora's skin.

Then Perfuma spoke. "You embarrassed me."

Adora stumbled slightly. "Perfuma, I—"

Perfuma's voice remained pleasant, though clipped. "I understand nerves. But I was humiliated in front of your entire family."

"I didn't mean to," Adora said quickly. "I froze. I don't know what happened. I—" She looked away, shame rising like heat in her neck. "I'm sorry. Truly. You didn't deserve that."

Perfuma's expression softened by a fraction. "No, I didn't."

"I… I promise I didn't mean it as rejection," Adora added, her voice barely above a whisper.

Perfuma's eyes flickered to hers. "So do you intend to propose, then?"

Adora's heart stuttered. Her mouth opened…then closed.

She hesitated. Just for a moment.

But then she nodded.

Perfuma exhaled, relief blooming in her expression. She smiled, luminous and lovely. “Good.”

Across the room, Catra spun in Scorpia’s arms, stiff in her shoulders and carefully distant. Her hair was slicked back and her dress clung to her curves, yet her eyes were anywhere but on her dance partner.

Scorpia, in a similar vain, also did not gaze upon her dance partner, instead following the two blondes. “Do you think she will propose?” She asked softly.

Catra blinked, startled. She looked at Scorpia, not flirting now, not grinning like a fool. Just… worried.

Catra’s mouth opened, but all that came out was a quiet, “I don’t know.”

Scorpia nodded, her lips tight, and gave Catra’s hand a reassuring squeeze.

Back in the center of the ballroom, Perfuma looked up at Adora with a gentler expression.

“If you truly plan to ask me,” she murmured, “I want my sister’s blessing. She’s been difficult, yes, but I want her to mean it.”

Adora felt her stomach drop. Catra had *already* forced her hand. She had *insisted* on the proposal. But Perfuma didn’t know that, and Adora didn’t have the heart to tell her. So she only gave a small nod, her throat tight.

The music changed.

As tradition dictated, the partners shifted and another person fell into her arms.

Catra stilled as she realised Adora’s arms were on her waist. Her body language was guarded, her eyes unreadable. She moved

Adora’s hand to her own and their bodies fell into the steps of the dance.

Adora, desperately, tried not to look at her, but it was almost impossible.

Adora hadn’t meant to look. Truly, she hadn’t. Catra looked devastating. The candlelight caught in the sharp lines of her cheekbones, her dark dress tailored to perfection, open just enough to reveal the slender curve of her throat. Her hair was swept back with an elegance that made her look older, more composed, but it was her eyes, lined in a way that made them smolder, almost golden in the light, that undid Adora entirely. There was a wild beauty to her tonight, refined yet untamed, like something no ballroom could contain. And Adora, even now, even still, wanted to be the one to try.

Catra’s jaw was clenched, her gaze staying on the wall behind Adora’s shoulder. She didn't dare speak.

The silence grew unbearable.

“I…” Adora started, but faltered. Her breath caught.

Catra’s eyes flicked to her, confused, just as Adora spun her, and for a brief, suspended moment, their eyes locked.

Adora saw something soften in Catra’s face, not pity, not distance.

Something else.

Sadness. Heat. A longing she didn’t want to name.

Adora’s heart stuttered in her chest.

“She wants me to get your blessing,” Adora said suddenly, her voice low, breaking the fragile spell. “Perfuma.”

Catra stilled in her arms for a beat, and then slowly looked down, her eyes cast to the floor as the next spin came. Her face

hardened again, and that look disappeared.

“You already know my feelings on the matter,” she said quietly.

“This is what you want?” Adora said, scared of the answer.

“It does not matter what I want. Not when it comes to Perfuma.”

Adora’s stomach twisted, she felt like she could be sick. “Do you really think it’s a curse?” she asked, her voice hoarse. “Is that all this is to you?”

Catra’s lips parted. She searched Adora’s face, something wounded in her gaze.

“I don’t know what else to call it,” she said eventually. “These circumstances… they’re not natural. They hurt too many people.”

Adora pulled back as if struck, her breath catching.

She didn’t want to hear more.

She couldn’t.

Adora could still hear the word echoing in her brain, *curse* , and though Catra had spoken it softly, almost regretfully, it landed like a blade in her chest. Because wasn’t it true? Whatever had rooted itself between them, whatever pull existed, it hadn’t brought clarity, only chaos. It was beautiful and wrong, aching and impossible. And still, it hurt. Stars, it hurt. She clenched her fists to hide the tremble in her fingers, ashamed of the way she’d nearly hoped for something she had no right to want.

This thing between them, this impossible want, was a fault line threatening to crack everything she’d built, everything her family depended on. She was a Grayskull. She had a duty, legacy, order to uphold. But right now, all she could feel was that if she let this get any deeper, if she let herself fall any further, she’d ruin it all. She’d ruin Perfuma, ruin her family, and ruin Catra. Maybe she

already had. She knew she was too late anyway, she had fallen impossibly deep.

Without another word, she turned and strode from the ballroom, her skirts trailing behind her like a wound.

Catra stood frozen on the dance floor, heart hammering, pulse ringing in her ears. She knew what she wanted, but she couldn't be selfish. Not when Perfuma was involved.

Then she looked across the room.

Perfuma stood at the edge of the floor, her expression worried and downright devastated, watching Adora run away. Her eyes met Catra's, pleading, silent, desperate. No doubt she thought Catra had refused to give Adora her approval.

Catra exhaled sharply.

Behind her, she could feel Light Spinner's piercing stare, Mara's breath catching in her throat.

But she didn't care.

She turned and followed Adora out of the ballroom.

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Catra chased after Adora, wordlessly.

The air was sharp in her lungs, her slippers soaked through from the dew-slick grass, but she didn't care. She just ran after Adora, deeper and deeper into the woods, until the music from the ballroom had only become a faint hum and the moonlight barely peeked through the clouds.

Catra tore through the trees after her, breathless and finally calling her name as she lost sight of the woman. "Adora! Adora, stop!"

But then—

A rustle behind her. Not Adora.

Melog.

The creature melted from the shadows like moonlight itself, their form shimmering with soft red pulses. Catra stopped dead in her tracks as they stepped between her and the path, eyes aglow, tail twitching.

"Where is she?" Catra panted, taking a step forward. "Did you find her?"

Melog didn't speak aloud, not exactly, but Catra heard them all the same.

"Adora… safe. Come."

And then a shift, a shimmer of magic like warm mist, and suddenly Catra wasn't there at all. She blinked, and the forest looked... different. Dimmer. She glanced down.

She couldn't see her hands.

"Invisible?" she whispered.

Melog nodded once, their purr low and reverberating.

"Adora…honor…Grayskull. Alone. Not unwatched."

Catra didn't argue, she didn't really know how to.

She followed.

The forest opened into a clearing she hadn't seen before. Ancient, untouched. Moonlight poured down in a silvery beam through the trees, falling on a raised stone embedded in the earth, almost like an altar, overgrown with moss and vines.

Adora stood at the center of it.

Her back was to them, breathing hard, her jacket torn from the branches, her hair wild around her face, the usual ponytail torn through. She just looked like a young girl now, not Viscount Grayskull, just a girl, on the edge of something she didn't understand.

Her back was to them, breathing hard, skirts torn from branches, her hair wild around her face. She looked like a girl on the edge of something she didn't understand.

And then she saw it.

A sword.

It jutted from the stone, half hidden by ivy yet it glowed all the same. Its gleam pulsed faintly, as if beckoning both to get closer, pulsing like a heartbeat.

Catra went to walk towards it, and Melog mewled quietly.

"Stay. Watch."

Adora took a shaky step forward now.

She reached out.

Her fingers wrapped around the hilt and—

With barely any effort, it slid free.

Then…she fell to the floor.

"Adora!" Catra gasped, breaking free of Melog and running towards the slumped figure.

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Bright, searing light fractured through the trees, much like the blade she had grabbed, stabbing through Adora's eyelids until she was forced awake. The world felt warped—too still, too bright, too unreal. Blinking against the radiance, she saw her: a tall,

translucent figure standing amidst the clearing. Not flesh and bone, but light and code, humming softly like a machine trying to remember how to be human.

"Adora…" the voice came in pulses, distorted and echoing, as though pulled from deep water. "Adora…"

Adora staggered to her feet. Her breath came shallow, heart thudding in her ears. The figure regarded her with hollow eyes, neither cruel nor kind, simply expectant. Behind the static of the voice, something else rippled, softer, like a memory pressed between the layers of sound.

"I don't want this…" whispered another voice, sounding so similar to…Mara's? A shiver ran down Adora's spine. Her sister's voice was faint, almost lost to the breeze, but unmistakable in its grief. *"This isn't what I choose!"*

The holographic woman lifted her arm and more light spilled into the glade, flooding everything in gold and white. The sword hilt that Adora had found, now glowing at her side, pulsed with a warmth that felt both alien and familiar. She reached for it without thinking, her fingers drawn like a magnet.

"Balance must be restored," the voice declared, now layered with something ancient and imperious. "Etheria must seek a hero."

Adora's hand trembled as it hovered over the hilt.

The figure took a step forward, light rippling around her like a veil.

"Adora," she said again, this time clearer, more commanding. "Will you fight… for the Honor of Grayskull?"

Grayskull? Her surname?

The question hung heavy in the air, and Adora could feel its weight in her very bones—not a request, but a summons. A legacy pressing down. And beneath it all, that echo of Mara's voice, almost lost in the light…

"Please, don't- don't take her."

Adora's breath caught as Mara's voice faded into the air like mist, curling around the syllables of her name. It was unmistakable, that quiet desperation threaded through every word. *"I didn't want this."*

"No," Adora whispered, backing away from the glowing figure. Her feet stumbled over roots that materialised. "That isn't real. That isn't—" She turned wildly, eyes scanning the glowing treeline. "Mara? Where are you?"

Silence answered. No birdsong. No breeze. Just the soft mechanical hum of the hologram, still standing patiently in the clearing like it hadn't just torn a hole through her world.

Adora clutched her head. "This is a dream," she muttered. "It has to be. I- I hit my head, I fell asleep, something." Her heart pounded painfully against her ribs. "This doesn't make any sense."

She turned again, this time sprinting to the edge of the clearing, crashing into branches, searching for anything familiar. "Catra?" she called. She knew the woman had followed her, where was she now?!

Her voice cracked. "Catra, please! Are you here?"

But no footsteps followed. No sarcastic reply. Just the growing panic in Adora's throat.

"What do you mean Grayskull?" she whispered, glancing back at the sword embedded in the earth. It shimmered faintly in the golden light, the hilt strange and old. "Why would I fight for it? What am I fighting?" She shook her head, fists clenched. "There's no war anymore. Etheria doesn't need a hero. This isn't *real* ."

And yet, the memory of Mara's voice haunted her again— *"Please, don't take her."* It sounded like a warning. A plea. A curse passed down in blood.

Adora turned back toward the figure, trembling. “Why did I hear her?” she demanded. “What does she have to do with this? What do *I* have to do with this?”

The hologram blinked, frozen in her last gesture. A cruel stillness filled the air, and Adora suddenly felt very small. The world around her didn’t feel like a dream anymore, it felt like a story that had been waiting for someone to walk into it. A story that didn’t care whether she understood it or not.

And worse, Adora had the terrible, gnawing feeling that Mara once stood exactly where she was now, asking the very same questions.

“Adora…Adora.” The woman whispered

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“Adora! Adora!”

Catra was on her knees, gripping Adora’s shoulders as if trying to anchor her back to the world. Her own heart thundered painfully in her chest, loud enough that she could barely hear herself think. Panic clawed at her throat. Adora had just collapsed, gone silent and still, and Catra didn’t know what she had seen or what had taken her.

“Come on, come on,” she whispered, shaking her a little harder. “Don’t do this, don’t just disappear on me-”

Melog sat nearby, watching calmly, tail flicking. They gave a soft, unbothered mewl in response, utterly useless and infuriating in the moment.

“Seriously?” Catra snapped. “You led me here, now *explain* ! What the hell was that?”

But Melog simply blinked, unmoved.

And then, Adora gasped.

She jerked upright with a choked breath, eyes wild and unfocused, like someone waking from a drowning dream. Her chest heaved as she looked around frantically, trying to remember where she was, who she was with.

"Adora…" Catra breathed, immediate relief flooding her voice. She caught her before she could stumble, steadying her in her arms. "Hey. Hey, it's alright. You're okay. You're here."

Adora looked at her, the panic still evident in her gaze as she clutched at Catra's dress, white-knuckled. "I- Mara? The woman? I don't know what happened…"

Catra furrowed her brows, what did Mara have to do with this? What woman? If she hadn't seen the magical glowing sword, she would simply believe Adora was coming down with a fever and was delirious, but she knew whatever it was, had to do with what Melog had told her earlier.

Adora's hands were still shaking by the time Catra looked down.

She looked pale, eyes wide and unfocused, strands of hair stuck to her forehead with sweat. Her lips were parted like she couldn't quite catch her breath.

"Hey," Catra called out gently, approaching with cautious steps, her voice laced with concern.

She closed the distance, placing steady hands on Adora's arms. "Okay, okay, slow down," she murmured, grounding her. "You're safe. Breathe with me."

Adora did, barely. Her pulse was still erratic, and her eyes flitted back to the clearing, as though afraid it might disappear behind them.

"I'm losing my mind," Adora whispered. "That's the only explanation. This…this was a dream. Or something Mara set up years ago. Or-"

“It wasn’t a dream,” Catra said quietly, glancing back toward where Melog had led her. “Melog saw it too. That… whatever it was, it was real. And it shook you.”

“I don’t know what ‘the honor of Grayskull *means*’,” Adora admitted, voice cracking. “And why did Mara not want this? What if I’m being pulled into something that’s *wrong* ?”

Catra’s grip tightened slightly. “We’ll ask her,” she said firmly. “When we get back to the ball. She’ll know what this is. But for now, let’s just walk. You’re shaking.”

Adora nodded weakly. They walked in silence through the edge of the Whispering Woods, moonlight dappling between the branches, soft wind stirring the trees. The tension in her chest was still there, but it eased with Catra beside her.

“Talk to me,” Adora said suddenly, her voice still rough. “Distract me. Please.”

Catra hesitated, then sighed, letting her eyes wander to the crooked canopy above. “You really want to be distracted?”

Adora nodded. “With anything. I just… I need to stop thinking about it for a moment.”

Catra gave a little shrug. “Alright. I suppose I could tell you about Halfmoon.”

“I know you manage the house and… run things?” Adora guessed vaguely.

“I’m a seamstress,” Catra replied, glancing at her from the corner of her eye. She didn’t really want to get any closer to the Viscount, to let her in, but she supposed this was a desperate moment, and talking about work wasn’t really personal.

Adora blinked. “You… sew?”

“Yes,” Catra replied, half-smiling at her bafflement. “With needles. Fabric. Thread. Dresses don’t just grow on trees, you know.”

“I didn’t expect that,” Adora said, almost sheepish. “I guess I imagined you storming about bossing around butlers or something.”

Catra snorted. “Oh, I do that too. But I spend most of my mornings behind a table with callused fingers, stabbing myself in the hand.”

She held up her palms, and Adora reached instinctively, catching one in hers. The skin was rougher than she’d imagined, scattered with tiny pricks and faint scars. Real marks of care. Of labor. Adora ran her fingers over the little scars making Catra gasp, wanting to snatch her hand back but fearing Adora would slip into panic again.

“What kind of dresses do you make?” Adora asked, still gently holding Catra’s hand.

“The ones you have been seeing Perfuma and I wear all Season are made by yours truly.” Catra grinned, she was proud of her work, and seeing Adora’s eyes widen at her words made her cheeks warm a little.

Catra continued. “Halfmoon is known for its silks. We dye, we stitch. Most of our wealth is trade. Perfuma sometimes helps with designs, but I handle most of the work.”

Adora looked down at the hand in hers. “They are beautiful,” she said softly.

“Thanks,” Catra muttered, pulling her hand back a little too quickly. “Not that it matters.”

“It does,” Adora said. Then, after a pause, “In my future, I think I’d like to wear more dresses.”

Catra gave her a curious look. “You?”

A flash of Adora in her nightdress came to Catra. The thin material barely containing the silhouette of her body, her curves…her *legs* .

No.

Adora shrugged. “I like my attire, but… when I wore dresses, I felt light. Not like a viscount. Not like someone carrying a name. Just… me. Like I was allowed to be something pretty, for once. Not dutiful.”

Catra’s expression softened, but she didn’t tease. Instead, she murmured, “You are allowed, you know. You’re allowed to be pretty *and* powerful. Those aren’t opposites.”

And Adora certainly was both of those. Even in her suits, she was still effortlessly pretty. But that was a thought Catra would have to keep to herself.

They walked a bit farther, letting the silence swell between them, quieter this time. Companionable.

But even as Adora felt herself calm, the echo of Mara’s cry haunted her still— *I don’t want this!*

And the sword, buried in earth like a secret waiting to be unearthed again

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The grand doors of the Grayskull ballroom creaked open, echoing across the marble as Adora and Catra stepped through the doorway, mud still clinging to their boots, their clothes disheveled from the woods, once more. The glittering chandeliers above had dimmed now, to a sleepy glow as most of the guests had dispersed.

The quiet was broken by Glimmer, arms crossed as she stepped forward. “Why is it that every time you two disappear,” she

drawled, her gaze flickering to the giant cat behind them, "you return with some strange magical being."

Catra blinked, startled. She turned to look behind her, Melog had padded in silently, somehow unnoticed by the pair, and in their mouth gleamed the golden hilt of the sword Adora had drawn from the forest. It shimmered now, as though awakened under the starlight.

Adora froze.

Mara, who had been standing to the side with Hope and Marlena, went pale. Her wine glass slipped from her hand and shattered to the floor, but she didn't seem to notice. "W-where did you get that?" she asked quietly.

Hope's face had also drained of colour. Marlena's mouth tightened, her hand flailing instinctively to her chest.

Entrapta darted forward in a whirl of excitement, Bow trailing a few steps behind her, the pair vibrating in excitement. "Ooh! That is a first one's artifact! I have never come across one with such energy_"

Adora didn't respond right away. She was staring at Mara, at the way her sister's expression twisted from fear to guilt to something like grief.

"I found it," Adora said slowly, "in the woods. It… it called to me. And then this woman, she was a projection, I think, but she knew my name. She said Etheria needed a hero. She kept saying something about the honor of Grayskull." Her eyes sharpened. "And you—" she turned toward Mara "—you were there."

Mara's lips parted, but she didn't speak fast enough.

Adora's voice rose, sharp with confusion and anger. "What aren't you telling me? What *is* this sword? Why was there some ancient magic *calling* to me?"

Mara stepped forward urgently. “Adora, you need to take it back. Right now. You have no idea what you’re getting involved in.”

“I *know* that,” Adora snapped, “which is why I’m asking for the truth.”

Catra shifted uneasily beside her, now holding the sword.

From behind them, a soft voice cut through the tension like silk on glass.

“She-Ra,” whispered Queen Angella, who had silently entered through the side corridor.

Everyone turned. Angella stepped into the room, her presence commanding and calm.

“She-Ra,” she repeated. “The sword chooses a champion when Etheria’s balance teeters. When the world has been quiet too long… when old blood begins to stir. The Honor of Grayskull is more than a calling, it is a burden, passed through generations.”

Adora stared at her. “But… There *is* no war anymore. There’s no darkness threatening the realm.”

“No,” Angella agreed softly.

Across the ballroom, Mara’s breath hitched audibly.

Hope touched her arm. Marlena had gone very still.

Adora looked down at the sword now glinting in the candlelight. A thousand questions bloomed behind her eyes.

And none of the answers looked like anything she wanted to hear.

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The sword gleamed in Adora’s hand as silence stretched across the ballroom. The name *She-Ra* hung between them all like an echo from another world.

Adora felt the pulse of something ancient thrumming in her chest, not just from the sword, but from the looks she was getting. Marlena, tense. Hope, shaken. Angella, watchful. And Mara, looking at her like she was already breaking.

"Mara," Adora said, voice low. "Tell me the truth."

Her sister's lips parted, but her gaze flicked to Hope, as if silently asking permission. Hope gave a single, subtle nod.

Mara took a breath and stepped closer. Her voice was careful, quiet, but not uncertain.

"The sword," she said, "is a key. It was forged by our First One ancestors, not to protect Etheria, but to *control* it. It links to something called the Heart of Etheria — a weapon buried deep beneath the continent. Power enough to essentially explode our world and hurt our enemies. But we don't have enemies anymore."

Adora went cold.

"You said it chose me," she whispered. "Why?"

"Because you're a Grayskull," Mara said, and her voice cracked. "It only answers to us. But the sword's magic is old and narrow. It only allows a *daughter* of Grayskull to wield She-Ra's form. You were always next in line but…I tried to hide the sword, to make sure it wouldn't get to you. I should've known…I should have destroyed it.

Adora blinked, struggling to make sense of the crashing pieces. "So a hologram…? That's who I saw."

Mara nodded grimly. "She's not a person, Adora. She's programming — a projection built by the First Ones to preserve their vision of peace. But that peace was control. Light Hope was never supposed to stop. She still believes there's a war. She still thinks the only way to protect Etheria is to activate the Heart."

“Light…Hope?” Adora remembered the vision of the woman and her eyes snapped to her sister-in-law. Hope gulped.

“She was originally my great grandmother.” Hope breathed, her shudder visible. “The programme is built to look like her.”

Mara nodded, sorrowfully. “Light Hope isn’t always evil. There’s good in her, but the First One’s have several versions that can override any good she feels, to fulfil the mission…She-Ra is meant to be a symbol of hope amongst war and also to…activate the heart.”

“But there *isn’t* a war,” Adora breathed. “Why doesn’t she know that?”

“Because she was never meant to learn. She isn’t sentient, not really. She just repeats orders — to train a weapon, awaken She-Ra, and set off the Heart. That’s why I left. That’s why I buried the sword.”

Mara’s voice thickened. “She tried to get Father to do it, you know. Said he could override the line. He refused. She called him a failed protector. And then… then he died. That same summer. I couldn’t—I couldn’t let her take anyone else.”

Adora’s stomach churned. “She called me. She *chose* me.”

“She’s not choosing *you* ,” Mara said gently. “She’s choosing a means to an end.”

Catra moved to Adora’s side, her presence grounding. Her hand brushed against Adora’s wrist, just enough to let her know she was there. Adora gripped the sword tighter.

“So what do I do?” she asked, breathless. “I can feel it. The magic. The strength. It’s inside me.”

“You *can* be She-Ra,” Hope finally said. “But not *her* She-Ra. Not the First Ones’ vision. That vision was a lie built on war. Now it’s our choice what kind of hero She-Ra becomes. Mara didn’t

understand that when she fled, didn't understand that she didn't have to listen to Light Hope. But she still didn't want it. She didn't want to be some purposeful warrior."

Mara stepped forward, resting a hand over Adora's heart.

"Maybe…you could help rebuild Etheria — Dryl's borders still haven't healed from the war, the Scorpioni kingdom is scattered, there are places that still live in ruin. You could be a symbol for restoration. Not destruction. But…you also don't have to. You have a choice in this."

Adora swallowed hard. "And Light Hope?"

"You must not speak to her again," Mara said, firmly now. "She's not guidance, she's a ghost. If you follow her path, she'll lead you straight into the same trap. Just like she tried to lead me."

The sword pulsed softly in Adora's hand, but this time she felt something else beneath it, a flicker of choice.

Responsibility.

And a future not written by prophecy, but by her.

Catra glanced sideways at her, watching the change ripple through her shoulders. "So," she muttered, "not a destroyer. Just a really dramatic renovation project."

Adora barked a soft laugh, blinking back a tear. "Something like that."

Mara stepped back. "You can carry the sword. Just don't listen to the voice in the light. Listen to yourself." Her voice was stern and gaze almost hesitant, but that melted away once her wife's hand encapsulated hers.

And for the first time since the woods, Adora felt like she could breathe again.

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It was strange, Adora thought, the feeling of finally having a choice. For so long, her life had been shaped by duty: to her family, to tradition, to the legacy of Grayskull. Now, the weight of another destiny pressed against her chest, one she hadn't asked for. One that hadn't even belonged to her parents' time. Fixing a world ravaged by a war long ended, was that truly her burden to bear? Was it selfish to wonder if her responsibilities at home should come first? To marry, to secure her family's name, to raise children with Perfuma and keep the Grayskull estate from crumbling under the weight of expectation?

Could she do both — wear the sword and the ring? Could Perfuma care for the family while she became something more than human? Was it even fair to ask? The choice was hers now, but it didn't feel like freedom. It felt like standing on the edge of something vast, with no map and no promise that she could come back whole.

The thought was too overwhelming. Up until now, her greatest worry was whether or not to propose, and whilst that was…an immense and crucial choice, the choice of being a mythical being felt as though it may override that.

Adora shook her head. She needed to make a choice now, the proposal was the main thing on her mind. She-Ra would come later.

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"Perfuma? Where did you run off to?"
Catra's voice was soft as she stepped into their shared room, only to find her sister sitting at the vanity with her back turned, shoulders tense, eyes red and puffy in the reflection of the mirror.

"I should be asking you that," Perfuma replied, not turning around. Her voice lacked any sharpness, wilted and tired like petals left too long in the sun.

“I…” Catra hesitated, guilt clawing at her throat. “I did find her. The Viscount.”

Perfuma finally turned to face her, blinking away the dampness in her eyes. “Did you? And?” Her voice was barely more than a breath.

Catra didn’t answer right away. She simply crossed the room and wrapped her arms around her sister from behind, resting her chin lightly on Perfuma’s shoulder. For a moment, neither of them moved.

“We found something,” Catra murmured. “Something strange, something… magical.”

Perfuma let out a quiet, bitter laugh. “So she’s not going to propose then.”

It wasn’t a question. It landed like a fact, flat and unadorned, between them.

“I don’t know,” Catra admitted, tightening her arms around her.

Perfuma shook her head slowly. “I thought she was serious. I thought this time it would be different. That I was different.”

“You are,” Catra said firmly. “None of this is about you, I swear it. This place, this family—it tangles everything up. She’s scared.”

“Of what?” Perfuma whispered.

“Of all of it. Of what she wants. Of what she’s supposed to be. Of… hurting you.”

Perfuma closed her eyes. “Too late for that.”

Catra felt the ache settle in her chest. She wished she could fix it, take the sharpness of disappointment and dull it. But there was no quick salve for heartbreak, not even from her. All she could do was stay, hold her, and try not to crumble herself.

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The morning air hung heavy with the scent of dew-soaked grass and the quiet ache of goodbyes. The Driluths walked slowly toward their carriage, the estate behind them already beginning to feel like a memory. The household staff lingered politely at a distance, and the Grayskulls remained unseen from the main steps. It was as if everyone knew how fragile the moment was, how one wrong word could shatter it completely.

Catra walked beside Perfuma, her hand lightly holding her sister's. It was a gentle, anchoring touch, more for herself than for Perfuma.

"I'm sorry," Catra murmured at last, eyes downcast.

Perfuma shook her head softly. "Don't be. There's nothing more to do," she said with a tired smile. "Perhaps the Viscount's head was… elsewhere. She has a lot to carry. We should've known."

Catra's throat closed up. She hated how right her sister was. But she didn't know, didn't know how deep her entanglement lay with the Viscount. How she probably was more the reason for this delayed, and probably never to come proposal. It didn't feel finished, not yet. As Perfuma stepped onto the footrest of the carriage, Catra's grip tightened.

"Perfuma," she said suddenly, voice faltering. "I…I need to tell you something."

Perfuma turned, blinking. "Yes?"

Catra's mouth opened, but the words caught in her chest. *Tell her. Just tell her. Like Light Spinner said. She deserves to know.* She took a breath, her heart hammering. Maybe if she came clean… Adora and Catra might be able to-

"Miss Driluth!" a voice rang out across the gravel drive. "Can I talk to you?"

Catra froze. Her heart stuttered. That voice. That damn voice.

Adora was running, hair slightly mussed, cloak flapping behind her, expression determined and breathless. She slowed just as she reached them.

Catra stepped forward instinctively. “Of course,” she said quietly. Maybe Adora had…chose her? Despite Catra’s insistence-

But Adora didn’t even look at her.

“I’m sorry,” she said, eyes flicking briefly to Catra, yet with no emotion, but then sliding past her. “That wasn’t meant for you.”

She stepped around Catra and stopped before Perfuma, the space between them electric.

Slowly…she sank down on one knee and produced a small box.

Adora’s voice was trembling but resolute. “Miss Perfuma Driluth… will you…marry me?”

The silence stretched, sharp and taut, before Perfuma gasped, eyes wide, her hand flying to her chest. And then, all at once, her face bloomed into a brilliant smile, so bright it felt like spring. Flowers bloomed beneath her feat, circling her and Adora in a lovely bush of roses. Catra stepped back quickly, narrowly avoiding a thorn.

“Yes!” she cried, her voice bubbling with joy. “Yes, I will marry you! I will be your Viscountess!”

Catra stood there, still as stone. Her outstretched hand slowly lowered, the confession withering on her tongue. The air had changed. The moment was over.

And she hadn’t said a word.

Chapter End Notes

guys i swear it will only be annoying for like ONE more chapter…kind of. Anyway, this fic won't go suuuuper into the whole she-ra thing, it's just crucial for a couple moments :p

Chapter 10: A Funeral

Chapter Notes

> Sorry for slight delay, this chapter was super difficult to write BUT its twenty pages sooo…
>
> songs i was listening to when writing : slipping through my fingers, abba — when Catra is taking off the tape from Perfuma's hands.
> Starling, Sarah Kinsley, can be applied anywhere tbh.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Warm light streamed through the tall windows of the Modiste, spilling golden shafts across racks of imported lace and glittering beads. The scent of fresh linens mixed with lavender and a distinct smell that Catra recognised meant the silks were imported from Halfmoon, filled the air that rustled with silk and murmurs of excitement. In the centre of the room, Perfuma stood upon a circular platform, her arms slightly raised as the seamstress and two assistants flitted around her with pins and measuring tape.

The gown she wore was a vision of pale satin, the bodice fitted snug with delicate pearl embroidery and a soft organza overlay that fluttered gently as she turned to admire herself in the mirror. Her hair was pulled back in soft waves and she radiated the kind of joy that made her skin glow brighter than any colour of fabric could.

Cyra clapped her hands together from her chair. "Oh, darling, you look radiant. Simply a dream." Her smile was broad, cheeks flushed with maternal pride.

Perfuma's own smile seemed to widen, if that was even possible. "Do you truly think so? It's only the third I've tried but…I think I love this one the best. Adora will– oh I hope she will love this too!" She laughed, giddy and warm as she twirled. "I want to make her speechless on our wedding day, show her that we truly

are a match made in the stars.” Flowers bloomed happily under her step and wound themselves around her feet.

Catra looked on in the corner, absently twirling a loose pin between her fingers, her expression unreadable. She had tried not to stare too long– tried to keep her emotions at bay as she saw how happy her sister looked, how the light illuminated her skin and caught on her veil, how she practically shimmered when she said Adora’s name. But it was impossible to look away.

Perfuma noticed, of course she did, and her gaze flickered to her, softening. “Sister…? You’re…awfully quiet? Do you not like the dress?”

Catra looked up. Her fingers froze around the pin.

“No it's not that-” she started, then faltered. There were words clawing at the back of her throat. Words she should have said weeks ago. But what good would it do now? The announcement had already reached every parlour in Brightmoon. Adora and Perfuma were to be wed. The Viscount had made her intentions clear in front of the entire estate. And Perfuma was happy.

That was the truth of it. Perfuma was incandescent.

So Catra swallowed the ache, tucked it deep beneath her ribs.

“I’m just…” she managed, “emotional.”

Perfuma tilted her head. “About the wedding?”

Catra forced a smile, the kind that never quite reached her eyes. “About everything, I suppose. You look beautiful….Mama would be so proud.”

The seamstress paused with her pins and glanced up, smiling at the sentiment. Perfuma turned toward Catra, her eyes shining as she stepped down carefully from the platform.

“You really think so?”

Catra nodded, and this time the smile came more easily. “I know so.”

She didn’t add that her Mama would absolutely not be proud of her other daughter right now. That she probably would be so ashamed.

Perfuma beamed, hands fluttering to her waist as if unsure what to do with the flood of emotion. “Oh, Catra…” She crossed the distance and pulled her sister into a tight hug. “I’m so glad you’re here for this.”

Catra held her, breathing in the scent of rosewater and tulle. She didn’t trust herself to speak.

Cyra looked on with a softened gaze, her eyes damp.

And for a moment, in that warm little shop filled with silks and pins and the dreams of a wedding soon to come, Catra let herself believe that caring quietly, silently, would still be enough.

But the silence was beginning to take its toll.

And she wasn’t sure how much longer she could hold it in

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Light Spinner’s estate stood silent under the haze of late morning, its windows glinted dully beneath the grey cloud cover. Adora clutched the ring box in her gloved hands, her steps measured as she approached the front entrance. The gold band nestled inside was too loose on Perfuma’s delicate finger. She was here to fix that.

One of the maids greeted her with a slight bow, murmuring something about Light Spinner being out, and ushering her into the sitting room to wait for Razz, the eccentric family friend who, among her many quirks, dabbled in jewellery and welding. Adora sat stiffly on the embroidered settee, her gloves smoothed over her knees and her jaw tense.

Razz appeared moments later with a clatter, her curls wild as ever, her wire-rimmed glasses hanging askew from her nose.

"Oh, Mara!" she preened fondly, spotting Adora. The woman, for all her talents, couldn't seem to place a difference between Adora and her older sister. "Come about the ring, eh? Knew it the moment the woods shifted. My dearie is to be wed!" She twirled once and fell into a rocking chair with a creak, her eyes sparkling. "Let's see it then."

She offered the velvet box, her hand steady despite the sudden pang in her chest. The moment Razz lifted the lid, a soft *gasp* came from the doorway.

Adora froze.

Cartra stood in the doorway, her hair wild and unbrushed, tangled from sleep, her nightgown was loose around her shoulders. Her eyes were puffy with fatigue yet she still looked like something akin to a dream Adora found herself having often these days, despite her many efforts to rid them.

"Oh," Catra said, blinking. "I didn't realize we had… company."

Adora's head jerked down, her eyes fixed now on the carpet. It was too dangerous to make eye contact with Catra, especially when she looked like this. "I didn't realize anyone else was home. Forgive me."

Razz, oblivious to the sudden shift in the room's atmosphere, snapped the box shut with a gasp. "Is this your Viscountess, dearie?" She bustled over to Catra, looking her up and down and humming thoughtfully. "I must say, this is earlier than I expected. But no worries! She is beautiful."

Catra sputtered, walking back a few steps. "No…no. That would be my sister."

This was the second time someone had made that mistake. Adora flushed, she should've known not to bring Razz, and instead

maybe someone with more social tact.

Razz muttered something incoherent about…it not being the right time yet, and pestered on.

Catra walked further into the room, rubbing at her face. "Right. Well. Light Spinner, Perfuma and my mother are out. It's just me."

"Very well," Adora said quickly, rising to her feet. "We'll be on our way—"

"Wait, is that pie?" Razz interrupted, pointing with one crooked finger at the half-eaten tart on the side table.

Catra winced. "Yes…I suppose."

"I haven't had pie in *weeks,* " Razz lamented, placing a hand dramatically over her heart. Then she looked at Catra expectantly, eyes wide.

Catra exhaled sharply through her nose. "If you insist."

"I do!" Razz beamed, already helping herself. "And some tea, if we're to sit proper."

Catra muttered something under her breath but left briefly to fetch the tea tray. When she returned, Adora had reluctantly resumed her seat, her back straight, trying not to look anywhere near Catra's collarbone.

They sat around the small tea table now, Razz humming to herself between bites of pastry, blissfully unaware. Catra slouched across from her, arms crossed tightly over her chest. The silence settled thick and awkward over the room.

Adora cleared her throat. "What nice weather we have been having lately."

Catra scoffed loudly.

Adora bristled. “What?”

“You want to talk to me about the *weather?* ” Catra repeated, bitter amusement lacing every syllable.

“Is there something more appropriate we ought to discuss?”

That did it.

Catra stood abruptly, her chair screeching back. She stalked toward Adora, fire flaring behind her eyes. “There’s *nothing* appropriate about what you are doing proceeding with this engagement.”

Adora scoffed, all her bitterness and anger bubbling inside her now. Wasn’t this exactly what she had wanted? What she had told Adora was now the proper thing to do? Adora was the one trying to end the engagement in the first place. She swallowed her emotions down, willing her next words to come out monotone and detached. “On the contrary, I believe this is the most proper outcome for all…And isn’t this what you wanted?!”

Catra stilled, her ears pinned back and her tail lashed as she looked anywhere but Adora.

“That…that was before…”

Adora felt her head spinning, as she looked at Catra now, it almost seemed as though the woman was embarrassed, or bashful. But none of those emotions aligned with her scathing words the weeks before, calling their *predicament* a ‘curse.’

“Before what, Catra.” Adora almost growled, her anger rising once again. She hated this utter confusion and helplessness she felt.

“Before…what passed between us, before–before you collapsed and–”

Adora lifted her chin, her voice cold. “Nothing passed between us. I am a *gentleman.* ”

Catra laughed once, sharp and low. “Right. A gentleman,” she echoed. “Need I remind you, Adora, that if anyone but your sister had found us that night, a scandal would produce and we too, would be obliged to wed.”

Adora’s hands clenched at her sides. It was foolish to let her heart even consider the possibility. “Nothing happened that night. Though would the two of us being obliged to marry be the outcome you desire?”

Catra stammered, her eyes faltering from Adora’s gaze and her tail swaying once more. “O-of course not!”

Adora held back a sigh, looking down. She already knew the answer, but it still hurt just the same. “Then let us be glad that we have…avoided this curse you are scared of.”

Catra’s eyes searched Adora’s for a minute, no words being spoken. Her gaze was angry, her brows furrowed and her breathing sharp. Adora was used to seeing that anger from her, what she wasn’t used to though, was the hurt underlying it all. The way her ears flattened against her scalp and her tail hung limply. Had Catra’s feelings on the matter changed in the short time between the ball and finding the sword? The question was ridiculous to even ask.

“I say…Miss Driluth…” Razz called from the side, utterly ignoring the whispered dispute. “Do you and your sister happen to share gloves?”

“Uh- Yes, on occasion.” Catra said, shaking her head out of confusion.

“I knew it! We may be able to use your finger to size the ring! Save us from a trip.” Razz exclaimed with glee.

“I do not think that’s a good ide-”

“That shan’t be necessary-”

“Nonsense, Dearie!” She dismissed, waving a hand and pulling out the ring box. “Here,” she handed it to Adora. “Put it on, my hands have gotten too shaky with age.”

Adora gulped, looking at Catra, who mirrored her nervous stare and rigid shoulders. She shook her head to herself. What was even worse that could happen now?

She braced herself and opened the box, staring at her Mother’s ring. It was a gold piece, with a simple m shape in the middle, almost like a mask. The shape was filled with intricate swirls and Adora remembered how it glinted off her mother’s finger all those years ago.

Catra hesitated, then held her hand upwards.

Adora took it gently. Her fingers brushed against the worn skin of Catra’s palm, still calloused from threadwork, small puncture scars scattered across her knuckles from pins and needles. It was a seamstress’s hand, skilled, scarred, real. Her hands were nothing like Perfuma’s whose hands were always soft to the touch and unblemished.

She slid the ring slowly onto Catra’s finger. It slipped on with a soft resistance, settling at the base of her finger snugly.

Adora stared at it for a beat too long. There it was: her symbol, her mark, sitting on Catra’s hand like it belonged there. Like it always had.

“It fits,” she murmured, though she wasn’t sure she was talking about the ring anymore.

Catra looked down at it. “Hm.”

“It’s…it’s a tad big on Perfuma. I suppose gloves are not the most accurate sizing.” She chuckled, attempting to ease the air and stepping a little closer to Catra, unknowingly.

“It’s beautiful,” was all Catra supplied, but her words were enough to demonstrate her awe, if her expression wasn’t.

Adora hummed, her finger absentmindedly running on the band of the ring, and grasping her finger softly. She felt out of control of her actions, as if merely seeing her ring on Catra’s hands were enough to take all caution out of the window. Seeing the ring on her, painted visions of a completely false future for the two of them in her brain. How Catra would fit in with her family, how they would bicker together and eventually maybe create a family.

It seemed the same for Catra too, as she stared up at Adora, vulnerable for the first time in weeks, her gaze pleading. Pleading for what, Adora was unsure, but she still couldn’t tear from the gaze, instead inching stupidly closer.

“We are back!” Light Spinner’s voice crooned through the hallway, stopping as she made eye contact with the pair.

Adora and Catra jumped apart just before Perfuma and Cyra walked into the room.

“Oh! Viscount!” Perfuma gasped from the doorway, her happiness shining on her face. “You are here…” She smiled, making her way towards the pair.

“Uh yes- we were…waiting for you.” Adora stammered, clearing her throat and nodding.

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Catra barely registered Perfuma’s arrival before she snapped into motion, her eyes dropping to the ring on her finger like it had become a live coal.

She reached for it quickly, too quickly. The band resisted, snug against her skin as if it didn’t want to leave. Her breath caught, and panic edged her movements. Perfuma was right there. She couldn’t see this. She might figure out what this meant to her, even if the gesture was meant to be innocent at first.

Catra gave the ring a sharp yank, wincing as it finally slipped free. A faint red imprint bloomed across her finger, angry and unmistakable. She tucked her hand behind her back immediately.

Perfuma frowned, just slightly. "Is everything alright?" she asked.

Catra offered a crooked smile. "Of course. Miss….Razz here, thought since…you and I shared gloves, I would be able to size the ring in place of you, but…it seems there is a slight discrepancy and it was tight instead." She rushed the words out, hoping, begging, that she didn't seem as nervous as she felt.

"Yes my dear!" Razz called from the other side of the room, bumbling towards the ring and holding it up to Perfuma's now. The ring slipped onto her finger effortlessly, but as she moved her hand, slipped right off, showing it needed to be sized down.

Light Spinner, watching the entire exchange from across the room, didn't look surprised in the slightest. She merely shook her head once and muttered something under her breath about "Grayskulls and their dramatics."

Before anyone could further press the awkward moment, she lifted her chin and clapped her hands together.

"Well, now that we've finished with…that" she said breezily, "I do have one more announcement."

Everyone looked to her, still recovering from the uncomfortable tension that lingered like a fog.

"The Queen has extended an invitation. She would like us all to dine at the palace tonight."

Cyra lit up beside Perfuma, her expression warm with excitement. "How lovely! We haven't dined with the court in ages. I must find my lavender lace…"

"I'll go iron the collars," Perfuma chirped, still brimming with excitement as she reached for her mother's hand. "This is so

wonderful, Adora!”

Adora managed a stiff nod. “Wonderful, yes.”

Catra didn’t say a word. She only looked at her finger, the mark left by the ring still raw, and turned away.

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The walls of the palace glowed with evening light, moonstone lanterns casting a warm hue over the grand hall. Musicians played softly from the balconies above, and platters of delicacies were passed around by attendants in deep indigo livery.

Adora sat near the head of the table, beside Perfuma, her posture straight and formal. Bow and Glimmer sat across from them, laughing quietly together. Cyra was recounting some amusing tale to a politely confused royal cousin. Catra, dressed immaculately but clearly uncomfortable, sat at the far end of the table, quiet and withdrawn.

The Queen watched them all, serene and radiant, and then she stood, gently raising her glass.

“I hope this evening has been pleasant,” Angella began, her voice commanding attention even as it remained warm. “And that you all feel welcome here. It has been some time since we’ve had such a promising union to celebrate.”

Adora tilted her head, confused.

“Which is why,” Angella continued with a graceful smile, “I’ve decided it would be most fitting for the wedding to take place here, at the palace.”

A hush fell across the table.

Adora nearly knocked over her wine. “Oh! Your Majesty, that’s very generous, but I assure you, it isn’t necessary—”

“It really isn’t,” Glimmer chimed in quickly, exchanging a wary look with Bow. “The Grayskulls must already have something planned-”

“Nonsense,” Angella interrupted gently, her tone leaving no room for debate. “Adora, you are like a daughter to me. I would be honored to host your wedding in the palace gardens. It is only right.”

Perfuma, glowing with happiness, looked up at Adora as if she'd just been crowned queen herself. “Can you imagine?” she whispered. “How beautiful it will be...”

Adora forced a smile, though her stomach twisted into a knot.

At the end of the table, Catra said nothing. She didn’t even look up. She simply stared at the untouched dessert on her plate, her fingers curled tightly in her lap. It had felt impossible to end before, for Adora to maybe come around and cancel the engagement, but with the Queen herself getting more entangled in the nuptials, it would take a miracle for Catra to do anything more than dream that this would end.

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The air on the Grayskull estate training grounds was thick with late-summer heat, the trees rustling softly above as if whispering secrets to one another. Adora stood in the middle of the field, her boots sunk slightly into the cracked earth, her hands clenched at the golden sword. A soft golden sheen shimmered over her skin, and her eyes glowed faintly, but that was all.

Across from her, Mara sighed and lowered her hand, the runes in her palm fizzling out.

“Okay. That’s enough for now,” she said gently.

Adora exhaled through gritted teeth. “I almost had it.”

“You’ve almost had it five times this week,” Mara replied, coming closer. “You get right to the edge, and then-”

“Something blocks it,” Adora muttered, wiping the sweat from her brow. “I know. I can *feel* it.”

Mara didn’t say anything for a moment. Then, she spoke carefully. “You seem… stressed.”

Adora blinked, pulling herself upright. “I’m always stressed.”

“True,” Mara allowed with a huff of laughter. “But this is different. You’re holding things in. And I don’t just mean She-Ra’s power.”

Adora's shoulders tightened. “I’m fine.”

“You can talk to me, you know,” Mara said, tilting her head. “Even if I don’t agree. I’m still here.”

Adora’s expression twisted at that, the words striking something raw. “And what place do you have to talk about this?” she snapped. “You ran away with a married woman twice your age and left me to pick up the pieces. You don't get to judge me now.”

Mara’s eyes narrowed, her face going still. “No,” she said quietly. “I don’t get to judge you. And you’re right, it wasn’t a brilliant decision. But it was the only one I *had* . I didn’t have options, Adora. Not like you.”

Adora let out a harsh laugh. “You think I have options?”

“You do,” Mara said firmly. “You have more leeway than I ever did. No one’s going to exile you for loving the wrong person. And you don’t have to run away to keep them in your life. You can choose.”

Adora looked away, her throat tightening.

“The choice is yours this time.”

Adora turned back to her, eyes glowing again. “I haven’t had a *real* choice since the day you left.”

Mara flinched, but stood her ground. “That’s not true.”

Adora scoffed. “Isn’t it? Everything since then has just been duty. Responsibility. Keeping the family name clean. Making sure no one ever thinks we’re weak. You left, and I had to *become* something. Someone. I didn’t *choose* this.”

“You chose to propose,” Mara said softly. “That was still your choice.”

Adora’s breath caught. Her face twisted in quiet rage, for a moment. Then she stopped, her body deflating slightly. Mara had got her there, it was actually her choice…though she thought she had been doing it for the right reasons, for what was good for her future and what ultimately was what Catra had wanted.

“I don’t want to argue,” Mara said, softer now. “But I do want to talk. About this. About everything. If we don’t talk now, when will we?”

Adora stared at the ground, fingers twitching at her sides.

The breeze picked up, stirring the edges of their coats. The shimmer in Adora’s eyes faded, and she looked lost, like the little girl Mara had left behind.

“I don’t know if I can say it,” Adora whispered. “Not out loud.”

“Start with what’s really blocking you,” Mara said. “She-Ra’s power is tied to your heart. If something’s keeping you from transforming, it’s not magic. It’s you.”

Adora hesitated. For a long moment, she just stood there, hands clenched, jaw tight. Then, quietly, like cracking ice, she spoke.

“Catra.” She whispered.

Mara’s expression softened, but she stayed silent, letting Adora speak.

“I thought I was doing what she wanted,” Adora said, her voice barely above a whisper. “I thought I was making the right

decision. I wanted to be good. I wanted to be… *safe* . And Perfuma—she's wonderful. She's kind, and steady, and she deserves someone who doesn't hesitate."

"But you hesitated," Mara said gently.

Adora gave a bitter laugh. "I still *hesitate* . Because I keep thinking about Catra. And I hate myself for it."

She dragged her hands through her hair, pacing in a slow, frustrated circle. "I thought it was all in my head, Mara. Just…one sided. Something that would eventually pass. I thought I was just imagining things afterward. I practically confessed to her and then she– and then she pushed me away. But when I visited her, when I saw her again, truly looked her in the eyes, she looked at me as though-" Adora cut herself off with a bitter, unbelieving laugh. "She looked at me as though *I* was the one that had carved her open. As though she didn't actually tell me to proceed with this."

"She…is clearly conflicted. Maybe things had changed for her and then when she finally accepted it– this happened." Mara mused.

"I know," Adora said, her voice wobbling. "I saw it. She is so *angry* with me- and closed off. But then I saw something else too. I saw that she might…" Her throat bobbed as she swallowed harshly. "She might feel something. Something actually real beneath her anger. Something maybe even *close* to what I feel."

Mara raised a brow and gave a short, knowing scoff. "Of course she feels the same. Have you *seen* the way she looks at you?"

Adora shook her head, her mouth twisting in disbelief. "No, you don't understand. I thought it was just… chemistry. Fire. But now, she looks at me like I broke something. And I think I did."

"She's not made of glass," Mara said. "Neither are you."

"I wasn't prepared for her to *say* anything had changed," Adora murmured. "But she did. Or… she nearly did. I could see it. And I

—” she stopped, her voice cracking. “It was too late. I’d already proposed. I made the public announcement. And now…”

She sank down on the edge of the low stone wall, burying her face in her hands. “Now Angella is going to host the wedding at the palace. Catra barely looks at me. I’ve lost her. There’s nothing left to do.”

Mara stepped closer, kneeling slightly so she could look Adora in the eye. “That’s not true. You could still–”

Adora looked up, eyes red-rimmed. “Still what, Mara? Call everything off, tell the Queen and the Ton that I made a mistake and run off with her sister into the sunset? Not only would it ruin both of our families, it would probably break Catra’s family.”

Mara let out a sigh. “I suppose you are…right. I hate to say it. But I truly don’t know what you could do.”

Adora gave a weak laugh. “I told you. No choice.”

Adora stared off into the trees, the weight of it all pressing down on her shoulders. But the words were out now. No longer buried. No longer silent.

She didn’t glow. She didn’t transform.

But the ache in her chest began, ever so slightly, to lift.

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The morning of the wedding was hushed at first. Not quiet, exactly, outside, the estate buzzed with movement, carriages pulling in, florists trimming last blossoms, footsteps racing across the halls, but in the bedroom, there was only stillness. A sacred kind of stillness, like the world held onto its breath.

Catra sat beside Perfuma at the edge of the bed, hands cradling her sister’s as if they were made of glass. The henna had dried overnight, dark, intricate patterns spidering across her palms and

wrists, curling into delicate vines, scattered with hidden symbols of their childhood. Catra had taken six hours the night before, hunched over her sister's palm, squeezing the tiny tube carefully, so as to not get her claws to pierce the tube, adding more flowers than usual to symbolise her sister's personality.

Carefully, gently, Catra began peeling back the strips of mefix tape.

One by one.

Her fingers moved with practiced ease, but her chest ached.

"You kept so still," she said softly. "Didn't smudge a thing."

Perfuma smiled a little, her eyes lowered. "You did them beautifully."

Catra didn't answer. She only stared at the brown stains, each swirl a reminder of time passing too quickly. The tape came away clean. The henna had settled deep. It would stay for weeks. In Halfmoon, it was said that if your wedding henna had stained dark, almost black, it was a sign your future mother-in-law would love you deeply.

She swallowed.

"I remember," she said slowly, "you used to make me draw flowers on your hands with charcoal pencils. We didn't have any proper paints then, and you'd get so mad when they rubbed off."

Perfuma let out a quiet laugh. "I used to cry."

"You used to *scream* ," Catra corrected, grinning faintly. "I thought you were going to combust the day I wiped it off with water so Mama wouldn't get mad at me for drawing on you again."

They both laughed, small, tired, and then let the quiet return.

Catra turned, reached for the dress hung on the wardrobe door. She brought it over with both arms, cradling it like something alive. It shimmered faintly in the light: white, embroidered with delicate vines and pale ivory lilies, the fabric soft as breath.

"Okay," she whispered. "Arms up."

Perfuma obeyed, lifting her arms like a child. Catra pulled the first part of the dress over her head, maneuvering her through the sleeves, smoothing it down her sides, adjusting the neckline so it sat just right. Her hands worked with a careful reverence.

She fastened each button down the back in silence. Tiny, pearl-like closures that took her longer than they should have. Her fingers were shaking.

"There," she murmured. "Perfect."

Perfuma turned toward the mirror as the dress settled against her frame. She was lovely. More than lovely.

Catra's breath caught.

When had this happened?

When had the wild, sharp-edged girl she'd once known, the one who could match Catra glare for glare, slipped away? The girl who, at thirteen, had stood on a desk and shouted down an entire classroom for mocking a boy who stuttered. The one Catra had bodily dragged from the room while she screamed every insult she knew at the bully, her braid swinging like a battle flag. The one who had more fire than sense, more defiance than fear.

And now… now she stood here in silk and pearls, still fierce in her own way, but softened, smoothed like river stone. A poised woman. A bride.

Catra swallowed hard, her fingers twitching at her sides.

When had she let so much time slip past her without noticing?

She should have been paying closer attention. She should have marked every change — the tilt of her smile, the way her voice gentled, the way her temper began to bloom into patience. She should have written it all down so she wouldn't be standing here now, realising too late that her little sister had grown up right in front of her.

And she hadn't even noticed until this moment.

She looked like everything Catra had ever wanted for her.

And it hurt.

As Perfuma stood in front of her now, she was reminded of the dream she herself had once had, before she hardened herself up and put Perfuma before herself in everything. She didn't regret it though, not when Perfuma glowed like this. Perfuma may have not been her blood sister, but she was her sister in every sense still, and she would honor her mother's memory by taking care of her like this. She could always come after.

She brushed a few loose strands from Perfuma's face, her fingers tucking behind her ears, smoothing the edges of her hair.

Catra knelt again. She picked up the box of cosmetics, brushing a soft kohl liner gently beneath Perfuma's eyes. "Look up."

Perfuma obeyed, her lips trembling faintly. Neither of them spoke as Catra applied the barest bit of blush, the softest rose color, to her cheeks.

"You always did this for me," Perfuma whispered.

"I know." Catra smiled faintly. "It's different now."

She retrieved the veil last. A simple, gossamer net, stitched with tiny pearls along the hem. She adjusted it delicately over Perfuma's curls and secured the comb into place with shaking fingers.

They stood still together, Perfuma facing the mirror, Catra behind her. Their reflections stared back, two women, older now, weathered in different ways, bound by something deeper than blood.

Catra's voice cracked. "You're so beautiful, Fuma."

Perfuma turned, her eyes glassy. "Stop, you'll ruin my eyeliner."

"I don't care."

A soft sob escaped them both, and they pulled each other into a long, quiet hug.

Cyra stepped in just then, handkerchief already clutched in one hand. Her eyes welled instantly. "Oh, my girls. I wish… I wish Melendy were here."

Catra nodded against Perfuma's shoulder. "She is. In her own way."

When they pulled apart, Catra walked to the vanity and opened a small, worn box she had carried tucked in her coat since the morning. Inside was a set of wedding bangles: thin, gold, with soft green enamel flowers wrapping around the metal, warm with age and memory.

She brought them over wordlessly.

Perfuma gasped. "Catra…"

"They were Mama's," Catra said, her voice low. "She left them for my wedding day…but– I want you to have it."

Perfuma looked at her, wide-eyed, touched.

"No," she said. "She left them for *your* wedding day. Not mine."

Catra shook her head, lifting one bangle from the box. "She wanted me to take care of you. I want you to have them. She

should be there on your wedding day."

Perfuma's lip quivered as tears threatened to spill. "I can't—"

"You can," Catra insisted, slipping one gently onto her wrist. "They're yours."

Perfuma's fingers tightened around her sister's hand. "Then only if you put them on."

So Catra did. One by one, until the last was in place.

They glittered softly against her henna.

Perfuma whispered, "I'll wear them proudly."

"I know," Catra said, voice breaking. "That's why I gave them to you."

They stood there for a while, holding hands.

The world could wait a little longer.

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The palace gardens were dressed for the day in a kind of splendor that almost felt unreal. Rows of white chairs fanned out on either side of a long, petal-strewn aisle, each bloom carefully chosen. pale pink roses and creamy lilies nodding in the breeze. Strings of jasmine hung from iron arches, their aroma mingling with the warm scent of the sun on the grass. Beyond it all, the fountain caught the light, scattering it in a spray of silver droplets.

Catra's boots crunched softly on the gravel path as she led Perfuma toward the garden gate. The silk of Perfuma's dress whispered against the ground, a steady sound that somehow made Catra's heartbeat heavier.

Every step closer, the knot in her chest tightened.

She could feel it now, hope dying quietly inside her, not with a sharp break, but with a slow, inevitable fade. The same kind of ache she'd felt in the weeks after their mother died, when she'd stopped being just Perfuma's sister and started being everything else too, the one who made sure she ate, brushed her hair, did her schoolwork, the one who stood between her and the world when it got too sharp. Seven years between them had made that role natural. Necessary.

And now she was walking her to the edge of something new, something Catra wouldn't be part of, not in the same way again. Her and Perfuma would always be sisters but now…they would live apart. Perfuma would be a Viscountess and have children, and Catra would be a distant Aunt that visited occasionally and maintained her distance.

She didn't realise she was crying until a tear slid hot down her cheek. She swiped it away quickly, before Perfuma could notice.

They were almost at the gate when Perfuma stopped suddenly.

"Catra," she said softly.

Catra turned, brows knitting. "What?"

Perfuma held her gaze for a moment, then reached down to her wrist. Slowly, she slipped off the wedding bangles Catra had given her a couple of hours ago, the gold glinting in the sunlight.

"I can't wear them."

"What are you talking about?" Catra's voice was sharp with confusion.

Perfuma took her hand, pressing the bangles back into her palm. "I know you've always given me everything you had. And you've sacrificed more than I'll ever really understand. I want *you* to wear them today. Because Mama should be with you, too." Her smile trembled. "You were a mother to me in your own way. And today's yours, just as much as it's mine."

The air caught in Catra's throat, making it hard to speak. All she could manage was a watery smile as she nodded and slid the bangles over her wrist, the weight of them suddenly grounding her in a way she hadn't expected.

"I love you, Fuma," she murmured, her voice almost breaking.

Perfuma squeezed her hand once before letting go. "I love you too."

Catra turned back toward the gate, pushing it open with a quiet creak. The music swelled faintly from beyond the hedge. She stepped forward, the bangles warm against her skin, and led her sister toward the aisle, towards someone that she knew she loved.

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Adora stood at the end of the aisle, her palms damp against the seams of her trousers. The palace gardens shimmered in the soft late-afternoon light, the air thick with the scent of roses and freshly cut grass. Every color seemed brighter than it should be, the sky too blue, the flowers too vivid, like the world was mocking the hollow quiet inside her.

Her suit was immaculate, pressed to perfection, but it fit too close across the shoulders. Each breath felt tight, the fabric constricting her ribs. She shifted once, twice, as if a better stance might make it easier to exist in her own skin. It didn't.

The music playing in the background was gentle, lilting, something she knew she was supposed to hear as beautiful, but it blurred into a distant hum. Her gaze drifted over the guests, the arch woven with garlands, the aisle lined with flowers Perfuma had probably chosen herself. It was all perfect. And she felt far, far away from it.

Then the melody changed.

Adora's eyes lifted, almost without her permission.

Catra stepped into the garden.

Her dress was pastel, the color soft enough to catch the light like morning mist. It moved around her legs with each careful step, a bouquet of pale flowers held loosely in her hands. Her hair was gathered back just enough to frame her face, and the breeze caught at the loose strands, teasing them across her cheek.

Adora froze.

She told herself it was just a habit, watching for her, but the way the rest of the garden seemed to fall away betrayed her. Their eyes met, and for a moment it was as though the music, the guests, the sunlight, all held their breath. Adora's chest tightened with something she didn't want to name.

A thought flickered before she could stop it: Catra, walking toward her like this, not as a bridesmaid, but as a bride. The pastel dress white instead, the bouquet hers to give.

Her breath caught, and she blinked hard, shoving the image away. She tore her gaze from Catra's, and caught, just in the edge of her vision, that Catra had looked away at the exact same time.

The weight in her chest thickened, heavy and mournful, pressing against her lungs until she had to force a swallow just to breathe. She kept her shoulders square, her expression smooth. She had to. Catra reached the altar, stepped up with silent grace, and moved to her place at the side, where Perfuma would soon stand.

And then Perfuma appeared.

If Catra had been soft light, Perfuma was pure radiance. Her veil caught the sunlight like spun gold, her dress flowing in a way that made it seem as though she was being carried by the breeze. The flowers she had chosen seemed to bow toward her as she passed.

Adora pulled a smile onto her face, willing her cheeks to hold it steady. She told herself, not for the first time, she might grow to love this, that love could be built, could bloom where it was

planted. That there was no reason for her heart to be aching like this.

Perfuma's gaze found hers immediately, and her face lit with a beaming smile. She walked with Cyra at her side, her hand resting trustingly in Cyra's arm. But halfway down the aisle, her smile faltered — just for a breath. A flicker of something unspoken.

Adora's brow almost furrowed, but before she could think about it, Perfuma shook her head faintly, the smallest dismissal of whatever thought had passed. Her smile bloomed again, brighter than before. Flowers opened under her steps as though the earth itself was celebrating her.

When she reached the altar, she took Adora's hand without hesitation, warm and sure. Adora's fingers curled gently in response, though the grief still clung to her ribs like a stubborn shadow.

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Perfuma stood beneath the arch of flowers, her hand resting in Adora's, the vows just about to begin. The air was warm and fragrant, the soft rustle of petals in the breeze blending with the hum of the guests. It should have been perfect.

But Adora felt… different.

Even standing so close, Perfuma could sense it, her aura a kind of quiet sorrow radiating off her, like a faint, aching note only she could hear. She told herself it was nerves, that Adora was simply overwhelmed by the weight of the day. That had to be it.

Her gaze softened as she took in the sight of her soon-to-be wife. Adora looked so handsome in her suit, the cut framing her broad shoulders and straight posture, the light catching at the pale gold in her hair. Perfuma's heart swelled with affection, with certainty. Soon, this woman would be hers in truth, her wife, the future mother of their children, her partner in all things. She would be

the luckiest woman in Brightmoon and maybe, Adora would even love her someday.

The officiant's voice cut through her thoughts, warm and practiced, introducing them to the gathered guests. Perfuma's smile lingered, her eyes fixed on Adora…

…who was staring at her blankly.

Something inside her shifted. Worry. Confusion. Could this really be chalked up to just nerves, or was there something she was missing?

The officiant turned toward Adora.
"Repeat after me: I, Adora Grayskull—"

Silence.

Perfuma blinked, staring at her in surprise. Adora's gaze, still was not on her at all, it was fixed somewhere just over Perfuma's shoulder. Her eyes were glassy, unfocused but held a modicum of grief that her disassociation clearly couldn't cover.

Perfuma turned her head slightly to follow that gaze.

And there she was.

Her…sister?

Standing a few feet next to Perfuma in her soft pastel dress, bouquet in hand, looking at Adora with an equally strange expression Perfuma couldn't bring herself to name. It wasn't joy, even though her sister would be marrying. It wasn't pride or anger, because she was marrying the Viscount. It was something more…raw and grief stricken, like the two of them were standing at a funeral instead of an altar.

Perfuma's pulse quickened. Surely not. No… she must be imagining it. She wouldn't let herself even think it. The idea was simply ludicrous.

She turned back to Adora, her brows drawing together in quiet alarm. “Adora,” she murmured softly, “the officiant wants you to repeat after him…”

The officiant repeated himself.

Adora startled slightly, as though yanked from a dream. She looked at Perfuma, nodded once.
“I, Adora Grayskull—”

The officiant continued. Perfuma followed, her voice steady but her thoughts anything but. She clung to the rhythm of the vows, hoping the rest would fall back into place.

And then, a faint clink broke the stillness.

Perfuma’s eyes dropped to see one of the golden bangles slip from Catra’s wrist, tumbling to the ground near her feet. Before she could brush it off and resume, both her bride and sister moved — almost in unison, bending down to retrieve it.

They reached for it at the same time. Their hands were inches apart.

For a heartbeat, neither moved. They just looked at each other, some silent exchange passing between them that Perfuma could feel but not hear. Something heavy. Something that made her stomach twist and breathing quicken.

Her throat tightened as she looked between them, her fingers curling around her bouquet and almost crushing the flowers as the stems bit into her skin. Was her mind playing tricks on her? Had she really been this stupid? Was she reading this correctly?

Adora straightened, returning to her place at Perfuma’s side. Her face had gone blank again. Perfuma felt the dread crawling up her spine, wrapping around her ribs.

No. She wouldn’t believe it.

But the officiant was moving toward the final words, the ones that would bind them.
“Adora Grayskull, do you take Perfuma Driluth to be your–”

“I– I need a break!”

The words burst from Perfuma before she even knew she’d spoken them. They were loud, rushed and filled with all the anxiety she had felt bubbling inside her.

Adora’s head snapped toward her, confusion flashing in her eyes. But all Perfuma could see was the grief, grief she hadn’t even fully understood until now. Her breath trembled. She took one step back, then another, her gaze fixed on Adora’s face, on the sorrow she had tried all morning not to name.

And then she turned.

Her skirts flared as she broke into a run down the aisle, her vision blurring. Somewhere behind her, she heard Catra’s voice, urgent, calling her name, and Cyra’s footsteps close behind.

The guests gasped. The music faltered.

Perfuma didn’t stop.

Chapter End Notes

> GOSh so we end it there...this will get easier soon, not sure what chapter count will be yet, maybe 15? no more than 20 surely. we've still got quite a bit til the end ofc.
>
> Leave a kudos / comment if you're enjoying this! Super motivating hehe
>
> Links to my socials here for art, fic updates and general catradora things
> Twitter
> Tumblr
> Bsky

Chapter 11: The brave one

Chapter Notes

Slight tw for brief mentions of self-harm and fertility struggles

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Perfuma burst into the nearest sitting room, the door slamming against the wall as she stumbled inside. Her chest rose and fell in ragged bursts, the silk of her gown trembling with every breath. She could barely feel her hands, her whole body was shaking, her pulse roaring in her ears.

Cyra and Catra were close behind, the scent of the flower arrangements in the room suddenly cloying, suffocating. Perfuma stared at the floor as if it might steady her, but all she could see in her mind was that moment, the two of them bent together, sharing a look they shouldn't have.

"Perfuma! Perfuma, stop- don't work yourself into such a state," Cyra urged, stepping forward, her voice brisk but meant to soothe. "We can fetch some calming tea, and then you can collect yourself and return. I'm certain the Viscount will understand—"

"It is not tea that I want!"

Perfuma's voice cracked through the air like a whip. She lifted her head, the words spitting out before she could temper them. Her gaze locked on Catra, her *sister* , who stood frozen, wide-eyed, as though caught in the act of some crime.

"What I want," Perfuma hissed, each word trembling with fury, "is the truth."

Catra flinched. And that was all Perfuma needed.

Her worst fear, the one she had pushed away every time it crept into the corners of her mind at the altar, was written there in

Catra's face. The guilt. The grief. The same grief she had seen in Adora's eyes.

The woman who had filled Perfuma's ears with grand speeches of love, of futures intertwined, of the wedding Perfuma had dreamed of since girlhood… stood silent. Silent when she should have been denying, when she should have been defending.

Catra shook her head quickly, her breath uneven, her eyes glassy with unshed tears.

"How could you?" Perfuma's voice cracked under the weight of her hurt. "Were you truly going to stand there and let me bind myself to her? Let me promise her my life, knowing—"

Catra looked at her almost pleadingly, shaking her head but still saying nothing.

"Oh, you cannot deny it now, sister,", her tone sharp, cutting, because she could not bear the softness that usually came to her when she saw her older sister.

"Perfuma…" Catra whispered, almost pleading. But the sound only stoked Perfuma's fury.

From behind them, Cyra's voice rose, sharp with frustration. "Can somebody tell me what in the Stars name is going on?!"

"What is going on…" Perfuma growled out, steadily making her way to Catra and looking her deep in the face. "Is that your *daughter* , has had feelings for the Viscount, this *whole* time! And — the Viscount reciprocates!"

Cyra's breath caught, her hand flying to her mouth as she turned to Catra in horror.

Catra couldn't meet her gaze. Her eyes fixed on the floor, shoulders hunched, as if trying to make herself smaller. Tears slipped free, striking the carpet one by one, each drop only stoking the fire in Perfuma's chest.

“How could I have been such a fool?” Perfuma’s voice was barely a whisper, but it burned all the same. The shame and humiliation clawed up her throat until it nearly strangled her. “I told myself you only wanted what was best for me. That all your warnings, your disapproval, it was because you wanted me to marry someone who would truly love me. That was why you hated Adora so much…”

“You are not a fool, Fuma…” Catra finally spoke, voice raw, stepping toward her with hands half-raised. “That’s the truth. That is my only true desire. I didn’t think Adora deserved you because-”

“Because you wanted her for yourself?!”

The words ripped out of Perfuma like a blade. She could barely swallow against the bile rising in her throat.

“The whole time,” she went on, her voice breaking, “you told me she’d still propose, kept me believing you simply… needed time to accept her. You told me you hated her, and I-” Her breath hitched, the final, horrible piece clicking into place. “That meant… gods, that meant—” She choked, sobbing, the truth striking so deep it was almost physical.

Her gaze dropped to her hands, to the intricate henna winding across her skin. Every curve and petal was a piece of her life: the two of them playing in the sand as children, the little boutique they had built together in Halfmoon, the family crest, the numerals for the day she had been adopted. Symbols Catra herself, had inked for her.

This was supposed to be her dream day. And Catra had poisoned it.

“You’ve filled my head with childish notions all my life,” Perfuma whispered, her voice shaking. “And people called me naive for believing them, for seeing the world through flowers. But you told me I was right. That I was seeing the world in its truest form.”

She shook her head, her lip trembling. “Did you… did you want me to be naive? Was it easier to keep me stupid so you could have what you wanted?”

“Perfuma, no-” Catra closed the distance, taking her hands in her own. “You are my *sister* . I would never-!”

Perfuma’s heart wrenched at the contact. But the rage was louder.

“No!” She tore her hands away as if burned. “I am your adopted sister.” The words tasted like ash in her mouth, but she saw the way they landed, saw Catra’s face crumple, and a cruel, vindictive part of her wanted her to feel even a fraction of this pain.

“That is enough, girls!” Cyra snapped, but the command fell into the dead weight of the silence between them.

Perfuma’s next question came out hoarse. “Do you love her?” She braced herself for either answer, because both would hurt. If Catra didn’t, then all of this had been for nothing. If she did… then Perfuma had been a blind fool for far too long.

But Catra said nothing.

And that was the answer.

“Catra,” Cyra said tightly, her disappointment like a knife. “Go. Anywhere else. Now.”

Catra’s mouth opened as if to speak, some desperate, half-formed plea, but no sound came. She turned, shoulders hunched, as though bracing against an invisible blow.

She stepped into the hallway, but her legs faltered. One hand caught the doorframe, the other curling tight against her side as if she could hold herself together by sheer will. She didn’t dare look back.

Perfuma watched her sister stagger down the corridor, each step heavy and uneven, like an animal limping away after being struck.

The sound of her footsteps faded, swallowed by the silence she left behind.

And still, Perfuma's chest ached with the cruel satisfaction of knowing Catra would carry this wound just as she would.

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Catra staggered out. The words felt as though they had burnt onto her skin and etched themselves into her very soul. Standing outside the room now, she ached, looking quickly around for a room where she could break finally. She stared towards the spiralling staircase, about to make her move downwards but stopped when she saw Adora, accompanied by her family, making her way upwards.

Panicking, she ran into a nearby room. The room was clearly made for storage, but she deemed it safe. Nobody would come in here, unless they somehow resumed the wedding. She wracked out a sob, the emotion choking her and almost breaking her entire being as she slid down against a shelving unit. The thick dust clung to her dress and her bangles snagged against the cloth. She stared at them, all her emotions pausing. With a harsh scream, she tore them off, throwing them across the room and threading her hands through her mane as they clinked onto the floor.

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"Maybe Perfuma just needed a minute?" Adam ventured, stepping slightly into Adora's line of sight, his hands half-raised in a helpless gesture. "She's a sensitive woman—days like this, all the attention, all the pressure, sometimes it just… gets too much." His voice was careful, almost pleading, as though if he said it gently enough, it might become true.

Adora barely blinked at him, her chest tight, her breath shallow. If it were only that, if Perfuma had simply been overwhelmed, it would be a kindness she didn't deserve.

Lonnie, lingering by the far wall with her arms folded, gave a quick, crooked grin. “Maybe she realised Adora wasn’t as much of a catch as she thought.” The joke was dry, almost lazy, until Marlena’s head snapped toward her, eyes narrowing in a glare so sharp Lonnie’s mouth shut mid-breath. She dropped her gaze to the floor, muttering something incoherent.

“Adora…” Glimmer’s voice came quietly, gently, the way one might speak to someone holding a fragile vase with trembling hands. Her eyes softened when they met Adora’s, but the sympathy there felt like a blade’s edge. She knew. Of course she knew.

The weight in Adora’s chest grew heavier. The image of Perfuma’s face kept flashing through her mind, the smile she’d worn earlier, the way she’d looked at Adora like she was something precious. She could see it now, that smile crumbling, and it was her fault. All of it.

She had hurt her. She had hurt them all. Whatever bond their families had built over these months, she’d cracked it with her own hands. The Grayskulls and the Diamond, tied together in a way that had felt so certain, were now fraying because she hadn’t been enough. If she had been better, more honest, more careful, if she had kept her own feelings buried deep enough to rot away, this wouldn’t have happened.

Bow edged closer, his expression soft but steady, as if he could will her into believing she wasn’t alone. His hand slid into hers, warm and grounding. Adora looked up at him, tears threatening at the edges of her vision.

“It wasn’t just you,” Bow said quietly, searching her face. “You don’t have to—”

“Yes, it was,” Adora cut in, her voice breaking as she gritted her teeth. “This is on me.” Her throat burned, but she refused to cry, not here, not yet.

She ran a harsh hand down her face, the pressure almost bruising, as though she could rub away the guilt, the memory, the shame. But it clung tighter.

“It’s all gone to shit,” she said, voice low, raw.

She turned to leave, to get away from the stifling air and the way everyone was looking at her like she might shatter. But in the doorway, she froze.

Mara stood there. Her posture was deceptively casual, but her eyes, her eyes were too sharp, too knowing. And there, beneath the recognition, was pity. Adora’s stomach dropped.

She sighed, brushing past her without meeting her gaze.

“You know something,” Marlena said, the words flat and certain.

Mara’s eyes darted away, a flush creeping up her neck. “Whaaat? No. I- I… know nothing!”

“Mara.” Marlena’s voice was calm, but it had the weight of command. “You may have been gone seven years, but you are still my daughter. Tell me what you know.”

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“What- What has even happened?” Angella stared at the empty altar, at the guests who awkwardly sat in their pews, wondering whether or not to leave yet, wondering whether the Queen would command them one way or the other.

“They are both…idiots.” Light Spinner gritted out, ominously. She had been given one job. Get Perfuma married. The older sister said she was not interested, yet at every single intersection, she herself had complicated it. Light Spinner felt sorry for her, to some degree, but her annoyance overruled everything. This would surely damage her reputation, the lady who took in the Diamond who ran away at the altar. She would surely be lucky if the gossip

pertained just to her, and not to the actual truth of the Viscount and Sister falling for each other.

This would have been an amazing set up for her reputation, if it had worked. She could have had the glory of not only coaching the chosen Diamond, but setting her up with the most eligible Bachelor of the season. The match would have been considered a love match for anyone who even laid eyes on Perfuma.

But now, as she stared at the wilting flowers, the thorns that barbed the flowers as Perfuma had run down the aisle, she knew it would indeed be very difficult to pull this off.

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Adora ascended the stairs, each step heavier than the last. The voices and music from below felt like they belonged to another world, one she had might soon be cast out of. In her mind, it was all over. She had ruined it. She had ruined everything. But Queen Angella had urged her—calmly, firmly—to check on Perfuma, to see if the ceremony could be salvaged.

So she made her way down the corridor, her boots muffled against the carpet, her heart thudding in her throat. Her mind was already rehearsing the conversation she dreaded having, when a movement to her left caught her attention.

A door opened just a crack. Catra slipped out of what looked like a storage room. She wasn't striding out with her usual lazy confidence, she staggered, almost, her breath uneven.

Adora froze.

Catra's gaze met hers, wild, startled, almost feral in its fear. For a moment, neither of them moved, the air between them taut and buzzing. And then, as if the sight of her was too much, Catra darted back into the room, disappearing into the shadows.

Adora's body moved before her mind could argue. She glanced quickly up and down the hallway, ensuring no one was watching,

and slipped inside after her.

The storage room was dim, smelling faintly of dust and old linens. Catra stood there, rigid, her back half-turned like she was ready to flee again.

“You shouldn’t have come in here,” she croaked, her voice ragged. It was the kind of tone that spoke of tears already shed and ones barely held back. Adora felt something twist deep in her chest.

“Someone might see us,” Catra added, ears flattening against her head and her tail lashing in wide arcs.

“I checked beforehand,” Adora murmured. “Nobody was outside.”

“That doesn’t matter. You still shouldn’t be here. It’s—” Catra’s throat bobbed, her gaze skittering away. “It’s inappropriate.”

Adora’s jaw tightened. “Isn’t it a bit late for that, Catra?”

The frustration in her voice slipped out before she could temper it. Weeks—months—of Catra dodging, running, burying what they both knew was there… and now, even with everything crumbling, she was still retreating. Still closing the door before Adora could step through.

Catra’s eyes flicked up to hers for the briefest second before she said, barely above a whisper, “Perfuma knows.”

Adora’s breath caught. She looked at her properly now, really looked. This wasn’t the cocky, sharp-tongued woman she had ridden with in the woods. Catra’s shoulders were hunched, her tail low and still. Her claws had dug crescents into her palms, leaving raw red marks. She looked…small. Fragile in a way Adora had never seen. And it broke something inside her.

“Do you think…” Adora began, the words catching. “Do you think it’s all over now?”

She wished, absurdly, that it could be over. That the wreckage could be cleared and the two of them, finally, honestly, could decide what they wanted without anyone else standing between them.

"I… I don't know, Adora."

Catra's voice cracked on her name, and for a moment, neither of them moved. The distance between them felt like a chasm. One step, and she could close it. One step, and she could ruin them completely.

Adora's fingers twitched at her side, the urge to reach for her almost overwhelming. She wanted—no, needed—to cup Catra's face, to wipe away whatever was left of her tears, to promise her they'd figure this out together.

Her hand started to lift, almost on its own.

But Catra took a step back, flinching. It was small, almost imperceptible, but it was enough to make Adora's breath falter.

Catra's gaze darted to the side, anywhere but her eyes. "Don't," she murmured.

Adora froze mid-motion, her hand suspended between them like a bridge that would never be built. "Why?" The word came out softer than she intended, thick with something dangerously close to pleading.

"Because…" Catra swallowed hard. "If you touch me right now, I won't be able to stop this and– and Perfuma is…she is so angry at me and– and– *heartbroken* , Adora."

The confession was a whisper, raw and unguarded, and it sliced straight through Adora. For one heartbeat, she imagined ignoring the warning, closing the distance, letting the rest of the world fall away. But then she saw it, the glint of panic in Catra's eyes, the tremor in her hands, and she knew that crossing that line now, here, would destroy what little they still had left.

So she let her arm fall, the weight of it like an anchor.

The silence between them was suffocating. Dust mites drifted in the narrow beam of light from the door, catching in Catra's hair. She looked impossibly far away despite standing only a step from her.

"I should go," Catra said at last, her voice tight.

Adora nodded, though it felt like tearing a part of herself away. "Yeah."

But neither of them moved.

Minutes went by and Adora just stared at Catra, and Catra just stared at the floor.

"I'm sorry." Adora whispered out, her voice breaking. The sound caused Catra to finally look up at Adora.

"What are you sorry for?!" Catra scoffed, shaking her head. "You didn't technically do anything. We both- we both had a part to play and we…we did what we could. You weren't going to propose but I- I pushed. I was the one with the responsibility to come clean to Perfuma." Shame leaked into her words as she hugged herself.

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"Still- you tried to tell me when I got the ring fitted– I thought there was nothing I could do but…but there was still time to fix things. To end things before it got this bad. If I had just-"

"Okay well we both had our part to play then." Catra cut her off. She couldn't believe Adora was really going to take all of the blame, as if the bride wasn't her sister, as if Catra wasn't clearly the one to fall first. As if she hadn't offered Adora a hug that night, as if she hadn't been so bold as to go riding with her.

Shaking her head, she sighed. She picked up the bangles from the floor and fiddled with them. Why hadn't she just told her? It probably would have still ended horribly, but it was so much better than her finding out at the altar, in front of the royal family and the entire ton. Not only had Catra nearly let her promise herself to someone that didn't reciprocate her feelings, she had practically embarrassed her in front of the whole ton.

She was *awful.*

Catra looked up when Adora chuckled weakly, pressing her palm to her forehead and mussing up her hair.

"If— If I had known that this wasn't one sided, not merely attraction then I'd have-"

Catra's breath caught. Before now, every time Adora had alluded to herself actually having feelings for her, she had refuted it in her mind. She didn't see herself worthy of her, nor of the plans Adora had for her future. The Viscount didn't know that the main thing she was looking for, Catra couldn't give. And that hurt impossibly.

She had pushed her away again and again, at first because she believed it was merely attraction, then because it was too late to change the course of her engagement, and then the thing that had niggled in her mind for months. Catra couldn't carry her child.

It was the main requirement on Adora's list. The main requirement for her bride. Childbearing Hips. Catra certainly hadn't had those, nor the strength to carry a kitten of her own. It had tore her apart when she had been told, and she coped with it by telling herself it would not matter. That her partner could do so, that even if she never had a child, she would have a beautiful niece or nephew from her sister.

She didn't realise at the time that the partner she would wish for, would not want to carry a child. That the same partner may be the Mother to her niece or nephew. And Adora…a child of her own

wasn’t something she wanted, it was something she deserved. Adora deserved someone who could give her that.

“It does not matter anyway. We could not ever be together.” She said, finally. Her hands twisted at her bangles as she found a very interesting area of dust to focus on.

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Obviously, Adora was hurt. She couldn’t deny it. But whatever hurt she felt, she pushed away because it was clear that whatever the reason Catra had thought this, hurt Catra more than it could possibly hurt her.

It was strange now, how she felt she truly saw Catra. The woman wasn’t denying their future out of malice or genuine denial to Adora, it wasn’t personal to her. Looking at her, it was clear that Catra didn’t want that to be true, that the woman genuinely did wish things were different, and that whatever the reason, truly made her feel as though they had no future together.

It felt more than her simply being Perfuma’s intended, ex intended (?), she wasn’t sure. Seeing her slightly dig her claws into her palm, the scars on her palm clearly weren't just from needles and from a genuine place of hurt and holding herself back. She hadn’t let herself want before, not truly. She was similar to Adora in that aspect, and that was maybe testament to how right she was for her, and how wrong Perfuma would have been for her.

They understood each other. It wasn’t some grandiose love they spun in fairytales, but something that was real. Perfuma had just fit into a sketchy ideal of what Adora’s future should look like. Their similarities only stood in their places, Perfuma as the Diamond and Adora as the Viscount. Perfuma may have been able to give her stability and children, but…that wasn’t enough for Adora anymore.

When she allowed herself to genuinely wish, she didn’t want stability. She just thought she needed it, because the others

needed it. What she wanted was excitement, purpose, to be seen and understood, not just from an objective standpoint but from someone else who truly…got her.

And who else would ever truly understand her like Catra?

Catra whose own mother had passed away, who had seen her body just like Adora had. Catra who took on the responsibility to an insane, slightly controlling degree, just like Adora had. Catra who couldn't sleep but pushed herself anyway, just like Adora. Catra who…despite all her similarities found ways to calm her, who still worked on herself and pushed her just enough that it wasn't scary.

Catra who infuriated her but perhaps…*loved* her all the same.

Who else was there besides *her*?

"I'm going to end this," Adora said at last, stepping forward before her courage could waver. She reached for Catra's hands, gently prying her fingers open so the claws no longer dug into flesh. She smoothed the tender skin with her thumbs and tilted her chin up so their eyes could meet.

Catra's mismatched eyes glistened with unshed tears, bright with fear and something dangerously close to hope.

"I don't care if she somehow makes it back to the altar. That's not what I want." In different circumstances, if they had broken things off, she would've used this opportunity to kiss Catra. "What I want is—"

"Adora…" She practically pleaded, she looked like she couldn't decide whether to be happy or utterly fearful.

"What I want is you, Catra. Even if you think it impossible. You don't need to give me an answer, or even act on it at all, but I don't want to marry Perfuma. I don't want to live my life regretting everything, watching you from the sidelines." She lifted Catra's hand and placed a chaste kiss to it, hoping that, even

though she wasn't good with words, even though she had to keep the sentences short so as to not scare the woman away, the message would come through to her.

She hoped… that maybe Catra would finally choose herself too.

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The walk in the corridor to the drawing room seemed longer than it had any right to be. Her boots made too much noise against the polished floor, and each sound resounded like a heartbreak she wished she could have kept quiet. She had always been decisive—at least in the eyes of the ton, but this was different. This wasn't a legal dispute over land or a specific type of silverware she needed to pick out, this was a person's heart, one she was about to break.

Perfuma was stood near the window when Adora entered, the late afternoon light catching on her pale hair like threads of sunshine. She turned, smiling tightly, and hesitantly, a carefulness that had grown there in the past day, and maybe even recent weeks.

"Adora," she said hesitantly, her hands poised in front of her waist. "You are here."

Adora didn't trust herself to answer right away. She stepped fully into the room and closed the door behind her, taking a moment to absorb Perfuma's face, her gentle posture, the way she seemed so perfectly at home in sunlight. She had been chosen, not only by Adora but by everyone who wanted the match. She was the embodiment of a secure future and a lovely girl.

"I needed to speak with you," Adora began, her voice steadier than she felt.

Perfuma let her smile drop and Adora saw a flash of anger for a second, before she dropped the look entirely and gestured towards the table. "Of course. Shall we sit?"

Adora crossed the room but remained standing once she reached the edge of the rug. “No. This… won’t be long.”

Something in her tone made Perfuma straighten. She watched Adora closely now, the warmth in her expression cooling, not just out of anger but out of the dawning awareness that something had shifted.

“I owe you honesty,” Adora said, her hands clasping and unclasping behind her back to keep from fidgeting. “I should have given it to you sooner, before the invitations were sent, before… any of it. But I’ve been—” She broke off, pressing her lips together. “I’ve been a coward.”

Perfuma’s gaze turned to her napkin as she fiddled with it, but she didn’t interrupt.

Adora took a breath and tried again. “I told myself I wanted this. I told myself it was right, The Viscount and Diamond, stability, heirs. You were… everything a family could ask for.” She swallowed. “But the truth is, I wanted it because I thought it was what I *should* want. Not because it was what my heart chose.”

The light shifted, casting Perfuma half in shadow. She didn’t move.

“Your heart has already chosen," she said quietly.

“I think…” Adora’s voice wavered now. “I think I mistook comfort for want. And you deserve more than that. You deserve someone whose heart is entirely yours, without question. Someone who wakes in the morning thinking of you, not of whether they are fulfilling some… checklist of obligations.”

Perfuma’s lips parted slightly, but she didn’t speak. Her gaze flicked away for the first time, to the gardens beyond the glass.

Adora stepped closer, every instinct screaming at her to soften the blow, but she forced herself to keep the truth bare. “I doubt you want to go back to the altar but…if you do, I won’t be there.”

There it was. The words hung in the air like the aftershock of a bell.

Perfuma's breath hitched, so slight Adora might have missed it if she weren't watching her so closely.

"I see," she murmured, though her voice trembled faintly at the edges. "Do you truly love her? Was it just because I wasn't exciting enough? Does she…will she have you?"

Adora sighed, stepping closer. "Perfuma. You have been nothing short of perfect. My feelings for your…sister- they are true and deep, we share so many similarities and difficulties. I won't deny that, initially, I didn't take my attraction to her seriously. I thought it was fleeing and purely because she was something different. I didn't take *her* seriously. She wasn't what I looked for in my perfect future— but that was because I wanted what I believed would be best for my family, not for me. You were genuinely perfect, you would have fit in with my future perfectly but— I am not perfect, and I don't think I want perfection anymore."

Adora massages a hand at the base of her tight ponytail. Even now, she was aching to let her hair out a little, but faltered thinking of whether it would be presentable enough.

"Catra…" She continued, "Catra and I did absolutely nothing. We of course shared emotions but at no point did we…The most we did was hug, after sharing our grief. She was always the one to put distance between us, the one who told me to propose to you, regardless of my feelings, because you deserved it. She told me she would leave, seldom be in my life, if only to infrequently visit you from Halfmoon. She was going to stay away.

She…she was always in your corner; Perfuma—"

"She was going to let me marry you, let me live a life with you knowing…" Perfuma shook her head angrily.

"I don't know if she realised the true extent of my feelings. If she even let herself acknowledge the extent of her own until…

recently. By then, she'd decided…to let me go. She wasn't trying to allow you into a loveless marriage, hell, she was the one continually telling you not to marry me for that reason. She thought…I suppose she thought we deserved each other maybe, that she would sacrifice whatever for you—

"But that is not for her to decide!" Perfuma interjected, growling with frustration. "I know, more than anyone, that she would give up anything for me. I know she took over responsibility for us. I saw her start work at 14, I saw her spend all her savings on keeping us upright during our grief, whilst she suppressed it all. But— this, this is not for her to simply decide. It's…controlling. I know she didn't intend to hurt me, I know that now but- but she still did. It is my life now, the rest of my life, and she treated it like a game of chess. I cannot…I cannot simply just forgive that."

Adora sighed, nodding. Perfuma was right to feel whatever she wanted to feel. Adora and Catra were in the wrong and nothing she could say to Perfuma would make her understand Catra's view any more. Perfuma knew her sister after all, when all the fog of uncertainty and overthought fell away, she knew Catra didn't intend to hurt her so. Even if it still happened.

Perfuma finally turned to look at her again, her eyes sadder now. "I had wondered," she admitted softly. "I felt it, that… distance. I hoped it was simply nerves before the wedding."

"I'm sorry," Adora said, the words heavier than any she had spoken before. "You have been nothing but gracious, Perfuma. And I have done you a disservice."

Perfuma was silent for a long moment, her gaze searching Adora's face, as though she wanted to be angrier but couldn't quite summon it, not for someone she had genuinely wished to love.

When she finally spoke, her voice was calm, but there was a strain beneath it. "It will be… a scandal."

“I know,” Adora said, straightening. “I will take the blame entirely. My reputation can bear it better than yours. If anyone asks, let them know I was the one to fail you.”

Perfuma gave a faint, incredulous huff—half a laugh, half disbelief. “You would do that?”

“Yes.”

The silence stretched between them again, but this time it was softer, not quite forgiveness, but not condemnation either.

Finally, Perfuma nodded once, as if making peace with the thing she couldn’t change. “Then… I wish you well, Adora. Truly. And…if she will have you…my sister– please treat her well.”

Her voice cracked on the last word, and she turned away before Adora could see the tears start to gather.

Adora stood there a moment longer, memorising the way Perfuma’s figure was haloed in the windowlight, before she turned and left, the door shutting behind her with the finality of a vow undone.

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Catra approached the doorway to Perfuma’s guest chamber with a heaviness in her chest that nearly strangled her breath. She had trudged all the way down the candle-lit corridor with the singular intention of finally telling the truth — or what remained of it now that everything had already begun to crumble. Her hand hovered over the door frame, but before she could knock, she realized Perfuma’s door was already slightly ajar.

Inside, Perfuma stood by the window, her back straight, arms crossed tightly over her chest as if trying to hold herself together. The moment Catra stepped in, Perfuma didn’t turn, but Catra saw the rigidness in her posture, the way her shoulders trembled minutely.

“Perfuma,” Catra said softly, her voice cracking like dried leaves. “Can I… can we talk?”

Perfuma stared out at the garden, her voice quiet but edged. “You’re already here. Say whatever it is you came to say.”

Catra took a few steps forward and braced herself. “I— I’m so sorry. I know that barely matters now but… I need you to know I never meant for it to go this way. I never meant to hurt you.”

Perfuma exhaled sharply. “Catra…there were so many instances where you could have told me the truth. Whether that was from when it first started, to even a couple of days before the wedding. Anything would have been better than this-”

“I know,” Catra rasped, voicing it out loud felt like swallowing shards. “I lied. And if you want me gone— out of your life completely— I will go. If it’ll make it easier for you, I'll leave so you never have to see me again. You can still have everything with Adora if you want it—”

Perfuma turned abruptly, her eyes blazing with a hard, hurt kind of fury. “Why do you think I would even want that? Adora came by herself to break things off. She was *honest* .” She shook her head in disbelief. “You truly thought the solution was disappearing and letting me live in some fantasy with a person who can’t even look me in the eye because she’s in love with *you* ?”

Catra's throat constricted. She stood very still, tail low, fingers clenched. “I didn’t know what else to do. I didn’t know she even–”

Perfuma’s expression flickered with something softer, but only briefly. “Are you going to start seeing the Viscount now?” she asked, quieter now, but strained around the edges.

Catra stared at the floor. “…I don’t…I don’t know– I can’t, I think.” She lifted her eyes with difficulty. “What do *you* want, Perfuma?”

Perfuma's jaw went tight, a bitter laugh escaping as she stepped back. "It's not always about what *I* want! That's the whole problem, Catra. We're here in this wreck of a mess because you put what I would want over your own, consequences be damned." Her breathing trembled. "You both hurt me. It was like my heart was some…curse to your actual feelings."

Catra swallowed hard and nodded slowly, sorrowfully. "No. Our feelings were the curse. I tried to end it– so many times. By the time I was finally going to tell you- to try with Adora she had…she had proposed, because I had told her to before."

Perfuma's voice broke, her eyes welling up even as she tried to speak with strength. "When I think about it… I was so close to promising my life to someone who didn't even think to tell me that she didn't truly feel for me. That the woman she truly was in love with intended to visit me on only rare occasions because she was actually my sister, and couldn't bear to see us living the life she wanted. You were going to keep me on the side, Catra. I would've waited for you and you would've let me believe that meant something — when really you'd already planned to spend most of your life in someone else's orbit. You didn't even tell me."

Catra's voice was hollow, pained. "I didn't want to lose you."

"You did anyway." Perfuma's tears spilled then, hot and furious. "And what hurts the most is — you treated me like I was just a task to complete. Like after you got this over with, your life would truly start. And– I pity you for that, more than anything but– it's not fair that I was placed on this pedestal to be perfect and take what you truly wanted. You treated me like I wouldn't be able to handle the truth, because I was too delicate to be spoken to honestly or too perfect. But you had seen me at my angriest, you know I struggle to keep my composure, and that I can handle a lot. Maybe I am naive but you– you cherished that! It's not some great burden that means I cannot be talked to honestly!"

Catra's ears drooped in shame. "You're right… about all of it. You deserved the truth. You deserved more than what I gave you."

Perfuma wiped her cheeks roughly, voice shaking. “I don’t know if I’ll ever truly forgive you. Maybe one day I’ll want to — I *want* to want to. But right now, I need space. I need you to let me be angry. Because I am… unbelievably angry.”

Catra nodded once, slowly, bitterly, though her eyes glistened. “I understand.”

Perfuma took a slow, shuddering breath. “And I need you to stop treating me like I’m perfect. I’m not. And I can handle the truth, being told something painful doesn’t humiliate me. But being lied to when I knew something was wrong the entire time? That did.”

Catra looked pained, but earnest. “I agree. I shouldn’t have. I won’t do it again.”

Perfuma turned back toward the window, unable to look at her for a moment. “Please leave me alone for now. I want to be by myself. I still care about you— and that’s what makes all this so much worse.”

Catra’s voice was barely above a whisper. “I’ll go.”

There was a long moment of silence, Perfuma’s breath uneven, and Catra stood there a second longer, as if searching for something to hold onto, but there was nothing. She stepped backward, opened the door, and quietly slipped out, leaving Perfuma alone with her grief and her righteous fury — and the faintest flicker of hope, however distant, that maybe, someday, something could be repaired. But for now, Perfuma was hurt, and Catra had to pretend that she wasn’t breaking slowly because of it.

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The altar was beautiful and empty. White roses wilting by the dusk light, their petals brushed with fading gold. Perfuma's touch lingered everywhere, delicate, thoughtful, full of a kind of hope Catra had never been able to hold in her own hands. Even now,

with Perfuma gone, it felt like the world she had built here still breathed around them.

And Adora stood at the center of it like a statue of grief. She didn’t move, didn't turn. Her shoulders were squared like she was still trying to hold up the sky. Like if she just stood still enough, maybe nothing would fall apart.

Catra kept her distance — a long stretch of the aisle between them, just enough space to pretend nothing had changed. Enough space so Adora might not feel the way Catra's shame was shaking out of her like a fever.

For a moment, Catra wondered if Adora could tell she’d nearly run the other way before stepping inside. She wasn’t sure she could bear the burn of Adora looking at her — especially not when all she could think about now was that same horrible truth she’d once buried deep: she couldn’t give Adora the future she deserved. Not a home, not children, nothing. She’d shoved that fear down months ago with bitter laughter. Told herself it didn’t matter because Adora never wanted her anyway.

Now she wasn’t sure that lie could save her.

“How did it go?” Adora asked, still facing forward. Her voice was quiet, tired.

Catra huffed a laugh that didn’t feel like hers. “As expected,” she said, folding her arms around herself. “We really fucked up.”

Adora exhaled through her nose, gaze still fixed on what might have been. “Your sister is… braver than both of us,” she said. “She figured it out — what we’ve been feeling for *half a year* . And she ended it. Right there, in front of everyone. Even with the scandal. Even knowing what it’d cost. She stopped it before we could ruin her more.”

Catra’s throat went tight. She looked down at the floorboards, jaw clenched. “She’s always been the brave one.”

Silence stretched. And then she felt it, Adora's gaze on her, heavy, searching.

"Did you ever want to be the brave one?" Adora asked, voice softer now, like it hurt to say.

Catra looked up.

She didn't answer. Couldn't. The words stuck behind everything else she'd never dared: *Yes. Yes, I did. But I thought I had nothing to offer you. I thought you deserved someone who could– I thought it didn't matter anyway because in what world would you even choose me?*

They stood there, eyes locked, not moving. All the unsaid things between them were loud enough to drown out the evening birdsong: fear, longing, *exhaustion* , months of wanting twisted into shame and denial. It felt sacred and shameful all at once.

Catra took one step, then another, until the air between them felt thin. Adora didn't move, only watched her like she wasn't sure if Catra would stay or strike.

Catra's hands moved before her mind caught up. One curled into the front of Adora's jacket, the other slid up her neck, into her hair. She pulled her forward and pressed her mouth to hers, quick, rough, like a stolen breath.

Adora made a sound, small, shocked — then melted forward, fingers gripping Catra's waist as if she'd been waiting this whole time for permission. Catra pressed closer, lips parting, her pulse loud in her ears. Adora's mouth was soft, warm, unfamiliar and too familiar all at once. Their noses brushed, breath mingling between kisses, everything frantic and greedy like they could make up for months of silence in one moment.

Catra tilted her head and deepened it, her teeth briefly scraping against Adora's bottom lip. Adora gasped into her mouth, and Catra swallowed the sound, pulling her even closer until there was no space left at all between them. She could feel Adora's

heartbeat under her hand, could feel how Adora trembled just slightly as they moved against each other, slow but intense, like neither of them knew how to be gentle anymore.

Adora brought a hand up to cradle the back of Catra's neck, thumb brushing her jaw so tenderly it almost hurt. She kissed Catra back like she was trying to tell her everything she'd never said — apologies, want, *relief* , all of it wordless and heavy on her lips.

Catra broke for just half a second, to breathe, her forehead resting against Adora's. Their breaths came out shaky. Then Adora pulled her back in, like she couldn't bear to stop, and Catra let her. let herself fall completely, mouth opening to Adora's again.

This was the feeling she had been looking for. The one thing that could stop the hollowness in her chest, if only for a moment.

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Chapter End Notes

FINALLLLLLLYYYYYY amirite? How are we feeling? Predictions for the next chapter?

SOCIALS -
twitter
Bluesky
tumblr

Chapter 12: Not good with words

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It had been two weeks since her absolute embarrassment of a wedding, and still Perfuma felt the hollow ache of betrayal and shame clinging to her ribs. She had laughed when she was meant to laugh, smiled politely at well wishers, and performed her duties as if her future had not been split open, but every so often, her composure faltered, especially when her sister was near.

The estate remained lively, too lively for Perfuma's bruised heart. Catra, to her credit, had tried multiple times to speak with her since the wedding, always approaching her with an almost uncharacteristic hesitation. But Perfuma had no patience left. Each time, she had met her attempts with a cool, practiced civility. A short nod. A simple 'excuse me, I have business to attend to.' Not cruel, nor cutting like she wanted to, just merely cold. Because if she allowed herself to answer truthfully. If she gave Catra more than that, she feared her anger would snap loose and burn whatever stones of a bridge they had left between them.

And so, she kept her distance.

This afternoon, she sat in the garden pavilion, tending to the blooms that had been left to overgrow whilst the rest of the household busied themselves. The roses bowed heavy with summer, the lilacs drooped lazily, their fragrance both soothing and stifling. Perfuma was about to weave them into a loose crown, something to keep her hands busy, when a voice called from the path.

"Lady Perfuma?"

Perfuma looked up to see Scorpia, half-hidden by the trellis, holding a bouquet of wildflowers. She looked almost embarrassed

to be standing there, as though she had stumbled into the wrong room at a ball.

Perfuma rose politely, brushing soil from her palms. “Scorpia. What a surprise.” And it was. A lovely surprise in fact. The woman, even though they had met very briefly, had left an impression on Perfuma. She was charmingly dopey, a soft disposition compared to her hard exoskeleton, her hulking, tall and *built* figure.

The woman grinned nervously, scratching at her neck with one claw. “I, uh— I brought these. For you.” She thrust the flowers forward almost too quickly, like a soldier presenting arms.

Perfuma blinked, then took them, the stems cool in her hand. They were simple meadow blooms, nothing cultivated or grand — but real, warm, alive. “Oh,” she breathed, softer than she meant to. “No one’s ever given me flowers before.” Her heart bloomed slightly, before she attempted to stamp it down.

Scorpia’s eyebrows shot up. “What? That’s ridiculous! You’re *Perfuma.* People should be bringing you flowers every day!”

Perfuma smiled faintly, though her heart ached. “There always was no point. I could simply grow my own with magic. But… it isn’t the same, is it? Receiving them.” She traced the edge of a daisy with her fingertip. “I do like it.”

Scorpia’s grin softened. “Well… they’re sort of ‘sorry flowers.’ Sorry for what you’re going through. Sorry that everything’s been… y’know. Rough.”

Perfuma’s chest tightened. She looked at Scorpia then, really looked, and found sincerity written all over her awkward face. “That’s kind of you.”

Scorpia was so devastatingly kind. Perfuma wondered if people made fun of her for being naive sometimes too, too trusting, like they had done to her.

Scorpia shifted her weight, awkwardly. “Well I mean it,” she paused, fidgeting with her claws. “You didn’t deserve that.”

Talking about it still hurt, she wasn’t completely ready. The whole incident made her just feel embarrassment all over, shame for not being enough.

“What happened, happened,” she shrugged.

“Well…what did happen? If you don’t mind me asking–” She fumbled, realising that may have been too direct. “I- I just mean, you’re– I just can’t imagine someone leaving you- *you* at the altar.”

Perfuma sadly shrugged. “I just wasn’t…what her heart desires.” She shrunk in on herself. This feeling was ridiculous. It wasn’t as though she was in love with the Viscount. It was merely that she felt that she had one job, and had failed at even that.

“Well then, her heart is a fool.” Scorpia surmised, bending down to sit by Perfuma. Her claws twined with the flowers softly, being careful not to cut them as she continued. “Do you uh…perhaps think you will go back into the Season? Looking…I mean.”

Perfuma tilted her head, studying her. There was something guileless about the question, as if Scorpia had only just realized she’d spoken it aloud. Perfuma decided to tease, just slightly. “That’s rather direct of you.”

“Oh—! No, no, I didn’t mean- I mean, yes, but not- I just…” Scorpia flailed a hand in the air, words stumbling over themselves like pebbles down a hill.

Perfuma’s lips curved despite herself. The fumbling was endearing, so unpolished compared to the slick dances of courtship she was accustomed to. “It’s all right,” she soothed gently. Then, after a pause, she admitted, “I don’t know if I’m ready for anything. It always felt as though I was supposed to find a wife and secure my future, as though love was another item to check off a list. But

the idea of it… happening when it's meant to… I think I like that better."

Scorpia's smile steadied. "That's how I feel. If it comes, it comes. I've never been good at… looking on command."

Perfuma held her gaze longer than she should have, her heart catching strangely. She liked that idea too, though part of her still felt wary. Her heart was not yet ready to trust; she still bore the sting of lies, the weight of nearly binding herself to something false. But here, in the warmth of Scorpia's presence, she felt the faintest shift. Not healing, not yet, but… the promise of something gentler.

To distract herself, she asked, "And your powers? I don't think I've ever asked."

"Oh, uh—" Scorpia looked sheepish, rubbing the back of her neck. "Electrokinesis. I can, y'know, control electricity. Not very glamorous outside of battle, though. The most impressive thing I can do is turn on a lamp without touching the switch. And half the sorcerers here can do that anyway."

Perfuma blinked, then let out a small, genuine laugh. "That's not useless. That's extraordinary."

Scorpia shrugged, embarrassed. "I guess. Just doesn't feel like much compared to people like you, who can make entire gardens bloom."

Perfuma glanced down at the bouquet in her hand, the flowers Scorpia had picked, clumsy stems and all. She touched one of the petals, softer than silk. "Sometimes," she said slowly, "the smallest magic is the kind that matters most. People find even my powers useless."

Their eyes met again, and for a moment the air seemed charged — whether from Scorpia's gift or something else, Perfuma could not tell. She looked away first, fingers tightening around the

flowers. She was not ready. Her heart was still raw, still wary. But she could not deny that something stirred.

Something she hadn't expected.

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Catra had never been good at waiting. Pacing, yes. Scratching her claws into furniture until Cyra had scolded her, definitely. But waiting? Sitting still whilst something gnawed at her chest? Impossible.

And yet, for over two weeks now, she had done nothing but wait.

Perfuma hadn't spoken to her beyond the barest civilities. A polite nod, a cold smile, a brief glance before she teared her gaze away. Catra knew she deserved it – Perfuma had every right to hate her very being, but the silence still drove her half-mad. It was like being erased from her sister's life whilst still standing directly in front of her.

It was partly for that reason…she hadn't spoken a word to Adora since the kiss. That one, searing, reckless moment that had cracked everything open again. The memory burned itself into Catra's mind, in her fingertips, in the centre of her chest. She thought of it on nights alone when things were too quiet and the only emotions she could bring herself to feel was the desire pooled between her legs. She wanted Adora. She wanted her so badly it ached. But she couldn't say it. Couldn't admit the truth of why she held back. Not without possibly being rejected due to her condition, making everything that conspired between them utterly not worth it.

So she stayed silent. And silence was rotting her from the inside out.

She was in the library that evening, curled into one of the high-backed chairs, pretending to read but really just staring at the same page for an hour. Her leg bounced restlessly. Her ears twitched at every sound. She felt like a caged animal.

“Catra?”

Her head jerked up. Her mother stood in the doorway, hands folded neatly, expression unreadable. Of course, it would be Cyra. Somehow, the woman always knew just when to appear and make Catra feel ultimately worse.

“What do you want?” Catra muttered, slumping deeper into the chair, wishing she could vanish into the upholstery.

Cyra didn’t answer right away. She crossed the room with quiet, measured steps, then sat down opposite her. The firelight painted her face in warm golds, but her eyes were sharp. “I want to know what’s happening with you.”

“Nothing,” Catra snapped too quickly. “I’m fine.”

Cyra arched one brow. “You look like you haven’t slept in days. Perfuma won’t speak to you. It seems the Viscount hasn’t looked you in the eye since the wedding. And you’re fine?”

Catra dug her claws into the arm of the chair, chest tightening. “Drop it.”

“No,” Cyra said simply.

Something inside Catra wavered, then cracked. She pressed the heel of her palm against her eye, trying to hold it back, but it spilled out anyway. “I’m going insane.” Her voice was raw, broken. “Perfuma ignores me like I don’t exist, and I know, I know that is… valid, she has every reason to, but it’s like being gutted alive every time she walks past me like I’m nothing. And Adora—” She choked, swore under her breath. Was she really going to admit this? Make everything worse?

“I…we kissed. And now I can’t look at her. I know she wants more but I- I can’t give her it. And I can’t even seem to tell her why, tell anyone why. But I do want- I want…”

Her throat closed. She couldn’t even form the words.

Cyra waited. She didn't push, didn't prod, just watched her with that piercing, patient gaze.

Finally, Catra let her head fall into her hands. "I want Adora. I want her so bad it hurts. But if I go after her, I'm the monster who shattered Perfuma's heart and stole the one thing she was trying to hold onto. And if I don't… I'm going to lose my mind. And if Adora doesn't want me after this then…I've lost everything for absolutely nothing."

The admission left her shaking, breaths shallow. She had never said it aloud before.

Cyra leaned forward slightly. Her voice was low, even. "I don't understand fully. Adora has told you she wants you, yes?"

"Yes but—"

"But what? What could she possibly find out that would change that?"

Catra tugged at the fur on her arms, practically begging for something to do with her hands, so she could finally tell someone.

"I…I cannot carry a child." She admitted, looking down at the floor beneath her.

She still heard the gasp though, and when she looked up, her mother was staring at her with wide eyes.

"Catra…" She whispered softly. It made all of Catra's hairs fluff up, she wasn't sure if that was in sadness or anger. Part of her hated having her Mother's pity, another part of her longed to just collapse in her Mother's arms and cry about it, cry about the fact that she had no one to tell. No one that even knew her fully.

"When did you find out?" Cyra asked instead.

Catra hugged herself, trying to make herself even smaller. “Four years ago.”

It wasn’t that the diagnosis was a death sentence, or that it would make it impossible for her to ever have kids. It was the fact that with…with Adora- she couldn’t give her the one thing she seemed to want the most. The one thing that might make her…worthy of her.

Her mother drew closer, and for a second all Catra could feel was panic. She wasn’t used to loving attention from her, nor any kind of closeness. But as the woman wrapped her arms around her, Catra let out a harsh sob. Why couldn’t she have this all those years ago? When her mama had died, even years after. Why now? When everything was practically over.

“I’m sorry you couldn’t tell me.” She whispered, stroking her kitten’s fur, the same way she did before Catra turned 13 and everything had gone to shit. Catra let out a stuttering purr, nudging her head into her palm for the first time since then, claiming her mother’s as hers once more.

“Do you think she’ll…”

“She would be a fool to give you up over that, kitten.” Cyra let out before Catra could finish her sentence. “But she is no fool. I have seen the way she looks at you. Perhaps I wasn’t as observant before the wedding but…her care for you runs deep. Almost instinctual. She wouldn’t let something like that stop her from being with you.”

“I feel…broken.” Catra admitted. Part of her felt somewhat in danger still, telling her Mother her deepest secrets, especially when she felt as though she didn’t deserve the comfort, after what she had done to Perfuma. But as she was bundled up, in her mother’s awkward and harsh hug, when she had honestly forgotten what that felt like, she found herself completely vulnerable.

"You are not broken. I… I am the same way." Cyra's voice came out hesitant, and the last part almost came out a harsh whisper but Catra heard it all the same.

Catra's brow furrowed. *Did that mean…?*

"Your mama carried you. Back then there wasn't even magic for us to have children together, so we had a surrogate too. She didn't want to carry children initially, she was scared shitless of perhaps not having 'good enough genes' to carry you. She believed what everyone in the ton was saying, that she was inferior to me because she was a blacksmith's daughter. She didn't have 'upperclass genetics' whatever bogus bigotry that means." Cyra laughed, though it came out harsh and forced. "She knew I couldn't carry though…We had found out after trying out surrogacy on myself the first time.

It was so much harder back then. Homophobia was still somewhat rife, two women still couldn't really have children without a male being involved…Melendy just felt…she was lost. Eventually, she saw more gay couples around us having children, regardless of their class. Some were just like us. It was easier…for her to picture us having children after that, seeing there was a community, that society was becoming more accepting, that she wasn't inferior. She told me she would carry a child after that and we were…so happy."

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Twenty seven years ago

"Cyra…"

The sound of her wife's voice carried across the courtyard, soft but trembling, fraying at the edges. Cyra turned quickly, brushing dust from her hands after returning from the market. She had expected Melendy's usual smile, the one that made every crowded street and long day worth it. But when she turned, all she saw

were those green-and-amber eyes wide with panic, her face pale and uncertain.

"Mel…" Cyra's chest tightened. She crossed the space between them at once, taking her wife's hands and folding them into her own. She smoothed her thumb over Melendy's knuckles, grounding them both. "Sweetheart? What's wrong? Are you hurt?"

Melendy shook her head quickly, lips parting as though to speak, then closing again. She fumbled, awkward, then pulled something from her pocket and held it out like it might burn her fingers.

Cyra blinked down at it.

A pregnancy test.

A *positive* pregnancy test.

"Oh…oh my god." The words tumbled out of her in a gasp. She snatched it almost clumsily, staring down at the two pink lines as if checking them twice, thrice, could change their meaning. Her heart hammered in her chest, thundering in her ears.

Melendy's voice came small, fractured. "I—You do still want this, right? With *me* ?"

For a moment, Cyra forgot how to breathe. Then it rushed back all at once, a flood of laughter breaking out of her, shaky and radiant. "Want this?" she echoed, before sweeping Melendy into her arms, lifting her right off the ground in a fierce embrace. She kissed her, deeply, joyously, because kissing Melendy was as natural as breathing, and she knew, even when they were wrinkled and gray and complaining about aching joints, it would still be the sweetest part of her day. It was her greatest wish to grow old with her wife. To see the world change for their children, to have grandchildren and bicker over small things.

And now they will have *children* .

"You— *gods* , you are incredible," she whispered against Melendy's lips, against her cheeks, peppering kisses across every freckle and dimple until her wife dissolved into warm laughter.

Melendy squirmed in her arms, giggling helplessly as she clung tighter around Cyra's shoulders. "I was worried sick," she confessed, voice muffled in Cyra's neck. "That maybe you would change your mind, that maybe…"

Cyra pulled back just enough to cup her wife's face in both hands, eyes fierce and steady. "I would *never* change my mind about you. Not in this lifetime, not in the next. There is nothing you could do, nothing that could happen, that would make me leave." Her voice broke slightly, but it was with love, not fear. "You are it for me. Always."

Melendy's eyes filled with tears, but this time they glimmered with something softer. Relief. Hope. She let Cyra kiss them away, let her press another chaste kiss to her mouth before Cyra, dizzy with happiness, spun her around in a circle. Melendy squealed, clinging tight until Cyra set her gently down again, both of them breathless with laughter.

"We're going to be mothers," Melendy whispered, pressing her hand over Cyra's, guiding it against her belly though it was far too soon to feel anything there. Her smile quivered but shone bright. "You're going to be such a beautiful mother, Cyra. I know they'll adore you."

Cyra closed her eyes briefly, letting the words sink in. Fear pricked at the edges of her mind, what if she wasn't enough, what if she failed, but she pressed it down, buried it beneath the tidal wave of love that filled her chest. All she could focus on was her wife, warm and alive and in her arms, and the miracle of what they were about to build together.

"I'm going back out to the market," she declared suddenly, as though struck by divine purpose. "I'm going to get your favorite

pastries and…pickles. Yes, *pickles* . That's what everyone says, right? Pregnant women crave pickles."

Melendy barked out a sharp laugh and tugged her closer by the waist. "You ridiculous busybody. Stay. Just stay with me tonight. No pickles yet, it's too early, I think. And I'd rather have you than any craving."

Cyra melted instantly, resting her forehead against hers. "Then you have me," she whispered. "Tonight, tomorrow, always."

And as Melendy kissed her again, tender and lingering, Cyra knew with absolute certainty: this was her greatest dream, her life's anchor. Not the market, not the battles she had once fought, not even the future they had yet to see. Just this. Just them. *Forever* .

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Adora was going half mad. The house was as lively as usual. Though she found it insufferable. She wanted one moment of peace, but apparently, being one of the most prestigious families amidst a scandal still wouldn't shut the Grayskulls up.

It had been two weeks, two weeks since the disaster of a wedding and two weeks since she had kissed the woman she had been pining over for half a year. It seemed that even kissing her, didn't cease the pining though, since she had shut Adora out, *again* .

Maybe shutting out wasn't the right word, but she certainly hadn't reached out. Though nor had Adora.

Amidst a scandal, being seen at Perfuma's house, unchaperoned would honestly lead to more rumours, and neither party needed that.

Though Adora had taken the fall, continually told gossipers that she was the one to fail Perfuma. The ton was still skeptical. Perfuma wasn't known very well around these parts, so many people still wondered what she had done to ruin the wedding. A

completely unfair assumption when all she had done was be utterly perfect.

So maybe she did know why Catra hadn't reached out. Maybe it did make sense. But that didn't make it ache any less.

"Focus, Adora! You nearly had it!" Mara chastised.

They were in the empty ballroom again, sword in hand and chanting the Grayskull name again and again, begging to just let her transform.

If Light Hope hadn't specifically told Adora, that she was next to be She-Ra, she honestly wouldn't have believed it. She felt utterly human and 'unmagical' next to her sister, whose eyes glowed despite her sisters dimmed ones.

"Can't you just be She-Ra instead? It clearly prefers you." Adora sighed. She knew the notion was childish, but she didn't feel like being an adult right now.

"We are both…She-Ra." Mara grimaced. "As much as I hate it. You just have a disadvantage because I'm not allowing that creepy robot lady to sink her holographic hands into you and make you train for months upon end."

"That 'creepy' robot lady, looks like your wife, so I would be careful about what you say about her." A voice said, stepping into the ballroom.

Hope joined Mara, pouting slightly. It was the most expression Adora ever really saw on her usually composed face.

"Did you want me to hit on your Great Great Grandma or something?" Mara rolled her eyes, bringing her hand to Hope's waist and squeezing.

It was a little painful to see. Painful when her own love life was currently in shambles.

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“A ball?!” Perfuma gritted out.

“Yes. Despite the Grayskull’s attempts to quell the gossip, it is still rife. We need to attend tonight’s ball, along with the Grayskulls to show we are amicable and have nothing to hide.” Light spinner said, ignoring Perfuma’s angry expression.

“Is it not too soon?” Catra asked, quietly.

“On the contrary. After your *fuck up* , now is better than ever to do damage control.” Light Spinner couldn’t bring herself to speak cordially to the Magicat. She was the reason for their tough position in the first place, and yet still wanted to question her?

“Do not speak to her like that.” Cyra growled, stepping forward. This was an interesting development. For all the time this family had stayed with her, the mother had never once actually taken much control over her children.

Light Spinner rolled her eyes, nodding and then bowing her head. It would not do any good to fight with the mother. “Yes, Cyra. Apologies. I merely mean to say that in these circumstances we need to do whatever it takes to quell the gossip. Whether we are comfortable or not.” She crooned, placatingly.

“Very well. Girls, get your gowns out.

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It was a beautiful ball, by all accounts. It hardly held a candle to the balls at the Palace or Grayskull’s estate, but was beautiful nonetheless. Adora couldn’t really dwell on it’s beauty though. She was sick to her stomach with nerves and excitement over being able to see a certain woman today.

The Driluth family was accompanied by the Scorpioni’s Princess today. Scorpia kept a respectable distance from them however,

probably so as to not stir up further rumours, but Adora knew she was there in support.

Whether that was to support Perfuma or Catra though, she hadn't decided yet. She still felt a lingering insecurity at how the woman had stared at Catra when they first met, though her eyes were clearly taken by Perfuma soon after.

"Ease up on the staring, Dor." Glimmer whispered from her side.

"When is it appropriate to go up to them?" Adam asked, whispering too. "Catra is so cool, I don't want Adora's dumbass to have ruined any way of conversation with her."

"Seems like we're in luck. The family is on their way to us right now." Lonnie smirked, gesturing towards them.

Adora finally looked up, making eyes with Catra, who was a vision in burgundy silks. The Magicat looked about as nervous as Adora felt, yet shook her head and quickly melted into a soft composure.

"Ah, the Grayskulls. What a pleasure to see you here." Light spinner crooned, ignoring the looks and whispers from the passersby.

"A- A pleasure to see you too, Lady Light Spinner." Adora cut in before her mother could. This was her mess, she wouldn't let anyone else even *attempt* to clean it up for her.

"Have you been well?" Cyra asked. It was strange to hear her voice really. Throughout their entire courtship, Perfuma's mother had been quiet, seemingly content to let Catra take the reigns. Maybe she had to take them back once the sisters argued.

Adora really hoped things were more amicable now between the two.

"Uh…Yes! Just been…busy."

"Busy doing what? My *sister* ?" Perfuma muttered quietly to herself, earning a gasp from both the Grayskulls and Driluth's.

She herself even seemed shocked she'd said it, slapping a hand over her mouth.

Catra was very, very red.

"Well…there's the answer to why it ended." Lonnie muttered, earning a jabbed elbow to her stomach from Mara.

"Uhh…" Adora said, not quite knowing how to reply.

"I'm just gonna- Yeah-" Scorpia chuckled awkwardly then grabbed Perfuma's elbow, leading her out to the dance floor and away from the two families that just stared at each other awkwardly.

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The families had dispered now, leaving Catra and Adora very tensely standing opposite each other. It was awkward as hell.

Distantly, a part of her was glad Perfuma still remained her snarky self, that the years of meditation didn't mould her little sister into some robotic happy being all the time.

It would be funnier if it wasn't at her expense.

"Uh- Do you…would you…"

Catra looked up at Adora, who was still blushing a pretty pink and stammering over her words. It was nice to see the normally so composed Viscount stuttering over a mere snarky joke of them sleeping together.

"Want to dance?" Catra offered, saving the woman from further embarrassment. She offered her hand to Adora who gave her a grateful look before nodding and taking it.

They stepped onto the floor, the silence thick around them except for the faint echo of music that still drifted through from somewhere deeper in the manor. Adora placed a hesitant hand at her waist, and Catra found her own hand settling on the Viscount's shoulder, the closeness both intoxicating and unbearable.

Catra shivered a little.

Adora smelled faintly of lavender and something sharper, like clean steel. Familiar, grounding, infuriating. She tried not to breathe too deeply, tried not to lean into it, but her body betrayed her.

She didn't want to let go.

Not of this moment.

Not of Adora.

Her heart beat harder with every step. She told herself she should look away, keep the walls up, keep her claws sharp. But when Adora's eyes flicked down, catching hers with that same intensity she'd had at the altar, Catra nearly lost it.

"You look nice." Adora offered her, smiling sheepishly at her. Catra wondered if her expression was guarded because of the gossiping ton looking upon them, or from their two weeks of not talking.

"You're not so bad yourself, Princess." Catra remarked. She wanted to tell the truth, to tell Adora genuinely how beautiful she seemed but the words felt stuck, like all she could offer was snark.

"Not a Princess. A Viscount." Adora rolled her eyes but squeezed her hip all the same.

Her hair was golden in this light, catching the lanterns in a shimmery wave. She had opted for a half updo today, a stark

difference compared to the tight ponytail she usually wore. It made her look more effortless, more pretty than uptight.

“You’re more a Princess, than a Viscount with that hairdo.”

“Do you not like it?” The woman looked worried, and Catra chastised herself. How could she keep saying the wrong things?

“I didn’t say that…It’s just…pretty. It suits you.” She forced out.

Adora beamed at her, her eyes sparkling and a dimple making its way into her cheek. The look made Catra swallow. Had she ever seen that look on her face? So delighted?

Yes, when they rode together.

“Careful. I might think you like me. How embarassing.” Adora teased.

Catra smiled playfully, twirling the Viscount around and giggling at her dazed expression. She would endure any amount of teasing if it got Adora to look at her like this.

“We’re a little past that, don’t you think?” She whispered.

Adora looked at her like she had hung the moon and stars with her confession.

“You like me?” She whispered back.

“Idiot.” Catra chuckled, dipping her slightly. “We shouldn’t really talk about that here. There’s too many eyes on us and…rumours are already rife.”

Adora’s eyes widened and she quickly scanned the room, seeing the Lords and Ladies eyeing them wearily. There hadn’t been any rumors regarding Adora and Catra— at least not that she had heard, but she didn’t want to start them up either way.

“Right- uh— Right. But can we- can we talk later? Like actually talk?”

The request was terrifying but she couldn’t bring herself to reject the notion anymore.

“Yes.” Catra nodded.

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The ball had finally dwindled to its end, the great manor settling into a hush of tired laughter and retreating footsteps. Lanterns glowed dimly along the garden paths, their soft golden light pooling across the trimmed hedges and roses. The night smelled of earth and lilac, and the crickets hummed an unsteady song.

Catra shoved her hands into her pockets as she padded across the stone steps, stealing glances at the figure beside her. Adora’s coat had been thrown over her shoulders—her ridiculous, oversized jacket that nearly swallowed her whole. The Viscount had insisted when she’d noticed Catra shivering, and Catra hadn’t had the energy to fight her on it. Hadn’t told her that her shivering was due to their proximity, and not the cold.

They walked in silence for a while, the air charged but fragile, like a thread pulled taut.

Adora was the first to break it.

“Catra…” Her voice was quiet, low enough that it nearly blended with the hum of the crickets. “Do you…truly want this? You hadn’t answered after the wedding and…I’m just feeling a little confused.”

Catra’s ears flattened against her head. She owed Adora the truth.

“I’m sorry,” she tried. Before these past two weeks, she hadn’t thought she had ever apologised before. Now it was all she seemed to do.

Adora deflated, looking at her with sad, sapphire eyes. “Because… you don’t want me?”

“No!” Catra shouted, then shrank back, embarrassed. “No- No I do– *Gods* I do-” She whispered out. “I just…I just can’t…give you what you want.”

Adora, who had perked up a little after her admission, now stared at her puzzled. “What I want?”

“You know…the woman with…childbearing hips, with sense…quiet manners.” She trailed off, hugging herself now. She had told herself at the time that she was so angry at Adora’s requirements because it made a woman seem like a mere checklist, like she was somehow above them. And whilst that was true, she also had felt so upset that she didn’t fit those.

Adora stared at her with a look akin to horror. This was it, she was going to end it.

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Gods. That was why she had been pulling away? Adora was so fucking stupid. Her requirements were always offensive, demeaning, but now she was fully realising how hard she had fucked up.

“Catra…” She tilted her chin up, so their gazes could meet. She wasn’t expecting a thin sheen of tears to be welling up in the Magicat’s eyes, and the horror she felt bubbled up within her.

She had been such a *fool* .

“Catra,” she said again, firmer this time, taking Catra’s hands into her own. Her voice trembled, but her grip was steady. “I was foolish. Those requirements I clung to, the lists, the expectations — they weren’t about love, they were about survival. About building a life that looked safe, respectable, easy to explain. I thought that was what would make my future secure. But I was wrong. I was ignorant.”

Her breath hitched, but she pushed through. "I didn't know what I truly wanted. I wasn't even looking for love, not really. And when it came, it didn't fit the picture I had painted for myself. Perfuma had every quality I thought I needed — she was gentle, patient, perfectly composed. But when it mattered…" Her eyes locked onto Catra's, fierce with honesty. "I didn't fall for her. I fell for you. I *choose* you, Catra. Not her. Not any list of requirements."

Catra looked up at her, her expression caught between strife and elation.

"You fell for me?" She whispered.

"Yes! - I - God I'm not good with words." Adora stammered.

Catra stepped closer, close enough to see the freckles across her nose, the little scar at her hairline she always fussed over. Close enough that the warmth of her chest seeped into her own. Her hand lifted, almost of its own accord, brushing against Adora's sleeve.

"I did too," Catra admitted, swallowing, "but- Adora…you don't get it. I can't-"

Adora shook her head feverishly. The admittance that her feelings were reciprocated, that Catra loved her too, even if they hadn't said it in so many words, was too much, she couldn't listen to Catra doubt herself any longer. No words would be as good as showing her.

And so she cut her off, kissing her softly.

Kissing Catra opened doors to Adora's future that she never knew she wanted. Feeling her soft lips upon hers, her sigh into her mouth and the trail of her hands into her hair, messing it up, made Adora know that if she only ever got to choose anything for herself, it would be this.

Adora held her impossibly tighter, drawing her in and kissing her feverishly Her knees nearly buckled as she matched Catra's sigh

with a gasp, her own arm gripping her waist tightly as Catra's arms winded around her neck. They broke apart to breathe, Catra giggling softly, wetly, a tear trailing softly down her cheek. Adora smiled softly at her and wiped it off, drawing her closer again.

Catra tilted her head and leaned in once more, her shaky hand rising to cup Adora's cheek softly, calloused thumb brushing underneath her eye and telling her exactly how she felt. This. Adora was good at this. Not so much with words than with this.

She felt dizzy with love as she grabbed Catra's palm and led her to the estate, both of them giggling like schoolchildren.

Chapter End Notes

> Okay see, after like 65k words they kind of get their shit together. Slowest slow burn ever? probably, but catradora got five seasons so I had to at least make it accurate. Next chapter will have smut at the beginning probably, so there will be a border of stars if you'd like to skip it. How are we feeling about everything? Frustrated that there is still some miscommunication? Yeah me too, but promise I'll make it worth it. Next chapter is going to be so juicy I promise, their shit is going to get together so soon.
>
> Then we'll wrap it up soon, Maybe a couple of more chapters left. I took my time with this fic, it's already longer than saviour complex and this fic is like my proud prodigy child tbh. SC needs to be rewritten fully, the writing is a little poop but I swear I'm gonna fix it up, though I'm so grateful for all the hits and kudos its gotten - thanks so much!
>
> ALSO I LOVE Snarky Perfuma
>
> Leave a kudos and comment here if you like !
>
> SOCIALS
> twitter
> bluesky
> tumblr

Let me know if you're coming from ao3! I don't really advertise my fic writing on anywhere but bsky soo it would be fun!

Until next update!

Chapter 13: Waking up with Adora

Chapter Notes

> We made it to the smut! If you are someone who would like to skip it, the beginning of the sfw part starts as 'waking up with Adora' The chapter isn't entirely smut, though that was tempting, but I wanted to add some fluff in there.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It had always been easier to pretend that the pull Adora had towards Catra was out of forbidden temptation, something she couldn't have, so she desperately wanted, something that wouldn't last outside of the bedroom and was merely physical. But staring down at the woman below her now, her rounded pupils and her usually prickly disposition, diminishing into a soft, begging mess, Adora knew that she was utterly fucked. Catra wasn't merely some dirty fantasy she had been having over the months, she was a woman Adora desperately wanted to spend her days with, whether that was clothed or unclothed.

The more sides Catra allowed her to see, the more Adora wanted to be the one to find out all facets of her, every small thing that made her tick, or smile, anything that would cause her to be the writhing, begging mess beneath her, anything that would make her feel safe enough to wake up next to in the morning.

She was beautiful beneath her, her cheeks flushed pink and heady and her fur smooth in all the places Adora had yet to explore. It made Adora feel like the luckiest person ever. As though she must have done something incredibly right in a past life to be able to have this woman like this.

She was overcome with emotion, when she looked at the woman staring at her with equal devotion and a small sense of bashfulness.

“Did you bring me here, just to admire, Viscount?” She rasped out, causing Adora to feel herself shudder. Catra’s voice had been haunting her, ever since their first ride together, that day in the whispering woods.

“Is it so wrong that I’d like to take my time with you?” She answered, once pulling herself together.

Leaning forward, she connected their lips together. The pull was all encompassing, and the relief she felt when their lips met was too great. She pressed herself fully to Catra’s body, moulding their lips desperately together, practically squeezing Catra’s cheek with the force of love she felt. Catra gasped beneath her, as Adora licked her fangs and practically vibrated with excitement and the hope that these same teeth would trail down her own body later.

“A-Adora-” She muffled into Adora’s mouth.

Adora pulled back, looking at Catra who already looked thoroughly fucked by her, though all they had done was kiss clothed so far.

“Yes?” She whispered, sliding her lips from hers, to her jaw. She was practically tongue fucking every single inch of her jaw, her neck and leaving dark bruises littering her neck. She could lay here for days.

“Stop teasing.” Catra gritted out, pushing Adora’s head with force down to her chest and making a move to try to take off her dress.

Adora huffed, laughing a little as she kissed the woman’s sternum. Catra gasped out, brokenly and muttered out a plea as Adora replaced her hands with her own and unzipped her dress from the back.

Once the dress was off, Adora took her time gently raising off her undergarments, bending down to kiss every curve on her body, every flex of a muscle and every scattered freckle, making sure Catra was watching and panting for her.

“You’re gorgeous, Catra.” She whispered as she stared at the breasts that fell out of her corset. They were smaller than Adora knew her own to be, and had darkened nipples that peaked at the cold biting air.

Catra herself let out a shudder, grabbing Adora from her stupor and bringing their lips to meet once again. Adora made sure to pour every amount of admiration she felt into the kiss, if Catra wouldn’t allow her to verbally sing her praises then she would show her.

“Take yours off too, Adora. I’ve been waiting a long enough time.” She hissed out as they broke apart, impatient and already making a move to unbutton her shirt, fingers practically shaking.

“Oh yeah?” Adora smirked, “How long have you been waiting?”

“Since I met you.” She admitted, her ears pinning to her head as she let out a frustrated growl.

Adora couldn’t stop the silly beam that slid across her face. She knew Catra had been attracted to her, but to hear that she had been wanting this since they had met, maybe even fantasised about it, made her joyful.

“Oaf.” Catra rolled her eyes fondly.

“Show me what you thought about.” Adora said instead, deciding to try to get back on track.

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Catra didn’t know it was possible to be this sexually frustrated when you were about to have sex. Adora was seriously making Catra more frustrated, albeit frustratedly horny, but this had to count as some type of sexual torture— and she wouldn’t stand for it. At least not for their first time.

She obliged Adora’s request. Sitting Adora up and climbing into her lap. Her first fantasy about Adora had been shame filled, and

didn’t really have coherent thought, just that she would feel Adora’s hands on her, and Adora’s breath on her neck.

She faced away from Adora as she sat in her lap, bringing the woman’s large hands over her breast and guiding her to squeeze it.

Fuck . Now they were getting somewhere.

Adora moaned at the feeling of Catra’s breast, taking a bit more control and squeezing her breasts with more force, almost painfully squeezing her nipple and making Catra’s hips arch. *So Adora did know exactly how to use her hands,* she just wanted to tease. Catra didn’t know why she ever imagined Adora was simply inexperienced — of course she had just wanted to frustrate her.

Adora kissed Catra’s neck, leaning down into the crook of it and trailing her strong hands down her curves, squeezing her every curve and eventually spreading her legs apart.

“Yes.” Catra hissed. She spread her thighs wider, and led Adora’s hand to her heat, to try dissuade her from simply paying attention to her thighs.

“Someone’s eager.” Adora chuckled, amused, before pushing Catra off her lap. Catra growled out angrily. How long was she going to long this out?

She didn’t finish her thought though, as Adora roughly pressed her against the bed on her back, caging her with her arms and pressing a chaste kiss to her lips before dragging her body down.

She kissed a path down Catra’s navel, licking and biting, making the magicat hiss and arch her back higher, begging the woman to finally meet her, and she wasn’t disappointed.

Adora looked down at Catra’s pussy and whispered a ‘fuck…’ before diving down.

Catra let out a loud cry as she felt her tongue trail from the bottom of her slit upwards, wrapping the warm heat of her lips around her swollen clit.

"Fuck…Please— Adora-" she cried. She felt the woman's lips curl into a smirk as she slurped happily on Catra's wetness and brought her closer and closer to the edge. Sucking, biting and fucking her tongue into her. The woman knew just what would get Catra off, but seemed to stall, holding off from fingers and merely bringing her to the edge again and again with her tongue.

Catra was gasping hard and grabbed Adora's head, pulling the half ponytail out and digging her claws into the woman's scalp, earning an equal hiss of pain and pleasure.

She bucked against Adora's tongue, placing her head there roughly and selfishly taking Adora's mouth like a toy, making the woman beneath her groan as she fucked herself against her, rolled her clit against her nose, tears falling from her eyes as she pleaded with Adora. Her tongue was soft and pliant against her pussy, practically swallowing her.

Then, just as Catra was about to cum, crying out harder and rutting herself faster against her tongue. Adora pulled away quickly, smirking.

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Catra stared up at Adora, her face wet with tears, frustration and her wild hair sticking in her face. The Magicat was utterly frustrated and looked about seconds away from scratching Adora in the face, if she didn't get back to what she was doing.

"What?!" She growled, "Get back to it."

Her demanding tone almost made Adora obey.

"You were so cocky and challenging all these months," Adora teased, knowing it would infuriate her. "Now look at you, practically writhing and begging me to continue."

Catra hissed, her competitiveness rising over her frustration. "Please." She scoffed, "you want this just as bad. As I recall, you were practically begging for me all these months."

Well…she had gotten her there. Adora *had* been the one pining over Catra, and probably would beg Catra to touch her if she ever held off. But she didn't need to know that.

"Well…you're the one on the brink of orgasm and I'm still clothed. Don't you think maybe you're the needy one?"

The words seemed to infuriate her more, making her close her legs and sit up. She dragged Adora by her shirt forward, connecting their lips in a rough kiss. Her tongue swept over Adora's lips immediately and bit punishingly into her lip, drawing blood. Then, she cupped Adora through her pants, smirking back up at her.

Adora gasped at the contact, not expecting to be groped so confidently and without shame. She felt herself, embarrassingly, push her sex into Catra's palm even more, seeking friction that she couldn't feel as much through her thick trousers.

"You're soaking through your pants, just by watching me. Would you really like to pretend that you're completely composed, and not equally enjoying this?" The woman drawled, her fang snagging into her lip as she smirked. And fuck, if that didn't undo Adora immediately.

"F-Fine." Adora acquiesced. She knew when to not fight a losing game, and instead rocked herself into Catra's hands.

"Here's what we'll do instead," Catra pushed Adora beneath her, crawling on top and pressing her very wet, exposed pussy to Adora's crotch, making Adora gasp and grab her hips to press her further. "I'm going to–" She started, detracting her claws and slicing through the buttons holding Adora's shirt together, "-take your shirt off and then–" she sliced through Adora's bindings making her tits fall out, earning a gasp from the blonde and a

softly drawn breath from herself. "-And then…." she trailed off, staring at Adora's breasts, which were fuller than most would expect. "And then, *fuck* - and then, your pants–" She sliced through those too, practically tearing them off her legs and smirking, her composure back.

"And now-" She leaned down, to Adora's crotch that was covered by thinly veiled cotton panties. She pressed her lips to Adora's V line, kissing it and then lower.

"Cat-Catra…" Adora gasped out, wanting to grab her hair and pull her down to her crotch already, but she was frozen in awe.

Catra looked up at her, biting Adora's hip bones and then dragging her rough tongue along the slit through Adora's panties, she gripped the side of it with her teeth and then, agonisingly slow, dragged it down Adora's muscled legs.

"Fuck…" Adora whispered out, watching her.

Adora is so beautiful, she couldn't help but think. For all the hard, masculine ways she carried herself, you wouldn't have believed the writhing mess she turned into, beneath Catra. Her blonde hair was pooled beneath her like a halo, her eyes tearful and wide, her cheeks a pretty pink as she bit down harshly onto her lip, anticipating what Catra would do next.

"And now," She got on top of Adora, spreading her legs slightly apart and settling herself in between, so that their crotches could press firmly against each other.

Adora cried out, her clit stiffening as she made contact with Catra's own. They both hissed as Catra experimentally rocked. "Now, I'm going to *shut* you up." She finished, hauling Adora's leg over her shoulder and grinding their centres.

Fuck.

Catra knew she wouldn't last long, not after Adora had teased her for so long, and not whilst her greatest fantasies were coming

true, despite all the things that stood against them. The adoration she felt for Adora only made her feel like she'd come apart sooner, not being able to control herself over this.

Adora was crying out beneath her, grabbing her hips punishingly and rocking her back and force over her clit, almost willing herself to fuck into her. Catra was barely in control now, hugging the leg that was placed over her shoulder and just twitching back, rutting into her sensitively as though any second she might fall apart.

Adora noticed, of course she did. She pulled Catra closer to her, so that they could still rub against each other but almost hug each other. She held her arms around catra, placing wet kisses down her neck and telling her how beautiful she was. It made the magicat bashful, she had never had sex that was so caring, usually a hurried mess before either party had some duty to fulfil, but this, this was unhurried, raw and utterly real, and Catra feared she might not make it out of this, whether she wanted to or not.

Catra was dangerously close now, but she needed more, and of course the other party sensed that. Snaking a hand behind Catra's back, Adora grabbed her tail and pulled.

"Shit- A-Adora!" She cried.

Catra then yowled, practically screaming into Adora as she came, her claws dragging down the woman's bicep. She gasped out as Adora kissed her neck, praising her, complimenting her and rutting against her softly still. Adora came soon after, groaning and gasping as Catra heaved for breath still. She had never taken so long to finish an orgasm, but as she laid on top of Adora, she felt unbelievably floaty.

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Adora burned red. She was utterly spent after they had both came together.

Catra was laying on her chest now, still breathing hard but purring loudly and vibrating Adora's body underneath her.

She smiled to herself, bringing a hand through Catra's hair and threading her fingers through it, pushing it to the side to see Catra's blissed out face.

"You okay, there?" She whispered, knowing her tone was overly fond.

"Mhm…" Catra mumbled into her chest, burrowing between them deeper and rubbing her face against them. Adora's heart swelled with affection as she chuckled, bending her head a little lower to kiss her hair.

Her eyes were heavy now, and she was just about to fall asleep when she felt a claw trail down her stomach. Her breath hitched and she bolted her eyes open to see Catra, eyes sparkling and her hand exploring her lazily.

"You're…you're so *pretty* , Adora." She whispered, her eyes still fixated on her breasts and stomach. Adora's eyes widened and she felt her heart beat treatariously loud. She wasn't used to compliments, much less compliments like *that* .

"You really think so?" She asked, inwardly cursing herself for sounding so weak.

"Yeah…" Catra was blushing a heavy red when she looked up at Adora's surprised face. "You're beautiful. Even when you wear your waistcoat and breeches. I thought that even when you told me you wanted to let yourself be pretty in a dress. You're pretty always." She confessed.

Adora felt a little teary eyed but she sobered up quickly to press a solid, harsh kiss to Catra's lips, pouring out all her gratitude.

"Can I show you?" Catra whispered against her lips.

"Show me what?"

"How pretty you are."

Adora blushed heavily and found herself choked up, so she nodded instead. Catra smiled and maintained eye contact as she slowly lathed Adora's neck with her rough tongue, dragging it downwards and pressing her lips between her tits.

She kissed her sternum more fully and began sucking harshly, making Adora gasp out and press her face against her more fully.

Fuck, Catra's tongue felt so good.

She brought her mouth to Adora's nipple, sucking and biting at it as Adora cried out, bucking her hips. Her tits had always been sensitive when she tweaked them herself, but every partner she had ever slept with, had never particularly paid attention to her this way. She wasn't used to receiving anything, and as she wrapped her legs around Catra's body, she realised she had probably been missing out.

"*Fuck*, Adora. You're so fucking sexy." Catra growled out, trailing a claw down her abs and groping her hips leisurely.

"Please.." Adora whispered out, bucking her hips to get Catra's attention lower.

Catra chuckled, pressing her canines against Adora's hip bone and dragging down, til finally she was face to face with Adora's pussy. Adora whimpered out, a flush of wetness pooling out of her and settling on the sheets below. She felt her clit twitch as she watched Catra pull her hair back, rake her claws down her hips as she settled between her legs.

"Fuck!" Adora gasped as Catra's tongue made contact with her slit. It was a feeling unlike anything she had felt before. Her tongue was inside of her, curling and dipping in as she assaulted Adora's pussy.

Adora cried out again, grabbing Catra's hair and bringing her face to her clit. When her clit was sucked in too, she bucked wildly and started begging, rutting herself shamelessly against Catra's face,

using her nose to pleasure her clit and her tongue to dip inside of her.

Catra smirked up at her, moving her face back slightly so Adora could see the entire of her face covered in her slick, and her wild hair even more untamed from Adora's stronghold.

"Fingers?" She asked, smugly.

All Adora could do was nod helplessly, arching herself up to Catra's face again, pathetically.

Catra retracted her claws and pushed one in. Adora moaned out, immediately asking for more.

Catra moved her tongue back to Adora's clit, pressing two fingers into Adora now as Adora screamed, grinding her body against Catra's fingers and riding them. Catra was moaning just as shamefully beneath her and grinding against the bed as she fucked her.

Adora was crying, hot tears falling down her face as she tweaked her nipple, and finally she screamed, clenching her thighs around Catra's head so her face was locked to her pussy as she jerked and shook against her. She felt her pussy releasing liquid onto Catra's face but she was too far gone, twitching and rutting still.

"Catr-ah!"

"Mmmff!—"

Adora's orgasm waved on for a while, but when she finally went slack, releasing Catra from her stronghold, she saw Catra's face drenched with her cum, red and smug. Adora's heart was even beating in her pussy and she weakly brought Catra up to her.

"Do you want me to…?" She looked at Catra who raised an eyebrow.

“Well if you look there, you can see that seeing you was enough for me.” Catra pointed to an area of the comforter that was just as wet, from where Catra had been laying down.

Adora grabbed Catra and kissed her again, licking into her mouth and tasting herself.

“You’re…incredible.” She breathed, as Catra purred and bumped her cheek against hers.

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Waking up with Adora was something Catra didn’t know she needed until she had it. She had never slept so well, and sure, maybe you could contribute that to the multiple orgasms wiping her out, but she knew better. The strong, comforting hold Adora had on her, her slightly hard bed but thick comforter, her gentle snore — all had lulled Catra into sleeping a comforting 9 hours without any nightmares, or uncomfortable dreams.

She was staring down at Adora now, with a full heart, purring softly and listening to the snores that filled her room. Looking around the room in daylight, she realised it was almost soldier-like, if soldiers had access to a little more luxury. Her room was pristine, white walls and grey curtains, a desk that was in the corner and a small chair. The room was completely impersonal, save for a small picture frame of Adora’s entire family, on her nightstand.

She had only seen Adora smile like she had in that photo, one time, and that was last night.

Catra purred louder, falling into Adora’s arms and snuggling. She really could get used to this, even if the fear in her mind still nagged at her, warning her that she hadn’t even been fully truthful yet.

She bit her lip, spiralling a little once more when the arms around her shifted, tighter, and a soft kiss was pressed to her hair.

“Morning…you awake?” Adora’s voice was thick with sleep and Catra felt her heart beat louder as she looked up at her.

“No,,,go back to sleep.” She rasped out, bumping her head further into Adora’s plush chest and earning a giggle.

“You’re so cute.”

“I am not cute.” Catra growled, her tail thumping annoyed beneath her.

Adora smirked and was about to say something else when they heard a strange chime in the room, Adora’s eyes widened, but before she could push Catra’s head under the covers, Glimmer and Bow materialised.

“Adora, it’s like 11am! You should be up by n- Oh shit!” Glimmer went bright red and covered her eyes, and Bow’s too, who hadn’t said anything; just stared at them slack jawed.

“Glimmer!! How many times have I told you about knocking on the door like a normal person!” Adora covered both of them with her duvet and was just as red as the other two. Catra merely smirked and sat up.

“Adora, can you pass me my corset?” She asked, grinning. Adora gritted her teeth and glared half-heartedly at Catra, who was absolutely about to stir things up.

“Actually, could you maybe call for a carriage? I’m not sure I’ll be able to walk…” She mused, revelling in the squeak Bow made.

“Adora!” Glimmer shrieked.

“Okay! You two- Get out!” Adora shouted back, using an embarrassed but commanding tone. Glimmer was more than happy to oblige clearly, immediately disappearing.

“You’re incorrigible.” Adora sighed, shaking her head at Catra’s fit of giggles. Messing with them had been a beautiful start to her

day.

She stopped giggling to find Adora staring at her fondly, pink cheeks and a sleepy grin.

“Can I…”

“Can you what, Viscount?” Catra smirked.

“Can I kiss you?” She asked sheepishly.

“Hmm…” Catra looked towards the ceiling and tapped her chin thoughtfully. “Well after last night I suppose you c- Oof-”

Adora grabbed her chin and kissed her hard, probably to shut her snark up, but Catra wasn’t complaining. She sighed and wounded her arms around the Viscount’s neck, kissing her softly.

“Wow…” Adora said as she pulled away.

“Don’t ruin it..” Catra smiled, purring a little still.

“You like me…” Adora smirked, causing another eye roll from Catra.

I love you. She thought, but shook her head anyway. Neither of them had said that so fully yet, so she wouldn’t be the first to right now.

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“You CHEATED!” Adora laughed breathlessly, waggling her fingers at Catra. “That’s low, even for you.”

Catra huffed, tugging the reigns a little on her horse and slowing him down. “Aww,” she crooned, “you know nothing is too low for me”

Adora shivered, Catra’s tone of voice sending her mind in a totally different track, forgetting their race and instead thinking of….

Catra giggled, seemingly being able to read her mind. “Do you want something, Viscount?” She asked, cocking a brow and urging her horse closer. “It’s a shame you’re too busy to have me over.” She jested, solemnly.

Adora pouted. The past couple of weeks since they had slept together, consisted of them sneaking around and waiting for the perfect time to see each other. Obviously, this wasn’t ideal, and Adora wanted to scream it from the rooftops that Catra was heard, but she knew that announcing that so soon from the wedding would probably be an even larger scandal that Mara’s.

Furthermore, it had been days since she could see Catra. Pushing herself harder and harder to try and transform into She-Ra. Catra herself had told her she was getting closer, that she could see Adora start to glow when they would sleep together, or when they would ride together.

Mara had caught on too, not wanting to pry further about what was making Adora closer to transforming, but not letting the change go unnoticed. They had started working on it everyday, leaving less time for her to get closer to Catra.

“What if..” Adora bit her lip, “What if I sneak out and meet you somewhere?” Her house was off-limits right now, Adam had reported hearing strange noises coming from around Adora's room recently and she was a little on edge. Adam seemed to know exactly what those ‘strange noises’ were, but she doubted he had realised she had reconnected with Catra, and not some random woman.

The nosy git would absolutely try and stick himself in it further and try to find out. Having Glimmer and Bow know, was already nerve wracking, despite them being strangely supportive.

Catra was flushed now, looking up at Adora with wide eyes. Adora stared at her in confusion, jerking her head to the side to ask what she was thinking.

“Like….meet outside?”

“Yes?” She was still so confused.

“You want to…sleep together outside? In the open?” Catra stared at her, gaping.

Adora flushed, going an even brighter red than Catra had been initially. “W-what?!” She squeaked, waving her hands, “No like-! Like a hangout- Not…”

Catra smirked, regaining her composure. “Like…a secret courtship?” She may have been smirking and steady, but her bright eyes and slight flush told Adora she was happy.

“Well…I mean aren’t we- aren’t we already courting?” Adora asked, fumbling with the reigns nervously.

The magicat blushed heavily now. “Well…I don’t know.” She shrugged, biting her lip as her tail waved slowly behind her. They hadn’t ever put a name on it, so Catra wasn’t sure if they had been hanging out as friends…despite the whole…’falling for each other’ thing. They did sleep together occasionally, but she had worked herself into such a spiral that she was wondering if that was all it was.

Adora stared at her, a little baffled. If this had happened a month ago, or even a few weeks ago, she would have been utterly sure that Catra professing her confusion over their status was an indication that she didn’t want them to be anything more. But as she got to know her, understand her avoidant gaze and thumping tail, her ears pressed to the back of her head, she knew she had been wrong.

“In that case,” Adora dismounted herself, holding the reigns but still walking closer to Catra and offering a hand out. “Can we- will you court me?” She asked sheepishly, not really knowing the right words.

Catra stared at her, her pupils dilated and her tail thumping softly on the back of her horse now. Blinking slowly, she nodded, putting her hand in the Viscount's as Adora raised it to her lips and kissed it.

"Oaf." Catra rolled her eyes, but her beaming smile said otherwise.

"You like me…How embarassing." Adora retorted, but that quickly died, when Catra leaned down, the height of the horse giving her leverage, and placed a soft kiss to her lips. Adora let go of the reigns and pressed herself to her tip-toes, digging a hand through Catra's hair and kissing her back just as sweetly.

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"You are so cheesy." Catra giggled, hopping down from her window, in a way that made Adora gawk.

Adora had arrived at her window, throwing pebbles at it to get her attention. When Catra had looked outside her window, Adora was there, albeit in a thin nightdress, holding a bouquet of flowers. And fuck, if that didn't do things to Catra. Maybe they would be engaging in voyeurism after all.

"Only for you," Adora grinned, shoving the bouquet of hyacinths in Catra's face and causing her to sneeze. She looked up at Adora, who was staring at her and grinning.

"Don't."

"Sorry- It's just, your sneeze is so-"

"No."

"Cute!"

Catra huffed and pushed Adora away, about to walk in the direction she assumed they would be walking.

“Actually I um” Catra looked up to see Adora gesturing awkwardly towards a carriage.

“You brought a carriage?!” She hissed, craning her head to look up at the driver. It was a royal footman, of all people.

“She won’t tell! She’s Glimmer’s footman and…she’s had plenty of opportunities to snitch on Glimmer…”

Catra eyed the footman suspiciously, the woman had pale blue hair and pretty dark skin, she grinned up at Catra and gave her a ‘thumbs up’.

“Young love…” She muttered, dreamily. Catra fought the urge to roll her eyes and instead smiled politely at the woman. Sure the footman could be dangerous, but she be damned if she would rather walk than ride in a carriage.

Adora held open the carriage door for her, and Catra snorted. “So gentlemanly.” She muttered, hopping in and waiting for Adora to get in after her.

“I am a gentleman, thank you for noticing!” Adora grinned.

“I don’t recall you doing this for Perfuma,” Catra shrugged, playing with her bouquet with a small smile on her face. It wasn’t really first date material, to bring up her sister and their previous engagement, but she felt like she was seeing someone completely different than her sister did.

“Perfuma wasn’t right for me. I didn’t realise but I didn’t…have the urge to do those things for her, take care of her. She seemed so…”

“Perfect?” Catra muttered bitterly. “And I am not?”

“No!” Adora shook her head vigorously. “Well…yes. But I don’t want perfect, and Perfuma just wasn’t right anyway. I just- just want you to be able to lean on me.” She bit her lip thoughtfully.

“It’s hard to explain but…I want to take care of you, and do nice things for you.”

Catra calmed down a little, sagging in her chair. If she was honest, she was a little insecure of Perfuma, despite that in the end, she was chosen. She did understand what Adora was saying though, she had never felt any drive to take care of someone besides her sister, but with Adora…she felt as though she wanted to make everything easier for her, help her lean on her just as she had been doing.

“I’m sorry, I didn’t want to ruin it. It’s hardly been five minutes and I’ve already—”

“No.” Adora pressed a kiss to her hair, “You have not ruined anything. The date has hardly begun.”

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Adora had led Catra to a small clearing in a field. If Catra had known Adora less, she would have definitely thought she was bringing her to hook up secretly. But as Adora led her to the blanket on the field, with stars in the sky and a small tiffin accompanying another bouquet, Catra was enamoured.

“When did you…even do this?” Catra whispered out, shivering a little at the biting cold. Adora smiled at her, pulling a jacket around Catra and another for herself.

“I came out here an hour before I got you. Netossa helped me set it up” She gestured to the footman, who grinned up at them and turned away pointedly.

“Come, sit.” She ushered Catra to the side of the blanket and sat down besides her, opening the first layer of the tiffin, causing a delicious aroma to waft out.

Catra gasped out, grabbing the tiffin from her to open each layer, and inspecting the contents. Traditional halfmoon curries, rice,

and fish met her eyes. She snapped her gaze to Adora, who looked a little embarrassed but proud.

“Where did you get these?” She asked, immediately plucking a slice of fish with her claws and tasting it, moaning at the tender flesh and warm sensation that bubbled in her stomach. She hadn’t had any food from Halfmoon in at least eight months.

“I’ve been to Halfmoon before,” She said sheepishly. “And one of our chefs is from there, I just asked him to make some traditional dishes from there and recalled what I ate when I was there on business."

Catra stared at her, her tail thumping excitedly. She was too overcome with words and simply pressed a kiss to Adora’s cheek gratefully.

“You’ve been to Halfmoon before?” She asked, trying to steer the subject a little to still the powerful thrum in her chest.

“Yeah.” Adora smiled wistfully, her eyes glazing. “I went there briefly. It was beautiful. So lively and homey. I honestly didn’t want to leave.”

Catra smiled at her. Maybe…maybe once the gossiping was over, Adora would visit Halfmoon to see her? She wasn’t sure what the plans were currently. Honestly, if her and Adora weren’t the way they were now…she probably would have left a lot sooner.

“Halfmoon is my favourite place ever. I haven’t ventured out a lot, honestly. Mostly briefly seeing Salineas and now Brightmoon. But Halfmoon will always be my home. There is quite nothing like it.” She had been feeling overly homesick over these past few months, it only increasing tenfold when Perfuma had stopped talking to her, but tucking into these dishes with Adora, the feeling stifled briefly.

“It’s a great place to raise a family, it seems. There’s kids running around everywhere.” Adora smiled at her wistfully.

Catra felt herself stiffen, her fur puffing up and dread pooling into her stomach. She wanted so badly to spill the truth to Adora, but the words couldn’t form outside the twisting of her gut.

“Mrow”

They both turned around, interrupted, and Melog materialized next to Catra, bumping their face into her palm.

‘Don’t be upset’ They said to her, chuffing and purring into her hand. She smiled softly and wrapped her arms around them, purring against them for comfort. She heard Adora gasp out, probably looking at them with dumb heart eyes.

She picked up a small piece of fish and fed it to the big cat, giggling a little as they purred louder.

Maybe she would tell Adora another day.

Chapter End Notes

> I know people are just screaming at Catra to say it already, but she's nervous okay...plus who would I be if I didn't add another layer for some drama. Anyway, I mentioned briefly that I based Halfmoon on south asia, mainly because I'm south asian so know that best, and also because Kate from the original bridgerton show is Indian! I've always thought of Halfmoon as South asian when I read fics though, the spices, the importing of materials and silks, love it.
>
> Anyway I wrote this all on my phone, which, yeah it was convenient, but for some reason the paragraphs get super spaced out when you copy them onto ao3, so I had to go back and backspace every single paragraph which was a pain.
>
> Let me know your thoughts on this chapter and leave a kudos if you'd like to :)
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Chapter 14: Do you still want to?

Chapter Notes

> Okay, there's some skippable smut that starts at the **** as usual, and ends at the **** stars!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora was exhausted. Every muscle in her body ached, her hair stuck to the nape of her neck with sweat, and her palms were still faintly glowing with She-Ra's lingering energy.

She'd been at this for weeks now, transforming, holding the form longer, mastering the weight of the sword as it shifted beneath her hands. She could feel her strength building, the land answering her when she pressed her palm to the dirt. Just days ago she had healed an entire stretch of a ruined Plumeria, watching it bloom with cautious new shoots where ash had lingered for years.

It was satisfying, of course. Purposeful. But it was also draining. She felt as though her very bones were made of lead, and sometimes she barely made it back to her room before collapsing face-first onto the bed.

But Adora didn't complain. Not when she saw the rubble-strewn villages, the families still patching together homes with their bare hands, the children who had no place to sleep because the war had swallowed theirs whole. She had been ignorant once, cocooned in her estate, believing her role was enough. Not anymore. Now she worked beside them, lifting beams, carrying bricks, lending her impossible strength to causes where no one else came.

And somehow, amidst it all, she'd gotten closer with Catra.

Closer in ways that made her heart pound and her cheeks flush whenever they shared a glance too long across a crowded

ballroom, or when Catra snuck a sharp quip that only Adora seemed to hear. They lived in secrets now—brushing hands beneath tablecloths, stolen moments in quiet hallways, the kind of games society forced them to play but which secretly thrilled Adora to no end.

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Catra had been planning this for weeks.

Ever since Adora had collapsed one evening after training, barely able to lift her fork at supper, Catra had known she needed to do something. The woman was running herself ragged, training with that sword, rebuilding half the countryside, walking into villages with her sleeves rolled up like she wasn't a viscount's heir but a common bricklayer. Admirable, sure. But infuriating, too.

So she decided she was going to *force* Adora to rest.

Which was how she found herself standing in one of Brightmoon's side corridors, arms crossed, waiting for Glimmer to finish rolling her eyes.

"So let me get this straight," Glimmer said, smirking as she leaned against the wall, Bow standing at her side looking far too entertained. "You want me to lie to half of Brightmoon society about Adora's whereabouts while you whisk her off to Mystacor. Alone."

Catra scowled, tugging her cloak tighter. "It's not— don't make it sound like that. She needs a break. She's exhausted. I just… want her to breathe for once."

Bow's smile softened. "That's actually really sweet of you, Catra. Adora's always been running herself ragged. If anyone could get her to rest, it would be you."

"Ugh, don't say that." Catra groaned, her ears flicking back. "It's not sweet, it's practical. If she burns out, what good is she to anyone? I'm just…"

“Taking her to soak in hot springs under starlight,” Glimmer cut in, grin wicked. “Scandalous.”

Catra’s face burned. “It’s not- Gods, you’re impossible.”

“Relax.” Glimmer winked. “I’ll tell Marlena she’s away on estate business. She’ll believe it. Though… you might want to warn your mother.”

Catra groaned again, but she’d already tried. Cyra had taken one look at her flushed face and muttered, “At least you’re finally doing something about it. Have fun, with Adora, kitten.” The memory made her ears flatten. She hadn’t even told Cyra she would be with Adora, just that she had business to attend to. But her mother was getting sharper and more involved by the day.

Now, all she had to do was fetch Adora without arousing suspicion from the rest of the ton.

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Adora was wiping sweat from her brow when Catra found her. She’d spent the entire afternoon training in the courtyard, summoning and dismissing She-Ra until her hands trembled.

“Catra?” Adora blinked at her, confused.

“Drop the sword, Princess,” Catra said, marching forward and tugging it out of her hands before she could protest. “You’re done for today.”

Adora frowned. “But—”

“No buts.” Catra’s tone was sharp, but her hand lingered just a little longer on Adora’s wrist. “Come with me.”

Adora let herself be tugged along, confused and stumbling as Catra led her down the side corridors until they reached Glimmer and Bow, waiting by a shimmering ring of magic.

“Surprise,” Glimmer sing-songed, lifting her hands.

“What’s happening?” Adora asked, wide-eyed.

“You’re taking a break,” Catra muttered. “And if you argue, I’ll leave you there by yourself.”

Bow chuckled. “She’s serious.”

Adora opened her mouth to protest again, but Glimmer clapped her hands and the world spun.

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They landed with a faint crackle of magic on warm stone, the scent of herbs and mineral water rising around them. Mystacor’s springs stretched out before them, steaming pools surrounded by carved archways and glowing crystals. The air shimmered with faint magic, making everything seem soft-edged, dreamlike.

Adora staggered, blinking in awe. “Catra… what is this?”

“It’s a hot spring, genius.” Catra shoved her hands into her pockets, trying not to squirm under the look Adora was giving her. “You’ve been working yourself to death. You need to relax. So. We’re going to sit in some very warm water until you stop looking like you’re about to fall over.”

Adora’s throat bobbed. She looked down at the steaming pools, then back at Catra. Her eyes shone, and when she finally spoke, her voice wobbled. “You… did this for me?”

Catra felt her ears go flat, tail twitching nervously. “Don’t make it weird. Just—yeah. You needed it. Someone had to.”

For a long moment, Adora didn’t move. Then she crossed the space between them in two strides and wrapped her arms around Catra, burying her face into her shoulder and sighing.

Catra stiffened, then melted, her claws flexing uselessly against Adora's back.

"Thank you," Adora whispered, voice thick. "I don't think anyone's ever thought about me like this before. Not… not really."

Catra swallowed hard, ears burning. She wanted to say *I always think about you*, but the words tangled in her throat. Instead she grunted, "Don't get sappy. Let's go soak."

- - - - - -

The springs were heaven.

Adora sank into the steaming water with a groan, tilting her head back, eyes fluttering shut. Her hair fanned out like golden silk across the surface. Catra watched her for a moment, her heart thudding strangely, before slipping in beside her.

For a while, they said nothing. Just the sound of water, the distant hum of Mystacor's wards.

Adora cracked one eye open. "This… is perfect."

Catra smirked. "Told you."

Adora reached under the water, finding Catra's hand, lacing their fingers together. She didn't say anything more, but the way her thumb traced slow circles against Catra's knuckles said enough.

Catra shifted her body, wading through the small space in the water to press herself up against Adora, who smiled gently at her and pressed a wrinkled, pruned hand to her face. Catra nuzzled it, despite hating the feel of the water on her face, and pressed a kiss to it, before arching her neck up and kissing Adora softly on the mouth.

Adora giggled, kissing her back and twining their bodies together, her hands on Catra's waist and Catra's arms around her shoulders. They fit together so perfectly and languidly, and Catra wondered if

she was really allowed to have this, allowed to have this for the unforeseeable future.

Adora broke away first, grinning and panting slightly, half from the heat of the springs and half from the weight of Catra's tongue licking into her mouth. "Is this your method of getting me to relax, kitty?"

"Kitty?" Catra scrunched up her face adorably. "That's way too close to the nickname my Mother uses." she sputtered out, a little red despite her words.

"Yeah…it's a shame." Adora cooed, trailing a finger down the magicat's furred arm and tracing patterns in the fur, causing her to shiver. "Kitten would've been such a good nickname." She whispered into Catra's ear, kissing the base of it and scratching up, causing the purr to kickstart and a gasp from the smaller woman, who arched into her touch.

"You still like it, don't you?" She grinned, trailing another hot kiss from her hair, to her cheek and then the base of her jaw.

"S-shut up." Catra retorted weakly, gripping both of Adora's arms and caging her in against her.

"Shutting up." Adora whispered, kissing her neck and definitely aiming to leave marks.

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Bathing in the afterglow of having sex with Catra, Adora's mind went into overdrive.

She had been rethinking everything she had ever thought she wanted in her future. Maybe she had been too harsh on Lonnie and Adam to complete further studies, maybe she didn't need to continue to take control of the family— maybe they were old enough that they didn't need to be kept in check.

Maybe, when they eventually had kids, Adora wouldn't need to remain in her study to work, maybe she could split work with Mara, Adam and eventually Lonnie when she was older…

Her and Catra were now relaxing in a bed in Mystacor, the Magicat was purring and kneading at the comforter mindlessly, and Adora felt her heart swell. How could she ever stay far away from Catra in the future?

Anxiety whirled inside her for a second, did Catra want a future with her? Sure she had said yes to courting her, but maybe they were casually courting? Maybe she didn't want to marry Adora… maybe she wasn't completely sure yet.

That would be okay. They were still in their early stages, barely a couple of months— but it had been closer to nine months since Adora had first laid eyes on her, first been called *Princess* by her.

"What are you thinking so hard about?" Catra whispered, prodding Adora's forehead with a claw.

Whether you'd want to marry me, have kids with me, move in with me and get closer to my family.

"You."

Catra giggled, rolling her eyes and pressing a chaste kiss to Adora's cheek. "Way to be vague, Princess."

All of her worries dissipated with that kiss, and she beamed at Catra, goofily.

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Another month had passed by now, and Adora finally had gotten the hang of transforming her sword. Her excitement when Mara had told her it could transform into anything, was palpable.

"Anything?" She grinned, bouncing from toe to toe, practically vibrating with excitement.

“Anything…” Mara laughed back, watching Adora turn it into a laser, then into a knife and then into a shield.

So now, she was telling Catra the same thing, except instead of her excited, childish tone, she took on a sultry tone that left Catra looking a little confused.

“O…kay? What are you so excited to show me?”

Well…that part made Adora a little nervous, she wasn’t sure how she would explain turning the sword into something that could… be used for those purposes. Male strap appendages weren’t very well known yet, but Glimmer had shown her them in a store they passed by one time, shortly after she had caught Catra in her bed, and explained (in agonising detail) what extents could be used.

Now, Adora knew way too much about Glimmer and Bow’s sex life. But it was eye-opening in a way.

Instead of explaining fully, she figured she would just turn the sword into it and hope Catra got the message, and if not, she would awkwardly explain.

What she didn’t expect, was Catra waving excitedly in front of it, like a cat about to pounce on its prey.

“And you can put it on?!” Catra gasped out, twanging the gold appendage a little and grinning as it bounced back in place.

“Yeah…It might hurt though so we’ll have to go slo-“

Catra rolled her eyes and raised an eyebrow, placing the harness onto the floor and motioning Adora to step in.

“There are some women in Halfmoon that already have these… appendages.” Catra dryly explained to Adora, whose brows had risen to her forehead.

“They have existed for that long?!” Adora cried out, pouting a little as she wondered how much she had missed.

"No as in-" Catra sighed, bringing a hand to her forehead and rubbing it slowly. "As in- non biological women that grow these, and decide to change sex."

Adora let out an 'ohhh…' as it dawned on her what Catra had been saying. Sure, she had known about this, but she didn't really know the relevance. At her still, apparent confusion, Catra spelt it out for her.

"And I have been with them. So it won't hurt me." Realisation dawned on her face and Catra chuckled. "But you might have to still go slow, it's been a while."

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Adora hoisted the harness above her waist and grinned as she felt the heaviness of the (sword? appendage? cock?) weigh down at her hips.

Catra bit her lip, grabbing Adora's…cock and tentatively stroking it.

Fuck-

Adora bucked her hips as the strange sensation buzzed into her, apparently, the sword actually welded into her system somehow, and it felt as though it was entirely attached to her, as though she actually *had* a cock.

"You can feel it?" Catra gasped out amazed. She was kneeling now, staring at the appendage about to go inside of her, the slight glow of the cock illuminating her face prettily.

Adora touched her face, grabbing her chin and guiding it down towards the cock slowly. "Y-yeah." She whispered out, whether that was an answer to Catra's question or approval of what was about to happen, she wasn't sure.

Catra opened her mouth and hung her tongue out a little, staring up at Adora with her heterochromic eyes and tentatively licking at

it. The blonde's whole body shook with pleasure as the rough tongue swirled over the tip, before trailing down the base of her cock, supporting it with her hand.

"Catra…" She whimpered, softly urging the Magicat's head forward to sink down on her cock.

"Ha—ah" Adora tentatively thrusted her hips forward at the feeling of Catra taking her to the back of her throat. The ridges, the roughness of her tongue, the warmth was too much, she was thrusting softly into her mouth, the same way she would when she'd sit on Catra's face.

She held Catra's head in place, holding her mane back and thrusting into her like she was a personal toy. The Magicat whimpered as she bobbed, gagging and moaning on her length whilst Adora grunted from exertion and this new feeling.

Catra swiped a finger underneath the harness, fingering her softly all the while sucking her off. Adora felt herself cry out, grabbing the back of Catra's head and thrusting in roughly now, chasing her release and revelling in Catra's muffled moans.

Fuck, she felt so good.

Spit trailed from the corners of her lips. Her eyes were teary as she watched Adora, looking completely helpless underneath her cock. Adora hadn't felt like she'd known power until this, chasing her pleasure whilst Catra sat there n took it, moaning just as much as she was, deriving pleasure from her own.

"Kit-ten— Fuck-"

Catra sucked harder at the nickname, her cheeks pink with exertion as Adora grabbed her head and rut herself shamelessly into her throat, her hips were stuttering, sloppy thrusts as she finally hit her peak.

"Holy sh-it Catra!" Adora gasped out, her clit felt as though it was being suctioned, the sensation overstimulating as she felt rope

after rope of thick release pool down Catra's throat, causing her to cough a little and it to spill down the sides of her cock. She was still cumming somehow, thrusting still, the semen feeling as though it was milking itself directly out of her clit, vibrating her body and causing her to glow softly.

Catra released her cock, kissing it still on the underside as it continued to flow. The release peetered and Adora slumped over, bringing Catra along with her as they both twitched.

"Fuck…" She whispered as Catra looked at her with something akin to amazement and utter feralness.

"I didn't know it would-" Catra bit her lip, trailing her finger down the side of the limp appendage, collecting the cum and feeling it between her fingers. "It feels real."

It probably was real, perhaps this is what they meant when they said magic could make two of the same sex have children. Shit- she'd have to be careful once she was inside Catra.

Adora brought a hand to Catra's cheek, brushing her thumb against the grain of her fur softly and bringing her forward to press a kiss to her lips. It was supposed to be sweet and chaste, but quickly turned dirty as she tasted herself on Catra. The release tasted just like her own usually, thicker and slightly saltier though. She felt herself harden again as Catra slipped her tongue in, pouring all of her frustration into the kiss.

"Ready so soon?" Catra purred, straddling Adora. She was completely naked now, her perky breasts and lithe frame elegantly perched around her legs. It was strange to think of her naked body as elegant, but there wasn't any other way to describe the way she flexibly spread her legs, nor the waving of her tail or the way her eyes shone mischievously.

"You're beautiful." Adora said back, basking in the flush that it brought to Catra's cheeks.

“You are too.” Catra rolled her eyes. Words were clearly still a little hard for her, truly expressing her feelings and being vulnerable. But Adora liked to think she knew her well enough to read her now, the soft blush on her cheeks, the way she would avert her gaze when she replied with a compliment. She wasn’t saying it to be nice, she truly felt Adora was beautiful.

Adora let a soft smile enter her face as she brought a hand to Catra’s pussy, causing a whine to slip from the woman’s throat.

“Do you think- Should I-“

“I’m wet enough to take it now, Adora.”

She wasn’t lying either, when Adora pulled her fingers back, a trail of slick dropped down her wrist and she licked her arm greedily, staring at Catra’s dilated eyes as she did so.

Catra growled out, positioning herself above the strap and Adora’s hands flew to her hips before she sank down, gasping and hissing as she took inch by inch.

“Fuck- you’re so big, Adora.” She whispered out as she bottomed onto the strap, her wetness causing her cock to harden fully and push deeper inside her.

It felt amazing. Adora felt jealous of men. Was this truly how they felt all the time? The closeness? This warmth?

“Catra..” She breathed as her cock was swallowed. The ridges on her inside bumping her cock and making it borderline impossible for her to sit and wait for Catra to get used to it.

“You can move…” Catra whispered out, lifting herself up and experimentally dropping back down onto the cock.

“Fuck!” Adora gripped her hips and began a steady pace, forcing herself to focus on what would make Catra feel good and not the relentless rut she truly wished.

Catra was moaning, riding her cock with an expertise Adora didn't want to wonder came from.

She was cursing, grinding her hips against the base of the cock, rubbing circles around her clit as she pushed herself up and down. The action looked exerting, and Adora felt almost useless as she sat there and watched Catra take her like a toy.

It felt good, to feel that though, somehow. But she also wanted to let Catra lay down and feel good.

"Can I- Can I flip you over?" Adora asked, grabbing her hips again and stopping her. When she got Catra's tearful nod, she pulled out slowly and flipped their positions, so that Catra was laying on the bed. She positioned herself at Catra's entrance and slid in without resistance, so that she was flush against Catra's pussy and could only see their hips meeting.

Catra mewled as she bottomed out, opening her arms to gesture to Adora to lay herself closer to the woman. Adora obeyed, thrusting against her rhythmically and laying closer.

"F-fuck" Catra cried, scratching her claws down Adora's back. Adora hissed once more but took that as a sign to go harder, rougher. She was slapping into Catra now, causing her bed to shake and quiver beneath them.

"Good girl," she whispered breathlessly, pulling out then slamming back in again, "you take it so well." Catra had tears streaming down her cheeks now as she trilled and let out a litany of moans.

"Rougher- p-please—" She choked out.

Adora loved hearing her beg, hearing her say *please*— it was such a stark contrast to the snark and crudeness she displayed to most people and was just another facet to Catra she loved to learn.

So she complied, pulling herself fully out and then thrusting into her fully, deeply and making her cry out. Catra bit into her

shoulder as Adora thrusted deeper into her, bucking with wild ambition as she sought her own release and circled Catra's clit.

"Cat-I'm close…" She whispered. Catra crossed her legs around her unbelievably tighter and nodded, indicating she too, was close.

Sparks of pleasure zapped into Adora, as she breathed heavier, "-Let go, I should pull out before I—"

"No- mmmh- you don't need to" She cried out, somehow clutching her closer.

Adora furrowed her brows in confusion, pumping deeper and crying out softly "Shit- Are you sure?" Her tone took on an urgent one, as she was seconds away, the sparks already flying behind her eyelids and her cock twitching inside Catra.

"Yes- I— it'll be fine, Adora." Catra gasped out, scratching down Adora's back as she trilled.

"Shit- Fuck-" Adora gasped as she slammed balls deep into Catra "I'm gonna- Catra!" She fell onto Catra and kept moving her hips, Catra bit on her shoulder and suddenly they were both cumming.

"Adora- Fuck!"

Adora hoarsely screamed, her release jetting hot into Catra as Catra cried and tightened around her. Her pussy was swallowing Adora's cock, milking her for every jet of cum she produced. She tightened her legs around Adora's midsection, still bucking and twitching as she cried out softly.

Holy shit.

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They were laying in each other's warmth now, not many words were exchanged besides Adora's soft praises and Catra's trilling. Adora had taken time to clean them both up, before laying down on the bed next to her and petting her ears, causing a deep rumble of a purr to encapsulate them as she pet her girlfriend.

Catra laid there in bliss. Her hips twitched every so often but she was fully satisfied. She hadn't orgasmed like that in…probably forever. Maybe She-Ra could be of use to her after all.

"So are you on new medication or something? I've heard that it has recently been invented but I wasn't sure if anyone besides princesses and high lords had access to it yet." Adora asked eventually, her hand still mussing up Catra's mane.

"What do you mean?" Catra mumbled into Adora's neck, rubbing herself there and scent marking as she purred.

Adora giggled. "Well, the sword is magic so…if you let me…release inside of you that would mean...So I just assumed maybe you were on the medication."

Catra froze, her heart was hammering a mile a minute and she couldn't help how rigid her body had become.

'This is it, This is it, This is it', Her mind droned on.

Slowly, she peeled herself away from Adora, putting some distance in between them and willing herself to find the words, though her mouth just kept opening and closing like a fish. How many times had she rehearsed this? Why had it all gone out of the window now?

"Catra?" Adora's blue eyes swam with worry as she grabbed Catra's hands. She still looked confused though, and Catra wished for once, she could just read her mind.

"Adora I…" Bile rose to her throat as her hands shook. It wasn't that she hadn't really made peace with it by now, it was that she

was terrified this would change things, that she wouldn't be enough for Adora just like she had been worrying.

"You can tell me anything, Catra." Adora whispered, her gaze boring into her own.

Adora…she wouldn't care right? Catra's own mother had told her that Adora cared for her, something this simple wouldn't change things right?

"I- I cannot carry a child, Adora." Catra rushed out, finally. She was shaking still, sure that her breathing was laboured and that she looked like a fool in front of this woman. Yet she couldn't will herself to look up at Adora's expression.

There was silence, for maybe five minutes. It wasn't a comfortable one either. And when it was finally broken, all was delivered was a simple 'Oh.'

Catra felt her heart breaking. Of course her mother was *wrong*, of course her instincts were right. She willed her tears to stay in her eyes as she silently got up and began to get dressed, waiting, begging for Adora to ask her to stay.

"Are you leaving?" Adora whispered to her, the question having an obvious answer.

Catra finally looked up to see Adora. Adora who looked shocked and confused but not…put off.

Catra forced herself to ask, "Do you still want to…" *Do you still want to be with me? Do you still want a future, to care for me?*

Adora was still quiet. Catra's shoulders slumped. If Adora was sure, she'd just say *yes*.

"You can stay…I just need to…think some things over." Adora said, her tone was somewhat begging, yet disconnected. Like she was asking Catra to stay yet trying to solve a math equation.

Catra just nodded. Adora needed time to think if she really wanted this with Catra.

Whatever. She didn't need her anyway. She had been doing just fine on her own.

She buttoned up the rest of her dress and opened the door. Part of her screamed to just look at Adora, see whether the woman was watching her or just staring into space, but she feared that she already knew the answer to that. Adora wasn't concerned about Catra right now, just about whether she would fit into her picture perfect future.

So she sighed, and opened the door and left.

The tears came the minute the door closed. Her shoulders were shaking and she made an immediate beeline for the front door, she felt like her heart was breaking, shame and guilt clawing at her throat. Shame for not being enough, guilt for not telling her sooner. Then there was the anger, aimed at herself for finally letting her guard down, for allowing things to even get to this point.

Her feelings were a weakness, that much rang true. She wouldn't be such a mess if she had just swallowed down her feelings in the first place, not let Adora in, let her ruin her relationship with her sister and have her *hope*.

"Catra?!" Catra looked up finally, just as she was about to sneak out. Mara stood there, looking increasingly worried and as though she was about to grab at her, but Catra just bit her lip and looked down, the shame too much. She shook her head softly and then bounded out the front door, getting on all fours and running back to Light Spinner's estate.

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It had been a few days since Catra had told her.
Her *status*.

Adora still remembered the moment with crystalline clarity: Catra's voice breaking, her claws digging into her palms as she confessed what she thought would end everything before it could truly begin. And Adora had been shocked, yes, confused, a little disappointed even, but not for long. Because once the sting had faded, the truth had settled into her chest like iron: so what if Catra couldn't bear children? That didn't change who she was, didn't change what Adora felt for her. They would figure it out. Together.

Adora had been journaling ever since, messy ink-stained pages where she tried to puzzle out her own heart. She found herself circling the same thoughts: she hadn't planned on carrying children herself, not with the estate to manage, not with her body forged into a weapon and her time endlessly consumed by duties. But now… now she caught herself wondering. What if she could? What if it meant building a future with Catra, a home that was truly theirs?

And if not…then adoption. She had seen too many orphans running the streets of Plumeria during the rebuilding, children with wide hungry eyes who deserved warmth and safety. The idea of scooping one of them into her arms, raising them together with Catra—Gods, it made something ache sweetly inside her chest.

The only thing she was certain of, beyond every journal scrawl, every half-formed plan, was that her future had Catra in it. *Always*.

Adora sighed and pressed her palm flat against her stomach, firm and muscled, still unfamiliar with the idea of it one day swelling with life. She wasn't ready to bring it up yet—not until she was sure she could speak without stammering, without fear knotting her throat. But tonight, she didn't want to think of the future in hypotheticals. She just wanted to *see* Catra. To hold her, kiss her until the storm passed, keep her distracted from the thunder that always made her ears flatten and her tail lash in agitation.

The rain battered against the windows, sheets of water slicing the darkness. She tugged on her clothes, her heart already leaning toward Catra's estate—

"Adora?!"

The familiar tinkle of bells jolted through her chamber, and Adora cursed, clutching at her half-fastened robe to cover herself.

"Glimmer! I told you to *knock*—" she snapped, cheeks flaming.

"This is no time for a lecture!" Glimmer's voice was high and tight, a kind of panic Adora wasn't used to hearing from her. Behind her stood a sodden Melog, their strange, liquid form pulsing with erratic swirls of blue and red.

Adora froze. "…Melog?"

"They just burst into my chambers," Glimmer said breathlessly. "They're frantic, Adora. They keep trying to show me something, but I can't understand. They dragged me here because they want *you*. It's… I think it's about Catra."

Melog let out a keening mewl, the sound thin and sharp, and their body convulsed with another flash of crimson.

Adora's stomach dropped.

"She's just—she hates storms," Adora muttered desperately, even as her pulse thundered in her ears. "I was going to see her, maybe she just…"

"No," Glimmer cut in, voice shaking. "This isn't that. Adora, they won't stop until I teleport us. It's urgent."

Adora's mouth had gone dry, but her body was already moving, snatching her sword from where it leaned against the wall. Her hands trembled as she strapped it to her back, the fear she'd been ignoring these past few days now rising like bile in her throat.

Catra. Something was wrong with Catra.

She turned to Glimmer, jaw set, eyes blazing despite the tears prickling at the corners. “Take me to her. *Now.*”

Chapter End Notes

dramatic ahh characters....anyway sorry for it taking a lil longer than usual for this update- it was my birthday! and then i kinda got some writers block, predictions for next chapter? The reason I introduced the she-ra aspect will come into play next chapter at least so thats one spoiler, let me know your thoughts!

Leave a kudos or comment if you're enjoying this!

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Chapter 15: Please be okay.

Chapter Notes

> Surprise! An update two days after the last ehehe-- the expense....a chapter that is slightly shorter - well it's still 4k but usually my chapters even around 5-7k. And another expense....this chapter oops.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It had been three days.

Three days since the silence settled heavy between her and Adora. No pebbles tapping her window at midnight, no muffled laughter as they slipped out the garden gate, no sudden bursts of glitter and light when Glimmer would appear to whisk them away. No horse rides, no stolen moments, no secret smiles.

Three days since Adora had looked at her with those impossibly blue eyes and said nothing at all. And Catra understood what silence meant.

Adora didn't want her. Not like this. *Maybe not ever.*

The pain came in waves — sharp, burning flashes when she let herself remember the way Adora's hand felt in hers, then long, dull throbs that dragged her down into herself. Maybe it wouldn't have cut so deeply months ago, when she still had Perfuma to lean on. But now? Now it was unbearable. Without Adora to distract her, the loneliness clawed its way in, relentless and merciless.

Perfuma still wouldn't look at her. Not hostile, not openly cruel or any snide comments, that would have been easier to fight against. Instead it was cold avoidance, the kind that left Catra chasing shadows, watching as Perfuma slipped away when she thought no one noticed. Slipped away to meet Scorpia.

Catra's chest burned with every thought of it. Perfuma, all smiles, with someone new. Perfuma laughing with someone else. Perfuma was so clearly interested in Scorpia even while she'd been courting Adora…so what had Catra ruined, really? What was the unforgivable crime? Why couldn't her sister just forgive her? Why couldn't they go back to normal?

The questions circled endlessly, sharp little teeth gnawing at her mind. No answers ever came.

So Catra lay there in her bed, staring at the ceiling until the shadows seemed to blur and pulse. She avoided Perfuma, avoided Light Spinner's cruel names, and avoided her mother most of all. Cyra had decided to be a mother again, hovering close, too close, asking questions Catra couldn't bear to answer. Questions that would unravel her if she let them.

And so she curled tighter into herself, wishing she could fold small enough to disappear.

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Catra sat on the edge of the low wall, the chill from the evening grass seeping through her skirts and into her bones. Rain had begun as a far-off promise, a smear on the horizon, and now it breathed closer, a steady hush that seemed to match the hollow in her chest. She watched the clouds bruise the sky and felt something in her clench until it hurt.

She tasted the words Adora had left her with, 'I just… I need to think some things over' It had been so tender and so impossibly distant, a plea wrapped in logic. Catra had nodded and left like a wounded animal, telling herself not to look back. But the ache lived beneath every step she took. It was a slow, insistent thing that reminded her of everything she had given up, the quiet sacrifices, the nights she'd swallowed yearning whole, the promises she'd never spoken aloud.

If she was honest, the truth she kept like a shard behind her ribs, this was her doing. She'd let herself want, then let it sit and fester until it became a secret she could no longer carry. She could picture how the scene at Adora's would have played out if she had said something sooner: a messy whisper in a kitchen, an admission, a blush, a shove, a laugh, perhaps chaos, perhaps solace. Instead, silence had allowed the altar to happen. Instead, Perfuma's eyes had turned on her; instead, Adora had looked at her the way…she always had.

She took the ache and folded it into plans. If not this life — then another. Maybe her modiste could grow. Maybe the little shop in Halfmoon could become something that mattered beyond her own small hands. Maybe she would make herself useful in ways that did not demand a cradle. Maybe one day she would be an aunt who spoiled a child and then sent them back home tired and happy. Maybe she would visit Melendy's grave more than she already did. Maybe she would learn to stand without leaning on anyone's forgiveness.

The future that came into focus was not all doom: it was work and stubbornness and small comforts. She could hunker down and fold herself into routine. She could be steady. She could be fine. She said the words in her head 'I will be fine' until they either convinced her or numbed her into believing them.

She hated that she believed it without wanting to. She hated that the thought of a life without Adora didn't make her scream. She hated, most of all, how easy it was to imagine being small and practical and safe, the very life she had promised herself she would never settle for. If she'd told the truth from the start, things might not have come this far. She held to that blame like a warm stone.

A low rumble moved through the sky. The first grumble of thunder made the hairs along her arms stand up. Her ears flattened against her head despite herself. reflex, memory, fear. Storms had always made her small and raw; they had a way of pulling at the seams she had sewn so carefully over the years. She should go

back in. She should hide. But staying inside felt like watching a fire from behind glass; she needed to move, to do something that wasn't *thinking*.

She swung up onto a horse from the stables, an old mare with calm eyes, and urged it forward to run down the woods. The rain was a fine net now, pricking her face and darkening her hair. The world smelled like wet earth and crushed leaves, clean and terrible. She rode faster, letting the motion beat some of the hot, jagged feelings out of her. She could feel the thrum of her heart matching the horse's hooves, and for a few moments she let herself be only speed and wind.

This exhilaration, this was the feeling she chased. She didn't need Adora to feel this, just herself and a horse.

Thoughts came and went in that trance: a future where the shop took off; the image of Perfuma laughing while chasing a child; the small, private idea of being that child's aunt. She pictured Adora's hands, steadier than anyone's, holding her new baby, the way Adora's smile softened when she wasn't performing for the ton. She wanted that for Adora. She wanted comfort for her, even if the comfort would be with someone else. Even if, eventually, she would have children with someone that wasn't her.

The clouds rolled faster now, a swelling, midnight ocean. She told herself a little rain never hurt anyone; it had chased away tougher days than this. But the sky's anger rose to a deep, rolling growl, and the horse's ears pricked. The animal shifted beneath her, uneasy. Catra felt that old, panicked animal knowledge flick through her like static. She shouldn't have come out. The sensible, small voice in her head said to turn back. She wanted to, but pride and some stubbornness of grief kept her moving.

Then the thunder cracked, close and furious. The mare shied, legs skidding on the slick track. Catra jerked the reins hard, gasping a little, but the beast panicked, rearing, hooves clipping a slick stone. She heard herself scream, faraway, useless, as the world went sideways.

For an instant everything slowed. The rain became a million pinpricks. The saddle was a sudden catapult under her. She felt herself lift and then be flung; the world turned as if someone had spun it too fast and let go. Her hip hit the saddle horn with a bruise that bloomed white-hot across her belly. Then the ground rushed up.

The edge of the lane had a path of rock, slate and undeniably cruel. Her skull met it with a sick, final thud that echoed down through her teeth and spine. Pain peeled across her vision like tearing vellum. For a second, if there was such a thing in the dark, images kindled and flared: Melendy's hands, warm and ink-stained; small Perfuma, sticky with jam and laughing; Adora's mouth saying *you can stay* a moment too late.

She lay very still, the rain hammering above her like a verdict. Blood might have been at her temple; the world seamed to be spooling away on threads of grey. For a few fragile seconds she realised that this was the end. A small, stunned smile touched her lips because it felt like an answer. Maybe she would see her Mama again. Maybe she could say the things she couldn't make herself say here.

Regret and relief braided into one hot, crystal thread. I'm *sorry*, she thought, not to herself now but into the dusk, to everyone she had hurt and everyone she had failed. *I'm sorry I let this get so far. I'm sorry I couldn't be braver sooner*. Then, softer, the thing she had never let herself admit, she felt herself wish she could have told Adora she loved her.

Darkness folded around her like a curtain, the thunder becoming a muted bass tone and she felt a harsh sob break out of her chest. As the world loosened its grip on her, she felt a childlike, starling thrill of walking towards her Mama, towards a voice she loved and missed so dearly, that she had not heard in far too long.

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“Catra?!” Adora’s voice ripped through the storm, ragged and raw. Her boots sank into the mud with every frantic step, the rain stinging her face as though the skies themselves had turned against her. Branches clawed at her sleeves, her hair clung wet to her cheeks, and still she pushed forward, her chest burning with panic.

Melog darted ahead, their form flickering wildly in shades of turquoise and deep blue, keening in a way that made Adora’s stomach twist. They kept sniffing at the ground, pawing at the mud, whining as though the storm itself had swallowed Catra whole.

Behind her, Glimmer appeared in flashes of light, teleporting behind trees, bushes, rocks, her voice growing more desperate with each call. “Catra! Catra, please!”

Why was she even out here? Why, when the thunder shook the earth and the lightning split the sky? Catra hated storms. She *knew* she hated them. Adora’s thoughts tangled, frantic, her pulse deafening in her ears.

Then, a shrill whinny cut through the night. Adora froze, her head snapping toward the sound. She bolted, her lungs straining, mud splashing up her legs as she ran toward it.

An old mare stood trembling near the treeline, reins dangling loose, its eyes rolling white with fear. Adora recognized her instantly, *Light Spinner’s horse*.

Her stomach dropped*.*

She sprinted past the animal, following the churn of hoofprints in the mud until she saw her.

Catra.

Slumped against a jagged rock, her body crumpled unnaturally, a dark pool of blood spreading beneath her.

"No no no no no—" The scream tore out of Adora's throat before she even realized she'd made it. She fell to her knees, the mud splattering up her skirts, and scrambled forward, hauling Catra into her arms. Catra looked uncharacteristically small, she could have been mistaken for a child with the way she was curled into herself, her tail covering half her body.

Her skin was cold. Too cold. Her lips tinged blue and her body rigid.

"Catra—*Cat*, please…wake up, come on—" Adora's voice shook as she pressed trembling fingers to her throat, to her wrist, to her chest, searching, pleading for a heartbeat. *Anything*. *Anything, please.*

There was nothing.

Her world caved in. She let out another raw scream and clutched her to her chest*. Please, no. Haven't I already lost enough? Not her too, please.*

"Adora—" Glimmer's voice broke behind her, choked with sobs, but it sounded distant, muffled, like she was underwater.

Melog pressed frantically at Catra's body, nudging her shoulder, keening in low, mournful tones, their colors flickering red with panic.

But Adora couldn't move. Couldn't breathe. She just stared at Catra's face, willing her chest to rise, willing her to laugh and shove her away and call her an idiot. Tell her it was a sick prank and that she was so gullible. Call her an asshole for not talking to her in a couple of days, for not making her stay.

But she stayed still.

A memory surged, unbidden, searing through the fog—

Her father, Randor, sprawled on the ground, his face swelling, his chest unmoving. Adora's smaller hands pressing at him, shaking

him, screaming for him to breathe. The same silence. The same unbearable stillness.

And now Catra.

Her chest heaved, her throat tearing as she clutched Catra tighter to her, rocking her as though sheer force could drag her back. "Don't do this to me," she begged, her voice cracking. "Don't you *dare* leave me too."

But Catra's body lay limp, and the storm raged on.

"Catra, please—please, I… I *love* you," Adora whispered, her voice breaking against the roar of the storm. *I love you, isn't that enough? Come back, please.* The words tumbled out raw, stripped bare, the first time she had said them aloud. They burned on her tongue, but it was nothing compared to the ice crushing her chest.

Behind her, Glimmer gasped, but Adora couldn't look back. She only saw Catra—pale, limp, blood soaking through the fabric of her gown.

Her brow furrowed hard, her body trembling as she bent over her. *No.* The word screamed in her mind. *No, this isn't it. This isn't how it ends. Not here, not like this.*

She pressed her forehead to Catra's damp hair, refusing the silence, refusing the stillness. And then, something in her broke open.

A warmth surged in her chest, wild and radiant, spreading to her fingertips until she realized…she was glowing. Light pulsed faintly from her skin, crackling with energy, humming as though answering her grief. She didn't have the sword. It didn't matter. The power was still there—*she* was still She-Ra.

Adora jerked back in shock, staring at her trembling hands as they shone like they carried the sun. Then she pressed them to Catra's

chest, desperate. “Please, please, please—come back to me,” she begged.

The glow beneath her palms deepened. Adora gasped as a dull ache shuddered through her body, like the magic was siphoning her own strength, her own breath. But then—she felt it. *She actually felt it!* Catra’s body lifted ever so slightly under her touch, her chest rising against Adora’s palm, a faint light blooming under her skin.

And then-

Catra gasped. A broken, rasping sound that racked her entire body, but it was *life*.

Adora choked on a sob, her tears spilling hot and unrelenting as her arms folded around Catra, tightly. “Oh thank gods—” her voice cracked, relief shredding through her, making her tremble violently.

Catra still lay weak, her limbs heavy and unmoving, but there was breath in her, shallow and ragged.

Melog keened, their form twisting, their colors turning a furious, glowing red. They pressed themselves against Catra, their body morphing, generating heat to chase away the cold that still clung to her skin.

Adora kept her glowing hands pressed over Catra’s chest, weeping openly now, unable to stop whispering her name like a prayer.

“Holy shit.” Glimmer whispered, as she cradled the four of them in her arms. Adora felt the tell-tale sign of her about to teleport, and she clutched to Catra impossibly tighter.

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“She-Ra’s healing is remarkable,” the physician said carefully, straightening as she pulled her stethoscope from Catra’s chest. Her voice carried the tone of someone treading gently, but her

words cut sharp all the same. "But she is not at full magical capacity. She restored perhaps thirty percent of the damage."

Perfuma's breath hitched. *Thirty percent*. Not enough. Her gaze locked on her sister's still face, framed by damp bangs the doctor brushed aside with quiet tenderness. Catra looked so small, so fragile. Nothing like the sharp, untamable woman Perfuma had grown up beside.

"It is enough to keep her alive," the doctor continued softly, "but the head trauma remains severe, and several bones are fractured. She will not wake for some time."

Perfuma felt her knees weaken. Her hands curled into tight fists at her sides as her voice trembled out: "How long is… *a while*?"

The doctor bowed her head, unable to meet Perfuma's eyes. "I cannot say with certainty."

Perfuma's throat closed, tears pricking as her body went cold. That uncertainty was worse than any definitive answer.

"What good are you, then?!" Adora's voice cracked the air like a whip. She surged forward, her whole body thrumming with frantic energy, glaring at the doctor as if sheer willpower might force her to say something different.

"Adora—" Bow began, but she cut him off, snapping her gaze to Glimmer, blue eyes wild and furious.

"Who even is this?! Get me the best doctor in Brightmoon!"

Bow flinched and reached for her hand, his own voice low and soothing. "Adora… She *is* the best doctor in Brightmoon." He gave her fingers a squeeze, but she yanked away, restless, inconsolable.

"Then find me the best doctor in all of Etheria!" Adora barked, her voice breaking as she shoved herself into motion, pacing the

length of the room like a caged animal, her hands fisting in her hair.

'She really does love her.' Perfuma thought. It made her feel a little better, that she had Adora all whilst Perfuma had been ignoring her. At least she wasn't…lonely.

Perfuma swallowed hard, her body trembling as she watched Glimmer and Bow exchange a look: fearful, pitying, helpless. It only made the dread twist tighter inside her.

She turned back to the doctor, her lips quivering as she whispered the only question that mattered: "Will she… will she be okay?"

The doctor, clearly insulted by Adora's accusations but too professional to retort, drew in a long breath. Her eyes softened as they lingered on Catra's unconscious form.

"Yes," she said finally, her voice steady. "Not today. Not tomorrow. But eventually—*yes*. She will heal."

Perfuma exhaled shakily, pressing her fist against her lips to keep a sob from spilling out.

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"How are you holding up?" Glimmer asked softly, once Adora had finally ridden back to her estate. Her fingers were laced with Bow's, her steps careful as she edged closer to where Perfuma sat, rigid and pale.

Perfuma's eyes didn't leave the wall in front of her. "About as well as you'd expect," she said flatly. The words sounded hollow even to her own ears. Perhaps rude, especially to a princess, but she didn't have the strength to dress her grief up in pleasantries.

"That's fair," Bow murmured, his smile a weak, awkward twitch. His voice cracked on the last word, and he gave Glimmer's hand a gentle tug, trying to guide her away toward the door.

But Glimmer didn't move. Her feet stayed rooted, her gaze sharp, almost stubborn. "Have you forgiven Catra yet?"

Perfuma blinked, stunned. "What?!" she sputtered, heat rushing to her cheeks as anger rose in her chest.

"You've been mad at her for months," Glimmer pressed, unwavering. "And sure, at first—it was warranted. I'm not saying it wasn't. But… isn't it about time you let it go? She *died*, Perfuma. If not now, when?"

"Glimmer…" Bow warned gently, his tone strained, his eyes darting nervously between the two of them like he was bracing for an explosion.

Perfuma's nails dug into her palms, her fists curling tight at her sides. "So I should just *choose* to forgive her?" Her voice rose, brittle and cracking. "Just forget everything she did? Pretend there wasn't a betrayal? Because it's been a couple of months, I should… what—erase it?!"

"Well yeah!" Glimmer yelled out, her hands flailing about in the air. "It's not like they actually did anything-"

"It was still emotional!" Perfuma defended.

"Well you've had enough time now- and you're literally seeing Scorpia!" Glimmer was red in the face now, her tone shrill and exasperated.

Perfuma felt her face go hot. How did they even know about that?! Were they the only ones that knew? Did that truly mean she should just forgive and forget?

"I think…" Perfuma gritted out, "You should not speak on things you do not know."

Bow squeaked, grabbing Glimmer by her shoulders and muttering out apologies, "you are totally right Perfuma! We're so very sorry,

we will take our leave now!" He shakily gave a thumbs up and pushed Glimmer out of the door, despite her squeaky protests.

Sighing, she sat down on the sofa, putting her head in her hands. Was she really in the wrong? Was it out of order to still be upset? *No*. Her feelings were valid just– would they really not reconcile with each other? It had been three months and she could count the times they had actually spoken to one another on one hand, despite them living together. And now….her sister was…

"You okay there, sweetheart?" Perfuma looked up tearily, to her Mother standing in the doorway, her hands clasped but tremoring, clearly shaken up by what was occurring.

"Yeah…I'm okay." Perfuma stood up, grabbing her Mother by her shaking shoulders and leading her to lie down on the couch. Cyra was still shaking, her forehead wrinkling with worry.

"Will she be okay, Fuma?" Cyra asked her, like she was a child and Perfuma was her Mother. Like how Perfuma used to ask her *sister*.

"She'll be okay." Perfuma reassured, stroking Cyra's greying hair. God, how had time passed by so fast? Had her mother always been this frail? How had she not noticed?

She closed her eyes as the memory answered her question. Catra covering their Mother with a blanket as she refused to talk to her. Her Mother basically being rendered mute over the years and occasionally talking, just to criticize Catra– a far cry of the Mother she used to be. Catra never saying anything back, just taking Perfuma away from it all, treating her with kindness despite just previously getting chastised for Perfuma's own mistakes.

Perfuma felt her shoulders slump. Catra had messed up. But that was so…so *insignificant* when she considered the years she nurtured her, took care of her and basically became her mother. It was insignificant when she saw her sister lay there looking impossibly broken and small.

She felt herself wince at her harsh words those months ago, saying that she was adopted and not *truly* Catra's sister. Despite them not sharing any blood, she never even registered that they didn't share any DNA. Maybe briefly, when children would bully her for looking different than the other Magicats that resided there, but the thought was always swallowed up when she would tell her older sister who would beat them up despite her being seven years their senior.

Guilt overwhelmed her, and when she finally opened her eyes, she saw her Mother was sleeping soundly on the sofa. She brought a blanket up to her and tucked her in gently, before padding out the door, to enter where Catra laid in her room again.

She sat on the edge of the bed, her hand brushing through her sister's short curls. Her heart broke a little as she mourned the locks of hair that had been cut down to examine her injuries more closely, the hair a short, fluffy pixie now. She thought to herself that maybe Catra would grow to love it eventually, when she woke up. But she also knew Catra would hate it at first.

Catra murmured a low murmur, pushing her cheek further into Perfuma's hand. She felt herself gasp and tears finally made their way down her cheek as she cradled her face. This was her *sister*. She didn't truly care about anything else as long as she would be okay.

"Please be okay." She whispered, stroking Catra's forehead, which was hot with fever. "You have to be okay."

Chapter End Notes

Is adding temporary character death to the tags a spoiler?....yeah I'll have to avoid that probably. But at least I didn't give you guys a cliffhanger for long!

Also don't worry Glimmer teleported with the horse, horse is okay

Leave a kudos or comment if you're enjoying this!

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Chapter 16: That was barely anything

Chapter Notes

> Big boy chapter! Sorry for the lateness - I have a valid reason I swear...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Adora, seriously? You're sending *flowers* again without even checking on her?"

Lonnie's voice cut through the training hall, sharp as a whip. She and Adam were in the doorway, both their arms bundled awkwardly around overflowing bouquets, roses, lilies, lavender, more than any single room could hold.

Adora's jaw clenched. "She's not going to wake yet," she muttered, refusing to look at them. Her grip tightened on the hilt of her sword as the holographic soldiers lunged forward, their blades flashing. The golden glow of Entrapta's simulation surrounded her, and she threw herself into it, as though sheer force could drown out the words clawing at her chest.

It was all she'd done since the storm. Train. Fight. Bleed herself into the ground to sharpen She-Ra into something better, stronger, worthy of the name. Because when it had mattered most, when Catra had been broken and bleeding in her arms, She-Ra had only managed thirty percent. *Thirty*.

"She doesn't need flowers, Adora."

Lonnie's voice snapped again, louder this time. She strode across the hall and slammed the control panel off. The holograms flickered out, leaving Adora standing alone, panting, her skin still faintly glowing.

"What she *needs*," Lonnie said firmly, her eyes soft but unyielding, "is *you*. By her side. Talking to her. Reminding her why she should

come back."

Adam nodded, shifting the flowers awkwardly. "It's been weeks, Dor. You haven't gone in there once since that night. What if she wakes up and you're not there?"

Adora bristled, a sharp sound ripping from her throat. "You don't *understand*!"

Her voice echoed in the empty hall, raw and ragged. She dropped the sword, the clang of metal on stone ringing in the silence. Her hands trembled, her chest heaving as if the air itself was fighting her.

"You didn't find her," she choked out, her voice breaking. "You didn't see her lying there. She was cold—her lips were *blue*, there was no heartbeat! I-" Her voice cracked and she dragged both hands through her hair, gripping hard as though she could tear the memory out. "I thought she was gone. I thought I *lost her*, the way I lost…."

The words ripped free before she could swallow them back down. She staggered a step, her knees buckling, and sank onto the cold stone floor. Her shoulders shook, her breath hitching like she'd been holding it for weeks.

"I keep seeing it," she whispered hoarsely, tears finally spilling. "Every time I close my eyes, she's gone again. And when I asked Mara, when I begged her, she said she *couldn't* heal her. That because she didn't wield the sword…That I've already done more than she ever could. But it wasn't *enough*! *Thirty* percent isn't enough. *I* wasn't enough! What if Catra never—what if she never opens her eyes again?"

Her voice dissolved into a sob, raw and desperate. "What if she dies somehow and I've built up all this hope for nothing? What if it was my fault because I didn't tell her to *stay*-"

Lonnie dropped the flowers in her arms and crouched down, her expression tight with emotion as she put a hand on Adora's

trembling shoulder. Adam set his bouquets aside, kneeling too, his face soft with quiet grief.

"You're not enough? Are you kidding me?" Lonnie's voice shook, but she kept it steady. "Adora, you pulled her back from *death*. You did that. No one else could have. If she's still breathing, if she's still here—it's because of *you*."

Adora pressed her hands over her face, sobbing into them, her body rocking as though she could hold herself together that way.

Adam's voice was quiet but firm as he reached out. "She needs you. Not She-Ra. Not flowers. *You*. Go sit by her. Hold her hand. That's what will bring her back."

Adora's throat closed around a sob, and she finally nodded, brokenly, her tears dripping down onto her lap.

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The room smelt of lavender and damp herbs, a poor attempt to cover the sterility of medicines and bandages. The fire in the hearth flickered low, throwing faint shadows across the bed where Catra lay, pale and impossibly still.

Adora froze in the doorway, her boots glued to the floor. It had been weeks since she'd seen her like this, weeks since she'd dared even step foot in here. And yet—nothing could've prepared her.

The sight gutted her. Catra's head was wrapped in neat white bandages, her arm resting in a splint. Her chest rose and fell shallowly beneath the covers, a rhythm that seemed too fragile, too borrowed, like a clock running out of time.

Perfuma sat at her bedside, her fingers gently combing through Catra's tangled bangs. She didn't look up at first, her gaze soft and full of quiet ache. But then she noticed Adora, standing rigid in the doorway, her hands twisted in fists at her sides.

“So,” Perfuma said, her voice sharper than she intended. “You’re finally here, huh?”

Adora’s breath caught. She flinched, shame rolling hot through her chest. She wanted to say something, anything, but her throat locked.

Silence stretched. The only sounds were Catra’s shallow breathing and the faint crackle of firewood.

Perfuma let out a long, shaky breath. “I’m sorry.” Her voice softened, almost breaking. “That wasn’t fair. I’m just… scared. I’ve been so angry at her for so long, but sitting here, watching her like this…” Perfuma’s lips wobbled. She smoothed Catra’s bangs back again, her eyes glistening. “She loves you, Adora. She really does. And I can tell you love her too.”

Adora’s vision blurred. She nodded, stepping closer at last, until she was standing beside Perfuma, their shoulders nearly touching.

“I do,” Adora whispered, her voice cracking. She stared down at Catra, her chest aching with the truth of it. “More than I ever thought possible. I—” She broke off, swallowing hard. “I know it hasn’t been long but…I don’t know how to do this without her.”

Perfuma’s hand slipped from Catra’s hair to cover Adora’s trembling one. “You won’t have to.”

Adora looked at her, startled, and Perfuma offered a watery smile. “She’s too stubborn to let go. Trust me. She’s going to wake up, and when she does, she’ll need you right here. Not running. Not hiding. Just… you.”

Adora’s breath hitched as fresh tears welled, but this time she let them fall. Perfuma leaned her head against her shoulder for just a moment, both of them silently clinging to the fragile hope that Catra would come back to them.

Then Perfuma stood slowly, brushing at her eyes. “I’ll give you two some time.” Her voice wavered, but there was gentleness

there now, not bitterness. She slipped toward the door, pausing only once to look back at her sister. Her expression was soft, vulnerable. Then she left, shutting the door with a quiet click.

Adora was alone with Catra.

She sank into the chair Perfuma had vacated, her trembling hand reaching for Catra's. It was cold, limp, but real. Adora cradled it between both of hers, pressing her forehead down to their entwined fingers.

"Hey, Cat." Her voice cracked on the nickname, but she pushed through, whispering into the silence. "I'm here. I should've been here sooner, but I was scared. I'm so sorry. Please, please don't leave. There's so much I still need to tell you…"

Her words broke off into quiet sobs as she clung to Catra's hand, the storm outside rattling faintly against the windows.

Catra stirred faintly, a small sigh escaping her lips as her head lulled to the side. A broken, uneven purr vibrated weakly in her chest, so soft Adora *almost* thought she imagined it.

Her breath caught.

Adora froze in place, her hands tightening around Catra's limp fingers as though she could anchor her here, to this world, with sheer force of will. It wasn't her waking up, not at all. But it was something. A sound, a flicker of movement, proof that she wasn't lost.

Adora's heart lurched, pounding so fiercely she thought it might crack her ribs. "Catra?" Her voice was a whisper, trembling and desperate, as though speaking too loud might scare the moment away.

No answer. No flutter of lashes. But that purr, that precious, fragile sound that Adora *loved*, thrummed faintly against her ear when she leaned closer, a sign that somewhere, somehow, Catra was still fighting.

This was more any sign of life than her Father had shown. *Catra was still there*.

Tears blurred Adora's vision. "You're still in there." A shaky laugh broke out of her chest, half a sob, half disbelief. "Gods, you're still in there."

Her thumb brushed over the back of Catra's cold hand, tracing every scar, every ridge, memorizing it as if afraid it might vanish. The relief was dizzying, overwhelming. She wasn't dead. She wasn't gone, trapped in some silent, lifeless body. She was here. Somewhere deep inside, Catra was still clawing her way back.

Adora bent down until her forehead pressed against Catra's temple, breathing in the faint scent of herbs and rainwater clinging to her hair. "You hear me, right? You're not allowed to quit on me. Not now, not ever. I'll wait as long as it takes. months, years—whatever you need. I'm not going anywhere."

Her voice broke, tears falling hot against Catra's bandages. "I thought I lost you. I thought…I thought the last thing you'd ever hear from me was silence. I can't…" She squeezed her hand tighter, as if afraid she might slip away again. "I can't lose you, Cat. You mean too much. You're everything. Do you get that? You're everything to me."

Another faint, uneven purr rumbled from Catra's chest. Weak, yes—but alive.

Adora pulled back just enough to see her face, to take in the subtle movement of her lips parting, the faint crease of her brow. It wasn't consciousness, but it was an answer all the same. Her whole body flooded with warmth, fragile but fierce, a hope she hadn't dared allow herself until now.

"You're coming back to me." Adora smiled through her tears, brushing her knuckles tenderly against Catra's cheek. "I know you are. And when you do, I'll be right here waiting. Always. I don't care about…baring children, about your infertility. I wouldn't care

about anything like that as long as I had you. Nothing really bad could happen as long as we had each other. So…come back to me."

She stayed like that, curled beside her, clinging to the sound of that fragile purr like a lifeline, the *promise* that Catra was still fighting her way home.

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Perfuma had slipped out of Catra's room quietly, not trusting her voice to hold steady if she lingered. She pressed her back to the wall just beyond the door, trying to breathe through the weight in her chest. Her hands shook. She hated herself for it—for still feeling so tangled, so raw. For months, she had clung to her anger, because at least anger was something solid. Forgiveness felt like standing on quick sand that would swallow her up if she shifted so much as shifted.

"Perfuma?"

She startled at the voice and turned to see Scorpia standing there, awkward as ever, her massive claws twitching as though she didn't know what to do with them. She gave Perfuma a sheepish smile. "Uh…sorry, I didn't mean to sneak up on you. I was just coming to check if you…needed anything."

Perfuma blinked, realizing only then that her cheeks were wet. She swiped at her tears quickly, though it was pointless. "I'm fine." Her voice cracked, betraying her. She sighed. "Or maybe I'm not. I don't really know anymore."

Scorpia stepped closer, her heavy tread slow and cautious. "It's a lot. You don't have to have it all figured out right away."

Perfuma shook her head, her braid slipping over her shoulder. "I should have forgiven her sooner. I thought…" Her throat closed up. She forced the words out. "I thought if I held on to my anger, it would make things simpler. That it would…protect me. But now,

seeing her like this, my *older sister*—it feels like I wasted so much time being stubborn. What if she thinks I hated her?"

Scorpia's gaze softened, and she lowered herself onto the bench beside Perfuma. Her claws fidgeted before she finally let one rest carefully on Perfuma's arm, gentle despite the weight of it. "You're allowed to feel hurt. She did hurt you. But admitting that, and still loving her enough to let it go? That's…that's brave. That's love. She wouldn't think you hated her, I'm sure she was just waiting for you to talk."

Perfuma looked up at her, surprised. "You think so?"

Scorpia nodded firmly. "Yeah. Lots of people hold grudges forever, even when it eats them up inside. But you—you're willing to set yours aside for her. That's not a weakness. That's *strength*."

Perfuma swallowed, the tears slipping freely again now, but they didn't burn quite as much. Scorpia's words nestled somewhere deep in her chest. She reached up without thinking and placed her hand over Scorpia's claw. "You always know how to make me feel…lighter."

Scorpia's smile widened, bashful and soft. "Guess I've had a lot of practice trying to make people laugh. Or, you know, at least not cry."

Perfuma let out a shaky laugh, and the sound seemed to ease something between them. They sat there in the quiet, the storm still faintly echoing outside, until Perfuma's gaze lingered on Scorpia's lips a beat too long.

Her heart skipped. She should look away. She should. But Scorpia's eyes were wide and earnest, her cheeks flushed a pretty red, and Perfuma realized she didn't want to look away.

Tentatively, she leaned in. Scorpia froze for a moment, shocked, but then met her halfway, their lips brushing in a tentative, sweet kiss. Her heart was beating a mile a minute, far more feelings filling her chest than whatever person she had courted during the

season. It was clumsy, soft, and over too quickly—but when they pulled apart, they were both smiling.

Perfuma's breath caught. "Can we uh- Can we do that again?"

Scorpia chuckled nervously, rubbing the back of her neck with a claw. "I would- I would *really* like that." She breathed out.

Perfuma surprised herself by laughing, really laughing, for the first time in weeks. And for a fleeting moment, the heaviness in her chest lifted.

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"You know you won't get much further if you keep training while you're upset," Mara's voice cut through the empty clang of steel.

Adora froze mid-swing, her grip slackening until the sword dropped from her hand with a hollow thud against the training mat. She stood there, shoulders heaving, chest tight, her whole body trembling with exhaustion and something sharper, *desperation*.

"What do you suppose I do then?" she snapped, though her voice cracked halfway through. She crossed her arms tightly across her chest, as though holding herself together. Her lip quivered despite her best efforts to steel it. "It's been six weeks, Mara. A month and a half, and she's still—still asleep. No matter how many times she purrs or whispers something half-formed, she's not…she's not *here*." *Not here with me.*

Her eyes stung, and she blinked furiously, refusing to cry again. She was so tired of crying.

Mara rolled her eyes softly, though her expression was anything but dismissive. She crossed the room, her steps slow but purposeful, and laid a hand gently on Adora's slumped shoulder. "Then stop fighting yourself."

Adora turned toward her, frowning. Mara reached up, fingers deftly tugging free the tie that bound Adora's hair into its tight ponytail. Blonde waves spilled loose, and Mara's hands smoothed through them, massaging the tension from Adora's temples. Adora nearly broke right there, at the simple comfort.

"Let yourself feel love, Adora." Mara's voice was quiet, certain.

Adora swallowed hard, trying to push back the lump in her throat. "What does that even mean?"

"It means your power is built on love," Mara explained, brushing Adora's hair back from her damp forehead like she had when they were children. "Mine surged when Father died. My grief, my fury, my need for change—that was my foundation. But you? Yours is different. Yours only grows stronger when you let yourself love. That's how you're designed."

Adora furrowed her brow, shaking her head. "That sounds like… like some cheesy ballad. Love makes me stronger? That's ridiculous."

"Is it?" Mara's eyes held hers steadily. "Was it a coincidence you found the sword when you finally stopped fighting how you felt about Catra? Was it a coincidence that the very first time you healed someone was when you dragged her back from death?"

Adora flinched, the memory hitting like a dagger to the ribs. Catra's still body in her arms, her lips cold, her skin grey. The way Adora had begged until her throat bled. And then the impossible glow, the spark of life again.

Adora's voice dropped to a whisper, raw and broken. "If my power really comes from love, then why wasn't it enough to heal her completely? Why is she still—" Her hands balled into fists. "Why isn't she better?"

Mara's hand squeezed her shoulder firmly, grounding her. "Because even love has limits. Do you know how much power it would take to fully heal the kind of fall she endured? Even the

She-Ra of legend would have struggled. You didn't fail her, Adora. You brought her back. You gave her life again."

"But it wasn't enough," Adora choked, her body bowing under the weight of guilt.

"It was more than enough," Mara countered softly. "You've given her time. The rest is hers to take when she's ready. Your powers will grow, yes, but you *can't* keep breaking yourself every time they don't perform a miracle. Even miracles aren't perfect."

Silence fell between them. Adora stared at the sword lying on the ground, blurred by the tears she couldn't stop this time. Mara gently tilted her chin upward, forcing her to meet her gaze.

"Adora. She's still here. That's because of you."

Adora pressed her lips together, fighting back a sob, but it broke loose anyway. She folded forward, and Mara caught her in an embrace, holding her steady as she trembled.

"She's still here," Mara whispered into her hair, steady as stone. "And so are you. Don't lose yourself while you wait for her to wake."

Adora closed her eyes, clutching at her sister's sleeve like she was twenty again, the night their father had died. Only this time, it wasn't grief that roared in her chest—it was a love so fierce, so consuming, it terrified her.

Love that she was finally starting to realize wasn't her weakness.

It was her strength.

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In the time that Catra slept, Adora healed Plumeria fully — well, with the help of Perfuma of course. The once barren wasteland, decrepit with tech and dead plants, now flourished beautifully.

Vines parted every corner, flowers sprouted from the plush ground of clover and the land was finally…liveable.

Perfuma had finally realised that her powers were nothing short of incredible, and with the help of her new…partner *(? They hadn't seemed to have labelled it yet.)* they had started rebuilding into something truly beautiful. Scorpia had powered every built house, had channeled electricity into new machines that could rebuild them, had used just brute strength to change the rubble of stone and wood into fully formed homes.

They were a sickenly cute couple, Adora thought to herself. They were always at each others sides, blushing furiously, whispering to each other, it was devastatingly right. Still, it made Adora's own heart ache.

She sat by her lover now, stroking the fur on her fingers and memorising each boney knuckle that jutted out from her fingers. Her hope had been dwindling the minute it had taken more than four weeks, but she didn't let herself show it. She had to be strong, for Catra's mother and sister.

Cyra couldn't bring herself to visit Catra. As much as Adora wanted to be upset at her for it, she couldn't. She knew exactly the thoughts and memories that must be running through her mind. It was evident too, with the way she couldn't stomach food past a simple tea and occasional biscuit, from the way her eyes dropped to the floor when she saw Adora come out of Catra's room, to the way she only spoke in hoarse, one-word whispers to anyone that dared awkwardly try to talk to her. She was breaking, and Adora didn't really know what to do.

Still, she made sure to always leave a healing tea for Cyra, when she ventured out of her room, to pluck a small flower out of the bouquet she would bring for Catra, to smile at her encouragingly if she ventured out into the halls.

Adora was glad Perfuma had Scorpia. Hopefully the woman was doing a good job at comforting her considering she was practically

mourning her entire family right now.

She sighed, gathering her things with one hand, though the other lingered stubbornly in Catra's. She'd already recounted the day's events, already whispered every story and secret she could think of into the quiet of the room, but Catra didn't stir. She never did. And now Adora was left staring at her, drinking in every line of her face, caught between aching devotion and bone-deep weariness.

It wasn't doing her any favors, staying like this. Sitting in limbo.

With a reluctant breath, she eased her hand free, untangling their fingers one by one and moving to leave. *But then-*

A twitch. A pressure. This faint, faltering grasp...

Adora froze, her head snapping toward Catra. The girl was still slumped to the side, eyes closed, lips parted in shallow breaths. Adora's pulse thundered in her ears. *I imagined that. I must have.*

But when she tried again to slip free, she heard it.

A broken murmur, barely shaped into sound: "Mm… stay."

Adora's eyes went wide, her heart leaping to her throat. She dropped everything and sat back down at once, clutching Catra's hand as though afraid it might vanish.

"Catra?" Her voice cracked. She pressed her palm to Catra's shoulder, shaking her gently, searching her face. "Can you hear me?"

Nothing.

The silence cut sharper than a blade, and Adora sagged forward, her hope crumbling as quickly as it had risen. She swallowed, a bitter lump clawing at her throat.

And then, the rasp of a voice—hoarse, thin, but undeniably hers:

“Stay… just this once… please.”

Adora’s breath hitched. Tears pricked hot at the corners of her eyes as she leaned close, pressing her forehead against Catra’s temple. “I’ll stay,” she whispered, her voice trembling. “Not just this once. Always. You hear me? I’m not leaving you. Not ever.”

She kissed Catra’s cheek, soft and lingering, a promise etched into her skin.

For a moment, nothing happened. Just the sound of rain against the windows, the slow rhythm of Catra’s breathing.

And then…

Her lashes fluttered. A shiver coursed through her body. Adora pulled back just enough to see amber and cerulean eyes, the sun and the ocean, bleary and dazed, crack open.

Adora choked on a sob, her whole body trembling as she clutched her hand tighter. “Catra?”

The faintest smile ghosted across Catra’s lips. Weak. Fragile. But real.

“Hey, Adora.” She whispered.

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Adora steadied the glass carefully, her hand trembling as she tilted it against Catra’s lips. Her thumb pressed gently under her chin, coaxing her to drink. Catra’s sips were shallow, deliberate, and Adora found herself counting each one like it was a miracle.

Her heart wouldn’t stop racing. Even with Catra warm against her side, even with her voice rasping and her breaths real, *alive*, her pulse hammered in her ears as though she might lose her all over again.

“I’ve already sent for the physician,” Adora murmured, pulling the cup back just a little. “They’ll be here soon.”

Catra frowned, her voice scratchy but teasing: “I told you not to. I want to rest some more before all the annoying questions and faff.”

“You’ve been asleep for months, Catra. Don’t you think that’s enough rest?!” Adora cried.

Instead of snapping back, Catra chuckled, low and tired. She tugged clumsily at Adora’s arm until Adora gave in, allowing herself to be drawn down beside her. Catra curled in close, her head tucked into the curve of Adora’s shoulder despite the stiffness in her movements.

The familiarity of it—the weight of her, the scent of her hair—made Adora’s chest ache so sharply she almost couldn’t breathe.

Neither of them spoke after that. Catra’s eyes drifted shut again, and Adora… she just stared. Watching her breathe. Watching the way her chest rose and fell, steady and fragile. It didn’t feel real, not after so many nights imagining this exact moment, begging for it, dreaming of it.

She had so much to say. Months of words stacked in her throat like stones. But faced with the reality of her finally being awake, Adora couldn’t find her voice.

“Stop thinking so hard,” Catra muttered suddenly, her words muffled against Adora’s collarbone.

Adora startled. Then, after a moment of silence, she asked softly, “What was it like?”

Catra’s brow furrowed faintly.

“I mean… while you were under. Was it like… a long nap? Or could you hear us?”

Catra let her lips brush the rim of the glass as Adora tilted it for her again. When she pulled back, her voice was quiet, careful. "It was like… when you're half-asleep. You know? Just before you fall all the way under. You're aware, but you can't move. My body felt… heavy. Like it wasn't mine. Like rice stuffed into a sack." She winced faintly, then sighed. "Most of the time it was just muffled sounds. Like voices under water. And a constant headache. But sometimes…" She hesitated. "Sometimes I thought I could feel you."

Adora's throat tightened. "You could?"

Catra cracked open one hazel eye, weak but smirking. "You talk too much, Adora."

Adora let out a shaky laugh, brushing back the bangs from Catra's forehead. Her hand lingered there, trembling slightly. She wanted to say it—to pour everything out—but her chest locked tight.

"I'm sorry," she whispered at last, the words tumbling out raw and uneven. "I'm so, so sorry."

Catra blinked at her.

"I should've asked you to stay- that night. When I found you- all I could worry about was you thinking I had given up on us for some- for some stupid thing that wasn't even your fault. Catra-" She drew Catra's hands into hers and clutched them tightly. "- Catra. I don't care about your condition. I mean, I do in the sense that I am sorry you went through that but- but it never changed how i felt about you.

I hadn't faltered in our future. I merely didn't say anything because I was too busy thinking about logistics. Before you…I never thought I was allowed to want things for my own future, want something different than what was expected of me. But- I truly don't care if one day, when we are both ready we go an unconventional route. I also gave it some thought and realised I

would be comfortable carrying too…albeit maybe not for a while… But there are other options..”

Catra was staring at her, wide eyed and trembling, like she couldn’t believe what Adora was saying.

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“You really mean that?” She heard herself whisper. Her voice was cracked and parched even though she had been getting fluids, it felt strange to talk, to really even comprehensively think.

She couldn’t fathom Adora’s words. She had felt as though the woman had stayed by her side out of pity, mere obligation or guilt. She hadn’t even imagined that Adora would rethink her life, rethink *anything* for her.

“I mean it, Catra.” Her tone was solid, without any hint of a waver and Catra felt as though she might cry.

She felt the emotion bloom in her chest, expanding as if she might die a second time if she didn’t say it. Her last thoughts had been not being able to express it to Adora soon enough, so she let herself.

“I- I love you, Adora.” She whispered, weakly bringing Adora’s hand to her mouth and kissing it. Adora was sitting there, stunned — and for just a minute, Catra feared she had said the wrong thing.

“I didn’t come here for the first couple of weeks…” Adora looked at her guiltily. “I should’ve been here. I should’ve stayed by your side instead of hiding in training or sending stupid flowers. I thought… I thought if I *loved* you any harder, I’d break in half. And I was so *scared* of losing you that I couldn’t even face you. And when I couldn’t heal you—” her voice cracked—“I felt like I failed you. Again. Just like I failed my father. And I can’t…” She broke off, swallowing hard as her eyes blurred. “I can’t lose you too, Catra. I won’t survive it.”

The silence that followed was thick, broken only by the storm still pattering outside. Catra's weak fingers twitched against Adora's wrist, tugging until Adora finally met her gaze.

"Idiot," Catra rasped softly. "You didn't fail me. You brought me back. You…you saved me."

Her expression shifted, tightening as her voice faltered. "And I'm sorry too. For everything. For not telling you sooner. About… not being able to have kids. For making you think you'd wasted your time loving me when I can't give you the life you want. For pushing you away, even before all of this. If I'd been honest from the start—"

"Stop." Adora shook her head fiercely, tears slipping free now as she cupped Catra's face in both hands. "Don't you dare apologize for that. I don't care about that stuff. I just want you. Kids or no kids, scars or no scars. You are it for me, Catra. You're all I'll ever want."

Catra's eyes glistened, her lips trembling as though she might argue—but then Adora kissed her forehead, soft and lingering, and the words died in her throat.

"Please," Adora whispered against her skin. "Don't ever think you're not enough. Because you're more than I ever thought I'd have."

Catra exhaled a shaky laugh, her claws curling weakly into Adora's tunic as she buried her face in her chest. "You truly love me?"

Adora smiled through her tears, pressing her cheek into Catra's hair. "The entire time, Cat."

And for the first time in months, she let herself believe everything might be okay.

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Catra had already told herself she wouldn’t cry. She had already sort of broken that during Adora’s confession, shedding a few tears whilst shaky and disorientated, clinging to Adora’s hand like a lifeline. She had figured that would be the last of it, no more tears.

She wasn’t usually so emotional. But the moment her mother had entered the room, her resolve loosened.

Cyra had entered the room, ashen and worn. Her eyes were wide and disbelieving in a way that made Catra’s chest cave in. She hadn’t said anything at first, merely walked up to her and pressed a shaky hand to her forehead, then smoothing over her eyes and cheeks, feeling the warmth in her skin. Catra thought for a long minute that that might be it- the extent of her reaction. But then Cyra threw herself forward, her arms encircling her like a vice, and breaking Catra‘s own resolve completely.

“My kitten,” Cyra had wailed, her voice cracking so raw and loud it rattled Catra’s bones. She clutched Catra tighter, her fingers trembling violently as if she were afraid she might slip away again. “My baby, My—, stars, I thought I’d *lost* you.”

Up until then, Catra had awkwardly been clutched in her arms. She couldn’t remember a time her mother had ever held her like this, she couldn't even remember a time she saw her mother cry. When her mama had died, it was like Cyra did too, resolving to staying in her room and never crying even at the funeral. She hadn’t even attended, and Catra had thought simply

The embrace was suffocating, nearly choking, but Catra didn’t dare pull away. Her mother’s arms—fierce and desperate, almost wild—felt like home in a way Catra hadn’t felt since her Mama had been alive. The gap between them, once wide and jagged, closed in an instant as Cyra wrapped every piece of herself around her daughter and refused to let go, pulling a deep comforting purr from her.

Catra's finally, heaving sobs soaked through the fabric of her mother's gown, her claws curling weakly into Cyra's back. She could barely process the sound of her mother's childlike cries. Cyra, who had never been one for grand displays of emotion, who offered small nicknames and the occasional, quiet encouragement even in her best days, was unraveling now. Her voice was ragged, breaking, each cry torn from a place far too deep.

It frightened Catra almost as much as it comforted her.

Because when she pulled back for a moment, just enough to see her mother's face, she was struck by how *frail* she looked. Smaller. Diminished. Her frame was thinner, her shoulders weighed down, her cheeks hollowed. She looked… like *Mama* had, in her final months.

The realization made Catra's stomach twist.

This wasn't just relief, it was desperation. Cyra was holding her as though she were still dead, mourning her as though she'd already buried her.

Catra cried harder, not for herself this time but for her mother, for the way this near-loss had carved pieces out of her.

Adora had warned her earlier, gently, that Cyra hadn't been well. That she'd closed herself in her room most days, barely eating, speaking to almost no one. Catra hadn't wanted to believe it—she couldn't really fathom her absence affecting someone so much, even just seeing it in Adora was enlightening. She didn't really think she mattered all that much to *anyone*... But seeing it now… seeing her mother break down the moment she heard Catra's weak croak of "Mother"-

It gutted her.

"I'm here," Catra rasped between sobs, clinging tighter, though her voice was hoarse and her arms weak. "I'm here, Ma. I'm not going anywhere."

Cyra only cried harder, pressing frantic kisses to her hair, rocking her as though Catra were still a child.

And for the first time in years, Catra let herself be small in her mother's arms, feeling five years old and twenty nine all the same.

She was still broken sobbing when Perfuma and Scorpia burst in, Perfuma looking tired and unkempt, all her perfectness washed away, looking hopeful yet guilty as she rushed in.

"Sister." She let out a harsh, shaky inhale and enveloped her into a hug, joining Cyra and smushing Catra effectively into mush. The hug was painful, but she couldn't bring herself to say anything—not when they hadn't spoken in practically half a year now.

Scorpia looked over to Catra worryingly, noting her discomfort but leaving to give them space once Catra nodded towards her.

The three sat there, curled around each other with tears staining their cheeks. Catra had started heaving at one point, her sobs drying her throat. Perfuma was muttering out apologies that she desperately wanted to be present for, but her head was pounding as she shook her head and silenced her.

The physician had entered then, carefully extracting her family away from their desperate hold on her, and started running tests. She was given further fluids, and told to not speak for a while, that it be too harsh on her vocal cords and not to strain herself.

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The next few days passed in a strange, muddled haze.

Catra was awake now, truly awake, but she didn't feel alive in the way she remembered. Everything was too slow. Too quiet. Too soft. And somehow still too much.

The physician had ordered more rest. *More* rest! As though months of lying motionless in a bed hadn't been enough to last

her nine lifetimes. Catra wanted to scream when she heard it the first time, but all that came out was a pathetic rasp and a coughing fit that made her head spin.

Her body understood before her pride did. Every bone, every nerve, every muscle she used to take for granted now felt carved from glass. The simplest things, sitting up, stretching her fingers, turning her head too quickly, made her body throb in protest.

Useless. She felt useless.

And the worst part was that she couldn't even argue that she wasn’t.

Her right arm had regained most of its strength, thanks to Adora pouring magic into it even when she swayed with exhaustion. The legs were next, Adora had insisted, stubborn as ever, but even with the warmth of healing, they felt unfamiliar. Heavy. Half-asleep. There was this awful sensation, like her body belonged to someone else and she’d been dropped back into it without all the instructions.

She tried swinging her legs over the side of the bed once. Just once. The moment her feet touched the floor, her knees buckled and Adora practically dove to catch her.

She’d never seen Adora pale like that—ashen, frantic, breathless—like she’d watched Catra fall off that horse all over again. Catra had snarled at her, embarrassed and furious, but the shame of it clung to her longer than the pain.

And her throat—Gods, her *throat*. It burned and scraped whenever she tried to talk, like she’d swallowed smoke and gravel. Every word caught and dragged, and speaking more than a sentence left her winded. Sometimes she had to close her eyes and focus just to swallow water.

She hated the sound of her own voice now, weak, cracked, like she was learning to speak for the first time. Even forming words hurt. And yet people kept asking her questions.

“How are you feeling?”

“Can you drink this?”

“Would you want soup?”

“Are you too warm?”

“Too cold?”

“Tired?”

“Do you need—”

She wanted to snap, but half the time she couldn’t even get the words out before the ache in her throat shut them down. She wasn't used to being taken care of like this, of being treated like a porcelain doll. Gods…was this how Perfuma felt all the time? She owed her a serious apology when her voice allowed her.

So she just laid back, staring at the ceiling, her tail twitching uselessly at her side. Days bled together. Morning or night barely mattered. The world moved around her and she was stuck—between sleep and wakefulness, between healing and helplessness, between relief and shame.

And through it all, Adora was always there. Hovering. Watching. Fussing. Flinching every time Catra so much as winced.

Catra couldn’t decide if it comforted her or made her want to scream.

Maybe both.

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By the time the sun dipped and the healer had come and gone, Catra was drowsy but stubbornly awake. Adora had lingered for hours without seeming to realize it, fetching broth, rearranging

blankets, threatening two separate attendants who tried to shoo her out.

Eventually, Cyra retired, and the house fell into an evening hush.

Adora was still there.

Catra squinted at her from the nest of pillows. “Adora, if you stack those pillows any higher, I am going to suffocate.”

Adora giggled, awkwardly shuffling away from the pillows and hesitating before saying, “You look better nowadays.”

She scoffed, rolling her eyes and smirking, “don’t jest. I look as though I have been thrown off of a horse.”

“Well you look like a very pretty victim of the horse.” She smiled softly.

Catra huffed, to hide the loud beating of her heart. She shuffled awkwardly closer to Adora and cupped her face, fondly. “It’s past dusk now.”

Adora blinked, glancing at the door like she’d only just realized time existed. “Oh. Right. I can—uh—go if you want.”

There was something so absurd in the way she said it, as though she expected to be escorted to the gallows, that Catra rolled her eyes so hard it nearly hurt.

“Sit down, you big idiot.”

Adora sat. Immediately. Too fast. Like she'd been ordered by a general.

Catra smirked. “Stars, you’re pathetic.”

“You asked me to stay,” Adora muttered, cheeks pink.

“I didn’t ask. I commanded.” She crossed her arms.

Adora huffed, but her shoulders relaxed. Melog, still curled at Catra's feet, stretched up the mattress and bumped its head into Adora's hip until she turned and stroked between its ears.

The room grew quiet again. Catra's eyes were heavy, but she refused to close them yet.

"You should sleep," Adora murmured.

"So should you," Catra rasped back. "You look like someone wrung you out and forgot to hang you up."

Adora snorted softly. "Thanks."

Catra's gaze flicked to the settee shoved against the wall. It was narrow, old, and probably felt like sleeping on a cartwheel. Adora had been taking short naps on it whilst she tended to Catra. Only leaving if absolutely necessary. It was stupid. She laid down on the thing, as though a few months prior, her face hadn't spent hours between Catra's thighs.

She nodded toward it anyway. "If you're gonna hover, at least don't go home and come back at dawn. It's annoying. Stay."

Adora froze mid-stroke on Melog's head. "Stay… here?...In the bed?"

"Unless you'd rather crawl under it. Your choice."

Adora hesitated only long enough to kick off her boots. The ridiculous thing was, she actually looked nervous as she moved to the other side of the bed and sat gingerly on top of the blanket, like she might sink through it.

Catra flicked her tail against Adora's thigh. "You can get under the covers, you know. I'm injured, not contagious."

Adora's ears went dusty pink this time. She slid under the blanket slowly, careful of Catra's legs, her arm brushing Catra's side.

Silence settled again, but it felt… lighter.

Catra's eyes drifted shut halfway. "You're staring."

"No, I'm not," Adora whispered immediately.

"You are. I can feel it on my face."

A beat.

"…maybe a little."

Catra smirked without opening her eyes. "Take a picture. It'll last longer."

Adora huffed a laugh. Everything inside Catra warmed at the sound, buzzing happily.

A few moments passed. Then Adora shifted closer, just a fraction, and brushed a loose strand of hair off Catra's forehead. "You scared the shit out of me," she whispered.

Catra cracked one eye open. The look on Adora's face was raw, and stupidly earnest. It made something in her chest ache.

"Do not agitate yourself. I'm hard to get rid of," Catra murmured.

Adora's answering smile was soft and wrecked. She leaned in, slowly, giving Catra ample time to push her away, but Catra didn't. Their foreheads touched first. Then noses. Then, gently, Adora ghosted a kiss at the corner of Catra's mouth.

Catra let out a sound halfway between a sigh and a purr. "That was barely anything."

Adora fought a grin. "I'm being careful."

"Be less careful."

Adora didn't need more encouragement than that. She kissed her properly this time. A soft aching kiss to her lips, slow and reverent

as though she was scared Catra might fade if she pressed too hard.

Catra's fingers curled weakly into the front of Adora's shirt. "Again," she whispered against her lips. She had missed this the most.

So Adora did. Her hand cupping Catra's cheek and angling her face to slot their lips together. Catra huffed a sigh and Adora took the opportunity to lick into her mouth. Catra gasped in turn and sucked onto her tongue, pulling Adora's hair softly and earning an eager groan.

Eventually, Melog made an indignant chirp and flopped itself across both of their thighs like a furry armrest, clearly over the dramatics.

Adora pulled back, laughing breathlessly into Catra's shoulder.

"You're ridiculous," Catra muttered, eyes finally closing.

"You keep saying that," Adora murmured, settling closer, "but you never sound like you want me to stop."

Catra huffed. "…shut up and sleep."

Adora smiled into Catra's hair and finally, *finally*—let herself rest.

Melog, satisfied with its matchmaking, turned a warm pink and purred low in approval.

Chapter End Notes

> "Love is your design" Anyone else heard the new Marina song Princess of Power? Yeahhh totally from that - i love it so she ra
>
> Okay so I think this work will have another work after - where we can see their future afterwards, because I think it might be a bit long to add into this work. That being said, the next

chapter may be the last one or maybe the one after that...since I don't like odd numbers...How are we feeling after this chapter?

Leave a kudos or comment if you're enjoying this!

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Chapter 17: Love is...everything

Chapter Notes

Okay a bit of a late chapter but that's because I may finally be employed soon...woah. It was also because I wanted to finish some sketches I had done beforehand so - look no further.

See the end of the chapter for more notes



The poster I've been working on since I started this fic! Did this myself, will be posting on chap 1 now too!

Catra had never felt more humiliated by her own body.

The physician had warned her that even with She-Ra's partial healing, her muscles would be stiff, her nerves slow to respond, and balance would take time to regain. Catra had assumed that

meant a couple of days of discomfort and then she'd be back to prowling around estates and climbing ledges like she always had.

She was wrong.

It had been two weeks now and she still felt like a stupid sack of rice.

"Try again," Adora said gently from the floor in front of her, hands hovering just over Catra's uncooperative thigh. "Just flex—just this bit here, don't worry about the rest."

Catra grit her teeth and attempted to lift her leg from where she sat propped up in bed. The muscle jumped, tightened, and then trembled uselessly. A sharp jolt of pain shot up her hip and she hissed through her teeth, tail lashing the mattress as she told herself not to cry.

"I'm tired," she snapped, even though it was barely the fourth rep.

"I know," Adora said, voice maddeningly soft. "That's why we're doing only a few at a time."

"It isn't doing anything," Catra growled. "It's useless. *I feel useless.*" She admitted, angrily.

"You're not," Adora replied immediately, and that, somehow, made it worse.

Catra glared down at her own traitorous legs. Months ago, she'd never even thought about moving. She just moved. Now every stretch, every twitch, every tiny lift felt like trying to drag boulders through wet sand.

Adora reached for her again. "Just one more try—"

"No," Catra snapped, yanking her leg away from Adora's touch harder than she meant to. "I said I'm done."

Guilt seeped into her like ice water, settling somewhere deep beneath muscle and bone the moment she caught the look on Adora's face, not angry, not disappointed… merely confused. Catra hated that look more than any fury. Confusion meant Adora didn't understand why Catra was pushing back, why she was retreating, why the sharpness in her tone had crept in uninvited.

She hadn't meant to snap. Not really. But the ache in her legs, the humiliating tremor in her hands, the way her body stubbornly refused to obey her — it scraped at every raw edge she had left.

The air between them went still.

Silence didn't just fall, it stretched. Wide and suffocating. It felt like being held underwater, both of them waiting for the other to move, to speak, to break.

Catra's shoulders stiffened, jaw tight as she prepared herself for impact. She knew how this usually went. Adora would try to push through it, power through her resistance the way she always had in the past. Catra could already hear the words she expected:

'You're overreacting.
You're stronger than this.
Come on, don't quit now.'

Maybe even a gentle lecture about progress, or determination, or not giving up. Something painfully earnest and well-intentioned that would only make Catra feel smaller.

She braced herself for it, for the argument, the insistence, the bright-eyed optimism she wasn't sure she could take right now. Her claws dug into the cushion beneath her, and she locked her jaw so tightly a tremor ran through her teeth. The silence pressed in harder, thick and tense as a storm cloud.

But Adora didn't say a word.

Instead, Adora simply sat back on her heels. "Okay," she said softly. "Then we rest."

Catra's jaw clenched. The quiet kindness in Adora’s tone only made her shame burn hotter. She was just so…good. She was so good to her and Catra didn’t deserve her. She deserved someone who could give her everything, not someone who could barely walk, talk or even bare children.

“Stop it.”

Catra looked up from her spiralling to Adora’s gentle yet stern expression. She waited a beat, then reached for the blanket and draped it over Catra’s lap. She didn’t say anything else. Didn't lecture her, sigh or pity her, instead just covering her gently and sitting at the edge of the bed, beside her.

Minutes passed. The tension in Catra’s shoulders finally loosened enough for breath to flow without stinging.

“I hate this,” she muttered eventually, voice low and rough. “I hate not being able to just… do things. I hate you having to help me walk. I hate depending on people.”

Adora glanced at her, eyes so stupidly soft it made Catra want to throw something. “I don’t mind helping you.”

“Well, I mind.” Catra crossed her arms and stared at the wall. “I’m not some broken doll for you to fix and fuss over.”

“You’re not broken,” Adora said quietly.

Catra scoffed. “Debatable.”

“No,” Adora whispered, firm now. “You’re hurt. That’s different. And you’re healing. That’s different too.”

Catra let out a bitter laugh and immediately regretted it when her chest twinged. “You always have an answer, don’t you?”

“I only say it because it's true.”

The silence that followed wasn't as brittle this time. After a while, Adora shifted closer and gently rested her hand on Catra's shin. "Do you want me to massage them? Your calves?"

Catra hesitated, pride prickling. But the ache in her thighs and calves was real and relentless.

"…Fine," she said, pretending to sound annoyed.

Adora hid a smile as she slid off the bed to sit on the floor again. She carefully raised Catra's leg, resting her calf across her lap. Her hands were warm, warmer than they should've been—as though she was the literal sun, and she kneaded very gently at first, careful of the bruised tissue and newly healed bone.

Catra hissed at the initial pressure. "Ow—slow down."

Adora's thumbs softened immediately. "Is this better?"

Catra didn't answer, but she stopped flinching. Her claws retracted as she curled into the blankets whilst Adora worked the muscle with patient, practiced care. The tension in Catra's shoulders began to ease despite herself and she began purring softly, half out of contentment and half to self soothe. She absently kneaded the blanket beneath her fingers and she stared at Adora with sleepy, lidded eyes.

Without warning, Adora bent down and pressed a soft kiss to Catra's ankle.

Catra jolted. "What the hell was that?"

"A kiss," Adora said simply, as though she were announcing the weather.

"Why?"

Adora looked up at her with a baffling sincerity that made Catra's chest tug strangely. "Because I love you, and you're hurting, and

you don’t deserve to feel like you’re failing just because your body needs time.”

Catra sucked in a sharp breath, eyes stinging unexpectedly. She looked away quickly before Adora could notice the shine in them. Adora had taken to absently reminding her of her love. Catra tried to as well, but she could not find it in herself to say it so nonchalantly, as though it was simply as easy as breathing.

Adora resumed her gentle massaging, occasionally pressing soft kisses along the line of Catra’s thigh and knee, murmuring praise under her breath as though Catra were made of something precious and fragile and irreplaceable.

Slowly, Catra’s rigid posture melted back into the pillows.

“You’re being sappy,” she muttered, trying to keep her voice steady and not showcase the fondness and love bubbling in her chest.

Adora smiled without looking up. “You’ll live.”

“Doubt it.”

Adora’s hand squeezed her ankle. “You already did.”

The room went still.

Neither of them spoke after that, for once, the silence between them wasn’t tense or awkward, but warm in a way Catra could almost relax into. Melog eventually hopped up beside Catra and curled into the crook of her ribs, purring, their tail flicking lazily against Adora’s thigh.

When Adora finished, she gently laid Catra’s leg back atop the cushions, then leaned in and pressed one last kiss to her shin as though sealing her work.

Catra blinked down at her, something soft and traitorous in her chest.

“Tomorrow,” Adora said quietly, brushing a thumb along her calf, “we’ll try again. And even if you snap at me, I’m still not going anywhere.”

Catra stared at her for a long moment.

Then, begrudgingly, she whispered, “Okay…I- I love you.” She confessed quietly.

Adora heard it all the same, her beam brighter than anything else in that dark room.

“I love you too. So much.”

- - - - - - -

Perfuma’s visits to Plumeria had started as a once-a-week thing.

Now she was gone more often than she was home.

Catra didn’t really mind, if anything, it was strange how much she *didn’t* mind. Perfuma came back smelling like rain-washed petals and river wind, skin sun-touched and eyes brighter than Catra had seen in years. They had made up shortly after she had woken up. Once she was actually able to listen to her coherently. If she was being honest, she didn’t think Perfuma needed to apologise. Sure it had royally sucked having her sister ignore her for months, but she couldn't have said it was unwarranted. Still, Perfuma had apologised profusely, crying for her sister and claiming she couldn’t imagine how lonely Catra must have felt just before she passed away. That, obviously, made Catra cry too. *Stars, being in Brightmoon had turned her soft.*

One late afternoon, Perfuma returned with dirt under her nails and an excited flush in her cheeks. Catra was sprawled on the couch, Melog snoring on her lap, while Adora tried and failed to braid Catra’s hair without getting distracted by kissing the back of her neck every two minutes. It made Catra trill, a sight that made her mother chuckle fondly at the pair, and caused Catra to blush heavily. Light Spinner promptly chose to sneer and walk away.

Perfuma walked in, and Catra could tell immediately, something was up.

"Fuma…you look as though you are about to announce a baby, a war or that you're eloping."

Perfuma practically *glowed* as she dropped onto the armchair. "You're not far off."

Adora perked up. Melog cracked one glowing eye and Cyra looked as though she might faint.

Catra squeaked, "Pregnant, Fuma? Already? Sheesh, you guys move fast-"

Cyra spoke at the same time, "It's just scandal after scandal with you guys." She sighed, shaking her head but not offering a lecture either way.

"No!" Perfuma flushed a bright red as she waved her hands erratically, a sight that was so endearingly taken from Scorpia.

She instead, took a breath. "Plumeria… is growing. Fast. A lot of people who were displaced during the war or who don't feel connected to their kingdoms anymore like travelers, refugees, nomads, they're settling there. The community is getting bigger."

Catra raised a brow. "And you're… helping them move?"

"I've been coordinating transports, helping build housing, organizing crop systems…" Perfuma's voice was quietly proud. "They asked me to mediate a council meeting last week. There's talk of setting up official leadership for the region."

Catra sat up a little too fast, startling Melog. "And?"

Perfuma hesitated only for a second. "Someone suggested I run for one of the leadership roles. Co-chair of the council."

Adora gasped "Perfuma! That's amazing!"

Catra's grin spread slow and wide. She scooped Melog off her lap and set them aside so she could shakily stand and clasp Perfuma's shoulders. "Are you kidding me? That's—Perfuma, that's perfect. You'd be incredible. Plumeria huh? I suppose that land is completely ridden with flowers now, thanks to you, it will be perfect."

Perfuma ducked her head, cheeks pink. "It's just an idea right now. But I… I do think I want to do it. And if I did, I'd probably move out there. Not permanently at first… but maybe eventually."

Catra blinked, processing. "You'd move to Plumeria full-time?"

Cyra looked worried. "By yourself?"

Perfuma's smile was soft but sure. "I think so. I feel… useful there. Needed. And happy. And…maybe I'll move there by myself-or maybe I will move with Scorpia for a bit…I'm not completely sure. After all she is literally a princess with her own kingdom."

Catra surprised herself by pulling her into a hug so suddenly Perfuma squeaked. "I'm so proud of you, you have no idea."

Cyra smiled again eventually, joining the hug. "We. *We* are proud of you."

Perfuma hugged her back fiercely, laughing into her shoulder. "You're not… upset?"

Catra snorted. "Upset? You finally found something that doesn't involve crying over dead succulents and apologizing to moss. I'm thrilled."

Adora chimed in, still starry-eyed on the couch. "Plus, if you're in charge, you can make the festival foods better. Those rosehip sandwiches tasted like soap and sadness."

Perfuma groaned and threw a pillow at her.

Melog, catching the excitement, turned a pleased shade of pink and head-butted Perfuma's leg before curling up in her lap.

Perfuma looked at both of them, Catra still beaming, Adora smiling wide and earnest—and relaxed like a weight had fully lifted. Cyra was still quiet but looked on proudly.

"I'm going to talk to Scorpia about it tonight," she said quietly. "But… I think this is the path I want. I'm ready for it."

Catra nudged her with her tail. "Then go take it."

And she meant it.

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Catra pretended not to stare, but she absolutely was staring.

Perfuma and Scorpia were across the garden, laughing at something dumb Scorpia said while pretending not to trip over a rake. Perfuma swatted at her arm, cheeks flushed, and Scorpia's whole face lit up with that ridiculous sunshine-smile she only ever seemed to wear around people she really loved.

It was… sweet. *Gross*, but sweet.

Catra leaned back against the bench as Perfuma eventually approached with a watering can in hand, pretending like she hadn't just been hanging off Scorpia like a vine.

"You're staring," Perfuma said lightly as she knelt to arrange a pot of moonbloom cuttings.

"I don't stare," Catra said, absolutely staring.

Perfuma just hummed.

Silence passed for a minute, a comfortable one, for once.

Then Catra spoke without looking at her. "You and Scorpia seem… good."

Perfuma's smile curled at the edges, soft and a little shy. "We are. It's still new, but… it feels right. Easy, even when it's not."

Catra picked at a loose thread on her sleeve. "You really like her?"

Perfuma glanced up, eyes brightening. "I do. I have a…" she hesitated, then laughed under her breath, "—a *really* good feeling."

Catra nodded, pretending that didn't make her chest feel weird and warm. "Do you ever think about… the future with her?"

Perfuma blinked at the question, then set down the watering can carefully. "You mean marriage?"

Catra grimaced. "I didn't say that word."

"You almost did," Perfuma teased, then shrugged, gaze drifting. "Honestly? I'm not sure what the universe has in store for us. I don't think we'll do the whole…traditional marriage thing. The ceremony, the politics, the roles—I've realised none of that actually matters to me. I thought I wanted it because it was expected but…I don't really care for what society thinks anymore. I'd rather our relationship be on our own terms.Partnership, promise, something meaningful—but ours."

Catra contemplated her words for a moment. She didn't even know that was an option…something to solidify your love outside of marriage. Did she want that? *What did she actually want?*…. "I'm happy for you. Really."

Perfuma smiled at her like she believed it. Then, quietly: "What about you and Adora?"

Catra stiffened. "You really wanna talk about that?"

Perfuma sighed softly. "Catra, I told you…I'm *fine*. I'm not angry anymore. I don't feel that resentment. When I see you two… I actually like it. It doesn't hurt. It feels lighter now."

Catra dared to meet her eyes, found no bitterness there, just honesty.

"…One day," she said slowly, surprising even herself as the words left her. "I think I'd like to marry her."

Her heart stammered softly in her chest as she admitted that. She knew that the idea wouldn't be foreign to most couples, but it felt like a secret she kept close to her chest, despite knowing Adora would probably be…happy with the idea.

Perfuma's lips parted in a soft, stunned smile.

"I never… really let myself think about it before," Catra continued, voice low. "But I do like the idea. And maybe…" she swallowed, cheeks heating, "...kids. Eventually. If she wanted that too."

Perfuma didn't squeal, didn't overreact. She just touched Catra's arm gently and whispered softly, "I think she'd be over the moon to hear that."

Catra huffed out something like an uncomfortable laugh. "Yeah, well. Don't tell her before I do."

"My lips are sealed." Perfuma winked, then added with a sly smile, "But just so you know… you'd make an amazing mother."

"Shut up." Catra smiled.

Perfuma only giggled, and across the way, Scorpia looked over at them with a fond wave. Catra found herself waving back.

And for once, the future didn't feel so intimidating.

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They were still warm from sex, their skin damp with sweat and their breaths syncing. Catra's tail lazily curled around Adora's muscled thigh beneath the sheets. The lantern on the dresser flickered low, catching in Adora's sunlight hair as she sprawled on

her back, one arm tucked under her head whilst the other rested on Catra's stomach.

For a while, the only thing that filled the air was their quiet panting and Catra's contented purr. But Adora broke it, with a voice soft and hesitant.

"What do you think comes next?" She whispered, her voice steady but hands shaky. "In the future, I mean. Where would you like to live?"

Catra blinked up at the ceiling, heart kicking up, because she'd known this was coming eventually. She told herself not to panic. This was her chance. Her moment to be honest before she ruined something good again.

She cleared her throat, trying not to sound like she was about to confess to a crime. "I… I think…eventually—I'd like to settle in Halfmoon. It's home in my bones, y'know? But if it came down to it, I wouldn't be opposed to… compromise. Whether it's Halfmoon or Brightmoon…I think I could be happy wherever." *As long as you're there.*

Adora's fingers absently traced circles against her skin. Catra could feel the nervous energy radiating off her like steam.

"I know we haven't… been together that long," Adora said, cautious, eyes fixed on the ceiling now too.

Catra snorted, turning her head with a lazy, all too fond, grin. "We've been together for nine months, Viscount."

Adora blinked over at her. "Three of those months you were in a coma," she deadpanned.

Catra shrugged. "Still counts. And don't forget the seven months of embarrassingly intense pining and unresolved tension before that. It hasn't been *that* short."

Adora huffed a laugh, but her pulse was still racing, Catra could practically feel it in the way her hand trembled slightly against her.

"Even so," Adora murmured, "I don't want to… scare you off. Or rush anything. But I want to ask you something, and I need you to know you can say no."

Catra rolled onto her side now, chin propped on her hand, amused and already rosy-cheeked. Her heart was pounding."Just ask, dummy."

Adora hesitated a moment too long. Then-

"Do you ever see marriage in your future?"

The breath Catra took was stuck halfway in her lungs.

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The lanternlight hit just right, catching the pink blooming across her cheeks. Adora saw it—and the shy little twitch of Catra's mouth she tried to hide by ducking her gaze.

Adora's heart did something embarrassing.

Catra swallowed, voice quieter than she meant it to be. "I… had to rethink a lot. You know. While I was… not exactly conscious, but—everything after, too. Perfuma. You. The things I used to push on her because I thought that was the only way to be 'legitimate.'"

She toyed with the edge of the blanket, ears flicking down softly. "But I… kind of like the idea. Marriage. Maybe even kids. Doesn't have to be the conventional, fancy-vow, five-hundred-guest melarky. But… the idea of choosing someone. Building something. I don't hate it anymore."

Adora didn't speak right away. Her fingers moved up and brushed Catra's jaw, tilting her face back toward her. Her heart was

hammering in her chest as she tried to swallow down the excited grin that was threatening to bloom on her face.

Catra wanted a marriage, and children…with her.

Her voice was barely above a whisper. "You're sure?"

Catra gave her a look, one of those sharp, fond, don't-be-an-idiot ones. "I wouldn't say it if I didn't mean it."

Adora's chest ached in that good, terrifying way, like her ribs had been unlatched. She leaned in and pressed a slow kiss to Catra's cheek, right at the flushed spot. She let herself beam in a way that had the Magicat grinning back and giggling.

"You want to marry me?" She whispered, knowing her eyes were giving away her excitement. It was no matter though, Catra's eyes practically sparkled back as she shyly nodded.

"That better not be your proposal though." She muttered back, playing faux annoyed despite nudging her cheek against Adora's and scent marking her with a light trill.

Adora went quiet. How *would* Catra like a proposal? Fireworks and the queen? No, that was too extravagant…Over dinner? No…she deserved more.

"I can hear you overcomplicating, Dor." Her partner whispered, nudging her back to reality, "I don't need much." She pressed another kiss to Adora's cheek and snuggled up further to her, settling in with a deeper purr and chasing Adora's eyes to fall heavy with sleep.

She would make sure it was special either way.

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"You're here to ask my permission to marry her." Cyra asked, sitting upright and sipping her tea, the statement coming out

before Adora had even asked. How had she known? Was she that obvious in her intent?

"Y-yes Ma'am." They straightened their posture, trying to make herself appear larger. She needed to show Catra's mother that she could and would protect her as much as possible.

Cyra regarded her for a minute, her stern frown twitching before she burst into a fit of giggles. Adora awkwardly stood there, her posture sagging slightly as she continued to stare.

"What's so funny?" She finally asked.

"The vision of you standing taller to remind me you'd protect her as if I haven't seen you do so for the better part of a year."

It was so strange to see Cyra giggling. She had come a far way since Adora had first seen her, timid and quiet in the shadow of her daughters and Light Spinner. She had gotten far better during the weeks of Catra's recovery, her frame filling out once again and the colour coming back to her cheeks. She looked even healthier than she was when she arrived, and now walked about with a calmer, more confident air about her.

Her and her daughters had gotten closer too. Catra had opened up to Adora one night about how their relationship had been strained, and her confusion on how things were progressing better between them. She seemed to be a little put off from the idea of finally being able to rely on her mother again, not just as a confidant but as someone that loved her.

Even so, Cyra treated both Perfuma, Catra and now Adora like her children. She woke early to make them breakfast, humming tunes under her breath and floating about the place, finding solace in painting and sight-seeing in Brightmoon. She had also gotten closer with Angella once more, her departure out of society during her marriage now forgotten.

"You… approve?" Adora asked, wary, almost disbelieving. She'd prepared for resistance—an interrogation, at the very least. She

hadn’t prepared for laughter and tea.

Cyra stood and crossed the room without hurry, the sway of her tail flicking behind her. She took Adora’s hand in both of hers, the fur along her palm heated and soft—comforting in a way that made Adora’s breath wobble.

“Adora,” she said gently. “You have looked after my daughter better than I ever did. You make her happy in a way I didn’t think she’d ever allow herself to be.” Her eyes softened, glistening with something close to pride. “I’d be a fool to deny her that.”

Adora swallowed the lump in her throat, begging the tears that threatened her to not spill. “Thank you. I- I won’t ever stop trying to be worthy of her.”

“You already are,” Cyra said simply.

And then, before Adora could register it, Cyra tugged her into a hug, firm and brief, but real. When she pulled back, there was a sly little glint in her eye.

“You better not propose with the same ring you did with Perfuma.” She chuckled.

Adora balked. Shit. *Shit!* She hadn’t even thought about that.

Cyra shook her head fondly at Adora’s panicked expression. “Do not fret, dear. I might have an idea.”

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“A proposal!” Perfuma squealed as pretty flowers bloomed beneath her feet. “Oh my stars! It’s about time!” She gasped out, clutching Adora’s arm excitedly.

Admittedly, Adora was a little worried about telling Perfuma. Though she had acted even sisterly towards Adora now, she wasn’t sure if the topic might breach awkward territory, but it seemed though her worries had been in vain.

“Hah…yes. I was a little worried it wouldn’t be something Catra wanted for a while.” She rubbed the back of her neck embarrassed.

“Catra has always wanted this. You just let her have things now. She has already mentioned how she’d like marriage and kids with you, months ago.”

“Months?!” Adora blanched. This new information sent her reeling.

“Months.” Perfuma smirked, “Now, you’ll need to tell me all about your plan and Ooh- I could set you up with the perfect flowers.

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“Surprise!” Adora took their hands off of Catra’s eyes and the first thing she saw was Adora’s sunshine smile. She hadn’t even looked at her surprise yet and this was already enough.

Adora had been a little sneaky for the past couple of weeks, leaving her room early and cancelling on Catra’s plans occasionally. At first she had started to feel rejected, wondering if the Viscount had already lost interest in her. She moped about the house when she saw her mother, beaming at her with a knowing smile and talking about how much she loved Adora, and how much Adora clearly loved Catra.

It sent Catra on a tizzy, and when Adora had finally told her she had been thinking about asking Glimmer to teleport them to a surprise destination, it all made sense. Adora had just been sneaking around to surprise Catra on her birthday, and it was a lovely gift.

She finally took her eyes away from Adora, taking in a minute to look at her surroundings, and gasped.

It hit her, the warmth in the air, the way the spices wafted through her nostrils and embedded themselves deep into her soul. She was finally *home*.

Halfmoon.

“How- How did you…” She started. Tears formed in her eyes as she took in her home. It had been closer to two years since she had been back, and she had been feeling terribly homesick. She hadn’t voiced it to Adora so much, besides the odd comment, but of course she had noticed. Of course she had pulled off such a beautiful gesture, seemingly effortlessly. They stood now in her family home, Glimmer long gone to give them privacy. “Adora…” She trailed off.

She took a step away from her and walked around the house. It was large and as empty as they left it. Not that it had always been that way. She touched a pillar, the cold stone beneath it grounding her and reminiscing on a time where the house was filled with lively chatter.

The room blurred.

She swallowed and spoke without turning around. “Why did you bring me here?”

Adora shifted, just enough that Catra could feel heat radiating from her back. “Because you miss it,” she said simply. “And I…” She hesitated, then breathed out. “I wanted to see you here. Happy. Somewhere you feel like you belong.”

Catra’s throat tightened.

Adora went on, voice low but sure. “I want to walk through the markets with you. See the orchards you told me about. Meet the baker you said gave you your first pastry. I want to stay here with you for a little while, write some new memories with you and see the place you love so much. It's not fair for you to stay in Brightmoon with me when this is clearly where your heart belongs.”

Catra turned then.

Adora was watching her with that painfully earnest focus, like she hung the moons and sun and all the rivers between. As if she clearly hadn't just done that for her.

She looked away because if she didn't, she'd cry all over her own damn birthday surprise.

"You… wanted to travel through Halfmoon?"

Adora nodded, stepping closer. "With you. There's more than just this house. You told me once you knew every inch of the valley, that you and Perfuma used to race through the lavender fields and get in trouble for tracking dirt into the baths."

Catra let out a strangled laugh. "Mama was going to skin us alive."

Adora smiled. "I want to see those fields with you. I want to see everything here through your eyes." She paused, then added more quietly, "I want to imagine what it could look like again- with you here someday. If you'd have me."

The words landed like a quiet, certain promise. It wasn't a proposal, but it was damn near close. They hadn't spoken much about their future since their last conversation, it seemed whenever it was brought up- Adora would flush a bright red and start stuttering. At first it made Catra egg her on, jesting with her lightly. But then after a while, she wondered if perhaps maybe the Viscount changed their mind.

This clearly proved the contrary though.

Catra's shoulders dropped with something that wasn't quite *just* relief, something softer and deeper. "I can't believe you did all this." *For me.*

Adora's cheeks pinked, and she rubbed the back of her neck. "I asked Perfuma to help me hide it from you. Your mother knew too. She cried when I told her you'd get to come home."

That stung in a warm, aching way.

Catra drifted across the room, fingertips trailing the curve of the old wooden table where she used to sew scraps from Cyra's cast-offs. She paused at the edge of the arched doorway looking into the sitting room.

"Feels like if I turn the corner, she'll be sitting there," Catra whispered. "Mama with her tea and woodwork spread out on the table."

Adora approached her gently from behind, not quite touching. "Maybe we can light the hearth later. Or go up to your room. Whatever you want to see first."

Catra turned, blinking through the film of memory. "You're really planning to stay? Overnight?"

"We can stay however long as you want," Adora said. "A night or a week. Maybe even a month I packed enough clothes to survive your climate and your attitude. And if you'd like to stay longer, we can always travel back."

Catra snorted. Then, after a beat, stepped into Adora's arms and pressed her face into their chest. Adora wrapped around her instinctively, warm and firm and *safe*.

"Thank you," Catra mumbled, voice muffled. "This is… the best birthday I've had since I was ten and Perfuma dropped a honey cake on my head. I…I appreciate you so much."

Adora laughed into her hair. "That is a high bar." Then she whispered into her curls, "Happy birthday, kitten."

Catra huffed, her cheeks pinking as they always did after that *stupid* nickname. "Shut up."

They stood like that in the quiet of the old house, surrounded by ghosts, but for the first time in years, Catra didn't feel like one of them.

And beyond the windows, Halfmoon waited.

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Adora couldn't remember the last time a market felt this peaceful.

Well…she also couldn't remember the last time she had entered the market, usually that was the job of the maids.

She sighed, feeling the warm sunlight hit her temple, listening to the buzz of the vendors and feeling Catra's hand loosely laced with hers as they strolled through the main square of Halfmoon.

Catra's tail flicked occasionally, brushing Adora's thigh every few steps. Adora pretended she wasn't counting each time it happened.

They passed a small stall overflowing with flowers, the vivid petals spilling over the edges in bundles and tied with soft twine. She slowed to admire them but didn't say anything, just smiling at the vendor and nodding politely.

Eventually, they turned into the scent of something warm, sweet and friend curling into the air. A vendor was turning small golden spheres in a wide pan, the steam rising as he scooped them into a bowl of sweet thick syrup.

"Have you ever had these?" Catra pointed.

Adora peered over there, and shook her head. Shivering with excitement, she said, "No, but they smell like heavens."

They bought a paper cone of them, along with a savoury version of thin fried dough shells filled with chickpeas, spices and a tangy watery sauce. Adora bit into one of them and moaned.

"Stars…Catra. Why didn't you make me try these earlier?" She whined, grabbing another and biting into it before pouting as the chickpeas fell out of the ball and cracked.

"You're meant to shove the whole thing in your mouth, oaf." Catra cackled, wiping the sauce from Adora's mouth fondly and going to

shove one in her mouth. The sight was adorable, her cheeks filled like a chipmunk that made Adora chuckle and coo.

“I bet I can eat more than you.” Adora challenged.

“Oh it’s on!”

Eventually, Adora won, but Catra insisted it was because she let her, and eventually demanded a rematch another time.

As Adora went to pay the vendor, she heard Catra slip away. She turned back, after depositing the small gold coins and tipping him generously, only to see Catra standing there, shy and with a bouquet full of flowers.

“Here.” She awkwardly shoved the bouquet in Adora’s hand and looked down to avoid her gaze, a heavy blush adorning her freckles.

“For me?…” Adora’s brows rose to her hairline, studying the blues, pinks and yellow marigolds of the bouquet, a matching blush spreading across her face too.

“Obviously.” Catra scratched the back of her neck.

Adora felt their smile turn over, first fond and then smug as she took in Catra’s awkward shuffle of her feet and high strung demeanor.

“Wow…you must really like me.” She smirked, letting her arm drape across Catra’s shoulder and pull her in closer.

“I- I do not!” She growled, attempting to shove Adora away weakly.

“You do! That’s so embarrassing, kitty.” Adora giggled, laughing harder at Catra’s heavy blush that coated after the nickname, as she smacked Adora hard and muttered at her to ‘shut up.’

She stared at the bouquet in her arms a little longer. It was so strange to be courted as though she was a woman, and not a Viscount. Since she was typically considered the suitor, women never had attempted to treat her as though she was anything more than her title, instead of wooing her, they simply tried to sell themselves as the best candidate.

Of course, they had played into it. She hadn't really thought of an alternative life she could have. One that was filled with a woman treating her as her equal, buying her flowers and treating her to the most amazing food she had ever had the pleasure of tasting.

They were so incredibly grateful for Catra. For showing her this life, for allowing her to be more comfortable in expressing her gender identity without being too fussed on labels. It was only months into they started dating that Adora had started to feel more comfortable in wearing less tight clothing, binding their chest less frequently yet still having days where she constricted it just because it was more comfortable.

Catra had never even blinked twice.

They turned down a quieter street, leaving the thicker crowd behind. The modiste came into view, a wide, airy building with ivy strung along the windows and bolts of fabric visible through the front display. Adora's heart squeezed seeing the spark in Catra's eyes when she glanced at it.

"You want to go in?" Adora asked gently.

Catra shrugged, pretending nonchalance, but her tail betrayed her with its excited thwap. "Just to say hi."

The bell chimed as they stepped through the door. Inside, the shop was busy, three seamstresses threading needles at a long table, another taking measurements of a client by the window. In the back, a young man with sleeves rolled to his elbows was sorting through a rack of finished garments.

He looked up, and lit up. “Miss Catra! Look who finally decided she’s too good for retirement!”

Catra rolled her eyes, but she was smiling. “I was never retired, Theo.”

Theo crossed the room in a few long strides and beamed at Adora. “You retire for two years and bring back a Viscount?” He smirked, eyeing the pair up and down and rolling his eyes at Catra’s scoff.

Adora’s ears went hot. She and Catra both muttered something unintelligible.

Theo just laughed and clapped his hands. “What are we making today?”

Adora blinked, startled. “Oh-oh, no, you don’t have to—”

Catra raised a brow. “I want to get you something. Let him.”

Theo’s eyes swept over Adora appraisingly. Not in a rude way, just like he was already mentally taking her measurements. “She’s broad in the shoulders. Doesn’t like tight sleeves?”

Adora almost asked how he knew that, but Catra was already nodding with a smirk. “They pulls on the necklines when they get flustered, too.”

“I do not—!”

“They do,” Catra cut in.

Theo disappeared behind a partition, then returned with fabric swatches in warm neutrals and soft blues. “They seem the type who’d hate anything frilly, but we can make something elegant. Structured without choking her.”

Adora was half bewildered, half charmed.

Twenty minutes later, Theo brought her something to try: a knee-length kurta-style tunic, slit at the sides for movement, fitted just enough at the shoulders but loose through the body. The collar dipped into a subtle V-shape instead of buttoning to the throat. It was navy, a colour she wasn't new to wearing but muted and light enough to still feel…more airy.

Adora slipped it on in the adjoining room and stared at herself in the mirror.

She looked…good. And rested. It felt like her. Not a costume nor armour, nor formal wear. It was something she could breathe in, potentially fight in, lounge in. It fluttered down their waist in a more oversized style, not clinging to her chest, something inherently masculine about it yet feminine enough to make her feel pretty.

She studied herself a moment, untying her ponytail and letting her hair drape across her shoulders and her bangs part down the centre of her face. Gods, she had only been here a day and she already felt more comfortable and restrd than they ever had in their adult life.

When she came out, Catra was leaning against a worktable, arms crossed.

Her ears went high and pupils widened, as she eyed Adora's arms. She was steadily turning a shade of pink, a sight that made Adora shift nervously yet cross her arms and absentmindedly flex.

"You let down your hair…" Catra murmured, openly ogling her. "I'm going to pull on it later."

Adora chuckled nervously, trying not to blush too hard.

Theo reappeared with a second garment folded over his arm, a similar design, but in softer lines and a slightly more fitted waist, with embroidery along the middle that caught the light and a matching scarf to drape around her neck.

He handed it to Catra. “Matching set. Couldn’t help myself.”

Catra scoffed, but her eyes were gleaming. She brushed her fingers along the fabric almost shyly.

Adora watched her, heart doing somersaults, and thought, quietly, that this might be one of the happiest afternoons of her life.



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“Are you definitely comfortable with me being there?” Adora asked, as Catra practically dragged her to the courtyard.

Catra had changed into the matching outfit now, and Adora had to fight to keep her smile from stretching off her face as onlookers openly cooed at the couple. It seemed many of the townsfolk knew Catra and felt comfortable enough teasing her.

Catra had made a big show of hissing at anyone that looked at them with anything other than nonchalance, growling and threatening them yet never straying from her loop around Adora's arm. It made them pull her closer, ruffle her curls and kiss her hair, causing the magicat to trill and then promptly smack her when she too, cooed, openly.

They were standing outside the place where her Mama was buried now. Adora hadn't noticed at first until she took in Catra's hesitance and looked off into the far distance.

"I wouldn't bring you here if I wasn't. Now come, I haven't spoken to her in nearly two years."

It caused a feeling of discomfort in Adora if she was being completely honest. Since her father had been buried, she had never visited the gravesite. Never spoken to him in hushed tones, never asked him for advice nor openly spoke of him. Now, she felt almost guilty that she would do so to Catra's Mama, and she only hoped that wherever he was, her father didn't feel as though she ever forgot him.

"One moment." Adora quickly let go of Catra's hand and made a move to leave, but not before she saw the insecurity on her partner's face. She quickly drew back, kissing her softly and holding her, "Don't worry, I'll be back quickly. I want to meet her."

Catra bit her lip but nodded, taking a step back and waiting.

Adora hadn't lied, she had arrived five minutes later with an arm full of bouquets. It was clear she hadn't known what to pick, because in her arms was the damn near florist booth.

"Suddenly think you're Perfuma?" Catra raised a brow yet shaking her head fondly, putting her hand on the small of Adora's back

and leading her to the gravestone.

“Mama, I want you to meet someone.”

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Adora was fast asleep in her arms now.

Her breathing had evened out into a soft, steady rhythm, her cheek pressed against Catra’s collarbone, golden hair spread across her chest like sunlight spilled over silk. Catra couldn’t stop staring. She honestly couldn’t believe that Adora, *her Adora*, was here. In her bed. In her home.

That she had followed her all the way to her mother’s grave, despite how visibly conflicted she’d been.

Catra had seen it, the way Adora’s jaw had trembled, the way her eyes had glossed over with unshed tears she refused to let fall, the way she’d reached out to touch the stone and then pulled her hand back as if it burned.

And yet she had done it anyway.

That quiet bravery, that relentless heart, it left Catra breathless.

Now, in the low light of her room, the muscular woman looked incredibly small. Peaceful, but drained. There was a soft frown still etched between their brows, as if she were dreaming about something heavy, and Catra brushed her thumb over it until it smoothed away.

She felt something deep in her chest, an ache that wasn’t pain, not exactly. It was too full, too warm. Pride, maybe. Or love that had nowhere to go but out, overflowing in her ribs until she thought she might burst from it.

It was undeniable that visiting the grave had done something for Adora. Catra could see it in their posture, in the way her shoulders had lowered for the first time in weeks. There was peace there

now. And maybe, just maybe, it would give Adora the courage to face her own grief too.

She tightened her arms around her, pulling Adora closer until their foreheads touched.

"I love you," Catra whispered, her voice barely audible in the hush of the room. "You're beautiful."

Adora murmured something incoherent in her sleep and nuzzled closer, her nose brushing against Catra's throat. Catra's chest seized.

Gods, she was lucky.

There was a time, not so long ago, that she'd believed she'd never have this. Not the comfort of another heartbeat against her own, not this impossible softness, not this love that felt like both sanctuary and wildfire.

She hadn't thought she'd be alone forever, exactly… just that she wasn't built for something like this.

But now, this woman in her arms, this warmth pressed against her, Catra felt everything she'd once thought impossible become real.

It was terrifying.

Because Adora Grayskull had become her home, her anchor, her undoing.

She pressed a kiss to Adora's hairline, lingering there until the world seemed to still around them.

Adora stirred slightly but didn't wake, her lips parting as she let out a soft sigh that brushed across Catra's skin.

Catra smiled faintly, eyes burning.

“Sleep, Princess,” she murmured, voice trembling with affection. “I’ve got you. Just rest.”

Outside, the night hummed low and steady, the wind whispering through the trees. Catra shifted only enough to reach for the blanket and pull it higher over them both.

Then she lay there, holding her entire world in her arms, terrified of how much she loved them, and yet completely at peace with it.

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Catra stumbled for what had to at least been the fourth, or perhaps *fifth(?)* time, in the last few minutes. She grumbled, her ears pinning back as she clutched Adora’s forearm like a lifeline.

“Adora, if I die by face planting into a ditch, trust that I will be haunting you.”

Adora’s giggle was bright, nervous and a little breathless, her sweaty palm squeezing Catra’s tightly as she guided her forward. “You won’t! I promise, just a few more steps.”

“You said that ten minutes ago.”

“Did I?” Adora said, and even without seeing her face, Catra could hear the mischievous smile in her voice.

Catra groaned dramatically, the blindfold itching at her temple. “If this is revenge for the mouse thing, I swear-“

“Oh my gods, it is not revenge for the mouse thing!” Adora spluttered, clearly flustered. “You’re never gonna let that go, are you?”

Catra smirked. “You ate a mouse.”

“You disguised it as chicken!”

“Still a mouse.” She giggled.

“Catraaa.”

The sound of her name drawn out like that made her laugh despite herself. She sighed, shaking her head. “Fine, fine. But if you’re leading me into a tree, I’m biting you.”

“Noted,” Adora said, and Catra could hear their smile widen.

Then…

Something shifted.

The air grew sweet. Floral. Thick with something Catra hadn’t smelled in years. She inhaled sharply, the scent flooding her senses, stirring something deep and familiar in her chest.

Lavender.

She stopped walking, her voice softening. “Adora…?”

A cool breeze stirred, carrying the scent stronger now: earthy, floral, *warm*. It was the smell of home. Of childhood. Of safety.

“Adora, why does this smell like—”

The blindfold slipped away, and her words fell silent.

The scene unfolded before her.

Before her, was an achingly familiar stretch of lavender fields, awash in purples and silver beneath the twilight sky. Rows upon rows of the blooms swayed gently in the warm breeze, each plant illuminated by fireflies that shimmered like captured stars. Strings of lanterns hung between wooden posts, their golden glow painting the night in warmth.

It was the fields that her and Perfuma would race in barefoot, her laughter echoing with her sister’s under the summer sun. She had told Adora it was one of her fondest childhood memories.

Not just because of how carefree they were before their Mama's death, but because of how vexed she would be when they came home utterly filthy from running around in compost. The memory was always fond, echoing a warm glow within her, but now it had transformed into something more like a dream.

For a moment, all she could do was stand there, the sight catching in her throat.

"Adora…"

When she finally turned around, she found Adora standing a few feet away, wringing her hands nervously with a soft pink flush dancing on her cheeks. Her golden hair was loose once again and glowed in the lanterns. She looked at Catra as though she had been waiting her whole life for this moment.

"Do…do you remember telling me," Adora began, her voice trembling slightly, "that this was the only place you ever truly felt free? Your perfect memory?"

Catra nodded, her heart racing as she stared at her, dumbfounded.

"I wanted you to feel that again." Adora took a step closer, her voice softer now. "But I also wanted to make a new memory here. One that's ours. If…if you'd like that."

Catra blinked, confusion and warmth tangling together in her chest. "Ours?", she said, breathless.

Adora smiled, shaky but radiant. Then, she reached into her pocket, and pulled out a small crimson, velvet box.

Catra froze. Her heart began hammering away at her chest, the nervousness she felt almost suffocating but her joy rising all the same.

"Adora? what are you—"

Adora dropped to one knee.

The world fell away, and Catra had to remind herself to breathe as she turned almost into a statue.

"Catra- I," they said, their voice breaking halfway through as though they might be sick with nerves. "I always thought that marriage was a duty I had to fulfil. That love would make me weaker and turn me away from my responsibilities. I had all these preconceived ideas of how things should be. But…But then I met *you*."

She wasn't even looking at Catra now, her gaze disassociating at the box she had yet to open, but a smile pulling away at her, achingly soft.

"But then I met you, riding in those woods- your hair wild and free and you looking at me all cocky as though I hadn't a clue in the world. I knew then that I would be thinking about you for a very long time, but I would have to push it down and keep going through. And then we met again at that ball. You berated me, made me feel like a misbehaving child, insulted me and poked at my forehead-"

Catra distantly heard a scandalised gasp but chalked it up to her imagination. She was too emotional.

"That was probably the moment I decided I wanted you. Not fully consciously but…You never left my mind since. Whether that was from me being angry at you, to being attracted to you until… eventually loving you. It happened all the same.

You helped me grieve my father in a way I never had before. I hadn't known anyone that I felt saw me the way you did, felt took on the same responsibilities I did, cared for others the way I did it….But. But you seemed to do it so much more gracefully. You showed me that taking care of myself wasn't selfish. That the world wouldn't end if I ever took a break. Catra."

She shakily opened the box and Catra gasped, looking down at the ring. Her vision was foggy from tears but she could still feel the distant recognition that lit up in her. *How did Adora-?*

"Catra. You made me realise love is…everything. It's the reason I fight, the reason I even feel alive. I never thought I could have you Catra, and when I finally did, I nearly *lost* you—" Her voice broke. "I realised I couldn't go on without trying my absolute best to never let go of you. Catra…

Catra, it would be everything to me if you'd marry me. I want to spend the rest of my life loving you, growing with you. Being in Halfmoon with you these past few days have been more freeing than I could ever imagine. And I would genuinely love to live the rest of my days with you here. If you'll have me."

Catra just stared at her, her hands shaking as she focused in on the ring that was shaking not just from her teary vision, but from Adora's trembling hands.

Inside the box, the ring was gold and delicate, yet a little worn from time. The metal gleamed softly in the glow of the lanterns, and the shape carved in its centre made Catra's breath catch in her throat.

An M shape. Two small dips in the middle forming the outline of the mask her Mama used to wear. It was stored away in a box now, but occasionally Perfuma and Catra would take turns wearing it when they especially missed her. Perfuma nowadays took to wearing her Mama's leaf crown, finding the lighter weight more pleasant around her face, whilst Catra still liked to frequent the mask whilst she could.

It hit her all at once.

Her voice finally came to her. "Adora…this was- this was my Mama's ring." Her voice broke around the words. "How did- how did you?"

Adora's hands stopped shaking a little and her eyes softened. "Cyra gave it to me. She told me it belonged with you and not collecting dust. Said your Mama would have wanted it that way."

Catra shook her head, laughing through the tears that spilled down her cheeks. "You didn't—Adora, you can't just—"

Adora reached for her hand, her voice trembling. "I wanted to. Because your Mama's ring…it matched my father's."

Catra looked up, startled, as Adora pulled the chain from under her shirt, revealing her father's ring hanging there—the same "M" shape, thicker, simpler, more solid. Two halves of a whole.

She recognised the ring from the one she would have worn to match Perfuma. Perfuma would have taken Adora's Mother's ring and Adora would have taken her father's.

They were almost identical. Her Mama's delicate mask. Adora's father's sharp crest. Two sides of the same story.

Catra let out a shaky laugh that broke into a sob. "You idiot," she whispered, pressing a trembling hand to her mouth. "You absolute- beautiful—*oaf*."

Adora smiled through her tears. "At least answer the question before you insult me" She jested, "Will you…will you marry me, Catra?"

The world stilled.

Catra's heart was pounding so hard she swore it echoed in the lavender around them. Every word, every look, every moment of their nearly two years, the loss, forgiveness, of being able to truly be with each other, crashed over her all at once.

And she nodded, fiercely, tearfully. "Yes. Yes, *Of course,* I'll marry you."

Adora exhaled a shaky breath that turned into a laugh, half-sob, half-joy, and she was on her feet before Catra could even blink, pulling her into her arms.

Catra met her halfway, crashing into her with enough force to knock them both back into the lavender. They laughed through tears, kissing—messy, salty, desperate kisses that tasted like promise.

When they finally pulled apart, Catra's forehead rested against Adora's. "You love me that much, huh?"

Adora's voice was barely a whisper. "More than I ever thought possible."

Catra smiled through tears, her hand cupping Adora's cheek. "Then you're stuck with me, you know that? No take backs."

"Good," Adora said, grinning against her lips. "That's exactly what I wanted."

A sudden shriek broke the quiet.

"Finally!"

"That was such a long speech! My legs were cramping!"

Catra flinched, turning to see Perfuma standing on the edge of the field, hands over her mouth and tears streaming down her face. Behind her, Bow and Glimmer emerged from the shadows, Glimmer clutching a handful of confetti and Bow barely restraining Scorpia, who looked ready to charge at them happily. The rest of their families were there too. Cyra with tears pouring down her face, Marlena with a fond smile. Lonnie and Adam were chuckling but smiling and Mara and Hope looked on almost wistfully.

Catra blinked. "You're all-"

"Surprise!" they shouted in unison.

Scorpia immediately scooped Catra and Adora into a crushing hug. “I am so proud of you two! You little lovebugs!”

Perfuma was sobbing openly now, taking Catra’s hands and laughing through her tears. “I knew it! I knew she was going to propose here!”

Catra rolled her eyes, laughing helplessly. “You all are unbelievable.”

Adora’s arm tightened around her waist. “You love it.”

Catra looked up at her fiancée, her *fiancée,* that would be her *wife*, and despite the chaos, the laughter, the tears all around them, it was the calmest she’d ever felt.

This wasn’t a fairytale. It wasn’t perfect. But it was *theirs*.

And as Adora leaned down and kissed her again, the lavender swayed around them, the stars glimmered above, and for once in her life, Catra let herself believe she had everything she’d ever dreamed of.

Chapter End Notes

Aaaaand it’s finished!! Thank you to everyone who was here from the start and others that picked it up a few days ago, and even if you’re reading this from the future!!

This fic is literally my CHILD!! I’m super duper proud of it and i’m lowkey emotional now that it’s basically done.

The next work for this fic series will be up soon! So keep an eye out - if you subscribe you'll get a notification or if you comment I can reply to you when it's up! The next work will be up within the next two weeks I believe, I already have an outline for it and it'll be easier since it's not a linear fic but

more short stories of how their life will go on from now, so if you're waiting for babies and more...stay tuned!

Adora does turn to she/they pronouns in this chapter and I really love it. i'll probably add something about that in the new fic too, along with a chapter about her coming to terms with her grief eventually, and maybe even some Lonnie/Adam shenanigans.

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Thanks so much guys! Until the next one :)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!